The Pact

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/29252253.

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Explicit

Archive Warnings:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Rape/Non-Con

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F/F, F/M, Multi

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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by the_deaf_pomegranate

Summary

After a lifetime of loss and trauma, Catra makes a life-changing promise to Bow and Glimmer that no-one ever expected her to make - least of all her girlfriend Adora, who has sacrificed her hopes of motherhood for a childfree life with Catra. Things get messy af.

Non-linear AU in which Catra is Bow and Glimmer's surrogate, and in which the lines between friendship, love, parenthood and survivorship blur. Potential triggering themes include childhood trauma, coming out and internalised homophobia, domestic violence, childbirth, infertility, loss, physical disfigurement, and exploration of ethnic/racial identity.

Catra knitted her eyebrows together, pressing her lips into a thin line. Adora caught her breath in her throat. She'd tried to avoid thinking too much about what this would be like, watching Catra in pain. It had been so many years since she'd seen Catra suffer, at least so visibly. She braced herself to keep focused in the moment, to not think back to the things she wished neither of them had had to live through. But it was so hard when Catra's pain responses still seemed to look exactly the same…

Notes

This is my first fic in over a decade, and the first for this fandom or on AO3 ever - I'd love it if you have feedback or comment to let me know if you'd like more... :) I've got a few chapters planned if people enjoy it!

Chapter 1

Catra settled herself down cautiously on the edge of the stool, reaching out to twist the shower dial behind her. She let out a breath of relief that she didn't even know she was holding as cold water began to trickle over her head, coursing through her curls and soothing the back of her neck. She felt so warm it almost hurt – or at least, it wasn't making the slow pain spreading from her back feel any less painful. She leaned back, resting her shoulders against the damp wet room tiles, her legs spread as wide as the space would allow while she rubbed circular motions into the side of her stomach.

Just to relieve the pain, she told herself, pressing the pads of her fingers deeper, *that's all it is*.

"Babe?"

Catra heard Adora calling from the apartment hallway. She was home quicker than Catra expected – but then again, Adora somehow always seemed to tick to a faster clock than her, and Catra had become so slow over the past few weeks that she'd half forgotten what normal travel times used to be. She crinkled her brow as Adora's clunky footsteps quickened in the distance – *she must still be wearing her Docs* - wincing as another wave of slow, steady pain reached its peak.

"Catra? Everything alright?"

Catra furrowed her brow, channelling all her energy into just getting through the last few seconds… *3, 2, 1*… She let out a soft moan as the bathroom door creaked open, before it was flung wide, hard wood bouncing off the side of the counter opposite her.

"Oh my God, Catra!"

Adora's blue eyes were wide, drinking in the sight of her girlfriend perched in the walk-in shower, her stomach shifting slightly as her shoulders tensed. Catra held up a finger in Adora's face, her eyes still closed as she massaged her belly with her other hand.

"Shoes."

Adora stopped in her tracks in the door frame, bundled up in her winter coat, and her cheeks red from the cold wind outside.

"Oh for fuck's sake, Catra, is this really the time to worry about–"

Catra snapped her eyes open to stare directly into Adora's, one eyebrow arching threateningly high.

"Jesus wept."

Adora muttered under her breath as she hastily shuffled back into the hallway, practically ripping her Doc Martens off and tossing them towards the shoe rack.

"How many minutes?" Adora paused, waiting for a response to her question. "Catra…?"

She shrugged off her coat hastily and threw it onto a hook, barging back into the bathroom.

"Still twenty-ish. I doubt there'll be any excitement for a while."

Adora's stance softened as Catra nudged her head towards the sink – she'd become obsessive about handwashing ever since they'd gone to Scorpia's twins' birthday party a couple of months ago and norovirus had ripped through the guests over the following days. It was only in the past couple of weeks or so that Catra had suddenly become just as insistent on it.

"Please tell me you haven't just left your Docs in the middle of the hallway ready for you to trip over."

Adora caught Catra's smirk in the mirror, pretending she didn't catch her studying the way Adora scrubbed her skin with the foamy soap between the fingers, across the backs of her hands, under her fingernails. She dried her hands on a clean towel, resting it on the radiator as she knelt down in front of her girlfriend.

"The student has become the master, eh?"

"Well, it only took four years of living with you to pick up your neat freak." Catra stuck her tongue out at Adora mischievously. "Besides, I just want to keep everything clean in case–"

Adora shook her head, resting her elbows on Catra's knees as her chin bumped on Catra's stretched abdomen. Catra shivered at the touch of Adora's face on her skin, icy from the outdoors.

"I know. And we won't let that happen."

"You're cold." She looked at Adora, the drops of water from the shower spreading damp pools on her shirt. "And you're getting your clothes wet."

Adora smiled, standing up and bending down to kiss Catra tenderly, cupping her cheek in her hand. She peeled her wet shirt over her head and tugged off her jeans and underwear, bundling them both into the nearby laundry hamper.

"Problem solved."

Adora grinned as she came back to Catra, increasing the pressure of the shower slightly and weaving her fingers through Catra's damp hair to massage her scalp.

"Mmm, I like your problem solving but I'm not sure how practical it is right now, Adora."

Adora chuckled.

"I dunno, this seems pretty practical right now to me."

Catra tapped her fingers on her belly, pushing where she'd felt movement just a second ago.

"Well, I'm pretty sure Glimmer and Bow are going to get here any minute, so unless you wanna answer the door naked…"

Adora gasped, her fingers freezing against Catra's scalp.

"Shit! Do you – *don't say need, Adora* - **want** a hand getting dressed?"

Catra sighed heavily, nudging her head back into Adora's hands, silently seeking further relief even though she knew they couldn't carry on like this for long. She stayed quiet for another few moments, relishing the pressure of the cold tile against her shoulder and the feeling of Adora massaging her roots over and over again, just like when they were kids and helped wash each other's hair in the school showers after swimming lessons, suds running down their swimming costumes. She blinked the memories away – they'd come so far since then.

"Honestly, this child is a fucking inferno… I'm not gonna survive this if I can't keep cool." Catra sensed Adora tensing at her words; she gulped guiltily, knowing full well that Adora was over-aware of the copious potential could-go-wrongs that the coming hours, *days really*, could bring. She cleared her throat, pushing the discomfort in her brain away. "Anyway, it's not as if they're not going to see everything eventually, is it?"

Adora's voice shook a little. "I guess… But Catra - remember this bit is all on your terms, yeah? You need more time here when they arrive, they can wait a little longer, ok?"

Catra nodded silently. They stayed there for a few minutes longer, Catra humming under her breath as the cool water riveted down her shoulders, chest and over her swollen belly. Eventually Adora stilled her fingers, shivering a little – if she was completely honest, she had never needed the cold shower in the first place and wouldn't have put herself through this chill under almost any

other circumstances – and leaned down to press a kiss to Catra's shoulder, her hand resting on top of Catra's thigh.

"I'm gonna get dried up, but I'll be just next door, okay?"

It happened faster than Adora even realised - Catra's fingers clenched around hers sharply, her entire demeanour changing in a split second as Adora stopped in place. Catra knitted her eyebrows together, pressing her lips into a thin line. Adora caught her breath in her throat. She'd tried to avoid thinking too much about what this would be like, watching Catra in pain. It had been so many years since she'd seen Catra suffer, at least so visibly. She braced herself to keep focused in the moment, to not think back to the things she wished neither of them had had to live through. But it was so hard when Catra's pain responses still seemed to look exactly the same…

She caught herself just in time, before the spiral could start to come to full fruition. She grounded herself, focusing on the things she could see right in front of her: *the baby hairs on Catra's hairline, the tiny droplets of cold water gathering in the hollows of her collarbones, the edge of Catra's oddly sharp incisors pressing down on her lower lip.*

"Another one? That must be way less than twenty since the last, surely?"

Catra grunted, her breath evening out as she inhaled and exhaled slowly. Adora waited until the tension drained from Catra's body and moved her thumb gently over Catra's cheek as she straightened up to leave.

"I'll set the stopwatch on my phone as I'm getting dressed, okay? Shout if I'm not back before the next one."

Catra squeezed Adora's fingers gratefully and leaned back on the tiles as her girlfriend left the room, letting the full length of her back stick against the wall as she resumed running her palms in

soothing circles across her heavy lower belly. She was starting to feel really nervous but she didn't want Adora to know that, not yet. Not when she could read Adora like a simple children's book, her anxiety bubbling through even when she tried so incredibly hard to hide it. What's worse, Catra knew the threshold of worry surrounding her was only about to quadruple to the max as soon as Glimmer and Bow arrived. It wasn't worth thinking about right now.

Taking another deep breath, Catra inched her fingers down below her belly as far as she could reach to see what dilation she could feel. She knew she was further along than she was letting on. She'd only gotten into this shower in the first place once she'd started to feel a warm trickle of liquid sink into her underwear over the last hour, slow and inconsistent. But the last year had been so surreal that Catra didn't really want to face up to it – once this bit was all over, once she'd given birth… *that thought was so bizarre as well, that she was about to give birth of all things*… then she wasn't sure what that would mean next, for her and Adora, or Glimmer and Bow, even their wider friendship circle. They were right on the precipice of big change, and even though they had a rock solid plan, an actual contract (!) they'd all discussed at *agonizing* length and signed, she couldn't imagine through the past few weeks' haze of hormones and soreness just quite how it was all going to pan out.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

Dammit, the writing bug came back quickly!

A little bit of context, and the first teasers of backstory coming up here... more is on its way (probably sooner than it should be given how many work *huge* deadlines I have this week)!

I'd love to hear what you think!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora stared at herself in the mirror, willing herself to swallow the sore lump of stifled tears that had balled up in her throat. She grimaced at how bloodshot her eyes were, bringing the backs of her hands up to her face to rub at them.

Now is not the time, Adora. Pull your shit together.

She straightened herself up, twisting the lid off Catra's moisturiser and scooping out a pea-sized blob with her index finger. She didn't usually dip into Catra's toiletries, but Adora wanted so desperately to feel close to her - the moisturiser wasn't even perfumed but somehow the non-descript scent always reminded Adora distinctly of her. She rubbed it between her fingertips, smoothing the cream over the ink of a tiny blue and yellow flower on the inside of her wrist and along her left bikini line.

Adora tugged on her clothes hastily, sliding a pack of antiseptic wipes under the tight waistband of her joggers and pulling out an outfit for Catra that she'd overheard her murmur aloud would be comfortable. Adora caught a glimpse of the stopwatch on her phone on the bed. *Four minutes and fifty three seconds*. She inhaled deeply through her nostrils, pushing the bulge in her throat back down again as she sighed in gratitude that she hadn't heard anything from the bathroom yet. They'd all known this

moment would come but Adora just didn't feel ready to be in the thick of it – that is, if they weren't already. This whole set-up just wasn't how she ever imagined experiencing… what? Pregnancy, parenthood, birth? Any, none and all of the above?

Adora could barely hold back a short bitter laugh, remembering yet again that her best friends managed to get the love of her life pregnant before she could. She hummed to herself for a second, brow drawn down as she got lost in thought. But the familiar wrap of a long, silky tail around her right calf nudged her out of it. Melog. Their compromise.

Adora had always wanted a big family. She and Catra had been surrounded by other kids in the children's home but she often felt lonely when everyone had drifted off to chat with their chosen friends. Maybe it was because she was so extroverted and the buzz of having people around her made her feel so energised that the loss of it felt even more profound. Her therapist suggested once that it might also be a desire for proactive fortification – building a stronghold of love and attention around herself with a group of kids that were dependent on her. Finally, a love that would be truly unconditional; one that she could devote her entire life towards, and no-one could ever doubt how much warmth and protection she had to give.

But Catra had always been honest with Adora. She didn't want kids. Not now, not ever. And deep down, Adora knew she never should have expected otherwise.

When Adora had been fostered and later adopted in their pre-teens, Catra found herself without an ally amongst all the others. The two of them had still hung out every day at school and stayed in touch throughout college – *well, apart from those last rocky few months* – but the dynamic had shifted irreversibly. Adora could see it clear as day from Catra's perspective (not that she'd ever expressed it out loud to her): the lively blonde with the promising talent for long-distance running found her forever home and the ethnically ambiguous kid with the unruly curls and the slightly alarming Catan obsession hadn't. They didn't talk about it

much, but she could see the goosebumps rise up on Catra's forearms every time they drove past their old neighbourhood – they still nicknamed it the Fright Zone – on their way to visit Adora's adoptive parents.

A year into their official romance, Catra had laid out the choice for Adora pretty fairly. If kids were the tie-breaker, they could recover a friendship after some necessary time-out. But Adora could see the grief and resignation in Catra's eyes already – *please, just stay* – and honestly? How could Adora ever choose a life with someone else, even an epic future love that was yet to exist, over *Catra*?

So thanks to an unspoken trade-off, they'd gotten Melog, an older cat who would never have found his way out the pound. They'd gone to the animal shelter hoping to get a dog; Adora had always wanted a Samoyed and Perfuma had tipped them off that she'd seen one being taken in while opening up her adjacent plant shop that day. They hurried over in their lunch breaks – Catra had even cleared her calendar for the afternoon to get the dog settled in at home (unlike Adora, she could ask her assistant to push all her meetings last minute) – but once they'd arrived, Adora had fallen completely in love with the cat. It only took that one afternoon while Adora finished up with her patients for Melog and Catra to become so deeply attached to one another that she often forgot that Catra didn't really want a pet in the first place.

She dropped down to stroke Melog's soft fur, letting his head nuzzle into her hand before grabbing her phone off the bed.

Six minutes, thirty eight seconds.

The doorbell rang – she locked the screen of her phone and shoved it in her pocket, making her way briskly down the apartment hallway and kicking her boots out of the way and to the side as she stormed past. She hadn't even reached the intercom when it buzzed again impatiently.

"Fuck's sake," she muttered to herself, straightening her shoulders as she pressed down on the keypad to open up the entrance

doors. She never used to swear this much.

Adora pulled her phone out of her pocket to check the timings, wiping it down with an antiseptic wipe. She knew it wasn't long until she'd become the fourth wheel and she never really felt confident knowing what to do with herself in the group anymore. She called out to Catra, trying to ignore the niggling feeling that she was somehow scrambling to save moments that were just between the two of them.

"They're on their way up, love. You doing okay?"

A distant acknowledgment drifted out the bathroom. Adora nearly set off to check on her girlfriend properly but there was already a banging at the door beside her. Adora willed the tension out of her body and opened the door.

You've done it a million times. Game face on.

Bow and Glimmer stood on the other side, teeming with anxious anticipation, their coats and shoes already shucked off and in their hands - they were far too familiar with the house rules by now. She stepped back into the hallway, letting them into the apartment and accepting a group hug.

"How is she?" Glimmer's frosty, wind-swept bob tickled her neck as they broke apart. Adora took their coats from them and hung them up while they set their shoes by the wall. Adora straightened hers beside theirs as well, realising that Catra wouldn't be too impressed by the sloppiness of her Docs - and there was no way she wouldn't notice, even given the circumstances.

"Good, just having a quick shower. How are you guys doing?"

"Agh! I don't even know how to feel!" Glimmer spluttered, almost incomprehensibly. Bow grasped Glimmer's hand tightly. It was clear that emotions were running even higher than Adora had expected – given her work and her long friendship with them both, she had no idea why she hadn't foreseen it.

A low cry of pain tore down the hall. Bow and Glimmer's heads shot up, their eyes darting over to the half-open door. Adora rushed down the hallway, double-checking her phone again in disbelief.

Barely eight minutes?

Adora tried to hide her concern as she slipped through the door, gently closing the opening to give Catra some privacy. She glanced back at Bow and Glimmer as she washed her hands again briskly – they'd followed so closely behind her it almost felt like a conga line.

"Let her get dressed, we'll be out in a minute."

Adora could see that Glimmer was about to object but Bow had squeezed her fingers again and she'd slunk back into his side, biting her lip.

Adora leaned over Catra to turn the shower off and crouched in front of her. She rested her hands on top of Catra's, whose fingernails dug into her knees as heavy vibrations started to tail off from the back of her throat.

Adora lifted Catra's knuckles towards her as the contraction ended, pressing her lips softly to them as the muscles in her girlfriend's fingers started to relax. She ignored the tiny crescent bruises peppered across Catra's legs that she'd somehow missed earlier. Catra winced slightly as her other hand brushed over the purpling indents. Adora knew better than to bring up the fact that she'd told her over and over again not to bother getting her gel extensions redone this week.

"How are they this strong already?" Catra struggled to regain her breath control for a second, the words falling out jaggedly.

Adora stroked Catra's knuckle with her thumb.

"I suspect that might be because they're a lot closer together than 20 minutes, huh?" Adora whispered quietly, not wanting to give

her eager friends outside any ammunition to rush in. “They’re lasting longer as well?”

Catra gave Adora a guilty smile as she watched her reset the stopwatch – she knew she’d been rumbled. Adora placed a hand on the side of Catra’s belly, reaching up to meet her lips to let her know she was still on her side.

“Adora…” Catra’s voice faltered, dipping to barely audible. “I tried to feel it before, but… can you check how dilated I am?”

Adora nodded, kissing her again briefly and crouching back onto her heels.

“Wait!” A voice rang out through the door – Adora’s eyes flashed back up to meet Catra’s mismatched ones. Glimmer hesitated, and they could almost hear her nervousness fizzle through the air. “Could I maybe do that?”

How could she possibly hear us?

Adora sighed, eyes narrowing as she dropped Catra’s gaze and rallied herself to let her friend down gently.

“Glim-“

But Catra’s voice rang out over hers before she could even start.

“Of course, Glimmer. Just give me a sec, yeah?”

“You sure?” Adora forgot to stay quiet, utterly failing to hide her surprise.

I am the expert here, remember?

“It’s her kid, babe.”

Catra's real point remained unspoken - *how else am I supposed to help her feel a part of this?*

Adora gulped. “I know.”

Catra squeezed her fingers. “I know you do.” She paused for a second. “Can you…?” She gestured over to the towel rack.

Adora knew this was the closest Catra ever got to explicitly asking for help. She pushed herself off the floor and swiped the towel off the rack, gently wrapping it around Catra’s shoulders so she could dry the water off her upper half herself. Adora plucked out a smaller hand towel and started on Catra’s legs, knowing she would hate to admit that she couldn't bend over to do it herself. When they were done, Adora stood up again to dump Catra’s used towels in their laundry hamper – *damn, it was getting full quickly* – and fished Catra’s oversized Nirvana t-shirt off the hook where she’d left it, tossing it over to her.

Adora paused, watching Catra jerk it over her head and twist her damp curls into a ponytail. She leaned over without question, pulling the hair band out her own hair to pass it over to Catra. Catra smiled at her, taking the band and biting it between her teeth as she finished gathering her hair up, nodding her head towards the door.

Adora cleared her throat, pulling on the doorknob.

“Let me get out the way so you have some space, hmm? The gloves are under the sink.”

Glimmer’s eyes caught hers, crinkling at the edges with gratitude. Bow pulled Adora in for another hug as she joined him in the hallway and she exhaled forcefully in relief while she listened out for the sound of water running and soap squidging between fingers. It had been a long time since she and Bow had a moment alone – and she knew that was mainly her fault. She berated herself for all of it: becoming so distant; visibly zoning out of all the baby conversations; the overwhelming protectiveness over Catra she felt powerless to resist.

As the feeling of Bow’s arms squeezing her torso grounded her, Adora balked at how she could almost burst with the love and admiration that her girlfriend could do something so incredible for

their dearest friends, while being simultaneously driven mad by the crushing feeling that even though she'd agreed to it multiple times over, nothing about this situation felt fair at all. *When on earth did Catra become the level-headed one between the two of us?*

A loud, sharp laugh jolted Adora out of her thoughts – she and Bow stepped back, their heads cocked in question towards the open bathroom door.

"Do you really have a tattoo of a fucking VIKING SWORD on your bikini line, Catra?!"

Adora blushed in crimson as she stepped back from Bow, knowing what would come next.

"Psshht, Sparkles. I only got it cos Adora insisted I match hers."

Adora cringed before Glimmer's cackle even started.

"Oh my God! This is the best day ever."

Catra snorted. "If that's all I needed to do to cheer you up, you could've told me a hell of a lot sooner."

Adora didn't wait to hear the rest of it.

She made her way into their living room, beckoning Bow to follow her to the couch as Melog jumped onto her lap.

"Mind if I put these in the fridge?"

Adora glanced up at Bow, eyebrows arching at the six pack of Amundsen Brewery in his hand. It was Catra's absolute favourite craft brand, which to her distress was almost impossible to hunt down.

"I thought it might be good for you guys at some point."

Adora smiled at him, nudging her head towards the refrigerator behind Bow in their open plan kitchen-lounge. She'd forgotten how thoughtful he could be sometimes.

"You must have good contacts in the Norwegian black market to get your hands on them."

Bow swung the fridge door shut and collapsed next to Adora on the sofa.

"Something like that," he smirked. "How's everyone's favourite OBGYN?"

Adora blinked at Bow in surprise. She thought back to what Catra implied earlier.

"Oh, don't worry about me – this is your moment, Bow. You guys have waited so long for this! After everything Glimmer's dealt with… she deserves to have all the focus on her."

Bow hesitated for a moment, reaching over to stroke the end of Melog's tail. Adora knew she'd brought up the sore point they usually avoided at length. She could see him formulating some kind of response in his mind and Adora really didn't want to know where this could go next. She decided to steer the conversation in a different direction before it got too emotional, too much to bear.

"I'm just gonna wait here until we inevitably find out that I actually do have to go in there and examine Catra properly, " Adora wiggled her phone in front of Bow, stopwatch still on display, "cause if all these years on wards has taught me anything, it's that we'll have to be on our way in to hospital sooner than she'd like to think."

Chapter End Notes

Next up, we'll get closer to how this whole arrangement came together...

Chapter 3

EIGHT YEARS PRIOR

Glimmer's eyes narrowed as she stared Adora down, gripping a 7kg dumbbell in each hand.

"Don't even try it, Adora."

She pushed past her friend, settling on the edge of the closest bench and rolling her shoulder blades back, knitting her muscles together in the centre of her upper back. She brought her arms up simultaneously, purposefully watching her form in the mirror opposite to avoid Adora's eye contact.

"Whoa, don't you usually go down a couple of kilograms for this one?"

Glimmer set her jaw in stone as she glared straight ahead, lowering the weights steadily to her shoulders.

If Adora ticks me off one more time…

She drove her arms above her head for the fourth time, her elbows wobbling more than they should. Maybe she should have stuck to her usual 5kg after all.

"I didn't realise you were coming along today to discuss my personal training plan." Glimmer practically spat her words out.

Adora shifted from foot to foot anxiously, pursing her lips as she watched her friend carry on with the set, clearly ready to jump in at any minute lest Glimmer's arms give in.

"Look Glim, I just… I'm not sure how to explain it."

"You could start with: 'I'm sorry I didn't listen to you and now you're in deep shit thanks to my little friend.'" Glimmer grunted as she spoke, straining to get the last couple of reps done. "Who, by the way, was *clearly* never going to stick around."

Now it was Adora's turn to bristle.

"I've told you, Glimmer. There's something else going on with her, and I don't know what it is but-"

Glimmer screeched in irritation, finally giving up on her set and resting the dumbbells on her thighs.

"I'll tell you what's going on – she's a fucking drug addict and a thief, and she *wants* to be left alone with that gross guy, ok?" Glimmer forged ahead, ignoring the twinge of hurt she saw in Adora eyes. "I should never have let you have your way."

"Have my way? Are you freaking kidding me?" Adora scoffed as Glimmer scowled at her in the mirror, "This coming from boss bitch of the century!"

"Was that supposed to be an insult?"

Adora hesitated, biting her lip. "Yes…?"

Glimmer flared her nostrils.

"Well, I'm not going to be a boss bitch much longer now that I'm about to lose my job. I could press charges!"

Adora wrung her wrists guiltily, her entire demeanour deflating.

"I'm really sorry, Glim. I don't know what else I can do."

Glimmer turned round to look Adora straight in the eye.

"Stop looking for her. She doesn't want you to fix her."

"What?"

Glimmer paused. She didn't like the change in dynamics that had upturned their nice, safe little apartment the minute that Adora's old school friend turned up. It had brought up so many uncomfortable feelings, pangs of jealousy she thought she'd grown out of in her teens. But it had hurt, suddenly playing second string in her most important friendship.

What's so special about this girl anyway?

Glimmer got up from the bench, passing Adora again to haul her dumbbells back to the rack. She knew this conversation would go far better if she could just calm down – the whole situation was unmistakably rough on her friend - but when something *really* got under Glimmer's skin, any attempt at controlling her mounting emotions felt futile.

Glimmer turned around to face Adora front-on, ignoring the disgruntled looks they were attracting from the gym-goers around them.

"It's one thing finding an old friend in a dodgy bar and inviting them home for a quick drink, but I didn't sign up for running Adora Gray's rescue/rehab program."

Adora was more self-conscious – her voice came out in a strangled whisper as she stepped closer towards Glimmer, the tips of her ears reddening.

"I didn't have a choice! What was I supposed to do?"

Glimmer let out a short, sharp bark of laughter. Adora's outrageous sense of obligation frequently drove her round the bend.

"Have a little chat about 'the good old days' like you pretend you give a shit and fuck off like everyone else on the planet!"

Adora looked completely dumbfounded.

"If this whole situation can drum anything into you, it's that nine out of ten people do not want a saviour."

Adora seemed like she was about to cry, her eyes focused a little too intensely on the mottled rubber floor. Glimmer shoved her earphones in, realising she might have pushed Adora too far. It had been a tough enough week as it was.

"Just… next time you want to bring strays off the street home, you better do a bloody risk assessment."

SIX YEARS PRIOR

"Double chocolate or peanut butter?"

Adora held up two bags of homemade cookies excitedly in front of Glimmer, practically jumping onto the couch beside her.

"That's a really stupid question, Adora," Glimmer took the bag of peanut butter cookies from Adora, zipping open the plastic seal, "Haven't I taught you better by now?"

Adora laughed, pressing play on the TV remote and opening the bag she held as well.

"Fuck me," Glimmer's mouth fell open, half a chewed cookie on display, "these are *really* good." She licked her lips, chewing further. "Like no offence, but when you baked at our old place, I could never tell if it was meant to be edible."

"Hey!" Adora shoved Glimmer playfully, "What about my lemon meringue pie? You even took that home to your mum!"

"Yeah, so I could throw it away without upsetting you."

Glimmer giggled, dodging the slap Adora aimed at her shoulder and sneaking a chocolate cookie out the bag her friend was holding.

"Seriously though, what gives? Tell me you're not auditioning for Bake Off…" Adora rolled her eyes – it was a long-time inside joke that she was too competitive for her boots and would spend an unreasonable number of hours honing a skill if she found a competition she thought she'd have a shot at. "You'd prob get on with these though. Damn, girl."

Adora cleared her throat nervously.

"Catra kind of made them, actually." Glimmer's nose twitched, her grip on the bag of cookies loosening, "it's really sweet of her, was all her own idea. She was going to give them to Bow for you tonight but when I said I was coming over anyway-"

"I don't get why they're hanging out."

Adora took a second to take a sip of tea. She kicked herself mentally for slipping; she knew that Catra and Bow's growing friendship wasn't good conversation fodder with Glimmer. And the point of this whole evening was to keep Glimmer's mood *up*, not to drag it back down to bottom again.

"I think they both just like having someone who appreciates a good craft ale."

The first time Catra mentioned she'd bumped into Bow picking up beers from a nearby microbrewery she rated, Adora hadn't thought much of it. But over the past few months, Bow and Catra had met on an almost weekly basis, checking out the pick of the week at a local bar or even driving out to meet a local brewer. She'd been so relieved to see Catra start to build a network outside of just her – after all, Catra had had to start from zero since that one fateful night, her entire life turned upside down in

mere hours. It was one of those things that left a permanent break in the timeline of your life: before Prime and after.

By now, it had been nine months since Catra cautiously agreed to stay with Adora for a couple of weeks while she got back on her feet. But Adora always found an excuse to convince Catra to stay: *there's no point paying rent in Bright Moon, it's extortionate round here*; *the spare room's just gonna sit empty otherwise; who'll stop me from eating crap every time I get home from a night shift?*

The real reason hung silently in the air around them: Adora was petrified Catra would go off the grid again. She couldn't take another two or three years of wondering every day whether she was alive or dead in a ditch.

Yet since Catra started hanging out with Bow, she'd started to open up, relax. She'd even reached out to a few old friends that Adora remembered vaguely from university – Scorpia, who had been her first year roommate, and her digital engineering classmate Entrapta, with whom Catra had always seemed to be coming up with some hair-brained tech idea that Adora never even attempted to try and understand. By some kind of magic, Adora didn't feel so much like they were tiptoeing around each other in her small apartment, though she'd started to grow self-conscious at the odd time she'd caught Catra watching her studiously, her eyes flicking away as soon as she caught her, dark curls falling across her face conveniently.

Glimmer's sharp inhale jerked Adora out of her thoughts.

"I thought drug addicts were supposed to avoid alcohol."

Adora sniffed in response.

"She's not an addict. You know that test was just in the terms of her immunity deal."

Glimmer raised an eyebrow. "If the shoe fits…"

"For God's sake, Glimmer! I know she's not your favourite person, but you know just as well as I do that Catra's been through more shit than any of us, and *you've* probably taken more drugs than she has!"

"More shit than any of us, eh?"

Adora gulped.

"Glim… I'm sorry, I was being stupid."

"Forget about it."

Glimmer wrinkled her nose and she turned towards the television, drawing her warm blanket tighter around her.

Adora rubbed at her forehead. She always managed to put her foot in. They sat in silence for a while longer, the colourful light from the TV casting shadows on her faces. Adora felt Glimmer shuffle beside her, stifling her sniffles.

She glanced over, edging closer to wipe the tears gently off Glimmer's face with the sleeve of her hoodie. Glimmer shifted, letting Adora curl into her side and grasp her hand. She spoke in such a tiny voice that Adora could barely hear her.

"I just don't like the idea that this insanely hot, mysterious crim girl is spending so much time with my fiancé."

Adora shushed her, ignoring the partial jibe. "Come on, Glim, Bow would never."

Besides, I'm not entirely sure anymore that Catra is even straight. Or is that just wishful thinking?

"He should. Why would anyone even want to be with me now?"

Adora squeezed their fingers together even tighter.

"Anyone would be beyond lucky to be with you. Besides, you have options. And I can set up a referral for you if or whenever you're ready."

She heard Glimmer cough, suppressing a sob.

It had been strange timing, only a couple of weeks after Catra had come back into her life. She'd just changed out of her scrubs, freeing her hair from the tight bun it had been tied up in all afternoon in surgery. She was only in her second year of specialised obs and gynae work, and that day she'd had to assist on a pretty complicated case. All Adora had wanted was to collapse on the sofa with Catra and watch some of the old cartoons they liked as kids (that is, if Catra would go along with it).

She'd pushed through the staff locker room door, swinging her rucksack over her shoulder, only to find Bow sitting in the waiting room with his head in his hands.

"Bow? What are you doing here?"

He'd looked up, the worry evident in wrinkles that seemed to have appeared out of nowhere on his face.

"They took her into surgery."

Adora's stomach had flipped in the worst possible way. She'd dropped into the seat next to Bow, a reassuring hand – for her or for him, she wasn't sure – placed on his back. She'd known better than to ask questions; he'd talk when he was ready.

"I didn't even know she was pregnant."

Pregnant? Adora had been pretty sure Glimmer couldn't have known either – surely she'd have said something? They'd gone out for dinner just two nights before.

Some time later, Adora had told Bow she'd get them some of the good coffee from the staff room. She'd known it wasn't a good

idea but she couldn’t stop herself from checking out the theatre boards on her way, scouring it desperately until she found Glimmer's name.

Theatre 4 – emergency hysterectomy.

Adora had wanted so badly to read Glimmer’s full medical notes – she had access after all – but she’d forced herself to go and make the coffee, willing her hands to stop shaking as hot liquid slipped over the rims of the mugs as she carried them back to the waiting room.

She'd waited until Glimmer had been discharged to press for the full story.

Catra had insisted Adora go and stay with them for a few days, assuring her that she’d cope alone in the apartment even if her nightmares kept her up (as if there were any chance that they wouldn’t). It hadn’t sat well with Adora to leave her alone, but the facts were clear as day: she had to learn to trust Catra, and it had certainly made both Bow and herself feel better knowing there was a qualified doctor around to watch over Glimmer.

It had been odd to hear medical terminology come out of Glimmer’s mouth – the words had sounded strange, made-up somehow in her voice.

Ruptured intramural ectopic pregnancy.

Just as Adora suspected, Glimmer hadn’t a clue she was nine weeks along; she’d only gone to the hospital for a routine cervical smear. And to make it worse, they'd discovered a tumour on her left ovary during her six-month post-surgical follow up.

Nestled into Glimmer on the sofa, Adora leaned forward to turn down the sound on the TV. Even with all her training, Adora still didn’t always know what to say. But then again, it was different when the patient was a person you loved.

She tugged on Glimmer's hand, prompting her to turn her face so their eyes could meet.

"I don't know what the future holds, Glimmer, but I promise – if there's anyone who has the strength and determination to go after what they want, it's you… And you know I'd do anything I could to help."

ONE YEAR PRIOR

Adora practically slammed the front door behind her, not really processing the effects of bewilderment spreading across her body.

Catra didn't even turn back to look, she just hung her coat up wearily and wandered into the lounge, her hand snaking through her hair.

Adora didn't know what was going on with her. She followed Catra, finding her pulling two beers out of the fridge, tapping the caps off on the edge of the kitchen counter. Adora didn't usually drink the night before a long shift but she really needed something to take the edge off, stat.

"Where on earth did that come from, Catra?"

They'd just been out for dinner with Bow and Glimmer – it had only taken five years of Catra staying in Bright Moon and four years of them dating for Glimmer to finally accept her fully into their group – and their friends had disclosed that they'd decided to find a surrogate to carry the embryos they'd frozen before Glimmer's first round of cancer treatment.

Adora had been about to congratulate them; her mind was already brimming with excitement, a million ideas erupting in her head about how she could advise them on what the process might be like when it came to hospital visits and the birth, or protections they might want to put in place based on the experience of families she'd treated. But Catra had surprised them all before Adora had even begun to open her mouth.

"Let me do it for you."

Needless to say, no one had really known what to say for the rest of dinner.

Adora set her phone down on the counter and took the beer from Catra, one eye trained beadily on her girlfriend as she took her first swig.

Catra stayed quiet for a minute. She opened her mouth to speak just as Adora's phone began to buzz, Glimmer's photo flashing on the screen.

"Take it."

Adora set her beer down as Catra turned around to lean her lower back on the edge of the counter, facing away from Adora while she nursed her own bottle.

Adora swiped her phone and made her way into Catra's home office, accepting the call as soon as she shut the door behind her.

"A-Adora?"

She couldn't think of a time when Glimmer had spoken to her with such trepidation.

"Long time, no speak, Glim."

She heard Glimmer inhale sharply. A few minutes of small talk, before Glimmer couldn't bear it any longer and got straight to it.

"Is she being serious?"

"I don't know. We just got home."

"Right." Another pause. "Sorry."

Adora leaned back in Catra's desk chair, her phone balanced precariously between her ear and the curve of her shoulder while she massaged her temples with both hands. She was about to make her apologies and hang up when Glimmer dropped her next question.

"Would you be okay with it?"

It wasn't so much that Adora didn't know what to say to Glimmer as much as her thoughts had gone completely and utterly blank.

<u>Am</u> I okay with this?

Almost every instinct in Adora's body was screaming at her to say no, but she couldn't shake the memory in her head. She'd promised Glimmer, multiple times over, that she'd always be there for her, that she'd do whatever she could to help when the time came.

She let out a deep breath.

"I need to talk to her."

"Yeah," *How could she fit so much disappointment into one syllable?* "Of course you do."

"Speak soon, okay?"

Adora hung up before Glimmer even had time to say her goodbyes. She turned her phone off, leaving it on Catra's desk before returning to the living room. Catra was sprawled on the sofa, her feet on the coffee table next to Adora's beer, which she'd brought over for her.

“So.”

“So.” Catra echoed Adora’s speech.

She swung her feet off the coffee table and stretched out on the sofa, passing Adora her beer before laying her head down on her girlfriend’s lap. Adora ran her hand through Catra’s hair, twisting ringlets around her fingers.

“Did you mean it?”

A short silence.

“Yeah. Like, I need some more time to think about it properly – and obviously, we need to…” Catra’s voice tailed off as she swayed her fingers back and forth between them, “It has to be a decision we make together. But I just… I really feel like it would be something so *good*, you know?”

Adora could hear the subtext clear as day. *I could be something so good.*

“Hmm. It would be.”

They sat like that for a while in the quiet, processing their thoughts individually. Eventually Catra spoke up.

“What’s going on in that dumb old head of yours? You’re usually Miss External Processor #1.”

Adora sighed, nudging Catra to lie prone on her lap, their eyes staring straight into one another’s.

“It would be the most incredible thing you could do for them, love.”

Adora hesitated, and Catra noticed.

“Be honest.”

“It’s just…” Catra waited patiently for Adora to gather her thoughts. She tried to put the words together diplomatically, but in the end they fell out in one big heap. “I can’t help but feel like this is some kind of redemption thing for you.”

“Adora-“

“You've spent so much time trying to prove how good you are over the years that you've forgotten how to stop. But fuck me, Catra, you are so incredibly *good*."

Catra’s eyes shimmered for a second before she blinked her emotions back, bringing a hand up to caress Adora’s cheek.

"Is that a compliment or a command?"

Catra let out an almighty cackle as Adora rolled her eyes to the heavens. She slapped Catra’s hand away from her cheek playfully.

"Sometimes I have no idea what I did to deserve your nasty self.”

Catra raised herself up, closing the gap between them and teasing Adora’s bottom lip between her teeth lightly.

“Hmm, me neither.”

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

Back into Catra's psyche now, as well as some further exploration of Adora's POV!

DAY ZERO

"Fuck, I'm go-"

Catra gagged, the dry heave jolting her entire body. She felt a cool hand settle on her upper arm just as she jerked over again; thankfully someone had shoved a cardboard bedpan into her hands just in time. Catra panted, wiping acrid dregs off her lips with the back of her hand.

"This is normal, right?"

She groaned internally at Glimmer's question, which she seemed committed to repeating on a far-too frequent basis for Catra's liking. She let her aching body fall back against the scratchy pillows, her nose wrinkling at the stagnant smell of antiseptic and sour vomit. She'd hoped that it would fade as she got used to it, but three hours in, it was just as strong as when they'd arrived.

She closed her eyes, just as the next band of pain began to tighten around her. So far, she'd largely avoided being on her back during contractions – they were much easier to deal with when she was upright or on all fours. *Just my luck.*

They'd started coming every few minutes now, and each one seemed to sap her energy even further than the one before. Her limbs were limp and shaky beyond belief – she could bet money on the odds that she'd faint when this one was over.

All she wanted to do was collapse, give into the ugly tears she'd been trying so hard to hold back, and curl up in her and Adora's bed back home; be anywhere but here, anywhere away from the horrific pressure of delivering this child safely to its parents.

She scolded herself for thinking this bit would be so simple – sure, she didn't expect it to be all shits and giggles, but *my God,* she was so hyperaware of every reaction Bow and Glimmer had to her labour. And even though she knew her friends would be distraught if they had any idea, Catra almost felt like she was a lab rat in a cage, being prodded and poked and monitored to ensure she met her objectives.

Staying strong for them – making sure that they didn't see her tremble, that they knew that she *had* this, that she wouldn't let them down – was taking a toll on her she hadn't foreseen. She'd let Glimmer rub lemon oil into the soft skin of her wrists, along her jawline and on her temples. She sipped water every time Bow prompted, even managing a grateful smile to encourage him. She even agreed *with enthusiasm* to the ridiculous playlist the two of them had created.

But worst of all – even worse than the exasperating flute meditation music that was currently ruining her day – was the fact that Adora wasn't even here.

Her girlfriend had excused herself, citing that it would be best to give Bow and Glimmer some space while she looked for something Catra could eat to keep her strength up. Somehow, she'd been gone for over an hour, and Catra could feel the incessant pressure of the head moving lower and lower, stronger and stronger, and she'd so much rather Adora be here when the time to push came – it wouldn't be long, she could just *tell* – than the infuriating locum who kept referring to her as the mother.

All it took was a few minutes of letting herself wonder *where the hell Adora could possibly be* for her mental resolve to come crashing down.

What if something goes wrong and Adora isn't here and the last time she ever sees me is when I'm throwing up all over myself with my vag on display, and she has to spend the rest of her life alone and every time she sees Glimmer and Bow and the kid (shit, if it even survives), it reminds her of how I just had *to do this and it'll be my fault she's miserable and she'll probably throw herself too far into work and one day, she'll have exhausted herself so much that she doesn't look before she crosses the street-*

"Hey," *Who the fuck is that?* "Hey… Catra!"

She blinked, coming back into herself, her chest heaving erratically. She could barely catch her breath.

She couldn't see anything but Bow right in front of her, their eyes level, his palms firmly framing Catra's face.

"I'm gonna take a deep breath in and out and you're going to do it with me, okay?" Bow stilled, about to draw a breath, "In, 1, 2, 3…"

"W-w-where is she?"

"Catra. You're hyperventilating. I need you to focus on-"

"I-I- can't…" *I can't do this without her.*

Catra bit back her words. She couldn't let it slip, couldn't risk revealing that she'd taken this whole thing too far; that she was completely consumed with a terrible dread that she actually wasn't strong enough to do this. She was a total fraud, and it was only a matter of time before she disappointed everyone, just like always.

She couldn't keep up eye contact with Bow any longer – the beginnings of another contraction were already creeping up on her, guttural wails falling uncontrollably from her throat, and Catra couldn't imagine that she'd possibly survive it.

"We've got you, I promise. But right now, you need to breathe with me, ok?"

Adora walked back and forth between the aisles again – anyone watching the CCTV footage would think she had gone clinically insane.

She'd picked up and put back a bunch of bananas on loop, and was trapped in the same indecisive cycle with apples, rice cakes and chocolate bars too. Her basket could have been in a video game, resetting to zero every time she failed to complete the level.

Adora was under no illusions: this was extreme procrastination, and the longer she failed to put an end to it, the more her rising guilt threatened to drown her.

The mistake was lack of a game plan.

Adora had always had a reputation for planning ahead for as long as she could remember. Even in her earliest memories, she recalled being told that she was worrying too much in advance; that it was a waste of time to fret over things that weren't even happening yet. The irony was that she was by far the most impulsive out of her friend group. Not in the way that most people were – she'd never gone on a last-minute holiday or splurged on a big purchase without talking it through with as many people she could find who would listen. But Adora *did* have her own unique brand of spontaneity. She'd get a burning feeling right in the pit of her stomach that she had to get her hair cut *now*, write off her entire schedule for the day so she could speak to a specific person that very minute, or redo an entire menu barely minutes before dinner guests arrived (and after Catra had bought groceries – much to her irritation). Adora could just tell when something was

wrong or had to be done differently. And she was terrified to admit that she'd carried that instinct around ever since the embryo took.

It had been a battle of mind vs body she couldn't share with anyone, and she'd never felt shame like it.

Enough is enough.

She picked up the damn bananas and took them straight to checkout, ignoring the nagging in her brain that she'd made the wrong choice, that there was something better, something *right* she was meant to buy instead.

She started to make her way back to the maternity ward, weaving through busy streets and hospital corridors. The one thing she could be grateful for was that she knew this route like the back of her own hand, and even out-of-hours her body could take her to where she should be before her brain could kick in and re-route her.

It wasn't until she was facing the door to the room they'd put Catra in, her fingers already on the metal handle, that Adora completely froze. She heard the agonizing of labouring women on a near-daily basis, but she'd only ever heard this sound once before, a full twenty years ago: Catra in pure emotional torture, sobs bleeding through the heavy door.

Her phone buzzed in her pocket continuously, her WiFi finally reconnecting to the staff network on the ward. She practically ripped it out of her pocket, her eyes widening in horror as she caught the time. She'd been gone for nearly an hour and a half.

What the fuck was I doing?

And just like that, the beast of growing self-loathing that had stalked the edges of her sub-conscious over recent weeks made its kill.

TWELVE WEEKS PRIOR

"Can you help me with Glim's update thing?"

Catra blocked Adora's view of the TV, a tape measure spilling out of her palm, right hip cocked.

Adora paused the game and leaned forward from her sprawl on the couch, pinching the bridge of her nose between her fingers before holding her hand out for the tape measure. Catra came closer, rolling her eyes.

"Jeez, way to go with the enthusiasm."

Adora pulled Catra's hand towards her, forcing Catra's knees to bump against the edge of the sofa.

"Whoa, 'Dor!"

Adora pulled Catra down gently so that she kneeled aside her thighs, bum resting on Adora's lap.

"I'm too big for this."

"You're not." Catra frowned, and Adora tipped her chin down with her fingers so they were forced to look directly into one another's eyes, mismatched blue and amber irises meeting grey. "Look, there's plenty of room here. We're all good."

Adora willed Catra to hear the deeper meaning in her words – the past week had been tense, though neither of them acknowledged it.

Last weekend, Catra had gone to Glimmer and Bow's place while Adora was on shift, and they'd ended up discussing the birth plan.

Adora had been exhausted when she'd gotten home after a 14-hour stint, crashing into bed at 1am. Yet Catra was still awake, and she curled as best as she could into Adora's side and murmured that Bow and Glimmer had insisted that Adora should be with them at the birth if that's what the two of them wanted – they'd affirmed over and over again how important both Adora and Catra would be in their child's life. Adora was too tired to mask her reaction (though in all honesty, she'd avoided thinking properly about what her role in the birth would look like), but even just the slight stiffening of her body set off a weighty conversation so completely inconvenient in the inky darkness. Adora shouldn't have been surprised. Catra had always been able to read every one of her imperceptible twitches as if they'd been amplified through a lab-grade microscope.

They'd gone round and round in circles: Catra trying to get Adora to talk about how she wanted to be involved; Adora trying to coax Catra into sharing her real wishes instead of echoing Bow and Glimmer's preferences. Since they got together, Catra had worked at voicing what she actually wanted. But over the course of this surrogacy, Adora had noticed her slipping, increasingly hiding her desires behind a wall of carefully crafted indifference. By 3am they were still at it, Adora barely able to keep her eyes open even as she could feel the baby kicking into her side faintly through the firmness of Catra's belly. Eventually Adora had cracked, not bothering to hide her exhausted frustration at Catra's total opaqueness, leaving their bed to seek uninterrupted sleep on the futon in the home office. It wasn't long until Catra was kneeled beside her, grasping desperately at Adora's hands, panic oozing out of every pore. And just as instinct had always served her, Adora had known exactly what she needed to do. She'd led her girlfriend back to bed, wrapped her arms around her as far as she could and promised to stay as long as Catra wanted her – whether it be in their bed, the birthing room or otherwise. Adora knew staying was the single most important thing, central to the promises they'd broken, healed and depended upon over the decades.

Since then, Adora had been mentally stuck on how to resist the overwhelming urge to barricade Catra and herself in their apartment forever, to ignore this pregnancy, go back to a moment in time with no complications. Sometimes it helped to imagine the warm spread of happiness flow through her body when Glimmer and Bow's child was finally born and united with its parents. But no matter how proud or bittersweet Adora felt about it, well, it all just felt a little too *familiar.*

Adora had spent enough time in therapy to know she'd built an entire identity around being the selfless one – never a shift too late, a patient too demanding, a friend too difficult if it meant helping someone through something. Until recently, that had always felt like such a positive thing.

It wasn't that Adora didn't crave the surety that would allow her to truly be there for Bow and Glimmer. She wanted so badly to help them get the happy ending they deserved. But standing on the side-lines while Catra made the ultimate sacrifice of time and body, as she displayed a strength and stoicism that Adora couldn't ever imagine matching, made her feel so… *insignificant*. If Catra – who Glimmer had alienated and criticized for years – could put herself through all of this for Adora's best friends and she could barely even witness it, what did that say about her?

Adora knew her behaviour had been completely off the whole week – she'd sensed Catra studying her, reminding Adora not to forget her keys again, or that they'd pre-ordered from the good pizza place for dinner and to *please* not buy groceries they already had on her way home yet another time*.*

Even now, Adora could sense Catra's uncertainty. She craned up to meet her lips, drinking in Catra's scent, fixing her fingers at the back of Catra's head and stretching her other hand out to rest on her hip.

"It won't bite, you know."

Adora thought she'd done a better job of hiding her efforts to evade the bump. When Catra's stomach first started to harden, she revelled at every ghosted touch, even joining Glimmer in spreading her palms out firmly across Catra's increasingly taut belly, laughing at the soft nudges pushing back at them. But in the past few days, it had started to sour – a constant reminder that this was not and would never be her and Catra's child. She decided to play it down, letting out a breezy (or so she hoped) laugh.

"Just making sure you're comfortable," she kissed Catra again, deeper this time, "besides, isn't this the *enthusiasm* you were looking for?"

Catra pecked her on the lips playfully. Adora got the feeling she was letting it drop – she knew Catra wasn't fooled in the slightest.

"Cute. Now, are you gonna help me out with this or not?"

Adora stole one last kiss before helping Catra up, finally taking the tape measure from her hand as Catra hitched up her shirt. Adora got to work dutifully, stretching the tape from Catra's pubic bone all the way up to the top of her curved stomach.

"27cm, just a little below average." Adora hummed as Catra texted Glimmer, "maybe don't tell her that though?"

Catra snorted.

"As if. This ain't my first time round the rodeo, babe." She held her phone up as it chimed repeatedly, "aaand… Glimmer says that's a little below average for 29 weeks and can you please let her know if that's ok?"

Adora rolled her eyes, her own phone now chiming with message notifications as well.

"Oh," Catra laughed out loud, "She says the baby is an acorn squash now. Sometimes I wonder if I'm growing her a child or a vegetable patch."

“You haven’t got the patience for a vegetable patch.”

“True,” Catra shrugged, “at least I wouldn’t have to measure myself every week though… I feel like a marrow in the county fair!”

Adora hooked her arms around Catra’s neck.

“I’m sorry. Want me to talk to her?”

Catra paused, her energy deflating somewhat.

“Nah. It means a lot to her, and hey – only two months left.”

Adora cocked her head, “Ehhh… more like twelve wee-“

Catra placed a finger over her lips to shut her up.

“If you would like to stay a part of this relationship, I’d probably simmer down on that medical expertise.”

Adora ran an invisible zip across her lips.

“That’s more like it.” Catra shoved Adora back onto the sofa and settled back in her lap, dragging a pointed fingernail down the side of Adora’s neck. “Now, why don’t you carry on where you left off?”

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

Some time on the other side of the coin - a glimpse of Glimmer's perspective! Please feed my desperate need for external validation with comments :)

TEN MONTHS PRIOR

Glimmer winced as she ran cold water over her finger, wrapping it tightly in a paper towel to stem the blood.

“At least tell me this isn’t another avocado-related incident…”

Glimmer twisted round to watch Bow enter the kitchen, an easy smile spreading on her face as he reached on top of the fridge to retrieve the first aid kit.

“That was one time! And loads of people cut themselves chopping avos.”

The creases around Bow’s eyes crinkled as he chuckled under his breath, taking Glimmer’s hand in his and unwrapping it to inspect the damage.

“If you say so,” he cleansed the shallow cut across her index finger with an alcohol wipe and prepared a plaster to wrap around it, “but you really should be more careful.”

“I know,” she closed the distance between them, burrowing her face in Bow’s chest, “I’m just nervous.”

Glimmer sighed as Bow kissed the top of her head and she nuzzled into him further, his warmth settling her nerves for a split second. They stood there for a few minutes, the silence speaking volumes. Nervous was the understatement of the century.

It had been three months since they'd gone to the new Japanese restaurant that even the harshest food critics had been raving about with Catra and Adora. And true to form, the food had been excellent; even Glimmer didn't have any notes on what the chef could do to improve the food further. She just noted how fresh the fish tasted, how well the rice was seasoned – and she secretly loved how shocked the other three had been to hear her complete lack of criticism. She remembered how Bow squeezed her hand under the table when they'd begun to tell Adora and Catra that they were going to start looking for a surrogate. They would be the first friends she and Bow told, the first public step towards attempting to make their future family a reality.

The moment had weighed heavily on her mind for months leading up to that night. She and Bow had spent innumerable nights reading up on all the hoops they'd have to jump through to bring a child into the world; she couldn't be more grateful that they'd had embryos fertilised and frozen before they got married. Adora was to thank for that really – she'd encouraged Glimmer to think ahead, to imagine a time beyond the surgical recovery and the chemo when she might want the option to choose a different kind of life. So, the two of them had pooled their money before the wedding, foregoing the over-blown luxury honeymoon they'd meticulously saved for to secure a distant possibility for their future.

It shouldn't have been so hard to start talking about it outside the four walls of their home. But both Bow and Glimmer had struggled to overcome the lofty expectations of their parents, and they equally feared that this entire fertility journey could just be setting themselves up for failure. It had occurred to both of them to keep it under wraps until they'd gotten further through the process. Still, Bow had insisted that Adora and Catra would only ever be supportive, and it was easy for Glimmer to agree that they'd feel so much better with others to lean on – even if it was just to weather the disappointments.

Glimmer's heart jumped every time she replayed the memory of Catra's response.

Let me do it for you.

Sometimes she thought about it so often – the simple determination on Catra's face, the surprise registered on Adora's – that it blurred in her memory and she couldn't quite believe it had even happened. But she'd never forget how Bow's thigh had bumped against hers, his breath catching in his throat.

Was she really being serious about this?

The following weeks had been torture. Caught between the desperate hope that Catra might actually be willing to help them and the worry that even the idea of her carrying their child could lead to the messiest web of emotional dynamics, it took everything Glimmer had not to march right over to Catra and Adora's apartment and demand they put her out of her misery. Couldn't they just let her know sooner rather than later that Catra's offer had just been a spur of the moment retort, that it was simply too much?

We'd never expect you to do something like this for us – Glimmer had rehearsed her speech in her head like a broken record – *please, please don't feel like you have to.*

Glimmer had steeled herself for the let-down, but it never came. Even now, she could feel the ghosts of Catra's hands wrapped round her own across the table and see the shadow of Adora's palm laid atop Bow's on the rich wood.

We want to do this for you. You deserve this more than anyone.

All four of them had cried, arms clasped around each-other. Who would have thought life would lead them down this path?

The thorny process of contracts, legal mediation and medical consultations had kicked off soon after. And today was the day.

Glimmer stepped back from Bow, nudging her head towards the chopping board.

"Can you finish the salsa? I'll be right back."

Glimmer shrugged off her apron and made her way into the bathroom, locking the door behind her. She stared at herself in the mirror, examining her make-up. She'd applied a flick of eyeliner on her lids, not so dissimilar to the way Catra did hers. It gave her pause to think. *Am I doing this to make her like me?*

She'd thought a lot about their relationship these past weeks. It was no secret that they'd gotten off to a rocky start: Glimmer had bristled when Adora first brought her to their tiny shared apartment, and for years after Catra had settled in Bright Moon post-Prime, she hadn't gotten much friendlier. Their mutual animosity had faded drastically, for sure. But Glimmer still carried shame over the way she'd reacted to Bow and Catra's friendship – it had become increasingly significant to both of them over the years – and she greatly regretted the resistance she'd mounted towards bringing Catra into their group (almost as much as the bitter insults the two of them had exchanged in their numerous verbal sparring matches). Glimmer had come to realise that she and Catra were far more alike than either of them would have wanted to admit in the past; and given her own feelings towards Adora's girlfriend, she hoped to God that Catra's surrogacy wasn't guided by a similar longing to absolve herself of their volatile history.

Glimmer straightened up, locking her shoulders together and drawing her traps out the same way she always did when she needed to feel powerful. She'd slowly built her weight-lifting regime up again since her diagnoses and treatment, and it was probably the only thing that made her feel truly resilient. Resilience was something she'd need in buckets today.

Set in her superhero stance, Glimmer finally let her eyes drop down the bathroom counter. They'd bought three pregnancy tests – the most trusted and expensive ones, of course (Bow had insisted on it) – and they'd been taunting her all morning.

It was a strange feeling. She'd bought one six years ago but never got round to using it – she'd figured if she actually was pregnant, it would come up at her smear appointment. To be fair, she had been right about that. But now Glimmer was keenly aware that she'd never get to have that moment she assumed most mothers got – the intimacy of acknowledging another invisible person-to-be in the room, revelling in the awareness that she was the only person in the world who knew it. Having that sacred space for herself, even for just a few minutes before she'd tell Bow.

No point crying over spilt milk now, Glim.

She didn't want to let herself hope that Catra might actually be pregnant – what were the chances this could have possibly worked? She'd internalized the notion that she just wasn't a person to whom good things happened anymore. Getting sick hadn't just wrecked her physically – it had thrown her entire identity into the air like a twisted disc of pizza dough.

Battling her defeatist mindset had taken so much work. Yet now, Glimmer's heart soared every time she thought about the possibility that she might actually have a child, and the awe she felt for her friends – she was still coming to terms with the notion that she was loved this much, that they would want to do this for *her*. It astounded her on a near-hourly basis, a warmth that sustained itself even as she tried to manage her unwieldly hopefulness in favour of jarring realism.

Her ears picked up as she heard Bow greeting Adora and Catra at the door. She didn't know whether she wanted the result immediately or prolonged as long as possible. *Would knowing a negative result be worse than not knowing at all?* It was impossible to decide.

Glimmer exited the bathroom, greeting the couple with as much level-headedness as she could muster, leading them to the dining table full to the brim with painstakingly prepared fillets of seared tuna, complex salads, pineapple salsa, crushed avocado, three hand-whisked vinaigrettes, freshly-squeezed organic fruit juices…

she may have gone a little overboard. Their brunch passed in a mist of well-worn inside jokes, gossip and work anecdotes until Catra named the subject they'd all been tip-toeing around. She'd take the test (*okay, okay she'd take all three*), they'd know for sure, and could decide after whether they'd be drowning their sorrows over wine or partaking in a slice of celebratory cake.

The four of them gathered around the Tupperware box Bow had given Catra to put the sticks in.

These were the longest four minutes of Glimmer's life.

And then, just like that.

Pregnant.

It wasn't a guarantee, but it was a chance. And at this point in time, a chance was all that Glimmer wanted.

FIVE MONTHS PRIOR

"Oh my God, Catra, I can't listen to this anymore - it's really triggering!"

Catra snorted, her eyebrows raised high in the air.

"Dramatic much, Sparkles? I thought you'd *like* to hear how close I am to inbox zero."

She wiggled her phone in front of Glimmer's face, completely unfussed by the stares they were attracting from the women and couples around her.

"Ugh, I am literally drowning. I must have like six hundred flagged emails I was supposed to get to this week."

Catra let out a low whistle, ignoring the scowl of the receptionist.

"You gotta get yourself a better strategy."

"Strategy?"

"Yup. Little secret here, Sparks: there's a strategy in life for everything."

"Huh." Glimmer eyed Catra swiping fast on the screen of her smartphone, somehow going at breakneck speed despite her immaculate nails, "So you gonna let me in on it then?"

Catra tilted her head from side to side as if considering it.

"… Nah."

Glimmer gasped in mock outrage, shoving Catra's arm playfully.

"Hey – precious cargo here! Aren't you going to treat the *holy vessel of your chi*-"

Catra froze out of nowhere, her eyes immediately widening and locking onto Glimmer's.

"C-Catra?"

Glimmer's mind immediately ran through a million things that could be going wrong right that very minute – *it had to happen sooner or later, I knew getting so far into the second trimester wouldn't mean anything!* She craned her head around frantically, seeing if she could catch the attention of one of the nurses.

But Catra had grabbed her hand and pulled her halfway out her squeaking plastic chair, planting Glimmer's palm on the side of her protruding belly.

"Can you feel that?"

Glimmer's eyebrows furrowed in confusion, her eyes flickering back to Catra's. The way Catra looked at her with such intention, studying Glimmer's face for even the tiniest reaction, made the hair stand up on the back of her neck. She held Catra's gaze in silence for a short minute, the disappointment building in her chest as the realisation of what was happening dawned on her. She began to move her hand away, but Catra held on firmly, keeping it in place.

She can feel it, and I can't.

"I don't-"

Oh.

And there it was: barely there but unmistakeable. This time, Glimmer gasped for real.

"Is this the first…?"

Catra's eyes softened, her fingers folding around Glimmer's, still pressed flat against Catra's abdomen.

"I'd have told you, Glim." Catra brought her other hand over, squeezing Glimmer's with both. "Must be excited to see Mama again, right?"

Glimmer's heart felt like it swelled to double the size. She wrapped her arms around Catra, bringing her as close as she possibly could. She could sense Catra's surprise in the way she'd immediately gone rigid before slowly relaxing into Glimmer's embrace, her hands eventually resting on her back, kneading gentle strokes into her clothes. Glimmer squeezed her eyes shut, the faint rhythm of Catra's racing pulse reverberating into the skin of her shoulder. *How am I crying before we even get to the scan?*

"You're the most incredible person, you know that?"

Catra let out a nervous giggle. "Don't be silly…"

“I’m not.”

They held onto one another for a few moments more before letting go, their hands remaining intertwined between their seats as they waited for Catra’s name to be called out, the water bottle in her other hand getting emptier and emptier as their appointment time crept closer.

Halfway through the ultrasound, Glimmer realised that the sense of isolation that had settled heavily on her so far in this unorthodox process to motherhood had started to loosen; she wasn’t to know that Catra’s own situational loneliness was similarly slackening. For perhaps the first time ever in their chequered history, they finally had each other.

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

> Some Catradora relationship archaeology here, which will lead to some important discoveries soon! Let me know what you think, I love to hear your reactions!

TWENTY YEARS PRIOR

Adora tensed as she gripped the door handle. She wasn't sure anymore whether she should even open it.

She laid her forehead tentatively against the wood, careful not to get any splinters. She couldn't hear if anyone else was still in the room with Catra; this would only be harder with an audience. Everything in Adora's mind was telling her to give Catra space, to give her the privacy Adora knew Catra craved when she was upset. But something about the way Catra's sobs sounded – thick, rasping whimpers coated in unmistakeable misery – was different. Adora knew in the depths of her gut that Catra wanted (*no, needed*) her. And Adora had always struggled to stop herself from doing whatever she could to give Catra what she needed.

She straightened herself up, settling her nerves and wiggling her toes so she could ready herself to enter the room as lightly and calmly as possibly.

Here goes nothing…

Adora pushed the door open ultra-cautiously, frowning at the whining creak it made, unceremoniously giving her entrance away.

She breathed out a sigh of relief as she realised Catra was alone, her back facing the door as she lay on her side in bed. Adora lowered herself gingerly onto the edge of Catra's mattress,

stretching her fingers out towards Catra's hand. She waited for Catra to reach back, but their fingertips never connected.

"Catra?"

There was no response – just Catra's tears briefly giving way to frantic gulps of air. Adora sighed, shifting closer, laying a hand on Catra's back as her sobs began to intensify again. Anxiety knitted the muscles in her chest together; she'd never heard Catra cry like this, not even when they were really little.

It felt like she sat there trying to soothe Catra for a century. And then-

"You said you wouldn't leave me."

Adora bit her lip. It was weird, weighing up these extreme emotions of timid excitement and solemn guilt.

"I'm not leaving *you*, Catra."

"But you're going, aren't you?"

Adora shucked her slippers off, nudging Catra to move over under the sheets, slipping inside with her, the threadbare white material pulled over their heads. Finally face-to-face, Adora could see the crimson rims of Catra's eyes, stark against the glistening amber and blue of her irises, her cheeks striped with the ruins of shed tears.

"It's still us against the world, right? They can't keep us apart." Adora's throat tightened as she spoke, her words barely above a whisper.

"How do you even know that? They only want you."

Catra's voice trailed off, her eye contact dropping. Adora didn't need her to speak out loud to know what Catra couldn't voice.

No-one wants me.

"It's just fostering." *I'll be back before the end of term; we all know how this usually pans out.*

Catra stared back at Adora, her whimpers finally subsiding. Her nose twitched, and all of a sudden, the snarky exterior Adora had watched her build over the previous months since they started secondary school sealed all her emotions in. She studied Adora for a few brief seconds.

"Nah, you're going to get the happy ending. I can tell."

A small smile spread across Adora's face.

"You can tell, huh?"

Catra prodded Adora's cheek, her mischievous façade coming fully back in place.

"I can tell a lot of things."

Adora jabbed Catra back in the stomach, and it quickly turned into a poking match, their giggles escalating, the sheets falling off the bed. They didn't notice their roommate Lonnie come into the room, who had taken her turn in the bathroom after Adora to get ready for bed.

"You guys better shut up - I've got my Spanish test tomorrow!"

"Beauty sleep s'not gonna help you with that one, Lonnie."

Lonnie stuck her tongue out at Catra, ignoring the fact she'd obviously been crying. "Smart arse."

Catra jumped up to swipe her sheets off the floor, pulling down the hem of her pyjama top.

"Dunno why you always say that like it's an insult."

Lonnie rolled her eyes, reaching to turn off the light in their room. "Whatever, Catra."

Adora watched as Catra collapsed next to her on the bed, pulling the sheet around them, their bodies cloaked in the darkness. It took a few seconds for her eyes to readjust, but Adora could still sense the sadness returning to Catra's face.

Whenever they'd talked about finally leaving social care, it had always been that they'd do it together. Sure, they both knew deep down it was out of their control. They were just kids, and it was down to adults to make the big decisions. Adults who barely knew them and primarily liked the way they sounded on paper. Still, it was fun to imagine being fostered together, getting to hang out every day doing what they wanted with no curfews, no communal meals, no fights to get control of the TV remote. Maybe it was all wishful thinking. Still, it had felt good. It was an incredible feeling now, imagining packing up her few treasured belongings, knowing that she was finally going somewhere that might be different, where maybe – if she tried as hard as she could to be perfect, to please them enough - she could even be *loved* one day. But it was hard to think about it for too long knowing Catra would be left without her.

Adora worried that Catra would be able to feel the excitement humming off her – she didn't want Catra to think she was pleased to be moving out of their room with Lonnie, that she wanted to be apart from them. And Catra probably needed some time for herself. She knew just as well as anyone else in the home that seeing other kids getting fostered while you were still stuck in the same lumpy, too-worn bed was hard to stomach. She made to get out of Catra's bed and fumble her way back to her own for the night. But the second she began to move, she felt Catra's wrist clamp forcefully around her own. It made Adora think of how stupid it was that Catra refused to try out for any of the sports teams at school – her reflexes were next level. Nevertheless, the message was clear.

Stay.

Adora wasn't sure how many more nights she'd have in their room. So she burrowed her head into Catra's pillow, both of them

falling into a steady rhythm of sleep. She slept in Catra's bed every night for the next week, right up until it was time for their first goodbye.

FIFTEEN YEARS PRIOR

"Hey, can I sit here?"

Lonnie shrugged at Adora, nudging her head towards the chair opposite her.

"Thanks," Adora smiled nervously, pulling at the hem of her track shorts, "I know it's kind of been a while."

"Don't sweat it," Lonnie waved her hand in the air lazily, "s'just how these things go."

"I guess."

Lonnie took a bite of her sandwich, glancing up at Adora, who was watching her expectantly.

"You gonna eat?"

"Oh! Yeah," Adora dug around in her backpack, eventually pulling out a thoroughly squished sandwich. She peeled off the crumpled foil she'd hurriedly wrapped it in that morning, picking at the edges of the crust to avoid eating the rest of the mushy, tuna-soaked bread.

Lonnie paused, swallowing her bite in a loud gulp. She held out the other half of her sandwich.

"Go on."

“Lonnie! That’s your lunch!”

“Yeah, and you’re not gonna eat that, are you?”

Adora scrunched her face up, meeting Lonnie’s gaze shyly.

“Come on, Adora. The sooner you take the damn sandwich, the sooner we can start talking about what you actually came over here for.”

“Thanks,” Adora took the sandwich, pulling off a corner and pushing it into her mouth. “That obvious, huh?”

Lonnie laughed under her breath.

“You’re the most fucking obvious. Plus we shared a room for like, eight years or something, remember?”

“That was a pretty good set-up.”

Lonnie snorted. *If you say so, idiot!*

“Dealing with the two of you rolling around all the time? My life got *much* better when I didn’t have to third wheel your asses.”

Adora balked.

“It was barely third-wheeling, Lon.”

“If you say so.” Lonnie raised an eyebrow, taunting her, “But until I see you eye-fucking someone *else* for once-“ Adora scoffed, ”I’m gonna carry on with my survivors’ therapy.”

“You’re such a dick sometimes.”

Lonnie let a grin spread across her face.

“Ya really know how to sweet-talk a girl, ‘Dor.”

Adora rolled her eyes playfully, kicking Lonnie’s shin lightly under the table. Lonnie finished her half of the sandwich, leaning back in

her chair and crossing her arms.

"So, should I bother guessing what it is you wanna talk about?"

Adora swallowed her final mouthful, licking her lips.

"I'm just worried about her."

"Why? Don't you talk to her every day?"

"Well, yeah… But she's been hanging around with…"

Lonnie sighed.

"Look Adora, I know there's been a lot going on for you the last few months-" Adora's eyes narrowed. *Did everyone know about her coming out? And does it really have to be such a big deal?* "But Catra can do whatever she wants, okay? And maybe it isn't what you think she should do, but if she wants to date or fuck or do whatever it is she's doing with those guys, then you just have to let her get on with it."

Well, that was fucking dissatisfying.

Adora glared at Lonnie, but the other girl held her stare. She finally gave up, her shoulders sinking as she slumped in her chair.

"I just…" Adora gulped, questioning to herself whether she could even say it out loud. "I feel like I'm losing her."

The admission hung in the air between them.

"Dude!"

Adora and Lonnie twisted round: it was Catra, weaving her way through the crowded school grounds towards them in skin-tight ripped jeans, two pencils stuck into the messy bun of curls piled on her head. It seemed like kids in younger years knew instinctively to get out the way when she was walking, as if she

had an invisible entourage of bodyguards around her to clear her path.

"Since when did you hang out with Adora?" She hoisted herself onto the table, sitting cross legged-between them.

Adora glanced at Lonnie apprehensively, but there was no need to be worried.

"Just track talk. I have my fitness thing for the Army soon, thought 'Dor might have some tips on the whole long-distance thing."

"Yeah, we just talked about breathing patterns and stuff."

Catra nodded slowly, clearly not entirely convinced. She tore off a piece of Adora's abandoned sandwich.

"Okaaaaay. Well, if we're talking bullshit about the not-so-distance future, then I might as well tell you."

Adora perked up. *Did she finally hear back?*

"Looks like you're gonna have a buddy at BMU."

"Your grant came through?"

Catra beamed, laughing as Adora launched out of her chair, wrapping her arms around her in excitement. They'd talked about this for years, going to uni together, and it seemed like money (or lack of it) was going to put a stopper in their plans to study in the capital.

"Getting that maintenance check, baby."

Adora squealed in excitement. "We should apply to the same halls! How great would it be to live together again?"

Lonnie stood up, swinging her backpack over her shoulder. "Aaaand… I'm out. Had enough of this already for a lifetime."

Catra laughed, "Fuck off then."

Lonnie flipped her middle finger at them as she swaggered back towards the school doors, shaking her hair out behind her.

Adora couldn't contain herself.

"Catra, this is amazing - it'll be just like old times!"

Catra's smile faltered a little, her head drooping.

"Adora… you know I'm still going to have to get like two jobs to come to Bright Moon?" She exhaled heavily. "I'm probably not going to be able to live in halls with you."

Adora bit her lip, squeezing Catra's arm.

"Well… I'm still so happy we'll be there together."

"Me too."

Adora couldn't help it – she lunged towards Catra again, hugging her tight. She'd waited years for the opportunity for them to get back on the same path, to be equals, not just the scrappy care home kid and the lucky adoptee. No-one would know who they were in Bright Moon.

They'd just be Catra and Adora, finally.

TEN YEARS PRIOR

The weather was unbelievably shitty, and Adora had been waiting in the cold for far longer than she should have bothered. She bristled, checking her phone again impatiently.

At least text - it's my birthday, for God's sake!

She huffed angrily, bringing up Catra's contact against her better judgment. She stood up from the park bench, grunting in frustration as it went to voicemail *again.*

"Catra, can you please just text me? I've been waiting for over an hour." Adora sucked in air sharply, but she was way too irritable at this point to force her usual placating tone. "Honestly, this is really fucking shitty of you. It's one thing to refuse to come to my party – and really, I don't know what your issue is and why you always bail on meeting any of my friends – but I literally changed my entire schedule to get lunch with you and, *of course*, you don't even bother turning up. Fucking typical."

"Typical, huh?"

Adora whipped around, eyes widening in shock. Catra was panting, a thin sheen of sweat glistening on her forehead; she'd clearly been in a rush to get to the park.

"Catra…" Adora paled, hanging up the phone, "I was going to delete that."

Catra hardened, her nostrils flaring. There were deepened purple stains under eyes and her skin was an oddly ashy grey; she was clearly getting no sleep.

"Don't bother. Nice to know what you really think."

Adora whimpered.

"Come on, Catra! I didn't mean it. I just…"

"What?"

"I was just really looking forward to seeing you. We never hang out anymore. You're always with him."

"He has a name, you know."

Adora pinched the bridge of her nose. How was it that Catra managed to flip things around on her every time? She was the one who was late. Really late on her *birthday*. Adora was pissed off; they'd gotten through the first two years of university with little friction, but this final term had been a complete and total mess between the two of them.

"Yeah, well, I forget which one it is."

Catra shook her head, laughing under her breath in disbelief.

"Oh my God, who the fuck do you think you are?" Adora's head snapped up in shock. "Do I say anything about the girls you dick about with?"

"It's not like there's been many."

"Ha! And what am I doing, shagging a new guy every week? I've been with Prime for over a year, Adora!" she ran her hand through her hair raggedly. "I knew I should have listened to him."

"Listened to him? Is that why you're so late?"

"Jesus, kill me now."

"What? It seems like he controls every little thing you do. You won't come over for movie night, you won't go out for dinner with us, you won't even come to a study group!"

"Why would I want to do any of those things with your friends, Adora? I don't know them."

"That's only because you've refused to even meet them the whole time we've been here!"

Catra shut her eyes, seemingly trying to hold back fury that was seeping out of her skin. She spoke lowly, her jaw set in stone.

"Maybe I don't want my entire life to turn into a Pride parade, Adora. Maybe I don't want every conversation to be about queer

rights this, gentrification that, feminism 101 with boots on. Not all of us want to spend our lives rolling around in eco-glitter with a fucking loudspeaker."

Adora winced.

"What are you trying to say?"

"I'm trying to say, Adora, that I don't want to fit into whatever woke rainbow box you seem so determined to shoehorn me into."

Adora didn't know how to respond. What was Catra even referring to? Was it really such a problem that she talked about being gay or about dating girls? Or that she had friends that dressed and spoke the way they did? She instinctively brought her hand to her coat lapel, thumbing the pride pin that had been secured there since they left high school. She looked up at Catra, trying to figure it out. Had she been predatory or pressurising in any way at all? She'd tried so hard to always be 'normal' around Catra, to never push any physical boundaries or to look at her for too long. Even if it was completely platonic, and even though they'd always been so touchy with each other, Adora was beyond scared to fall into that trap of making the straight girl nervous, of being too queer. The last thing she wanted was to push Catra away – she'd spent years trying to keep her close despite the odds.

She made herself look Catra in the eye, and was shocked to see complete coldness staring back at her.

I guess there's a first time for everything.

Adora didn't want to believe this was it. That this was what their life-long friendship was going to boil down to. Surely this was just projection, a symptom of something bad happening in Catra's life, not the sickness itself*. It had to be, right?*

"What is going on with you?"

Catra didn't respond. She just glared at Adora beadily, until a flash of something – regret, or maybe even alarm? – overtook for a

second. Adora edged closer to her, keeping her hands firmly at her side.

Don't let it look like you're trying to touch her like that.

"Why are you saying these things? This isn't you, Catra." *It can't be.*

"You don't know me anymore, Adora."

Adora stared at Catra quizzically. *What the hell is happening here?*

"You live in this bubble!" Catra let out a laugh dripping in mirth, "You have literally no idea what the real world is like, but the worst thing is, you think you do because you spent a few measly years in social care with the rest of us runts."

"Catr-"

"I hold down three jobs on top of classes. I don't come to your stupid little things because I either have to study or can't afford the bus. And then you think I would want to hang out with your friends who have nothing better to do than debate the injustices of the world! And all that money, just throwing it around! Oh my God, they organised your party at a bar with a fucking fifty quid entry. And we're supposed to be *students*!"

"I d-didn't know…"

"Because you never fucking think!"

Catra turned away from Adora, searching frantically in the bag slung over her shoulder.

"You know why I was late? 'Cos I left your present at home and I didn't have enough on my card to get the bus there and back again. And I borrowed the cash off Prime to get it for you in the first place!"

She ripped a small gift-wrapped box out of the bag, throwing it on the ground by Adora's feet.

"Catra! Please, can we just-"

But it was too late. Catra had stormed off, and Adora knew her well enough to know that this time, she really did need space. She wasn't the only one - Adora felt like Catra's words had sliced through her; the cuts were deeper than she thought would even be possible.

She pocketed the gift box, shoving it into a drawer when she got home without opening it. For weeks, she was too anxious to talk about their argument with anybody, even though they kept asking how she was, that they knew something was deeply wrong.

But Adora had so much swirling around in her head; how could she express any of these deep, inner-held thoughts when the only person she ever would have opened up to before had blasted her entire sense of self apart? Was it really all her fault? Was she just some slut-shaming, over-privileged, stereotypical loudspeaker lesbian with no basic awareness? She wracked her brain trying to come up with the things she'd said or done that made Catra say what she had.

By the time end of year exams were over with, Adora finally mustered up the courage to reach out, to suggest a coffee – she offered to pay – so they could unpack everything and patch things up, just like they always did.

But Catra's phone was disconnected, her room was empty, and her socials had gone completely dead.

For all intents and purposes, Catra had dropped off the face of the earth. Wracked with worry, Adora was left to process all the damage alone.

Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

> TW: emotional abuse, masturbation, non-consensual sex/forced consent, gaslighting. This chapter provides backstory, but you'll still be able to make sense of the plot without it.

TEN YEARS PRIOR

Catra stretched out, her arm falling on the cool pillow beside her. She twisted the cotton blend fabric in her fist, pulling it towards her and hugging it to her chest. She should have known he wouldn't stay overnight – Prime hated her shabby room and disliked interacting with her roommates even more.

It was true that her cramped apartment wasn't the nicest place – there were holes in the walls left by previous tenants, all the taps were rusted up with limescale, and there were odd cracks in the internal doorframes that stopped them from locking completely. But Catra had been so grateful to find such cheap rent so close to campus; she'd only just managed to scrape the deposit money together a week before the start of first year, and raced to get it cash-in-hand to the landlord. She'd moved in that very evening – no point wasting more money on that awful hostel – and dumped a bin bag of her meagre belongings on the yellowing mattress. It wasn't much but it felt like a triumph. Her new life in Bright Moon, finally about to begin.

The sun streamed in through the thin blinds, streaking across her naked body. Catra fumbled in the drawer next to her bed, pulling out a small metal cylinder – cheap, but seven out of ten times it did the job. If she was in the right mood. She rolled back onto her front, burying her face in the pillow as she snaked her hand under the curve of her hips and stomach, dipping lower and lower until

the cold metal made her shiver slightly. She turned the bullet on, pressing her clit into it further. She played around, trying to build up the tension, tapping herself in random patterns, holding pressure in different places, squeezing her pelvic floor as tight as she could to trigger her body into giving her what she needed. *Please, just work with me today.* She only had five or ten minutes before she had to get up and she was so close, if she could just keep this building for just a little longer…

Catra moaned in frustration, half begging/half threatening her body to get there.

It wasn't that there was anything wrong with the way Prime fucked her, but it always felt somehow *lacking*. She imagined Adora teasing her, telling her that if she really wanted to cum properly, she was targeting the wrong demographic for sex.

Fuck.

Catra grunted in exasperation.

She'd avoided thinking about Adora for weeks. Yet even without any contact, she'd completely ruined Catra's buzz. She shuddered violently, twisting onto her side to find a new angle that worked better. But it was no use. Catra threw the bullet across the room in frustration; it whirred against the floor incessantly, but she couldn't give a shit.

She screeched into her hands, dismissing the sore, rough edges of her early morning throat and the faint smell of herself on her fingers. Given how shitty the past couple of months had been, getting worked up like that with no release felt like literally the worst thing that could happen. Catra knotted her fingers into her thick hair to massage her scalp, arching her back as she chased some kind of satisfaction to start her day.

Catra thought for a minute about the previous night's events. Prime had showed up unannounced again, demanding she stop cooking dinner so he could get what he wanted. And just like

every time, she gave it to him. It didn't matter that she'd just finished her final exams and all she wanted to do was sleep before the next never-ending day swallowed her up – it never seemed like the consequences of saying no were worth it.

She had laid there, letting him into her, his left hand rough against her ribs as he pressed her into the mattress over and over again. Sometimes he would bite down roughly on her shoulder or the curve of her neck – she liked that – but they never kissed during sex. Last night, it was just kind of… *transactional*. Catra's fingers drifted to her side, pressing tentatively into her skin. It was more tender than she'd like; she could imagine the bruise blossoming even without seeing it.

Catra sighed, ripping her phone away from its charging cable and opening up her messages. There weren't many, but what did she expect? She'd barely had time to make any friends on top of the jobs, the classes and the stuff she did on the side for Prime. Even though she was alone, Catra scrolled through WhatsApp with feigned indifference, refusing to admit what she was actually looking for.

She still hasn't texted.

They'd never gone so long without speaking. The realisation sunk like a crushing metal weight on Catra's chest.

She knew it had been bad, but she'd been so tired. She could barely remember half the things she'd said, but releasing in those snap seconds of freedom, speaking her mind after years of swallowing bitterness, felt so good. Her stomach warped a little, though. *Isn't it kind of fucked if it felt good?*

It was more worrying that Adora never reached out after. Usually, they'd play their classic game of tiptoeing round each other, then Adora would suggest they meet up to study at the library or go on a walk through campus. And the minute they met, it would be back to normal. Catra's guilt would dampen, Adora's anxiety would

settle, and they'd be joking along as always. She'd never had to actually say sorry.

This time it was different.

She could hear Prime's voice in her head, the tickle of his warm breath still heavy on her neck.

You should listen when I tell you not to bother with her.

You're crazy for thinking she actually likes you. She just wants to convince herself how much better she is.

Why aren't you studying? Do you think that dumb bitch is going to help you get anywhere?

You're not a stupid kid anymore, are you? Do you really need her now you've got me?

It was hard not to see his point. Adora had let her down over and over again, hadn't she? She'd been oblivious to all her pain, disrespectful to her relationship, insensitive to Catra's struggles. Why couldn't Adora understand how much Prime had done for her? He'd gotten her two of her jobs, pushed her to stay in school despite everything, and even taken over her phone contract so she had one less bill to worry about. Sure, she'd had to run a few numbers for him now and again – she was a maths and software engineering student after all – but Prime loved her, didn't he? At least, Catra presumed this was what love was supposed to feel like.

She couldn't believe how stupid she'd been. How much risk she'd taken to see Adora on her birthday: lying to Prime about the times of her shift at the coffee shop, praying to God he wouldn't pick that day to check that she was actually where she said she'd be; pretending to borrow the money to buy lingerie he'd like (she'd

swiped a red lacy set left behind at the gym when she was cleaning the showers in a staggering stroke of good luck) and hiding Adora's gift underneath her tampons; taking a cold shower before going to his place that night, because somehow he'd always pick up Adora's scent on her, and they turned the heating off in her flat after 10am.

Catra wouldn't learn until that afternoon that Prime had already seen and deleted a text from Adora when she was asleep. It only took hours for him to cut off her contract; all she had to do to make it up to him was move into his place and promise to never lie to him again.

Catra would almost be grateful for it – being in Prime's orbit was the closest she'd ever been to being truly protected from the unbending world around her. If losing Adora was the sacrifice, she'd take it.

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

> Okay, now we're starting to get into the real meat of the backstory... please feed me with comments :) it is so helpful to hear what you think!

NINE WEEKS PRIOR

Adora woke gently and pulled off her eye mask, her cheek soft against Catra's silk pillow. She loved it, that the first thing she smelled every morning was the linseed oil Catra worked into her hair every evening and the faint lavender of her night cream.

She smiled to herself with eyes closed as she thought how simple it had been over the past month. Something about the start of the third trimester had settled both of them – they could see the light at the end of the tunnel, imagine a life beyond this time where it was just the two of them again. And Adora had developed a blissful sense of temporary relief; it was like she'd started to see Catra again and not just the bump.

Sometimes she caught sight of Catra blowing hair out of her eyes, or rubbing moisturiser into her skin, or humming as she cooked, and the realisation that she belonged to this woman – and that this woman belonged to her – was astounding. Their journey to this life had been so long and so painful. *How could I possibly let this incredible gift she is trying to give come between us?*

It was in these moments that she couldn't help but pull Catra into her arms, and for the first time in weeks, the roundness of her belly and the flighty movements of the child inside her ignited warmth rather than bitterness. For all her time as a qualified specialist, Adora felt like she was experiencing an intimacy that usually eluded her when treating patients: the value of rubbing

bio-oil on sore stretch marks; of rubbing deft fingers in soothing circles on strained muscles; of keeping windows open despite the early autumn cool to relieve body temperature. Now and again, the disappointment slipped in – *if only this could be for us* – but she pushed it as forcefully as she could to the edges of her mind.

Deep down, Adora knew there would be triggers that dragged her anxiety back out into the open. She'd have to keep reminding herself that she'd been equally responsible for all of the steps that had led them here. She'd chosen Catra, chosen to encourage this surrogacy, and now for everyone's sake, she was choosing the role of the supportive partner. It was possible, after all, that this longing that had wildly grown inside Adora was just a halo effect of the pregnancy hormones – *I read a study once saying that could happen, right?* Maybe when it was just the two of them again, the urge to nest would fade. It had disappeared so quickly when she'd promised Catra that she would always be enough (*more than enough)* for Adora on her own.

For now, the linseed and lavender grounded her.

Adora inhaled deeply and half-rolled out of bed, pulling a jumper over her head. She padded towards the living room, ready to convince Catra to spend the rest of the day in bed with her; if finishing at 3pm wasn't a perk of being the boss, then what else was there?

It had become their practice for Catra to work from home when Adora had a day off after a string of night shifts. She'd let her sleep in until the afternoon, and Adora would wake to freshly made pancakes.

She rounded the corner to the kitchen, straining to savour the smell she'd been looking so forward to.

"Catra?"

The kitchen was untouched, the dishes from the day before still waiting in the drying rack to be put away.

Strange. She didn't say she'd be out today.

Adora veered back into the hallway absent-mindedly, glancing ahead to the bathroom and peeking her head around the doorway of their home office. Catra wasn't there – but Adora's phone was buzzing furiously on the desk, a slew of notifications from Bow and Glimmer filling up her lock screen.

She grabbed it from the charging dock, deciding to call Bow instead of reading all the messages.

"Hey, I saw-"

"Adora! I'm so relieved you're calling back, I've been trying to get through to you all day!" Bow sounded frantic; it immediately put her on edge.

"Sorry, I've only just got up – I've been on nights." The nervous energy was electric – it could have burned her. "Bow, is everything okay?"

She heard Bow breathe in sharply on the other end of the line.

"Is Catra with you?"

"No… she might have gone into the office for something."

"Adora, she's supposed to be on maternity leave."

"You know how she is about it, she's been working anyway. I'm sure it's-"

"Do you know for definite that's where she is?"

Adora was completely taken aback. *What the hell is going on?*

"No, Bow. She's a grown woman. Do you always know where Glimmer is?"

Bow fell silent; Adora could tell he was figuring out how to express himself diplomatically. She could hear the words forming

silently in his mind: *it's different.*

He redirected the conversation.

"She didn't turn up to the antenatal class this morning."

Adora's defence mechanism started to kick in. *Hadn't they gotten past all this?* It had been close to six years since Catra had last been missing.

"She probably just forgot, Bow, she's been dropping things all over the place. She's nearly eight months gone. It's expected."

"She's not picking up her phone. It's been seven hours."

Adora gritted her teeth.

"Bow."

"I'm sorry, Adora. You know I love Catra. But…"

Adora was having none of it.

"But *what*?"

He fell silent again for a long minute.

"If she hasn't come home yet, we're worried."

EIGHT YEARS PRIOR

The floorboards creaked under Adora's feet as she tip-toed through the tiny apartment she shared with Glimmer. Her throat was dry and her head throbbed with dehydration – she'd waited

all night to refill her glass. The last thing she wanted to do was disturb the guest on their sofa; for the past week she'd stayed with them, Catra had been tetchy at the best of times, let alone if intruded upon in the middle of the night. Adora was overly conscious of doing anything that might invade her privacy too much and push Catra to turn even deeper into herself.

It didn't help that Glimmer was both tactless and suspicious of her old friend – a thoroughly unhelpful combination. For every awkward moment that had gone down between Adora and Catra, there was a clear admission of distrust from Glimmer. It hadn't started like that; Glimmer had given them a decent amount of space for the first few days after Adora brought Catra home. And she'd barely put up any resistance to letting her stay (given everything she'd told Glimmer about her volatile relationship with Catra in the past, *that* had been more of a surprise). But as time went on, and as Adora spent more and more time trying to coax Catra out of her shell, the dramatic shift of Adora's attention triggered Glimmer to start asking Catra increasingly intrusive questions. Really, they were more like borderline accusations at times. Adora was petrified that Glimmer would push Catra away, and that she'd go back off the grid for God knows how many more years. She'd pinched herself every morning that it had actually happened – that she'd found Catra again, completely by chance.

Last Saturday night, she'd let herself be dragged to Crimson, a lesbian bar in the west end of Bright Moon. Her training cohort had qualified a few months ago, and she'd be starting her placement in obstetrics soon; her university friends who had stuck around in the city after graduation insisted that they celebrate. Glimmer and Bow had pushed her not to bail like she always did – ever since her disastrous birthday in third year, she rarely went to clubs and bars, hyper-aware of her privilege and the money she wouldn't have previously given a second thought to dropping on drink after drink. But her friends were so excited to have an excuse to go out (9-5 office life was apparently mundane beyond belief), and Adora had known that after more than two long, unsatisfying years of policing herself, she really did have to put

her insecurities to rest. *It doesn't make you some out-of-touch princess to let loose for one night!*

The bar had been pretty empty when they got there, but the alcohol flowed, the lights were dim, and the music was loud enough to drown out her thoughts. Adora had revelled in the feel of some muscular blonde's hands all over her; she never had time to date and she'd forgotten how good the taste of a stranger could be when you were truly touch-starved. She'd wanted more. She'd tugged gently on the woman's hand to lead her to the bathroom - it had been years since she did anything like this – crashing through the doors blindly as they kissed, letting herself be pushed against the sink counter as a firm thigh drove between her legs, rough hands slipping under her shirt to hold her in place. Adora had felt like she'd been revived, moans pouring out both their mouths, grinding down on that thigh placed in just the right spot, the bristles of a stranger's undercut tickling her fingertips. *Damn, I needed this.*

In that moment, she couldn't have cared less who came into the bathroom – there was nothing that could have possibly interrupted her chasing this release. Adora had felt more reckless than she ever had before and the sense of liberation coursing through her had made her giddy. She'd pushed the fingers gripping her waist aside to direct them south, guiding an eager hand past the jean buttons she'd hastily undone, beyond the waistband of her boyshorts until they were right where she had wanted them. She'd clenched her thighs, dropping forward into that hand, her clit bouncing against the heel of a hardened palm. *Christ, it had been so fucking long.*

Adora's kisses had gotten sloppier as she came closer to coming, rough fingers gliding through her labia, so dangerously close to entering…

Just a little more, come on, nearly there-

"Jesus, fuck."

A bitter, acerbic voice had rung out from a toilet stall, the door swinging open noisily as she had finally been entered. Irritation had niggled at Adora – *this is literally the worst timing ever* - but then-

It can't be…?

Adora had pushed the blonde off her, so zoned out that she barely registered protests of disbelief. The blood pulsing through her head had somehow got even louder, her heart had started pumping double time.

She'd have recognised that voice anywhere.

Adora had drunk in the sight of her. Her friend – *were they still friends?* – had looked so much skinnier than she'd remembered, her cheekbones harsher, her curls more defined. The edges of a tattoo crept out the open collar of her shirt across her left collarbone, black ink licking her skin like the slick eyeliner flicked across her lids. Even the way she'd slung a scruffy backpack over her shoulder had a sharpness to it that Adora didn't recognise.

What on earth is she doing here, of all places?

She still hadn't noticed Adora, grimacing at the running water as she washed her hands in the sink beside them.

"Don't stop on my account."

Adora had held her hand out in front of her like a barrier before the blonde could even move, her eyes still glued to tan skin and spattered freckles as she had buttoned her jeans back up. She'd barely registered it as the woman she'd been making out with just seconds before had left, muttering under her breath as the door slammed behind her.

The noise had jolted both of them, mismatched eyes finally darting up to the mirror, right into Adora's reflection.

For a split second, it seemed like Catra had almost choked, colour draining from her face. She'd recovered just as quickly; Adora had no idea how it was even possible.

"Hey, Adora."

A whole week later, Adora's breath still hitched when she thought of it.

Her memory of how she'd convinced Catra to come home with her was hazy. One minute, she'd breezed past Adora to leave the bar, completely unperturbed by Adora's attempts to get her to stay; the next, Catra had returned to ask her to call her an Uber, a crisp £10 note pressed into her palm in exchange. Adora had called the Uber, got her coat from the checkroom and just about forced Catra into her apartment.

It had quickly become clear that Catra was running away rather than towards something. Adora made it her mission to figure out what the fuck had happened to her, and who this new version of Catra seemed to be. If there was anything Adora was good at, it was fixing problems; this would be the biggest puzzle she'd solve.

Adora eased the door open tentatively, as quietly as she could. She smiled under her breath. *How many times had I tiptoed around Catra sleeping in the past?* She was nostalgic in a strange way for their old life in the care home, before her adoption and the rift between them started to fissure.

But the blankets had been thrown off the couch and Catra's backpack was gone from its now-permanent spot by the coffee table.

Panic spread through Adora's body like wildfire.

"Glimmer!"

She tore up the hallway, racing into Glimmer's room. She was barely able to see through the tears threatening to pour down her cheeks.

Glimmer groaned, lifting her head gingerly off Bow's bare chest. Adora had forgotten their mutual university friend, now Glimmer's boyfriend, had come over the night before.

"Adora, it's like 8am on a Sunday…"

It was Bow who noticed her distress first.

"Adora, what's wrong?"

Adora's shoulders shook as hoarse sobs fell from her throat.

"S-s-she's gone…"

In a flash, she felt warm arms wrap around her; she was too distraught to object to Bow's toplessness.

Glimmer stormed past them, dressed only in a thin vest top and tiny pyjama shorts.

"I told you, Adora-"

"This is not the time, Glim," Bow's voice rang out over Adora's head, calm and clear. "Come on, let's get some water."

Bow nudged Adora out of Glimmer's room, his arm slung around her shoulders. They joined Glimmer in the living room, where she was searching the room furiously.

"She's taken the fucking Victoria Cross!"

Adora's eyes widened.

"She can't have… she wouldn't!"

"She fucking has!" Glimmer spun round, her eyes staring into Adora's with an ire she'd never seen before.

Glimmer was pretty domineering when it came to the décor of their flat, and the one thing that there was absolutely no budging on was the prime placement of her great-grandfather's Victoria

Cross medal on the living room mantelpiece. Adora's heart sank lower than she thought possible. It was a priceless family heirloom, a mark of honour that Glimmer's family had treasured since the First World War robbed them of an entire generation of brothers; what's more, as the most prestigious military honour in the country, it had only taken Adora a few seconds on Google to find out it was worth hundreds of thousands of pounds.

She'd spent hours listening to Glimmer recount the story of how her great-grandfather, a decorated army surgeon, had worked for days under shells and gunfire as treated the wounded in clear sight of the enemy, inching far closer to enemy lines than any other medic even when night fell. It had been a huge deal when Glimmer's mother had given her the Cross to safeguard when she moved abroad after her father's recent death, a good luck charm to keep her on the straight and narrow.

She couldn't imagine that Glimmer and her family would ever forgive her for this; she'd spend her entire life trying to convince them that she was still worthy of their acceptance. Until now, they'd been like a second family to her.

"Oh my God, she's taken my work laptop as well!" Glimmer turned away from the dining room table where her USB mouse remained and sunk into the sofa, her head in her hands, "I wasn't even supposed to take it out of the office. It's got like national security shit on it!"

How could this even be getting worse?

Glimmer had joked for months that now she'd been promoted to new heights in the Civil Service, no-one would bat an eyelid if she brought her work home with her now and again. But they all knew that losing the documents on her laptop - even with all the security measures in place with quadruple verification - was an instantly fireable offence.

Adora was completely dumbfounded. She could only watch in a trance as Bow left her by the doorway to console Glimmer, with

nothing to do but wonder what could have happened to set off this absurd chain of events, and whether she'd ever see Catra again.

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

Hi there :)

This chapter is a chance to learn more about Bow and Catra's relationship, and the role it plays in the dynamics that have developed in the group. It. was a really complicated chapter for me to write as I've actually never really written any male POVs before (let alone one as nuanced as Bow's character in the series), so I hope it comes off well!

With the last couple of weeks I've had, this fic has no business taking up so much of my brain :p

NINE WEEKS PRIOR

Bow stared at the phone in his hand for a few minutes, not sure whether he'd played the whole thing completely wrong. What was it Catra always said? *The right tactics will get you wherever you need to be, Arrow Boy.* Pissing off Adora had not been a smart one.

"Hey."

Bow turned to Glimmer, relieved to see – at least outwardly – that her anxiety was nowhere near matching his.

"It's just Adora. She's physically incapable of staying mad at anyone for long."

"Yeah."

Glimmer squeezed his hand.

"I'm really worried about her, Glim."

"I know. I'm worried too."

Glimmer leaned forward over the kitchen table and pushed Bow's plate back towards him. His lunch had remained unfinished since midday.

"I'm not hungry."

"It doesn't do any of us any good if you don't eat, Bow. Come on."

Bow's lip quivered as he took a deep breath, pulling his glasses off his face to rub his brow.

"I can't figure out why she'd go AWOL like this. Something's happened." Glimmer drummed her finger on the side of the plate; Bow finally conceded, picking up a fork as he continued processing his thoughts aloud. "I don't think it's work – she's just sold off some insane source code."

Bow could sense Glimmer watching as he half-heartedly chewed cold pasta.

"You don't think it's to do with Adora, do you? It seems like things have been a bit…"

Glimmer's voice trailed off as their eyes met. Neither of them wanted to open this Pandora's box. *Had they pushed their friends too far, letting them do this?*

Bow didn't want to entertain the thought, especially not given the weighty conversations he'd had with Catra in the past. He responded resolutely, feigning confidence. "I doubt it. With everything they've been through, they're stronger than anyone."

Glimmer nodded. Neither of them wanted to test the strength of his statement.

Bow ate in silence, one hand clasping Glimmer's on the tabletop. Glimmer sniffed, a few plump tears falling as she blinked.

“She wouldn’t do anything risky, would she?”

Bow’s fork dropped with a clatter onto his plate; he immediately moved round the table towards his wife. He didn’t know how to fully answer the question. He and Catra had become so close since she’d stayed in Bright Moon, and Glimmer’s own relationship with her had come further in the past few months than it had in years. He was ninety-eight percent certain that Catra couldn’t be more careful. She’d been so consultative with them throughout the pregnancy, doing everything she could to keep them feeling wholly involved. In all honesty, she’d made more space for them in her life and thought so deeply about their needs and feelings (especially Glimmer’s) than he ever would have expected from a surrogate. More than Glimmer or Adora would ever know. But that remaining two percent refused to let his nerves settle.

Catra’s track record had improved so drastically – the person she was today was completely unrecognisable from the guarded woman he’d first met when Adora brought her home eight years ago. But Bow knew she would always operate in fight or flight mode. Given Catra’s history, it seemed like a modern miracle to him that she’d even stayed alive for this long, let alone flourished the way she had.

Anxiety, guilt and bewilderment pricked his brain relentlessly. He couldn’t understand why Catra, the woman usually so responsive and hyper-connected to her tech at all times, had now suddenly gone MIA. There were so many variables at this late stage in the pregnancy that could set off a harmful chain reaction; if Catra couldn’t see how this would affect them now, how could they fully trust that she’d look after herself and their child properly until the very end? Anything could be happening right this very second, and Glimmer and Bow could find themselves sidelined - or worse, absent - in the most important events to shape their lives yet. The realisation of powerlessness was devastating.

An uneasy concoction of desperate concern and unfamiliar anger simmered in Bow’s chest. He brought Glimmer towards him in a

gentle hug, initiating physical assurance for his own benefit as much as hers.

"We'll keep calling her. She has to pick up eventually."

She just has to.

SIX YEARS PRIOR

Catra sat rigidly in the booth, her right leg crossed tightly over her left. It looked to Bow like she was doing anything she could to take up as little space as possible. He slid the craft beer menu across the table towards her.

"Pick your poison. It's on me."

Catra examined Bow, barely glancing at the list.

"You pick first."

She pushed the glossy card back towards him, eyes trained on his face as he perused the options available. Bow felt like he was somehow undergoing a test, but he wasn't sure what its purpose was.

Catra's desire to take control of the situation wasn't much of a shock to him. From the blurred explanations Bow had heard second-hand from Adora, she'd spent much of the past few years starved of any real agency. And that didn't match up at all to the stories he'd heard about the firecracker version of Catra from Adora's childhood, told long before the Victoria Cross incident had ever occurred.

Reconciling the different Catras he'd collected in his mind felt vital to understanding what the truth behind all the drama really was: the spirited care home kid; the elusive university friend of a friend; the mysterious returnee; the thief; the survivor; and now – what? Bow had no idea.

She'd clearly been surprised when he reached out to find out if she was free for a drink – to be fair, he probably would have been too if their roles were reversed. But given the extreme dissonance building between Adora and Glimmer when it came to the subject of Catra, Bow had a feeling that he'd soon end up playing peacemaker. He wanted to figure out what he was dealing with before that happened. Running into Catra at that local microbrewery had given him an in he didn't even know he was searching for.

Beers paid for at the bar, Bow's mind raced trying to come up with things to say to avoid more awkward silence as he made his way back to the booth with their drinks. But just as he was easing himself back into his seat, Catra got there first.

"So. You're actually wearing cologne for this?"

Bow looked back at her quizzically. *She knows I don't think this is a date, right?*

"You got a problem with Paco Rabanne?"

Catra wrinkled her nose; Bow couldn't believe how much her dissatisfaction got under his skin. It had only been five minutes, but he was inexplicably determined to impress her.

"Well, yes actually – it's like the most basic one you could have picked." She pulled her glass towards her from where Bow had set it on the table with remarkable steadiness, passing it under her nose without a single drop tipping over the rim. Her eyes glinted as she continued. "Apart from *Pour Homme*."

Bow blushed. He had a bottle of that at home as well. Catra waved her hand lazily in the air, dismissing her own words before

crossing her arms over her chest.

"But that's not the point. It's fucking up the scent of these."

Bow blinked double-time as Catra frowned at the beers in front of them. *She did <u>not</u> come to play.*

"Rookie mistake, I guess."

She shrugged at him shrewdly, taking another short, sharp sniff of her glass before holding it up at eye level and inspecting – well, God knows what, Bow had no idea.

He brought his glass to his lips and they took their first sips at the same time. Quiet settled upon them comfortably for a few minutes as they nursed their beers.

"So, Rookie, what's this all about then? Making sure I'm legit?"

Bow nearly choked on his mouthful at her bluntness. If this was the way she wanted to play it…

"I'll give you an answer for an answer."

Finally, he'd hit the right nerve. A small, sly smile spread across Catra's lips for just a split second.

"I'm game."

"Good. One question each round, no skipping, no single word responses."

Catra tipped her head in approval, taking another sip. "Your ball."

"No agenda - figured if you're sticking around, I might as well get to know you." Bow rationalised that it was only a partial untruth; his usual optimism encouraged him to hope that Catra's re-emergence in Bright Moon wasn't just another temporary stint destined to unsettle all their interpersonal dynamics. Bow raised his glass. "How'd you become such an expert on this?"

Catra avoided his eye contact, running her finger round the rim of her glass to sluice the foam off, as if she was buying time to figure out whether or not to be honest.

"When you've no access to internet and you're watched round the clock by a guy who appreciates a hop, you get good at the things that build your currency. Started to enjoy it for myself eventually."

She sucked the foam off her thumb pensively, seemingly lost in thought before her wistfulness dissipated rapidly. Her eyes flicked back to Bow's sharply. "What's your excuse?"

Bow tilted his head.

"Eh, they order beers into the office on Fridays and a group of us started getting some craft IPAs in to make it more interesting. Went from there."

Catra stifled a snort.

"What?"

"No offence, but I can't really see you amongst a load of city lads knocking back cans." She'd finally started to loosen up a little, uncrossing her legs as she slumped a little against her seat, "Where do you work anyway?"

"Hey, them's not the rules."

"You asked 'what?'"

Bow scoffed incredulously. "Come on!"

"Don't hate the player, Rookie."

Bow shook his head in amusement. He'd started this game to get into Catra's head, but she'd turned the tables on him with breakneck speed.

“I’m a UX consultant at Arrow Tech. We’re coming up on the Big Five so it’s pretty sweet right now.”

Catra rolled her eyes.

“I said I didn’t have internet, not that I’ve been living under a rock. We were in like six of the same classes at BMU.”

“We were?”

Bow wracked his brains for a memory of Catra in the Computer Science or a comment from Adora that they might come across each other on campus. But he was coming up blank, and it was mortifyingly obvious.

“Jesus, Arrow Boy. Nice to know how memorable I am.”

“Sorry!” Bow held his hands up in front of him in surrender, a smile twitching on his lips as he realised he’d gained his second nickname in the space of ten minutes. “Didn’t see you hanging out around the CompSci building, I guess.”

“Yeah,” Catra scratched the back of her ear; her whole demeanour had gone a little tender, “I didn’t really have much time for socialising back then.”

Bow drained his glass, savouring the last dregs of light amber liquid, “Sounded rough, three jobs and all of that.”

Catra furrowed her brow.

“Adora’s been chatting since I turned up, huh?”

Bow barked in sharp laughter – it seemed to surprise her.

“Adora hasn’t shut up about you since we all met in halls. The girl is non-stop.”

“Non-stop?”

Bow waited as Catra got lost in her own mind again. It was hard to read her: an enigma who drifted in and out of the present, whose brain seemed to be a labyrinth of carefully crafted defences.

"I would have gone into web dev. Or probably apps by now. I had a thing at Google to begin with that was really good, but it…" Catra cleared her throat definitively, shaking herself out of her haze. "It wasn't feasible."

Bow had read enough about Prime in the newspapers to know he probably hadn't liked Catra being where he couldn't keep eyes on her. Especially with her smarts.

"Anyway." Catra picked up the beer list, twisting the thin card in her fingers. "You getting the next round or what?"

FIVE YEARS PRIOR

Catra sat with one leg on the wooden bench of the picnic table, her arm slung over her knee in the gentle sun. Bow had no idea how she always managed to sit in the least practical way possible. They were already halfway through the flights of beers they'd ordered, a packet of crisps gutted open between them.

Catra licked salt off her fingers and lifted her sunglasses off her face, perching them in her hair. Her excitement was palpable – Bow had never seen her worked up like this.

"So we've got a couple more meetings, but it seems like they're actually gonna go for it!"

"Three for three, huh?"

"Yep – I told Entrapta we could dev the first three apps in eighteen months. And now we'll have made a decent profit too!"

"It's pretty impressive, can't deny."

A snarky grin spread across her face. "Not bad for a couple of clueless chicks, right?"

A few weeks after that first beer Bow and Catra had shared, she'd reconnected with their old classmate Entrapta – Bow had definitely remembered seeing *her* in their classes – and shortly after convinced her to pack in her stifling software engineering job. It hadn't taken long for Entrapta to see the value of setting out on their own: not only had Catra failed to get even a basic entry level job despite her previously competitive credentials, but Entrapta was fast tiring of having her creativity suppressed by arrogant colleagues; she'd angered at how they'd both been underestimated and dismissed by men who claimed they knew code better. No exception to the rule, Bow had been embarrassed when he realised how successful Catra had been at university. Second only to Entrapta, she'd consistently achieved the highest marks in their year – and she'd somehow done it while dealing with all manner of difficult things. Four months of near 24/7 graft later, and they had sold their first app, still unfinished, to the highest bidder. It barely took another year before their turbo-charged timelines were catching the attention of industry insiders, and they were now fielding potential investors to take them through the next ten years.

"Not bad at all." Bow picked up the third small glass on his tray, teasing Catra to follow him. They went through their usual routine: smell, look, taste, discuss.

"So, how's Adora?"

As expected after nearly two years of weekly get-togethers, Catra threw it right back at him.

"How's *Glimmer*?"

Catra had become increasingly reserved about her relationship with Adora. It had been a shock to nobody but Catra when they had finally got together around nine months ago, but she still seemed uncertain sometimes, like she was waiting for the rug to be pulled out from under her. Bow didn't know whether Catra had dated any women before, or even just anyone aside from Prime. He reckoned if nudged gently, she'd start to open up. Catra was the kind of person with whom you had to tread carefully – strike too hard, too soon and you'd be frozen out permanently. The frosty nature of her relationship (if you could call it that) with Glimmer was testament to it.

"That's a more complicated question." Catra's eyebrow arched with suspicion at Bow's response, "Adora first."

Clearly thrown off by what he'd said, Catra tilted her head, dropping her leg to the floor so she could sit up straight.

"She's good." Bow stayed quiet, making it clear he expected her to elaborate. "We've just been taking things slow..." Her voice trailed off momentarily. "It was good I moved in with Entrapta at the start. We've been able to let things go a bit more… naturally."

"But…?"

Catra sighed, her eyes fixated on her hands. Her voice was barely audible; Bow had to strain to hear her.

"It's just hard to get a handle on things. Like, if she says she loves me, how do I know that she actually does? That it's not part of some plan?"

Bow waited for her, keenly aware that Catra had probably never said any of this aloud. He hadn't expected the conversation to turn in this direction, but he felt oddly warm inside that she trusted him this much, that he must make her feel safe.

"What if I do something that makes her… I just… I always set people off, right? And I really, *really* don't want…" She paused for what felt like hours, "I don't want to make her hate me."

Bow stretched his hand out on the table slowly, palm facing upwards – an open invitation for the off-chance she wanted it rather than a request. Catra's fingers twitched.

"Catra." Bow waited for her to raise her eyes, or at least meet him halfway. When she was looking at his hands, he spoke. "You never made anyone – especially not him – do anything. And the last thing you could possibly do is make Adora hate you."

Catra stayed unnervingly silent, a few rogue tears rolling down her cheeks. Bow adamantly held his tears back; he was certain that a reaction like that could be disastrously unhelpful in such a volatile conversation, especially with Catra.

"I made Glimmer hate me."

She was finally looking at him, studying his face nervously while still avoiding eye contact.

Bow took a deep breath. The only thing that was going to work here was absolute transparent honesty, even if it was hard to say.

"Catra… Glimmer hated what you did. But she's incapable of hating *you*. It's just the way she is sometimes, making it seem that way." Catra frowned. "Believe me – you're far from the only one who's been in her bad books! But seriously," Bow paused, holding the space between them with such care it seemed as if it could shatter in an instant, "she's a slow-burner when it comes to grudges but she'll come around eventually, I promise. There's just a lot going on for her right now, with the wedding and all the embryo-freezing stuff."

He felt Catra's fingers close over his at long last. It felt like a kind of victory – of what, he wasn't sure.

"She cares about Adora so much. And I know that if Adora loves you even a fraction of the amount that it is *abundantly* clear she does, she'll be your biggest fan. She's just taking a little longer to move past stuff, okay?"

Catra sniffed. They sat in the sun for a while longer, breaking their hands apart to drink their final beer in the flight. A while later, they got ready to leave, Catra embracing Bow in a hug different to any he remembered them sharing before.

"Thank you."

"You bought the drinks, Cat."

He held her for a moment longer, knowing she was soundlessly grateful to him for cutting through the heaviness of it all.

"See ya next week, Arrow Boy."

"Not if I see you first."

ONE AND A HALF YEARS PRIOR

"You can't tell Adora, okay?"

Catra looked up at Bow in surprise. It wasn't typical for one of them to invoke a secrecy pact when it came to their partners.

"Okay."

Bow hesitated, unsure if he should press ahead.

"I mean it. Glimmer is being very bunker mode about the entire thing, and she doesn't even know the half of it."

"It's just between us. What's going on?"

Bow could read the concern on Catra's face. They'd had a lot of difficult conversations over the years, to the point where they

could grade levels of anxiety in a single glance, or sense how much a joke had really landed to minute degree.

In the grand scheme of things, this really wasn't such a big secret, was it? If anything, it was just premature. *We were planning on telling them both in a couple of weeks anyway. You'd have to start this conversation before then, sooner rather than later.*

"Bow. You can tell me anything."

He paused as the bartender set their beers in front of them. Catra's eyes were trained on him hawkishly; he forgot how intense she could be when her attention was wholly focused on something. Bow took a long first sip of his drink. Catra followed suit, no ritual whatsoever.

Here we go.

"We decided we're ready."

Catra tilted her brow towards him in question.

"For a baby. We've been researching how to find a surrogate."

"Wow." Catra's hand grasped his on the bar, "Bow, that's incredible."

Bow pulled his hand away, his knee shaking.

"She's so excited about it. I haven't seen her be so hopeful about it all in years."

"So what's the problem? This is good, isn't it?"

Bow trembled as he inhaled. *No going back.*

"I didn't tell anyone that I invested half my savings in MystaCorp."

Catra's eyes widened. Bow didn't need to hear her say it to know it was running through her mind: *Oh, fuck.*

A good four or five years ago, he'd been at the end of his tether. His boss at Arrow Tech was fucking him around, shifting his deadlines left, right and centre. And for two quarters in a row, Bow's commission structure was tweaked, each time cheating him out of his full bonus on negligible margins. He'd been so unbelievably close to packing it all in and taking Catra up on her frequently repeated offer to join her newly established team.

But then an old friend had reached out, looking for a final investor for his start-up. Bow had reviewed the business plans at length with his financial advisor; moreover, the other investors were completely legit. He put in the money from all his bonuses over the previous few years that hadn't already gone into their wedding or the fertility treatment. It wasn't that he didn't tell Glimmer – he *had* to make sure Catra understood this – it's just that at the time, she'd been a little depressed since they cancelled the honeymoon, and she'd made it clear before that she trusted him with money more than she did herself. She knew that he'd put some money into a promising venture, but not exactly what and not quite how much.

He could still feel the chill of his blood running cold when he got a call from his broker twelve weeks ago. MystaCorp, which had been performing significantly above expectations and had accrued a shit ton of cash so far, had suffered a monumental security failure just days before he'd planned to sell his shares. It had been the biggest news in the entire tech community all year; a cautionary tale that Catra, more than anyone else, was acutely aware of. The tens of thousands he was planning to move into their joint savings account – that would fund any additional expenses incurred in their path to a family – melted into nothing.

"I thought I'd have more time to build it back up. I've got other stocks that are performing better, but not quickly enough, not even with my joining bonus from the new job. And I can't do this to her – after everything that's happened, I can't be the thing getting in the way of what she deserves. I'd never forgive myself."

Catra’s stable voice steadied him, her question almost business-like.

“How expensive is it, to get the surrogate?”

“If it’s not someone you know who's volunteered, it’s really bad.”

“Shit.”

Bow let out a single explosive sob; through all their years of friendship, he’d never properly cried in front of Catra, but admitting the gravity of the situation had taken a toll on him far greater than he’d anticipated.

“I don’t know how to tell her.”

Catra took Bow’s left hand in both of hers.

“We’ll figure it out. If there’s a will, there’s a way.”

“Catra-“

“I promise you, okay?”

Catra's words were comforting, but Bow couldn't imagine what kind of solution she could possibly come up for something as big as this.

"Let's work out how you can talk to Glim first, and leave the rest until later."

True to form, Catra never said a word to anyone about what Bow had told her. But when Glimmer insisted they share their news before he'd worked up the courage to intercept her, he hadn't known what to do. For months afterwards, he'd replay Catra's knee-jerk offer over and over again in his head.

This was completely nuts, wasn't it?

Bow felt trapped helplessly between shame, gratitude and relief. But above all, he was desperate to make sure Glimmer was never

let down again.

Chapter 10

Chapter Notes

Apologies for the slow update... it has been a very intense week, work-wise and personally. But we made it to the weekend!

If you want a soundtrack, the song referenced in the first part is First Aid Kit's cover of Kate Bush's 'Running Up That Hill' (absolute tune), which has been playing in my head on loop.

As always, please do feed me comments! I love hearing your thoughts and they really help me think of new ideas and directions that improve the plan in my head for this fic :)

NINE WEEKS PRIOR

It had been two hours since she spoke to Bow and Adora still hadn't managed to get through to Catra.

This is not like her.

It didn't help that Adora's brain was still unbearably fuzzy from the string of nightshifts she'd pulled that week - it had taken her thirty minutes just to realise that Catra had taken the car keys. *She really could be anywhere by now…* It was equally unhelpful that Adora's stubbornness was stopping her from calling Bow back. She knew both he and Glimmer would be there in an instant if she asked them to drive her around. She just didn't want to prove them right. *Catra's past all that - she'd never take off like that again. She wouldn't leave me!*

Would she?

Her stomach throbbed as it rumbled, dulling her mind further.

Adora hadn’t eaten for nearly twenty hours, but the idea of cooking rather than working out where Catra had gone seemed untenable. She steadied herself on the kitchen counter for a second, staring at Bow’s contact details on her phone and the list of missed calls she’d had from him and Glimmer in the past hour. *Just call them, for fuck’s sake. The only important thing is that we find her!*

She tore her eyes away from the screen with a groan as her stomach twisted again.

Well, I won’t be any help if I faint, will I?

Adora wrenched the fridge door open, picking at the leftovers Catra had boxed up the day before. She couldn’t justify warming up or plating anything; she just stood in the cold light of the fridge, door ajar, trying to ignore the countless intrusive thoughts pulsing through her.

If you really love her as much as you think you do, you’d know where she went

It must be the baby - you got too domestic. You scared her

You should have hidden it better; you made her feel like she pushed you away

This is all their fault - you should never have agreed to do this

You’re a terrible person – they were your friends first and now you’re screwing everything up! Don’t you want them to be happy?

What kind of person even are you?

Adora couldn’t eat any longer. She shoved the Tupperware plastic back onto the shelf clumsily, barely sealing the lid as nausea

washed over her.

She had to get past this. She ran through the list of all the places she'd checked Catra could be so far.

There's nothing in her calendar.

She's not at the hospital.

She hasn't gone to see Scorpia.

She isn't with police.

She can't be at a pub – she only ever used to go with Bow anyway.

She thinks the cinema is boring.

The pizza place she likes is shut on Mondays.

None of the neighbours say she's visited them (though why the hell would she?)

She'd never have gone to the gym for more than an hour, especially not now.

It's too late for her to be swimming, she hates it after school hours when the pool's full of kids and pushy parents.

It's too dark for any of her old walking routes.

They haven't seen her at the supermarket.

Adora's eye caught Catra's guitar on its stand in the corner of the living room. She'd been a little down the past couple of weeks as her belly had gotten too big to play it anymore, not even if she shifted it to the side – the angle just wrecked her wrist. But that wasn't cause for concern, was it? Adora tore through her memories of the past month, looking for any clue. Catra had been humming some acoustic 80s cover under her breath for days. Adora hadn't thought much of it, even though the lyrics were kind

of fragile. Afterall, it's not like Catra - who was totally fine the last time Adora saw her - was having some kind of mental breakdown that she was too blinkered to see coming. One song didn't mean anything, did it?

No, of course it can't. Can it? Oh my God, you are going absolutely fucking mad.

It was no use. Adora had to get her shit together and get on the road before she lost all sense of sanity. She decided to give herself one more out before she finally gave in and returned Bow's calls.

For the third time that hour, she rang Entrapta's mobile – finally, *thank God,* her call didn't go to voicemail.

"Adora! I see you've rung me twice already since 5:32pm. Are you running an experiment?"

Adora fought to keep her tone steady. She usually had such patience for Entrapta's distinctive way of seeing the world, but after the day she'd had... "No, Entrapta. I-"

"Hmm… in that case, it seems like there might be some kind of emergency that required you to ring me multiple times. But as we have been making very important progress on the alpha component of our testing before it progresses to the beta stage, it has been entirely necessary to work in a closed environment with no distractions!"

Adora stopped listening. *We? Does this mean Catra's just been working all day on some stupid piece of software?*

Adora didn't know whether she was feeling extreme anger, relief or plain ass hope. She interrupted Entrapta mid-sentence.

"Please, can you just put Catra on?"

"Catra?" Adora's heart sunk as Entrapta's confusion seeped through her words, "Adora, Catra is on maternity leave because

she is 34.5 weeks pregnant."

Adora rolled her eyes. There was no 'point five' when it came to pregnancy, and Entrapta's insatiable need for granularity had driven her round the bend for months (even when she was in a good mood).

"I *know* that-"

"This is a highly surprising conversation given your profession and severe tendency towards overprotectiveness in relation to Catra." Adora groaned as Entrapta continued, oblivious to her attempts to get a word in edgeways. "Are you not tracking her progress even though you will not be raising the child?"

"Yes, we are tracking it, Entrapta. But Catra has been missing all day."

"Missing? Is she not resting at home for her health? That is the primary purpose of maternity leave, according to company guidance."

"She's not at home. And because she isn't answering her phone, I can't figure out where she is."

"Oh. That is quite concerning."

"Yeah. It is."

A silence settled between them for a second.

"Well, no worry – I'll just track Catra's phone. It'll only take seconds to find her!"

Adora bristled. *Does Entrapta think I'm a complete idiot?* She had already tried checking the GPS location of Catra's phone multiple times but it was turned off, and she couldn't see anything on their bank records suggesting that Catra had bought anything the entire day using her phone or by card; not even food or water.

"I've tried that, Entrapta!"

Entrapta laughed heartily, fully tickled. Adora's blood could have boiled.

"You don't have my equipment, Adora! I'm the only person with encrypted access to the tracker I placed on Catra's devices."

"You tracked her?"

The clash of outrage and relief swallowed her up once again. She could hear Entrapta typing furiously on her keyboard already, the violent clattering of her fingertips echoing down the phone line.

"Of course! You do remember that Catra has disappeared multiple times since we attended university? Not to mention the fact that she is always leaving the office for hours at a time because she says she-"

A lightbulb went off in Adora's head. *How didn't I think of this sooner?*

"She thinks better at the park."

"Well, she's not at the one she usually likes right now, but I have the co-ordinates-"

All of a sudden, Adora's brain fog lifted and the dread that had consumed her body for hours started to drain out.

"'Trapta, I know where she is."

FOUR YEARS PRIOR

Adora watched Catra with bated breath. They'd both gone very, very still: one in anticipation, the other in disbelief.

"D'you mean it?"

Catra's words confused Adora.

"Of course… I want this more than anythi-!"

She couldn't finish her sentence before Catra was on top of her, her lips pressing against Adora's with unbelievable certainty. Catra's weight pressed her deeper and deeper into the grass; she could feel the prickle of every blade and the fuzz of crushed dandelions under the exposed skin of her back.

"There's kids everywhere." Adora murmured limply into Catra's cheek, only half committed.

"Doesn't sound to me like you care much."

Adora moaned as Catra nipped at her bottom lip, kissing her back chastely to try and slow them down. This action was having an effect on her; and not the kind she could respond to at 2pm on a Saturday afternoon in public.

She rubbed at Catra's arm soothingly, exhaling as she felt Catra shift off of her and curl into her side, the warmth of Catra's head on Adora's chest soaking through the thin linen of her sundress. She wished they could do this every day, forever; it reminded her why she'd asked the question in the first place.

"So, I take it that's a yes?"

Catra's arm tightened around her waist, but she didn't say anything. Adora waited for what felt like an eternity. She couldn't hear anything but the steady rise and fall of Catra's breath, just as consistent as it was before Adora couldn't stop herself from blurting it out. She'd wanted to ask for weeks, but she didn't know how. And then she recognised it. This was the moment. They were in one of Catra's favourite places, and thanks to the deal

she'd closed the day before on the company's third app, she was in a fantastic mood. The conditions couldn't be better.

Adora's heart started to drum faster, her panic only exacerbated by the realisation that Catra's face was laid right across her sternum, and she'd never even be able to pretend that she wasn't about to break due to the disappointment.

"I want to. But…"

Adora pushed herself to be reasonable. She was moving too fast, and it had been so good for them, having space and taking it slow.

"I-It's best if you stay with Entrapta. What with the company and everything." She squeezed Catra's arm, willing the devastation to hold off until she could get herself home and into bed to process the whole thing alone. "I get it."

"No!"

Adora's eyes blinked open, a couple of stray tears streaming out that she couldn't hold in.

"That's not what I meant!"

Catra pushed herself up on her elbow, gasping slightly as she saw the tear-tracks on Adora's face.

"You idiot." She smoothed her thumb over Adora's cheeks softly, soaking up the damp trails. "I want to move in with you so, so badly."

Adora stared up into Catra's eyes. She understood the science, but really, she could never quite get her head around how they could be so starkly, beautifully different. She got lost sometimes, stuck halfway between those amber and teal irises.

"It's just…" Adora watched as conflict contorted Catra's face, before she lay herself back down on her chest. She waited again

for Catra to say something. Then eventually: "I need some time to think before I can explain it properly."

"Okay."

Adora closed her eyes, running her hand through Catra's hair absentmindedly. She knew Catra must be deep in thought; she'd never let her ruin her curls like this usually, especially in this heat and when they had a long walk back through the city.

Maybe thirty minutes had passed before she heard Catra speak again, a definite cautiousness clear in her tone.

"You know when we were kids and I'd sneak out early from school?"

Catra paused for long enough that Adora didn't feel like she was interrupting. "I hated it when you did that. It made me-"

"Worry, I know. But after you got fostered, I couldn't help myself. I'd just find myself in Garnet Park without even realising where I was going."

"Garnet Park? That's kind of a rough part of town."

"Everywhere around the Fright Zone was a rough part of town, Adora. Remember?"

It had been a long time since either of them had mentioned the old nickname for the neighbourhood of their care home. It was like they'd had an unspoken agreement to censor it out since they left for Bright Moon.

"Anyway," Catra continued, her eyelashes fluttering against Adora's breast as she blinked, "I just felt like I couldn't think straight until I was there. And most the time, I only thought about the same thing over and over again."

"What was it?"

She heard Catra gulp nervously.

"Where my home was supposed to be if you weren't there."

Oh.

Adora's heart swelled. Her voice came out in a squeak.

"Even then?"

"Especially then. I just didn't understand what it meant."

A cloud passed over them, shielding them from the sun. Adora teased her eyes open further than her previous squint.

"So, come home."

Catra sighed, sadness spreading through the air between them.

"That's the point. I never chose anywhere, did I? I just fell into one place after another, wherever someone wanted me or where I could afford."

Adora waited for her to say it.

"I've never really had a home of my own."

"And you're not sure you just want to move into mine?"

Catra fell quiet for a few seconds, her breaths soft.

"I want something that's mine… *Ours*."

Adora could practically hear the gears working in Catra's head. She'd never ask Adora to do it, but she didn't really need to.

"We'll have to start looking then."

"…Really? But you love your place. *I* love your place."

“Catra. It’s not your home. So, it’s not mine either. Besides, we could probably find something decent if we bought together.”

“Adora-“

“I’m tired of throwing away half my pay check on rent.”

She felt Catra squeeze her fingers.

“So, we’ll find a flat? We’re really doing this?”

“Mm-hmm. Together.”

NINE WEEKS PRIOR

By now, the autumn sky was a thick navy, dull stars in the distance just visible over the grimy streetlamps.

Adora couldn’t believe what she was seeing: Catra dozing under a tree, a large brown envelope still gripped tightly in her hands on her lap.

It had been years since she’d been here – no, decades. She glanced back at Bow’s car as she made her way across the uneven tarmac, dodging jagged cracks and miniature potholes. She was grateful they’d listened to her and agreed to stay in the car while she looked for Catra; there were shades of shame that Adora still grappled with, and she didn’t have the resilience right now for Bow and Glimmer to see where she came from or who she really was. The Fright Zone would have that effect on you – it could yank the biggest insecurities out of you in seconds, undoing all the therapy, self-actualisation, and years of having parents who could – and did! – actually love you.

Even when it was totally empty, Garnet Park somehow looked almost exactly the same as she remembered it. There were just a few more overfilled recycling bins dotted around, and an extra dent or two in the fence. She wondered whether the kids that hung out here these days did the same things they used to do; whether there was another mini runner who ran laps around the grass, cheered on by her best friend. Or a group cramming themselves into the faded rubber tyre swing, shoving each other off and claiming dibs on that one outside spot that always got higher, moved faster, felt freer to sit on. It dawned on Adora that she didn't have a single memory of being here that hadn't involved Catra. It was strange to think that Catra's memories of this park must be so entirely different.

How many times had Catra sat here alone, just like she was doing now?

Adora shook her head, wondering how on earth she'd managed to stay here all day. Catra must be the only heavily pregnant person she'd ever interacted with who'd rather get twigs up her arse than sit in the comfort of her own home to relax. Though knowing her girlfriend, Adora doubted Catra had come here for that purpose.

She approached Catra with tremendous cautiousness. The last thing she wanted to do was shock her to death.

She knelt by her, ghosting her thumb over the back of Catra's hand, adding pressure slowly but surely.

"Catra." Adora spoke so softly, she wondered if she stood out from the cool wind at all. "It's time to wake up."

Slowly, Catra started to stir, sucking in her breath as her eyes began to squint open.

"Adora?"

Adora held Catra's cheek in her hand. Her skin was so cold.

"What are you doing here?"

“What am *I* doing here? This is my tree.”

Adora started rubbing Catra’s right hand between both of hers, trying to warm her up. She really needed to buy her a new coat, even if it was just for the next couple of months – despite her protestations, Catra really couldn’t spend the whole winter with her coat open thanks to the bump.

“Your tree, huh?”

“Yeah.”

Catra brought her hand up to her Adora’s face this time.

“You look so worried.”

“I’ve been looking for you all day.”

“You have?” Catra frowned, apparently only just noticing the night sky. “What time is it?”

“It’s seven thirty, babe.”

“It is?”

“Yeah. You’ve been missing all day. Gave us quite a scare.”

“Oh, shit… I’m sorry, I really didn’t mean-” Catra’s eyes widened in fear, a realisation washing over her, “’Are Bow and Glimmer okay? Are they mad at me?”

“No, no… they’re not mad. But you can’t do this, you know.” Adora rested her hand on Catra’s stomach, her touch reciprocated with a firm nudge from the inside. Catra winced. “Not like this.”

“Not with my track record.”

Adora didn’t know how to respond. She didn’t like to talk about it, the times she’d had no idea where Catra was, who had her, whether she’d ever see her again. She’d planned to get Catra warmed up in the car, back home ASAP. But she could tell Catra

needed more time. And when it came to what Catra needed, it was never an option for Adora not to give it. She hung on, waiting for Catra to continue, trying not to worry about the temperature and the fact that Catra likely hadn't eaten in hours.

"I'm so tired, 'Dor. I haven't been anywhere without thinking about whether they'd be okay with it. It's nothing they've done or said… But sometimes I feel like I'm just a vessel and not a human anymore."

Adora felt heavy. She'd no idea Catra was feeling so powerless in the situation; she always seemed so assured and in control throughout this whole pregnancy.

"It's not long now. And then it won't matter. We can go wherever we want. We can get *sushi*!"

Catra laughed softly.

"Fuck me, I never thought it was possible to crave uncooked fish so much!"

The shake of her shoulders rustled the stiff envelope still clutched in Catra's left hand, catching Adora's attention.

"What's this?"

Catra looked down, suddenly fixated on the envelope.

"Oh. I've been staring at it all day. I can't bring myself to open it… That's kind of why I came here." Catra turned it over in her fingers, tracing her name printed on its front. "When I got my funding applications back from BMU, I didn't open them for days. I came here, and eventually I could. But it's not working. I still can't do it."

"What's in there?"

Catra finally caught Adora's eye, her voice barely a whisper. "My records. I never thought I'd get access."

“Catra…”

“I picked them up from the home first thing. I was going to read them after the ante-natal-” She froze, eyes flicking ahead in alarm. “Oh shit, I completely forgot!”

“Don’t worry about it.”

Catra sighed heavily. “I just… I didn’t expect it to throw me like this. I drove round and round in circles. Must have been hours. And then I was here.”

“Your thinking spot.”

“Yeah.” Catra stared ahead, wistfully. “I always thought this, well, this place, was who I was. But what if I’ve been wrong all this time? What if I’m someone else?”

Adora opened her mouth to speak, but Catra turned to her, her eyes full of trepidation. “What if I have a family, and they still don’t want me?”

Adora took Catra’s shaking hands in hers, their palms closing around the envelope. She leaned forward, resting their foreheads together.

“You have a family, ok? And I want you so, so much. Know why?” Catra sniffed, her chin quivering. “Because I know *exactly* who you are, and it isn’t the Fright Zone, or what’s in that envelope. It’s your courage and kindness. Generosity, intelligence. Your determination. It’s how you’ve overcome more shit than anyone I’ve ever known and still somehow manage to make room for so many people. And the only thing I care about in the entire world is how I get to be the person that loves you.”

She leaned in, kissing Catra tenderly.

“I don’t want you to forget that, ever.”

Catra shivered as they huddled together; Adora could feel Catra's stomach shifting in their embrace, her hand coming up to rest on the side of her rounded belly. It was incredible, how much had changed, how normal it felt now. She got to her feet, starting the awkward process of getting Catra to her feet and supporting her balance as she shook out the pins and needles. Catra directed her to where she'd parked the car, waiting for Adora to text Bow and Glimmer that they'd make their own way home before handing her the keys to drive.

Safely buckled in, they sat in silence as the heater got going, Adora passing Catra a cereal bar from her pocket that Bow and Glimmer had brought from home.

"Will you open it with me? When we get home?"

Of course, Adora did, holding Catra as she cried, trying to make sense of the history that neither of them would have expected to unfold in front of them. Gaining access to a world so unfamiliar, they would never have guessed that day how much of a role one thin envelope would play in their path ahead.

Chapter 11

Chapter Notes

This might be the longest one yet, so buckle up!
Comments/feedback always deeply appreciated :)

SIX YEARS PRIOR

They'd been having the same conversation for weeks, going round and round in circles.

"I just don't get it, Glim. Am I going mad?"

For the umpteenth time, Glimmer squeezed Adora under the covers, shaking her head.

"Of course not, hon. The signals were super confusing."

Adora let out a frustrated whine.

"I was so sure of it, you know? It seemed like she *really* liked me. And it doesn't make sense, how all of it can add up to nothing! The touching, and the lingering hugs and the 'oh my God, you smell so good'…" Adora's eyes rolled back into her head as she put on a mocking voice. "Not to mention she didn't tell me she had a boyfriend for three months! Three months! Who she'd repeatedly referred to as a *friend*!"

Glimmer rubbed Adora's shoulder soothingly. She was so thoroughly bored of hearing this spiral again, but she'd never let Adora know that – the only way she'd ever gotten anything out of her system was to talk about it until her brain was fried and there was nothing left of it in her soul.

Holy Mother, please let her get over this goddamn straight girl soon.

"I mean, who the fuck does that?" Adora faltered, her tone suddenly becoming melancholy. "How could I get it so wrong?"

"Hey, don't be so hard on yourself! Honestly, it kind of seems like she *did* feel something but didn't know what to do with it." Glimmer scolded herself mentally as she realised she might have just prolonged the cool-off period she'd been trying so hard to hasten; she had to get it back on track, stat. "Look, either way – she's clearly immature and can't see past her own nose. Do you actually want to be with someone who fucks you about like that? It's kind of a red flag, babe."

Adora quietened for a second – like she always did at this point in the conversation – and curled her legs tighter under herself, breaking off a square of chocolate from one of the many half-eaten bars strewn across the duvet over them.

"I just wish it could be easier. Seems like when everyone else likes someone, they like them back. But I'm stuck trying to work out if a girl is woke or gay."

Glimmer chuckled. Finally, things had taken a different turn than usual.

"Woke or gay, huh?"

"The perennial question!" Adora jabbed a finger in the air before their faces. "Honestly, it's like I'm on the waiting list for a gaydar upgrade. Social justice is ruining my love life!"

Glimmer raised an eyebrow, laughing at her friend. Adora harumphed, knowing full well she was being ridiculous.

"You say some really dumb shit sometimes, Adora."

"Yeah well, easy for you to say, Miss 'just casually fell in love with my best friend and now I'm getting married and in five years, I'll probably have like a million insanely gorgeous babies'."

Glimmer nudged Adora jokingly. "I think a million is probably a stretch."

Glimmer watched as Adora buried herself further into the pillows. She hoped things would take a turn for the better soon for her friend: over the past couple of years since Glimmer had moved in with Bow and Adora had found her own place closer to work – the decision that had saved their friendship following the eventful visit of *she who must not be named* – Adora had suffered the failures of one consecutive almost-romance after another. Glimmer could understand her frustration. It can't have been easy, watching your two closest friends move on together in the very way that you'd always craved. And there was something about the way Adora navigated romance that made Glimmer suspect she was secretly holding out for someone; she always seemed to chase flirtations that were obviously doomed to fail.

Her mind flitted back to Adora's offhanded baby comment, holding her attention a little longer than she'd have liked. A few weeks ago, she (and consequently, Bow) had caught a horrific viral bug, and her stomach was much slower to fully recover than his – extreme nausea had become an unwanted yet expected part of her morning routine. In all honesty, she couldn't remember whether she'd managed to keep the pill down every day; time had become a fuzzy, incongruous thing when they were in the thick of it. Glimmer resolved that if the queasiness didn't pass over the next few weeks, she'd get herself checked out properly. What did she always tell Adora? *No point panicking before there's even a problem.*

The sound of Adora's phone ringing jarred her out of her thoughts.

"Weird, it's a withheld number."

Glimmer stretched her arms out, wondering who could be calling at 1am in the morning to interrupt their impromptu sleepover. She only half-listened as Adora answered a string of questions on the phone, not paying attention to the stark change in her demeanour

until Adora dragged herself groggily out of bed, pulling a jumper on over her pyjama top and stepping out her shorts.

"Okay, I'm on my way in – I'll be there in thirty."

Glimmer peered at Adora from the bed.

"What's going on? It's really late."

Adora swiped her leggings and socks off the floor and pulled them on, not even stopping to look at Glimmer. "I have to go to the hospital."

"Oh, I thought you weren't on call?"

"I'm not." Glimmer noticed Adora had paused, her whole body tensing up a little. She laid her palm on Adora's shoulder to reassure her, rubbing it gently with her thumb. *What could be going on?* "They have Catra." Glimmer's hand stilled. "Apparently I'm registered as her emergency contact."

Catra? I should have known she'd turn up again.

Adora seemed to be waiting for her to say something, but she must have taken too long; she shrugged Glimmer's hand off her shoulder, pinching the bridge of her nose between her fingers. Glimmer could tell Adora was super stressed – that had always been her tell.

"Fuck, it's too late to bike. I'm gonna have to call an Uber."

Glimmer sat in silence as Adora jammed her Doc Martens on, tugging a windbreaker over her hoodie. She looked in the mirror for a second, then pulled it off again, trying on a denim jacket instead. Adora's right leg was shaking with nervous energy.

Is she seriously worrying about what she's wearing right now? There's definitely more to this than she's let on.

Glimmer groaned to herself. *I am such a good fucking friend sometimes.*

"Come on, 'Dora. I'll drive you."

Glimmer could have winced at the surprise on Adora's face as she reached to put her bra back on under the oversized t-shirt she'd borrowed when she'd spontaneously agreed to stay over.

"Really?"

"Yes. Now shut up and grab the chocolate. The only way we're getting through this is with sugar."

Adora had barely moved an inch by the time Glimmer was ready to leave, keys in hand.

"Jesus, Adora, what are you hanging around for? Come on!"

That seemed to jog Adora out of her stupor; the two of them left the apartment and made into the night, the flashing lights of Glimmer and Bow's car illuminating the pavement ahead of them as she unlocked it. They bundled in, and it wasn't long until they were already on the main road, alone aside from a few drifters and a cruising police car in the distance.

The drive went more quickly than they anticipated at this time of night; Glimmer was grateful for that. The whole time, Adora's ceaseless fidgeting plucked at her nerves. It wasn't until they got to the hospital and Glimmer told Adora to go ahead while she found somewhere to park that she felt like she could breathe again.

Glimmer wasn't sure what was going to happen next. Parked up, she sat in the car for another ten minutes, hands still gripped on the steering wheel. She had no idea what kind of state Catra was going to be in, what Catra would want from Adora, or what response Adora would have to her. But Glimmer already felt so out of control, and she could feel the anger simmering under her skin already. She still felt so weak from that bug; the last thing she

needed was an explosive argument with Adora over Catra. She did the only thing that made sense.

Glimmer waited while the calling tone played out through the car speakers.

Please pick up, please pick up.

"Glim?" Glimmer inhaled as Bow's drowsy voice trickled through the air. "Everything okay?"

"She's back."

"What? Who? Aren't you staying over at Adora's?"

"It's Catra."

"*Catra*? Glim, what are you talking about?"

"Catra's back," Glimmer's voice finally cracked, "We're at the hospital."

Bow sounded more alert now. "Hold up – lemme take a step back. You're at the hospital? And Catra is there?"

"Adora got a call. But I don't know what's going on. I just… I don't know if I can hold my shit together around her."

"Okay-"

"Bow, I'm so angry I could literally combust. It's like that night all over again."

"Come home. I'll text Adora. She can get a cab later, it'll be fine."

"I can't do that. I should-"

"Yes, you can. You blow up at Adora and it's game over. And if she's sick enough to be in hospital, laying into Catra is only going to make it worse." He paused. "Love, I know it seems right now like it would, but it really won't feel good."

Glimmer groaned. He was right. This was why she called him, wasn't it? To talk her down. She told Bow she'd be back in twenty and fired off a short apology text to Adora, so quick that there wasn't time to change her mind.

Not such a good friend after all, then.

On the way home, she let herself speed up a little more on the motorway than she should, the thrill of risk tapping into her adrenaline.

She crawled into bed next to Bow, relief sinking into her when she felt his arm fold around her in the darkness.

"You stayed up?"

"Mmmhmm." His throat was thick with sleep.

"I'm the worst friend."

"Shhh." Bow nestled into the curve of Glimmer's neck. "Lesser evils."

It took Glimmer ages to get to sleep, her ear half trained on her phone, expecting a notification from Adora or some kind of confirmation that she hadn't… what? Fucked up? Behaved in exactly the kind of way she suspected Adora thought she did when they lived together: *selfish, controlling, domineering*? Adora had never said anything but Glimmer always felt self-conscious about it, especially after that first argument in the gym. Their bickering had gotten worse for weeks before Bow eventually intervened.

Eventually, Glimmer drifted into dreams that would play on her mind for days, spotlighting all her anxieties about where she'd stand with Adora now Catra was back, and how she'd possibly keep herself from tearing Catra apart when she saw her… *if* she saw her.

All Glimmer really believed was that forgiveness wasn't something anyone inherently deserved on principle – whether she was asking for it or dishing it out herself.

Adora slipped through the cubicle curtains tentatively, unsure of what she was going to find.

She'd found herself greeted by police officers when she arrived, a slew of questions probing her knowledge of what she knew about Catra's recent whereabouts, her past relationship with Prime and what she knew about some guy called Drew. She'd been utterly useless for the most part, but the officers didn't seem that surprised. Apparently, there had been barely any record of Catra existing since they graduated from university. Aside from a few months working at Google – that stunned her a little, but she wasn't sure why – there were no bank records, utility bills or phone contracts in Catra's name; she hadn't even visited a doctor. Adora was almost glad she was so clueless. She had no idea if anything she could know might be incriminating, to Catra or anyone else. Her fists tensed as she thought of how she'd barely managed to convince Glimmer not to report Catra to the police the last time she'd resurfaced; clearly, it would have been disastrous if the only record Catra had was criminal.

By 2:45am, they were done and said she could check in on Catra the next morning if she wanted; she'd been involved in some kind of traffic incident, and it had been decided to keep her in for a couple of days just in case.

Just in case what?

Adora couldn't find out directly from the doctors as she wasn't Catra's next of kin, even if she was listed as her emergency contact. But she sure as hell wasn't waiting until the morning to

find out, not while she had her hospital fob in her pocket and could unlock the security doors of the acute admissions ward herself.

She snuck past the nurse on night shift while he was washing his hands, catching Catra's surname on the boards of the room right ahead of her. Creeping through the doors, quick not to disturb any other patients in there, Adora found her. There wasn't time to hesitate; she practically raced to Catra's bedside, her eyes slowly adjusting to the dim light as she pulled the cubicle curtains around them. She steadied herself for a second, taking a deep breath before she turned round to face Catra.

She needn't have been so worried – Catra was fast asleep on her side, her breaths so shallow and distressed you'd think she hadn't slept in months, always waiting for a threat to emerge, never fully able to relinquish herself to rest. Adora crept closer to look at her; careful, tentative steps.

Bruises bloomed all over Catra's back and torso, deep purples and scarlet grazes visible even in the shadows. Adora could just about see there was still some bleeding on her left side; damp patches had started to seep through some of the bigger dressings, and there was still some fresh blood mottling the edge of her hairline and the corners of her mouth.

Adora's hand acted way before her brain caught up – all of a sudden, she noticed Catra stirring, a low painful groan easing its way out of her; she pulled her hand away from Catra's tangled curls as if she'd been burned, berating herself for being stupid enough to get swept away in the moment.

You don't know her anymore. You can't just touch her, especially not in this condition!

A slurred, feeble voice pierced the air: "You came?"

In the hurricane of her thoughts, Adora had completely missed that Catra was already staring at her uncertainly as if she were a

hologram, reddened eyes barely open but attentive.

Adora's words got stuck in her throat. *You wanted me?*

Catra coughed, her weakened body immediately shrinking back from the pain it caused, fresh blood lightly spattering from her mouth onto the hospital pillow. She groaned, unable to reach out for a tissue. Finally, Adora sprung into action. Catra grimaced as Adora dabbed at her lips with a tissue, recoiling sharply at the touch of Adora's hand on her chin, her eyes squeezing shut instantaneously in response. Adora thought she looked kind of afraid, like she was anticipating something about to happen next.

Okay, so we're looking at internal bleeding. Doesn't seem like any major broken bones, aside from maybe a rib… hard to tell how those bandages are placed in this light. She doesn't like being touched, though. Is it the pain, or is it…?

Adora's brain froze. Had the inkling in the back of her mind been right all those years ago? And she'd just let it happen, let Catra stay with him, not fought to keep her safe? Catra had never mentioned Prime the last time she turned up, but was he why she'd disappeared again? Is this why the police had so many questions about him?

Has he been hurting her all this time?

A sore gurgle – halfway between a sob and a gasp – escaped Adora's mouth. Catra stirred again, her voice small.

"I didn't think you'd come."

All Adora wanted to do was throw her arms around Catra and scream that *of course* she came, she'd always come running if Catra wanted her, there was nothing in the world that could have stopped her. But instead, she forced herself into the stiff plastic chair next to the bed, placing her hand on the edge of the mattress; close to Catra, but without threat of contact.

"All you ever had to do was call."

Catra stared at Adora's fingers for what felt like an eternity, and then, for the first time in over two years, their eyes met. Catra's lip twitched as if there was something she wanted to say but didn't know how, or had decided against it. Slowly, her eyes closed again, and she drifted off into a fitful sleep.

Adora hugged her knees to her chest, willing herself to get some rest as well. But with the familiar feeling of shame building inside her and the frequency of startling outbursts Catra let out as she dozed, Adora knew the old beast of guilty insomnia that chased her when she was first fostered was on its way to get her.

Us against the world, right? Adora fixated on the promises they'd whispered under tattered sheets and blankets for years, that she'd so miserably failed to keep. *They can't keep us apart.*

The minutes passed so slowly, yet simultaneously far too fast.

Adora pressed on the crick in her neck, rolling her head to try and ease the stiffness. She'd ended up staying in the hospital all night, luckily waking just in time to sneak out before the day nurses came in for their morning rounds. Catra had still been asleep; a quick peek at the medication Kardex at the foot of her bed had told Adora the amount of pain killers they had her on would knock her out for hours – she'd been amazed Catra had woken at all in the night.

I wonder if she'll even remember…

Distracted by the crushing fear that Catra could easily discharge herself and disappear at any minute, Adora's eyes had been trained on her watch all day; even the overseeing consultant had called her out, asking if she had somewhere more important to be. Adora had spilled the whole story of being called into the hospital without even realising it, her exhaustion swiftly

dismantling the filter she'd spent years building up around the more senior doctors. But for once, her blabbermouth hadn't wrought negative consequences – she found herself dismissed for the afternoon, sent off to sleep properly and sort out her personal affairs.

The idea of a few hours off to relax would have usually thrilled her, but Adora found her gut twisting in knots as she loitered in the staff changing rooms, gawking at the deep bags under her eyes as she psyched herself up for a second visit. Was it ironic that one of her strongest (and most traumatic) memories of Catra saw her glaring back in anger with the same dark circles?

Fuck, just get it over with.

Adora stuffed her clothes from the night before in her bag – thank God she'd had a change of clothes in her locker this morning – giving her neck one final rub. The route from maternity to acute admissions passed in slow-motion; every possible outcome of how Catra might react to seeing her again, this time in a more lucid state, ran through her head in a tormenting countdown montage.

Time's up.

She found herself at the ward doors and rang the doorbell to gain entry. It wouldn't do her well to barge in with her hospital fob today – the nurses always hated when doctors from other departments did that, and she'd already risked it once. Striding through the double doors at the sound of the entry buzzer, she loaded up with antibacterial gel, wringing her hands as she approached the reception desk.

Adora let out a huge sigh of relief as she was told Catra was still in bed, apparently in no fit state to be discharged yet. Slipping into Catra's ward, Adora noticed there was only one other patient there now, and she was thankfully fast asleep. *Maybe we'll have some privacy for this.* But she could hear voices seeping out from behind the half-open curtain around Catra's bed.

She furrowed her brow – *who could be visiting Catra?* – before realising it was the same police officers that she'd spoken to the night before. She held back, stopping by the doors, unsure whether she should stay or not.

"I don't know what you want to hear… isn't it obvious?"

Adora's ears strained to pick up what they could – Catra's voice sounded so timid and scratchy, like it hurt just to push the air through.

"We're not looking to hear anything in particular, Miss Smith," Adora couldn't stop a nervous shiver ripple through her – it had been years since she heard anyone address Catra with the common surname they'd shared as the two anonymous drop-off cases prior to her adoption by the Grays. "We're just trying to find out what happened from your perspective. You and your friend were involved in a very serious incident."

"We're not… *w-weren't* friends. She was trying to protect me." Catra's voice sounded small, twisted into barbed knots.

Weren't friends? She? Adora couldn't make sense of what she was listening to.

"Protect you?"

"From him." A pause. "Prime. He found us when we were trying to leave."

"Why were you trying to leave?"

"Why do you think? You know who he is, don't you? What he does? Isn't that why you're here? *To interrogate his slut*?" Catra's voice was rising, becoming increasingly frenzied.

"Miss Smith-"

"I tried so many times to get a…" Adora could barely listen to it any longer, Catra's words cutting through her, "And now because

of me, she's d-d…"

The shock of a loud noise next to Adora jarred her mind away from Catra's choked sob as the ward doors slammed behind the nurse supervisor, who was already storming past her towards the bed.

"Come on, gentlemen, I think that's enough questioning for now. Miss Smith needs her rest."

Adora moved to make herself scarce but it was too late; the nurse thrust open the cubicle curtains right as the police officers stepped away from Catra's bed, and Adora was caught like a rabbit in headlights, her face paling as Catra's narrowing eyes latched onto hers. Adora thought they were so full of pain and of longing – *longing for who?* – until a cold suspicion overtook, battered hands wiping tears off a sore, beaten face. Catra's bruising was far worse in the daylight.

"Shut the curtains."

And just like that, Adora felt like she was back in the park on her birthday or in the abandoned living room of her old flat, frozen out all over again.

Bow pulled up in front of the pick-up/drop-off point, surveying the two women in front of him outside the hospital doors. Thankfully, Glimmer had stayed home – that was one less drama to worry about – but it was already a sorry state of affairs.

He knew Adora had had a particularly rough time of it, convincing Catra that coming to stay at her apartment was the best option available. It hadn't helped that Glimmer tried to talk Adora out of it repeatedly since she'd collapsed on their sofa in tears earlier

that week, having rushed straight to their home after an apparently disastrous reunion of sorts.

But seeing Catra now, Bow could see exactly why Adora couldn't let her out of her sight. Blueish-black swellings were spread across the left side of her face and neck, their yellowing edges snaking all the way down to her back and shoulders. She stood stiffly, seemingly incapable of breathing freely, her eyes darting all over him as if evaluating whether it was best to stay or run, if there was still somewhere to escape to or if her fate was closing in on her.

Next to her, Adora clutched at the strap of her work rucksack, the absence of a bag for Catra made even more obvious. Apparently with nothing of her own, Catra was swamped in Adora's old BMU jumper, a pair of loose training shorts revealing slow-healing cuts and grazes on her legs

Bow had read a couple of vague local articles online about her accident - there wasn't much information, but the vague snippets Adora managed to tease out of Catra over the past week seemed to match up: a crazed criminal, the previously invisible head of one of the most prolific cyber-crime rings in the country, having allegedly hijacked a cab his unidentified girlfriend and a female associate were passengers in, reversing the ageing car into a solid concrete wall repeatedly as they were increasingly crushed under the blows.

Adora leaned forward to open the car door for Catra, a grateful smile directed at Bow as she caught his eye through the window. But Catra was remained unmoving, her eyes wide in trepidation as she stared at the backseat.

Adora tossed her rucksack into the car, straightening up again to assist Catra.

"I'll sit right next to you the whole time, Catra. It's just a short drive, I promise." Catra stared at Adora, silently pleading. Bow could only imagine how Adora had even gotten her to this point.

Bow could sense Catra's extreme anxiety even from his place behind the wheel.

"Are you sure we can't walk?"

Adora nodded slowly, resting her palm on the roof of the car, the other hand outstretched towards Catra. Bow could tell how delicately she spoke, as if even the slightest off note in her inflection would have catastrophic effect.

"It's too far, I'm sorry. Especially given your injuries. But it's okay, you can sit up front with Bow."

Adora reached towards the car door handle by the passenger seat; Catra stepped forward towards it. This close, Bow could see just how much she was trembling, her hands shaking violently. Catra flinched at the impact on her wounds as she sunk apprehensively into the seat next to him. Bow could practically smell the relief radiating off Adora – but before she could close the car door, Catra's hand had shot out, closing in a vice hold around her wrist.

"Don't! It's-"

"Catra, I'll be in the seat right behind you."

Bow could see Catra's fingers gripping Adora's arm even tighter in desperation, her nails starting to dig into pale skin. He was sure they'd reached a stalemate.

"Hey," Catra's head jerked around to him, alarm clear on her face. He reprimanded himself – he should have thought to temper his speech more, make himself gentler. "Why don't I let Adora drive?"

Catra studied him intently, clearly trying to suss him out. Finally, a nod, barely perceptible.

Bow nodded back in acknowledgement. "Okay."

He hauled himself out the driver's seat, locking eyes with Adora again as he threw the keys over the roof of the car towards her. She caught them one-handed, easing her other arm out of Catra's grip to shut the passenger door and take his place.

Bow settled himself into the backseat, seeing the road from a whole new angle for the first time; even though he and Glimmer bought the car when they moved in together, he'd never sat in the back. Nevertheless, he couldn't shake the foreboding feeling that they'd all be relinquishing control in some way or another over the coming weeks. Catra was here, and – if the way she'd resumed her hold on Adora, her hand clamped fearfully on top of their friend's knuckles on the gear stick, meant anything – Bow wondered if she might be desperate enough to stick around for good.

Chapter 12

Chapter Notes

TW - emotional abuse and mentions of physical abuse.

This was a difficult chapter to write but an important one! I hope you enjoy - always love reading your feedback, and please let me know what you want to see more of. I have a plan, but if a little more fluff or a little more angst (more, really???) is due, it's great to hear it :)

NINE YEARS PRIOR

Sometimes, the keyboard felt like her only true love. No emotional volatility or threat there.

Just you, me and the code, baby.

It had been six months since she'd been forced to give up the Google gig, and she'd just about convinced herself it didn't matter. Not when they were pulling in money like this. Did it really matter whether it was that legit?

Nothing that happened to her in life ever seemed that legit anyway.

Catra thought frequently about how she'd grown up, and how Prime had saved her. She owed him an awful lot, didn't she? He'd stood by her through thick and thin, always there to get her mindset straight when the rent was just a little too much, or one of her bosses was being a little too handsy, or her course load a little too overwhelming.

After all, when Catra thought about herself, who even was she? Just a random girl from that random care home, a huge question mark permanently lingering over her head. But he'd seen her.

He'd cherry-picked her out of the nothingness, just like Adora had been chosen by the Grays.

She remembered the first time they'd technically met like it was yesterday. It only took her a second to think about it and she'd be seventeen again, only months away from her social care expiry date. The curse of being a summer baby: you'd never have quite as much time. His younger brother – also a July baby, also her age – was still in care too, and thanks to a seven-year age gap, he'd somehow got enough money under his belt to have a room ready for his brother to move into. Catra suspected something might not be quite above board at the time – *this was Bright Moon after all, property did not come cheap, whether it was rented or bought* – but this was someone who looked after their own. Not many care kids had family who'd do that. Certainly not Catra, anyway.

She'd been in the corner of the TV room doing her maths homework when she first saw him. Pristine posture, smooth skin, and carefully tamed waves so unlike her own unruly ringlets. He'd followed his brother to the sofa, they'd cleared the other kids away and set up some games console – she didn't know or care which – that had everyone enraptured. Catra had liked the sound of them battling it out on the controllers in the background, and how the two brothers took the piss out of each other, not taking it too seriously but still not worried about letting their competitive sides take over. She'd never had any kind of relationship that was that unconditional, where she didn't have to curate herself in little ways to curb the everlasting danger of rejection.

Catra had sucked on the end of her pen, turning back to the task in hand. Usually, she had to get out the home to properly concentrate, but something about it had made her feel more like she belonged, like this would be what having brothers might be like. It had done the trick; her mind had zoned in on her Further Maths homework.

Best part of an hour later, Catra hadn't even noticed the game had ended until his voice reverberated right next to her ear.

“This is some tricky shit, kid.”

She’d smirked, turning round to face him as he peered over her shoulder, hoping he hadn’t seen her jump.

“If you say so.”

He’d raised an eyebrow: perfectly arched, perfectly placed. “Oh, I do.”

Catra had shrugged in response, returning to her work. She’d made easy work of it, sure, but she always had done. Adora had said all the time that she got the brains *and* the beauty, but Catra had never taken it much to heart. *Haven’t got anyone to thank for it, so why make a fuss?* Besides, she had never been able to shake the feeling that people only found her intelligence notable because she didn’t look like someone who was supposed to have it. Enough teachers had underestimated her at every stage of her schooling to know that she’d always be impressive; whether that reflected more on her or on other people was less clear-cut. But regardless, Catra had known that her brain was her ticket out of this life. She was going to be powerful one day because she knew how to play the game.

First, she’d get her degree in double honours – maths and computer science. It didn’t matter what it would take to get her through it: two, three jobs? Overtime to save up for living costs while doing a summer internship at a start-up, or one of the Big Five if she could swing it. She’d make sure she swung it. Knuckle down, prioritize grades over parties. Get the right role for her first tech job after uni. That would be the end of her retail career. No more shitty jobs in high street shops or cheap cafes. And from there, she would climb up and up. Catra depended on it. She’d rinse every fucking diversity scheme she could apply for if it meant she’d get where she needed to be. She ticked every box, after all. *Well, nearly every box – Adora’s the only person I know ticking that last one*. And where she needed to be was right at the very top. That’s what she deserved.

At that point in time, there had been no doubt in Catra's mind: she would make herself fucking remarkable. She'd make it so her absolute lack of any origin story would never be the most interesting thing about her again.

Catra sighed as she scanned the screen in front of her, well aware of her instructions from Prime. There wasn't much time to get everything he needed done, but it was hard to motivate herself sometimes. What would she be doing right now if he'd let her stay on her grad scheme? A shadow version of herself lived a different life, a perfect trajectory of the path she'd laid out for herself. *This is remarkable in some kind of way, I guess.*

Prime had made her feel extraordinary for the longest time. And not just in a sappy way. He'd made her feel like he was the only person who ever really saw her; who'd looked deep inside her soul and saw the pain, the longing for recognition, the deep desire to fit somewhere. *Anywhere.* He'd held her with such tenderness, making sure she knew that where she belonged was right with him.

After that one afternoon in the care home, their paths hadn't crossed for nearly two years until, of course, it happened totally by chance.

She'd been having the worst day. She had gotten into a stupidly shitty fight with Entrapta, basically her only friend in class, over how they should approach a joint project. And *oh my God,* they had come to blows. Catra had probably put up too much of a fight, but there was something of a fire under her belly that day and she just didn't feel like rolling over for the sake of an easy life. Why should *she* have to, anyway?

But it hadn't ended there – she had rushed to the coffee shop straight after class to report into her shift, only to find her hours had been miscommunicated; she had technically arrived late, and her pay would be docked for the first hour that she hadn't turned up. Catra had spent the first ten minutes at the till deciding how she'd best spread her budget out to account for the extra few

meals that hour's pay would have covered. It should have come as no surprise when she had got herself into a tangle with an unbelievably petty customer. *What does extra hot even mean? It's all made with bloody boiling water!*

She had just handed the girl her third coffee, insisting that she really did have to pay for the second replacement – *I hope it's so hot it fucking burns you, bitch* – when a ten pound note had floated in front of her face, rolled up between long thin, pale fingers.

"Let me cover that."

Oh, Jesus wept. Catra's eyes had practically rolled 360 degrees, they went so far back into her head. *Of course, some dick-drip wants to save the day.* What was it about men that made them think they could solve all her problems with a quick smile and the flash of a crisp note?

But when she'd finally followed sight of the cash to the person holding it, she'd been taken aback. It was *him.* Who'd have thought it?

He'd ordered his own coffee as well, and she'd taken the banknote from him, stating the total he owed before she'd even punched the numbers into the till.

"Still good with the numbers, then?"

Catra had shown him the same smirk she had the last time.

"I wouldn't sound so surprised if I were you. We don't all have brains the size of squirrels, you know."

He'd copied her expression – a trick it would take her too long to recognise and steal.

"Okay, girl. I'll bite." '*Girl', huh? That's a change from 'kid'.* "You come find me when you're on break."

Catra had watched as he settled in the corner of the shop with his coffee on the biggest and most imposing armchair in the place. He had seemed to be the first customer she'd ever seen who had truly filled it; his towering height was in proportion, his body commanding all its space.

She'd gone to the staff loo, smoothing her hands over her high-waisted jeans, inspecting the curve of her waist, how the denim of her thighs met just at the top, the dimples of her hips outlined through her pockets. Enough men had told her how beautiful she was. She'd taken some of them into her, let them explore her body like a map drawn especially for them, determined to please and be pleased. It was a much simpler route to validation than exerting time and effort on friends; that day's argument with Entrapta had proved that, and Adora had been drifting away into a foreign world of champagne socialism, queer club nights and overpriced group getaways with her new friends. She had loathed how the difference between them was now so much more obvious: Adora had money, an infectious personality and the headspace for fun. She'd skirted past it at school, even let herself feel better about it when Adora had come out – *finally, there was something not so perfect about her* – but at BMU, the truth she'd always suspected seemed undeniable. Adora was just better than she was, and everyone knew it.

When her shift had ended, she'd waited before going over to him. *Play your game, Smith.* But as soon as she did, it had been magnetic. He'd asked about her job, her studies, had seemed genuinely impressed. And then he'd offered her a bit of cash on the side working for him; he had a few gigs going on, needed more decent coders for all of them. She'd get more experience and could drop the coffee shop job for better pay and fewer hours – the only catch was she had to keep shtum. No-one could know. He'd told her they'd announced a hiring freeze to please an over-cautious investor, but he wanted to make an exception for her. Catra hadn't cared whether or not it was true.

Only a couple of weeks in, she'd vastly outperformed his expectations.

"I told you, you shouldn't be so surprised."

He'd smiled, and then his hands had gone where she'd imagined he'd wanted to touch her - *I knew this wasn't just in my mind* – and he'd confessed how much he'd wanted her from the very start, how the memory of her had been imprinted in his mind since he saw her the very first time, and it had been a gift from God when he'd walked into that coffee shop. *She* was a gift from God.

That first year had been a whirlwind; the taste of him sustained her through the third job she'd had to pick up after some fuckwit had stolen her phone and through the coursework she'd put extra time into to make sure she was the absolute best there was. *He deserves the best.*

Slowly but surely, things had shifted a little as she neared the end of her time at BMU. First, he'd been less excited than anticipated when she'd got into her prestigious grad scheme; he was upset she didn't want to work full time with him. It had shocked her, that she could have hurt him so much without even realising. She promised him, over and over again, that it didn't mean anything – it was just a route to more cash for them and she could take everything she learned and bring it home. It would benefit him just as much as her. He was still her first priority, *of course he was*.

A few weeks later, he'd insisted she move in with him after the disastrous discovery of her lies around Adora's birthday. She hadn't been quite sure whether she'd consented or complied. Either way, there had been a feeling deep in the pit of her stomach that having a choice wasn't really the most important thing – making sure that she didn't let him down again was.

Who else would love someone who's a liar like you?

How do you expect me to forgive you so easily, for going behind my back like this to see her? Aren't I enough? After everything I've done for you?

Don't you think about me at all? Don't you see how selfish you are?

Do you know how hard it is to love you, when you pull shit like this?

If you really loved me, you'd want me to have peace of mind, knowing where you are at all times.

He'd stonewalled her for three days after he cut off her phone, not speaking a word to her even as he threw her stuff into bin bags and hauled them into his car, throwing them into their newly shared bedroom when they'd arrived. She'd unpacked in silence, hoping she put things away in the right place, listening to his chest rise and fall in the dark as they slept side by side.

Nothing compared to the relief when he'd finally forgiven her.

Remembering it brought her back into herself. This was why the Google gig hadn't been worth it in the end; why she'd handed in her work phone, her only connection to the outside world. She had to remember what was really important – him and her against the world. He'd never leave her, and she'd promised she'd never leave him. He'd tell it to her over and over again: he'd known they were destined from the second he saw her. The second he'd plucked her out of the nothingness.

EIGHT YEARS PRIOR

Catra watched as the six-pack of beers were placed on the kitchen table in front of her. She looked up quizzically at the tall, flaxen-haired woman who'd set them down. Even though they'd spent the past few weeks together, Catra still wasn't sure what to make of her.

"This'll keep you in his good books."

"I think it'll take more than a few drinks, Drew."

"Maybe. But hey, it's something, right?"

Catra stood unsteadily – her hip still hurt a little – and hobbled over to the fridge, pushing the cans to the very back of the shelf to get cool.

"You could have let me do that." Catra shrugged as Drew spoke, both of them sliding into chairs at the table, "It's kind of what I'm here for."

Catra didn't answer. *We both know you're here to watch me.*

Drew was the first in a long line of safeguards that Prime had put in place to make sure she was committed to keeping her promises. She didn't go anywhere alone: not the supermarket, the local coffee shop, not even a walk round the block. What's more, there was no hope of her ever getting back into coding for him – he wanted her as far away from the internet as possible, to the extent he'd locked up the TV when he was out so she could only watch Netflix with him.

I'm sorry, my love, but I can't take the risk that you get silly ideas in your head again.

It was all much worse than it had ever been before – but Catra had known it would be. She'd chosen this over the alternative. She was well aware it wasn't the first and wouldn't be the last trade-off she'd make when it came to Prime.

And there had been a lot to make up for. It was bad enough he'd tracked her to Adora's flat and used it against her – *how could I have been so obvious?* She had never intended on ending up there; before the universe changed her direction, she'd actually planned to get as far away from Bright Moon as humanly possible. He knew that as well. He'd found a national bus schedule in the pocket of her leather jacket when he'd got her home and ripped through everything she'd tried to take with her.

Prime didn't know she was still hiding the biggest secret of all, and it was a ticking bomb waiting to go off. She'd need to figure out whether Drew could be trusted, fast.

SEVEN YEARS PRIOR

Catra stared at the white flecks of powder clinging to the internal walls of the bin, the only visible remains of her pills that weren't buried under vegetable peelings and the decaying waste of unfinished meals.

She closed her eyes as she inhaled deeply, remembering how she used to watch Adora run laps around the local park when they were little, soon graduating to their high school grounds and then the BMU athletic track. Catra wasn't much of an active runner – sure, she used to be a pretty decent sprinter, though she never had the patience for anything regular or long-distance. But right in that moment, she could imagine how it would feel to let loose with the wind gliding across her skin, cold air pulsing through her airways, her hair flying out behind her. How her feet would meet firm ground one after the other, over and over again, and all of the muscles in her body would be working together instead of against each other. She drew air in through her nose again with

purpose, almost as if she was priming herself to race right then. For a second, she was back in her teenage body, squeezing every ounce of energy she had out in the sports day relay, baton in hand. She felt lithe and so *alive*. She wondered if Adora still ran the Bright Moon half-marathon; last time they'd spoken – *the last time I left* – she'd been training ahead of her fourth.

Catra wiggled her toes on the tiled kitchen floor, letting the sensation of cool, dry ceramic imprint on her skin. She pretended that she was standing on grass as it tickled her bare soles instead, somewhere she could really think. There was rarely an opportunity for it these days; he liked her hidden, to keep her safe. Still, she couldn't help but imagine herself pounding the streets of Bright Moon neighbourhoods, coursing through green parks in the gentle sun, the sound of dogs being walked and children chattering as they whizzed down slides.

Is that what real freedom would look like?

She blinked, sniffing as she finally replaced the lid of the bin, her thoughts drifting back to the crushed contraceptive.

Freedom was even further away now.

She'd played the scene from that morning over and over again in her head. He'd been so angry when he found her stash, thin blister packs hidden inside old boots she didn't wear in their shoeboxes. The image of him shaking, almost vibrating in fury, as he tore into every single pack she had, punching each tiny tablet into nothingness between his fingers. Despite everything, Catra had never seen him like that; in all her shock, she didn't know what to think of it.

And then his white-dusted hand had come hurtling towards her, and it would have smacked right into the side of her ribs if she hadn't-

"Stop – I'm pregnant!"

He'd stilled immediately, his face drawing in so close to hers. His breath had prickled her cheek. She'd prayed he hadn't checked the expiry date of the pills, grateful at least that she'd had the sense to shred the boxes they'd been packaged in, labels and all. Drew might have got them for her – Catra still had no idea how – but she'd only ever received three months' worth at a time. She should have been smarter, spread them out across her various hiding places. How would she prevent a real pregnancy now?

"I promise you, those pills are old, I haven't taken them all year!" She'd willed her hand to stay steady, to not betray her with a tremble, as she'd reached out to cradle his face. "You know I wouldn't, not knowing how much you want this."

His eyes had hardened – she'd realised her slip. "How much *we* want this."

He'd dropped his hand from its planned trajectory near Catra's side, moving downwards to rest on her abdomen. He'd been almost reverent in his touch. It had taken her back years, right to the very start of them.

"Are you sure?"

Catra frequently wished she was the type of person for whom lying wasn't so easy, who lived the kind of life where it was an act of subversion rather than survival.

"I'm late, and I missed my last one. What else it could be?"

He'd chuckled in quiet incredulity; she'd copied him, her best form of camouflage.

They'd gone through all the usual motions: he'd apologised for the near violence, cleaned up the ripped shoeboxes and the powdery mess he'd made, tipping the ashes of her safety net into the kitchen bin; he'd whispered the same loving affirmations as always, though she wasn't sure if they sunk in the way they used to.

It's only because I love you so much, that I'm like this. You make me like this.

Catra finished putting away the plates that had been drying next to the sink. He hated it when they were left out overnight, and it had been drummed into her to never let that happen. If he was in a bad mood, the consequences could be dire.

Out of nowhere, bile began to rise up the back of her throat.

What the fuck am I going to do now?

The only option, surely, was to let him fuck her. To make good on her statement, make it true. It probably wouldn't take long; now she had nothing to protect her and no route to even a sniff of Plan B. It was incredible she'd got away with it for so long, feigning disappointment every month, blaming her low weight or the stress of worrying about him getting caught. But even before his first demand, nearly a year ago now, that she let him make her a mother, the idea made her blood curdle.

Even social care would be better than growing up in this. And how would I know what being a parent is, anyway?

Catra did the maths in her head. She had maybe eight weeks max before she'd no longer be able to bullshit away the lack of change in her body. That is, if he even let her go to appointments without him. She hummed to herself, mulling her risk assessment over; the breach of his last big operation might finally play out in her favour – he'd avoided public sector settings ever since his face and given name had been identified by police.

There was no getting around it. Catra didn't have it in her to gamble again; even though he never found out what she'd actually done – she'd definitely be dead if he had – the risks of repeating history were far too high. No, she had to find an alternative route before it got to that.

This is what you were always good at, Smith. First you plan; then you worry about the execution.

Catra made a promise to herself. She knew she had to find a way out of the zero-sum game she'd been trapped playing with Prime for years – this time for good.

Chapter 13

Chapter Notes

TW: non-graphic descriptions of self-harm and abortion.

Despite the trigger warnings, this chapter is mainly a little happier (I promise)! Share your thoughts and kudos, pretty please ♥

ONE DAY PRIOR

Adora smiled to herself as she folded her bike up, unbuckling the straps of her helmet. The ride home was her last commute for a couple of weeks; she was finally cashing in on the extra night shifts she'd picked up over the previous months, as well as being granted a few days of special dependants' leave. She couldn't wait to have this time with Catra – the relief that she wouldn't have to worry all day about how her girlfriend was doing or whether she'd had any contractions yet was profound.

It felt like they'd had little time to themselves recently. Adora had noticed that Catra spoke to Bow and Glimmer even more frequently since that day she ended up in Garnet Park. Adora was grateful that Catra had gotten particularly close to Glimmer during the third trimester, though sometimes her heart panged a little with jealousy that Catra seemed to be closer to both her best friends now than she felt. They would talk on the phone for hours, joking about silly things Bow and Adora had said or done, or arguing over where you could get the best tacos in Bright Moon. Now and again, the conversation would turn to the baby or the birth, but for the most part, it seemed like Catra had begun to see herself again in the final few weeks, beyond her role as the surrogate.

Adora hoped it was a good sign that this whole journey the four of them had undertaken would only serve to strengthen their friendships. Given their ups and downs and the way she'd struggled to steady her rollercoaster of emotions, she had to hold onto that thought.

In Adora's mind, tonight would be the start of their path back to being Catra and Adora. *Just the two of us, nothing and no-one else.*

She practically bounded into the living room, her hands itching for the feel of Catra's warmth under her palms. It was exactly what Adora needed after another unbearably long day away from her.

Ah. Maybe not right away, then.

Catra was out cold on the couch, curled on her side with a thick cushion propped between her thighs and under her belly. Adora snuck over, leaning down to press a kiss to her temple, ghosting her fingers over her curls.

She didn't notice Glimmer in the kitchen, dicing vegetables with practised precision, until she straightened up and turned to get water. Adora was surprised by how thankful she felt to see her – given the anti-climax, the last thing she wanted was to unwind alone.

"Hey," Adora spoke softly, squeezing Glimmer's upper arm as she leaned past her to grab a glass from the cupboard, "It's good to see you."

Adora didn't miss the slight slackening of Glimmer's shoulders as she paused her chopping, or the way she leaned slightly into her touch.

"It's good to see you too, 'Dor."

The sound of the tap running filled the room, drowning out the dull thuds of the knife sliding through aubergine flesh to meet the wooden chopping board.

Adora hugged her glass tight to her, tucking her chin into her chest, her eyes wandering back towards Catra. She'd never been much of a napper – if anything, Adora could never understand how little sleep Catra usually needed. She'd stay up at all hours when an idea got in her head; Entrapta was the same way, and left to their own devices to work, they could go days on only a few hours' sleep before Adora intervened. She supposed it was partly Catra's drive that got them here as well, ending up with her dozing under trees and on plumped sofas at any time of day.

Glimmer's voice knocked Adora out of her thoughts: "We went for a walk around the block. Tired her out."

Adora hummed through pressed lips. Catra had become highly unmotivated to move around much the past few days. It was only really the suggestion that a walk might ease her irregular cramps that ever got her out the house. "Have the Braxton Hicks started up again?"

Glimmer nodded. "Yeah." She set down the knife, her words tailing off. "I wish…"

Adora held the space, moving closer to Glimmer. There was something on her mind that she clearly needed to get off her chest.

"What is it?"

"This might sound crazy… But it kind of makes me jealous. I wish I could just take on the pain of it, you know, do all the hard work myself."

"That doesn't sound crazy at all, Glim."

Adora furrowed her brow, frustrated with herself that she hadn't thought much recently about how Glimmer might be dealing with all of this. She'd been so wrapped up in her own erratic feelings towards the surrogacy – fear, resentment, joy, pride, jealousy, longing, awe – that she'd lost sight of how even back when Glimmer had first decided she would get her eggs extracted, she'd

known this part would probably be the toughest on her friend. Time had increasingly revealed how similar Glimmer and Catra really were, and one of their most obvious likenesses was how much they liked to steer their own ships. Had she really missed this, so caught up in the self-pitying belief that this whole set-up was secretly tougher on her than anyone else?

Adora pulled Glimmer towards her, the first fully genuine hug she'd shared with either her or Bow in weeks.

"You'll have plenty of hard work all to yourself soon." Adora tried to push down the pain of reminding herself that she'd only borrowed this dream – her fantasy would end as Glimmer's new reality began. The kicks she felt every night as she wrapped her arms around Catra in bed wouldn't result in a squirming child nestling against her skin, or tiny fingers clamped around her own. "I bet that a month or two from now, you'll be begging us to take him off your hands so you can have a rest for a couple of hours!"

She'd been so focused on suppressing her thoughts that she hadn't noticed Glimmer draw away from her, her pupils widening as she sought eye contact.

"*Him*?"

Adora's mouth dropped open. She'd been the only one of them able to read the sonogram, figuring it out instantly the first time the photo was set in front of her – she hadn't even told Catra she knew the sex, knowing Bow and Glimmer wanted it to be a surprise. Was there anything she could manage to *not* fuck up?

"Oh shit, Glimmer, I'm *so* sorry!"

Glimmer choked back tears, her hold on Adora tightening. "We're having a *boy*?"

Adora nodded, tears starting to bead at the corners of her eyes too. "Glim, I'm so sorry, I feel terrible-"

But Glimmer had drifted somewhere else, laughter bubbling out the back of her throat. "Oh my God, I didn't think it could feel so much more real, knowing... This is actually happening*. A boy*!"

Adora couldn't help but giggle, the dismay at herself starting to slowly subside.

"Of course, it's happening!" She nudged her head towards Catra, still somehow asleep despite their commotion, "It's been happening for over forty bloody weeks!"

"I'm actually going to be a mum."

"Yeah. You really are, Glim."

They held each other for a few minutes longer, Adora taking over the dinner prep as Glimmer went to the bathroom to splash her face with water. It was the least she could do – Adora knew she wouldn't forgive herself for dropping that bomb for weeks, even though there'd been zero negative repercussions.

Her ears picked up as a soft groan drifted over from the other side of the room. Catra was finally beginning to stir.

"Hey there, sleepy head."

Catra rubbed the bottom of her swollen stomach, her fingers tracing the dark line under her belly button that peeked out from under her t-shirt.

"Mmmm… What are you doing in the kitchen?"

Adora snorted. "Don't you want dinner?"

"I did when Glimmer was cooking." Catra has closed her eyes again, snuggling deeper into the sofa. "Where is she?"

"Just the loo." Adora sprinkled salt into the pan, pushing the onions, garlic and aubergine around with a silicon spatula, their edges already turning golden. She inhaled deeply, letting the

smell overtake her senses. “I think cooking might be my calling, you know.”

Catra grunted. “Well, hang up.”

She forced one eye open at Adora’s gasp.

“What? You’re literally the worst cook.”

“I liked you better when you were asleep.”

“Whatever. You know there’s a reason Glimmer’s been coming over to batch cook now I’m so fucking exhausted all the time.”

“Because you’re about to give birth to her child, and she wants to see how her *incredibly* polite and supportive friend is?”

“Ugh, if it makes you feel better to think that...”

Catra groaned again, a little more deeply this time. Adora looked up from the pan again, studying the lines that had appeared on Catra’s forehead as she grimaced.

“Hey, you okay?”

“Yeah,” she sucked in air through her nostrils, lips pressed tightly together, “I’m just hosting some kind of kickboxing club in here.”

Adora hissed through her teeth, realising she’d let the onions and garlic burn to a crisp while she was distracted.

“Shit. How did it even burn that fast?”

“Case in point, babe.”

“Fine.” She turned the heat of the hob off, crossing her arms as she pondered how to fix the cremated remains.

“Jesus wept, I should have known not to leave you alone with this.” Catra snorted as Glimmer re-entered the room, gesturing for Adora to step away from the food. Adora started to object before

Glimmer interrupted her, her hand drifting out towards Catra. "Why don't you get this one into bed to rest properly while I figure out what I can give you both to actually eat?"

Adora conceded, making her way over to the other side of the room, helping Catra to slowly rise from the couch, her hands placed strategically on the small of her girlfriend's back and under her elbow. She rubbed Catra's shoulders as they made their way into the bedroom, moving the pregnancy pillow at the foot of their bed into place once Catra had lowered herself onto the mattress.

"I heard your little slip back there."

"Oh? You looked completely knocked out."

Catra shrugged. Adora perched on the bed next to her, interlocking their fingers.

"A boy, huh?"

"Yeah." Adora studied Catra, focusing on how her eyes had started to glaze over a little. Ever since Prime, she'd done this often, slipping in and out of the different worlds she'd lived in. It was so different to how Catra had been when they were younger. "What are you thinking?"

"I never got so far to thinking about it… you know, before." Her hand swept across the expanse of her stomach, "I just knew I couldn't..." She furrowed her brow. "It wasn't an option."

Adora pressed Catra's knuckles to her lips, leaning her cheek into Catra's palm as she opened her hand to Adora's jaw.

She closed her eyes, remembering how Catra had come to her a week or so after they'd had that fateful meal out with Bow and Glimmer, her hands trembling with nerves.

"What's the matter?" Adora had asked in alarm, eyes widening as Catra had pursed her lips together, avoiding her eyes.

“There’s something I never told you.”

“Okay.”

“But if I’m going to consider doing *it*, you know, for them, I need your help.” She took a deep breath, “I’m not sure I even can.”

“Catra, if you don’t want to, they’re not going to hold it against us. They have no expectations that you will, it’ll be completely fine.”

“No, I- I *want* to do it. I mean, physically, I’m not sure if I can.”

Adora had been confused. *Why wouldn’t she be able to?*

“What d’you mean?” She’d sat up straight at this point, beckoning Catra to finally join her on the sofa, opening her legs for Catra to curl up in the space between so her body could rest sideways against Adora’s torso; they’d always sat this way for the hardest conversations, learning that it removed the pressure of eye contact and gave each of them the space to moderate their initial reactions before responding.

Catra had felt more uncertain in her arms than she usually did, even more so than when they told the really difficult stories about what had happened to them in their years apart. Adora had kissed her hair and tightened her hold, desperate to make sure Catra knew she had her, that she wasn’t going anywhere.

This must be important, for her to be like this.

“You know that when I left, when I took Glimmer’s stuff, that it was because Prime had found me? And he’d threatened to…” Adora had nodded briskly, not wanting Catra to put herself through it all over again. “I didn’t take any of it because he wanted money. I pawned it all before I went back because *I* needed it… But you know if I had any idea what the Cross was or what it was actually worth, I never would have-”

"I know." She had pecked the top of Catra's head again to reassure her, "We all know that, love."

Catra had seemed to relax slightly for a second before she geared herself up to continue.

"I only got a few hundred. But it was enough at the time." She gulped nervously. "I needed it for an abortion."

Adora hadn't expected it and had been seriously thrown by the fact that Catra had never told her this before. She had wanted to ask so many questions about why it hadn't come up before, whether Catra had really thought that Adora would judge her or be unsupportive. But she had known that moment wasn't the time for a personal freak-out about whether Catra trusted her. Instead, she had focused her attention back on what Catra had appeared to be worrying about.

"Catra… you know having an abortion doesn't stop you from being able to get pregnant again? I've performed them on plenty of women who've gone on to have several kids."

"I know that. It's just, I didn't end up doing it that safely."

Adora had listened in silence as Catra explained that her plan had fallen apart once Prime had got her home and effectively locked her in the house, taking all the cash he'd found in her jacket pockets and tucked into the side of her bra. After the fourth time she'd thrown herself down the stairs in the dead of night – she'd insisted each time it had been an accident on her way to the bathroom – he'd brought Drew in to watch over her, clearly not believing she hadn't been trying to hurt herself. Catra had said it was a saving grace he thought she was suicidal rather than suspected she was desperate to force a miscarriage. She had tried scalding hot baths, knocking back shots of whiskey in advance to dull the sear of them, and had encouraged Prime to fuck her as hard as he could, feigning unbridled desire in the hope he'd do some damage. But despite the agony in the hip she had repeatedly landed on at the bottom of the stairs, and the spotting

in her underwear that had given her some short-lived hope, in the end, the only thing she'd been able to do was beg Drew to help her. She'd almost passed out when the pills had been covertly pressed into her hand a couple of days later, instructions whispered in her ear. Drew had waited outside the bathroom door for hours as she had laid cramping in the tub while Prime was running errands, tears of relief streaming into the reddening bath water as clots and clumps of tissue finally left her body. She'd never felt a reprieve like it.

Then Catra had explained how the thought of raising a kid had triggered her ever since, and she'd never spoken about it to anyone: not Bow, not Entrapta, especially not Adora. It was why she had offered Adora an out in case she wanted children all those years ago.

So Adora had asked why Catra even wanted to carry for Bow and Glimmer in the first place – *wouldn't it make all this trauma so much worse?*

"This probably won't make sense, but I think it'll help me make peace with it. I just want to do something positive with it, with my body."

In many ways it hadn't made any logical sense to Adora at all. Even before she had started to visualise all the challenges that watching Catra grow with their friends' child would bring, her words had reminded Adora of quite how much of a complicated maze her girlfriend's mind really was. Over the coming days, it would help her make a decision quickly – it had been clear to Adora since the car crash that what Catra needed above all else was autonomy. Control over her own body.

Maybe in some odd way, this actually <u>would</u> help her heal.

"It makes sense to me, love."

Adora had held Catra for a long time after they spoke, well into the night. She had finally begun to understand it – the desire to

follow through with this surrogacy wasn't really about Bow and Glimmer at all. The realisation had made it easy to arrange and accompany Catra through her first gynae check-up in nearly a decade (Adora had been outraged with herself that she'd never even checked whether Catra had been going to them in the first place), then once given the all-clear, sign contract after contract with their friends, despite the uneasy clenching around her heart.

Her thoughts shifted back to the view of the heavily pregnant woman laid out in front of her now, already drifting back to sleep.

There really wasn't anything she wouldn't do for Catra, to make sure the life she had lived so far was worth surviving.

Chapter 14

ONE DAY PRIOR

Catra opened the app up one last time, hissing in satisfaction now she'd finally managed to iron out the glitches that had been pissing her off for days.

She could see both camera views of the tester cams she'd hacked showing up on the interface – one feeding through sound and vision from the bedroom, the other giving her a distorted – *well, let's be honest… completely unflattering* – view of herself from its place on the nearby dining table. She checked the sound, shouting into the phone and listening out for the echo from the other room.

It fucking worked!

Catra grinned to herself, tapping her fingers on the side of her stomach.

"You, kid, are gonna be watched 24-fucking-7."

"Erm… who is going to be watched?"

Catra smiled at the sound of the front door closing behind Glimmer in the hallway, so grateful that she'd given her a spare key a couple of weeks before. Hauling herself out of this ginormous armchair and down the hallway was not something she could be bothered with whatsoever.

"Ah, you'll see in a minute..."

"Cryptic…" Glimmer raised an eyebrow as she entered the living room, scoffing at Catra. "How do you even get to sitting like that?"

Catra shrugged, peering down at herself. She was leaning back against one squishy chair arm with one foot propped on the other arm with her knee bent and resting on the chair back, while her other foot dangled off it entirely, her hips opened up wide.

“How do you expect to get up?”

“That’s a problem for later Catra.”

Glimmer plonked herself down on the sofa, taking the end closer to Catra.

“And how well has that been working for you recently?”

Catra paused for a second, trying to push up a little on her elbows to answer Glimmer and failing miserably to support herself.

“Don’t you even...!”

But Glimmer’s spluttering was infectious and soon both of them had been overcome with laughter, their entire bodies shaking. It wasn’t long until the third member of their trio joined in.

“Oh my God, Glimmer, you have to stop making me laugh,” Catra gasped for air through the giggles, “Your brat is trying to beat me up.”

Glimmer leaned over to watch the movements stretch the misshapen skin of Catra’s taut stomach, just about visible through her thin t-shirt, stretching out to rest her hand over it.

“Christ. Got a little thug in here, eh?” Glimmer joked, “Have to keep my eye on that.”

“Ah! Speaking of…” Catra finally managed to even out her breath and shake off her chuckles, “Can you get that thing on the table?”

“Sure…” Glimmer eyed Catra questioningly as she walked over to the table, picking up and rolling a small black ball in her hand, the light reflecting off its hard glass surface, “What is it?”

"Just a little something I've been working on… Gimme your phone."

Glimmer handed it over warily, examining the ball further as Catra did whatever the fuck it was she was doing on her mobile.

"Alright, so," Catra tossed Glimmer's phone back to her as she settled on the sofa again, "If you open up that app I just installed, you'll see it's connected to the satellite cam."

"Satellite cam?"

"Just look. And tap both those circle icons that come up."

Glimmer opened up the app, and all of a sudden, the black ball lit up, its view of Catra filling the screen. A couple of seconds later, a split view took over, showing the apartment bedroom as well.

"What's this for?"

Catra smirked to herself, clearly questioning Glimmer's intelligence.

"It's a baby monitor. Obviously. But I've built this *especially* for you because the apps on the market at the minute are seriously shit. This one, though… you can control which of the satellites – the balls, yeah? – is monitoring from your phone, doesn't matter how far away you are. And you can adjust the angle of the camera 360 degrees remotely - almost the entire surface of the satellite can record video. Entrapta helped with that, so the range is crazy!"

Glimmer couldn't have interrupted Catra mid-pitch even if she tried.

"*And* the sats are multi-directional so they can communicate with each other and divert the sound away from your phone if you just wanna do the whole walkie-talkie type thing. They'll track room temperature, movement, volume decibels, all the fancy shit. And if there's something you should know about, they'll flash to catch

your attention. I can build more of the sats and sync them if you want, so you can have one in every room."

"Whoa, that's a lot-"

"Right?!" Catra was getting even more excited, "Plus I've made the security so tight, the KGB couldn't hack it! I'll just need to install it on Bow's phone and you'll be good to go!"

Catra looked at Glimmer expectantly, clearly thrilled with herself.

"Wow, Catra – that's incredible."

Catra's eyes narrowed. "But what?"

Glimmer faltered, embarrassed that she hadn't been enthusiastic enough, "You really didn't have to do this. I mean, you're already doing so much-"

Catra scoffed, waving her hand dismissively in the air.

"Ah, it's given me something to do on the side for a while. Anyway, no point lugging this-" she pointed at her swollen stomach, "around for so long and then just handing it over to flail."

Glimmer snorted, "Flail, huh?"

"I hear babies are hard work."

Catra tried to hide her disappointment as she turned slightly - at least, as best she could - to face the back of the chair while she composed herself. It was probably just her hormones, but she really thought Glimmer would be impressed by her pet project. She must have been too obvious; it only took a few seconds before she felt Glimmer squeeze her hand.

"Seriously, it's awesome - I love it. Thank you."

"De nada."

But before Glimmer could let go of her hand, Catra winced, squeezing back with much more force as her whole face scrunched up.

"Was that…?"

"No," Catra sucked in air shakily through her nostrils as she rode out the pain, shaking her head breezily as her fingers loosened around Glimmer's, "Just the Hicks, same as always."

Glimmer nodded nervously.

"Okay. Maybe we should go for a walk then? That works most times to ease it, right?"

Catra hesitated, not wanting to entertain the thought of leaving the flat.

"Come on, just five minutes."

"It won't be five minutes; I move at the rate of a glacial snail." Catra glanced at Glimmer's worrisome face. "Ugh, fine."

It took them over twenty minutes just to get Catra out of the armchair, to the bathroom, and wrapped up ready to leave. But once they got out the lift, shuffled slowly out the building and hit the cold air, Catra couldn't help but admit that even though these walks frustrated her, underlining how painfully sluggish she'd become, the winter sun did make her feel slightly more refreshed.

Adora always says it's best to get some fresh air. Anyway, you don't want Glimmer to think there's something up when it's probably just nothing.

Catra tried not to think about it.

…Though that one felt kind of different… Kind of like the one earlier.

She cleared her throat to shake the thought from her mind, threading her arm through Glimmer's – partly for better stability in the cool wind, partly to make herself feel better about it all.

You'll tell her when you know for definite, of course. It's totally fine!

"So, there's something I wanted to talk to you about."

Catra's ears pricked up as the start of a new conversation knocked her out her thoughts – *thank God for that.* But Glimmer sounded timid, quite unlike her usual self. Catra kept her voice steady, relieved to have something else to focus on to stay calm.

"Sure, what's up, Glim?"

"Bow told me about the whole MystaCorp thing. A few weeks ago."

Oh.

"He told me you knew. Before you offered to carry for us."

Catra, nodded, uncertain of whether Glimmer was actually going to ask.

"What are you getting at?"

Glimmer hesitated for a second. "I was worried it's why you agreed to do it."

Catra frowned. "Would it change anything?"

Glimmer turned her head towards Catra in surprise.

"Oh… I guess not." Glimmer bit her bottom lip. "But I wanted you to know that I would have never held it against him, you know, if we'd had to wait a little longer." She waited for Catra to respond, though it never happened, "I know I've had my moments, but I'm

not this super judgmental person. I love Bow, I'd never want him to be nervous to share something like-"

"I know, Glimmer. Don't worry about it."

Glimmer nodded tersely, barely reassured. "It's only cos I know how close you two are-"

"Honestly, Glim, I don't think that of you." Catra caught Glimmer in her side-line of vision. She could tell how anxious her friend still was. "Anyway, it wasn't really the reason."

Catra's tone was resolute – thankfully Glimmer got the message and didn't press any further, though Catra could still feel some tension caught in her bicep. They carried on for a short while further, but the walk was starting to get wearisome; the gentle wind began to leach Catra's energy instead of rejuvenating her, the sound of her hair whipping about her ears not helping matters. Her sore ankles objected to the burden of her heavy body pressing too much into the pavement, and it felt more obvious than ever that half her organs had been pushed out the way to make room in her small frame for the baby.

She moaned – perhaps a little too loud – in pity for herself as the ache in her lower back and thighs slinked into the forefront of her mind. This was why Catra hadn't wanted to go out this morning, or the day before; why she'd decided just to stay in her and Adora's safe little flat, distracting herself from everything by focusing on the final tweaks to her baby monitor project. It was easier than coming to terms with the fact that it would all be over with shortly. Even though she'd been counting down the minutes until the weight of this baby would finally be out of her, she already felt a little lonely just knowing she'd be back alone in her body soon. She'd never dare tell anyone, but that thought – that she'd once more be her own biggest responsibility – alarmed her more than the idea of the birth.

At least airing her physical discomfort convinced Glimmer that returning home probably was for the best, and before she knew it,

she was home, her bladder freshly (gloriously!) emptied, insisting that she wouldn't fall asleep on the sofa and if she was really that tired, she would have just gone to bed.

Catra should have learned by this point that she always ended up snoozing, bed or no bed.

Her heart had beaten a little faster when she realised Adora was home, and that she and Glimmer were talking like they used to. Catra had worried that Adora had been off with just about everyone at points in the surrogacy, but it was especially painful to her that she might have come between Adora and her best friend again. It wasn't until she heard Adora mistakenly reveal the gender of the baby inside her that Catra realised she was actually fully awake, no longer drifting between two worlds of dream and reality.

A boy.

Of course, she'd known this child would have a sex – and in time, an identity. But knowing it made it (*him!*) seem like more of a person somehow. A person who would live outside of her, away from her body and her home and from the protection of Adora's soothing palms braced over her convex belly.

She forgot to stop the groan from bleeding out her mouth as she felt a familiar pain bear out from her lower back, wrapping around her pelvis, a little stronger than it had been a couple of hours earlier.

Catra was grateful the baby was kicking like there was no tomorrow; she didn't even have to outright lie, letting Adora think that Braxton Hicks and foetal football practice was all there was to report.

I just need a little more time, okay? To get used to it going back to the way it was before.

Being in her bed, returning to semi-consciousness with Adora's cheek cradled in her hand, made Catra feel like she had a magic

stopwatch, pausing the world around her – the world inside her – from its never-ending spin.

It wasn't until a dim flash on the dresser cut through her slumber, a voice calling out too crisp and clear to be as far away as the kitchen saturating the air.

Catra nuzzled into the soft cotton of her pregnancy pillow, cursing herself for forgetting to disable the monitors. She felt even rougher than before, her REM cycle cruelly cut off mid-way. She was about to reach for her phone to shut down both the satellite cams on her app when she realised Glimmer must have gone home. It was just Adora speaking, and her voice held a sad futility she hadn't heard in years.

"No, Mum. I haven't spoken to her about it yet."

Is she talking about me?

"Come on, what am I supposed to say? That I hate having to watch almost as much as I love her for doing it?"

Catra squeezed her eyes shut during the pause, her heart clenching sorely at Adora's words. There was no feigning ignorance over what this was probably about. She really should turn this off now, given how important privacy and trust was between the two of them. It was partly why their relationship worked so well – they had the utmost respect for boundaries; with their histories, they'd had to.

Making the right decision was easier said than done.

"Honestly, Mum? I wish… I just wish this was for us…" Catra could have howled at how broken Adora sounded, tears burning the corners of her eyes as the suspicions that she'd purposefully suppressed for so long were unbearably proven. "I know, I know. It'll be different after the birth..."

Catra's thumb hovered over her phone screen in the silence as Adora listened to her mother's response, willing herself to turn the

whole thing off.

"Yes, okay, I'll be open with her. *After* the birth… Listen, I'm not going to say anything that'll upset her before she delivers!" Catra was shocked that Adora sounded so angry; she'd never heard her push back against her parents before. "No, it just won't help anyone, trust me… It's been long enough. A week or so won't make a difference, it'll happen any day now."

Almost on cue, a tight band of pain began to spread through her body, the ache in her thighs more intense than it had been before, sustaining through the peak of her contraction and after it ebbed away. Catra reassured herself that it wasn't that bad yet, she'd still be able to breathe and talk through it if she had anyone there to say anything to. Besides, looking at the time on her phone, it had been well over an hour since the last one. She probably wouldn't move into active labour until the following morning at least. She just had to try and get a good night's sleep and save her energy. Tomorrow, she'd raise the alarm.

Catra finally disabled all the monitors, dropping her phone on the bedside table. She hadn't heard much more of Adora's phone call since the contraction had distracted her anyway. It hurt too much to think about.

Tomorrow. Just leave everything until then.

She stroked the top of her belly, noticing how it had somehow gotten even firmer over the past day or so. She'd spared no effort for over nine months to avoid connecting with this baby too much, determined to preserve the most important bond at stake – that between him and his parents. But in that moment, cloaked in the earthy comfort of her bedsheets, the tenderness she felt between her and the child thriving inside her was too strong to ignore.

We're at the finish line now, kid – what harm can a quiet goodbye between old friends do?

Chapter 15

Chapter Notes

For those of you who might not be aware, this week has been an incredibly hard one for women living in the UK - it's definitely made thinking about some of the themes of this fic particularly challenging. We are mourning the loss of countless women who have lost their lives to male violence, and struggling with a police force who not only fail to protect the right of every woman to get home safe, but sometimes prove themselves to be just as dangerous as the criminals they say they're saving us from.

We are facing a turning point - we can't pretend anymore that our police brutality is lesser than in the US or elsewhere, and the conversation of how women's vulnerability falls on men who say nothing and feel entitled to everything is finally starting to garner widespread attention. Tonight, we have lit candles across London in memory of Sarah Everad, and every woman who did everything she was 'supposed' to do to stay safe, but still never got home.

To anyone who's living here and been triggered this week by it all, I really hope you're okay.

Needless to say, I needed a little distraction from the main story of this fic at times, and so in addition to this chapter, I've published a one-shot called 'Barricade' that absolutely fits into this world. It'll give you the full story of how Adora came out to Catra that's referenced in this chapter. If you'd like to read it, you can find it here:

https://archiveofourown.org/works/30022227

Love and solidarity x

EIGHT YEARS PRIOR

Catra remembered how she'd held her head in her hands, the dropped test taunting her from the grimy floor. The walls of the toilet stall had felt like they were closing in her, and the distant music had started to pulse through her head like she was under attack.

Even a week later, she'd still not figured out why she'd decided to go there; why she'd slipped into a lesbian bar of all places to do it. True, it was one of only two open places near the 24-hour pharmacy that barely had a queue to get in – and there's no way she would have subjected herself to a musical theatre jazz bar.

Nevertheless, she'd felt immediately uncomfortable when the bouncers let her into Crimson, their objection to the size of her rucksack finally overcome. Her eyes had scoured every inch of the place, scanning all the different women enjoying themselves; Catra hadn't missed the way they'd looked at her either. *Did I look like I fitted in?*

Catra had lowered her head as she pushed her way through to the bathroom, grateful it was empty. The memory of Lonnie questioning her when she'd first got together with Prime had bubbled up in her mind out of nowhere, and she was pitifully failing to squash it down.

"Really? I kind of… like I kind of thought you'd be experimenting a bit…" Catra thought of how she'd stared back at the soldier on her FaceTime screen, completely taken aback. "I mean, you've got the whole big gay energy thing going on, you know?"

"What?"

Lonnie had scratched the back of her neck awkwardly, clearly thrown by how Catra had reacted.

"I don't know, it's just a vibe. You really never thought about this before? Even after Adora came out?"

"Well, what does Adora being gay have to do with me?"

Lonnie's eyebrows had travelled so far up her forehead, Catra's stomach had flipped. She'd interrogated her memory of how Adora had told her she was gay, and what she'd said when Catra had asked how she knew. Her vague response had kind of disappointed her, but she'd never put her finger on why. *Am I missing something here?*

Every time she'd spoken with Lonnie since had felt a little forced, even when she'd come to stay with Catra in her shitty student flat when she was on leave from her base. If it wasn't for the fact that she'd known Lonnie didn't have anywhere else to crash, Catra probably would have let their friendship fizzle out long before it eventually did.

The dreaded result of the pregnancy test had forced her attention back to the problem at hand. Catra had let a small whimper fall out of her mouth as her suspicions were painfully confirmed. She had to do something about this before he found her, in case she didn't get away for good. She'd known even then that there was no way he wouldn't force her to go through with it. That was why she'd left, right? Just in case. She'd been lucky he'd flown overseas for business – it had given her the chance to siphon tiny amounts of cash from all the hiding places where she'd watched him stash tight rolls of banknotes when he thought she wasn't looking.

Crying had never been something Catra really let herself indulge in, but she couldn't help but give herself five minutes to fall apart before she figured out her next move. Or at least she would have done were it not for the loud bang of the bathroom door swinging open, followed by echoes of breathy moans.

Seriously? For fuck's sake.

She had pulled herself together then, picking the pregnancy test off the floor and throwing it into the sanitary bin. Catra had no intention of fending off some concerned, sexually frustrated

bystander who might overhear her sobs if she actually let all her misery out.

Figuring the night couldn't get any worse, Catra had thrown the stall door open and marched to the sink, tossing her rucksack over her shoulder with irritation.

Can't I catch a fucking break?

She'd muttered something under her breath – honestly, she'd never actually remember what she'd said. How could she?

All that she'd ever recollect from that moment was meeting Adora's eyes in the mirror, and for the first time in forever – even if it was just for a split second before the ludicrousness of the situation sunk in – realising that she actually felt safe.

Now she'd been staying on Adora's sofa for nearly a week. She'd desperately tried to recover that feeling of safety – of *home* – but her brain was overrun with thoughts of blonde baby hairs wisping about Adora's temples, the blush of exertion on her cheeks, her blown pupils. Something deep in Catra was telling her *she* wanted to be the reason Adora had looked like that in their brief moment of reunion. She wanted to hold that kind of power over her. But there was no denying that right now, Adora held all the cards.

Catra hadn't meant to end up here – she'd actively tried to escape Adora in the club. But it was useless. Every time she'd asked someone to let her borrow their phone to order an Uber to the bus station, she'd been fobbed off or directed to a taxi rank she couldn't find. She'd told herself she didn't have a choice – she'd had to come back to Adora for help, and it had been easier to agree to stay just to shut the blonde up than explain why she had to run.

Once Catra had heard what kind of doctor Adora had become, her plan changed again. Maybe Adora could help her. She just needed a little longer to sit with the information, run a mental risk assessment of her next steps. What would she do after? Would

Prime really leave her alone? Or would she spend the rest of her life watching over her shoulder, hoping she'd never see a flash of him out the corner of her eye again?

It wasn't something she was willing to talk to Adora about, not yet. She could tell how much she was trying to be someone Catra could open up to. They'd spent several nights holed up in her room while Adora instigated deep chat after deep chat, slowly broaching tentative questions that Catra rarely actually answered. Her old (former?) friend had insisted over and over again that there was nothing that Catra could possibly tell her that would drive a wedge between them – she'd wanted to reconnect with her for so long! For the most part, Catra did believe her. She genuinely did want to tell Adora everything. But how was she supposed to admit that she'd been right all along? That Prime really had turned out to be as controlling as she'd implied, that he'd deprived her of a phone or access to her personal social media for nearly two years, and that he'd got her so involved in the worst of his cyber-hacking scams that all his abuse still carried less threat than the chance he'd leak information about what malware she'd made for him to the police, like he'd done to plenty of others when they'd upset him.

She had no idea how she'd let herself end up here. How she'd deviated from the most important thing: her grand plan. Catra calculated where she was supposed to be right now. Where she'd have gotten if she'd stayed at Google. She caught herself with her hand resting on her abdomen.

What the fuck was that, Smith?

She shook her hand off her belly aggressively, as if she was purging motherhood from her fingers.

You're supposed to be getting back on track, away from him. Away from this!

Catra caught sight of Adora's flatmate out the corner of her eye. This Glimmer girl was really getting on her nerves – she always

turned up at the least convenient moment when Catra really, r*eally* needed space.

"Is violent interpretative dance another thing of yours, then?"

Catra ignored her, turning towards the window. She'd taken to sitting on the sofa for hours at a time, watching the road for an unwanted number plate, or a car trailing past the building too slowly or frequently.

"Fine, be that way then."

Glimmer's words rolled off her back; she had no idea how little Catra gave a shit about what she thought of her. She'd seen how her rucksack had moved a little to the left the other day, how her meagre belongings weren't packed exactly how she'd left them. But what annoyed Catra most about Glimmer was how she always touched Adora as if she were hers, as if they shared an intimacy that Catra wasn't privy to. Didn't Glimmer know that she and Adora were the closest and most important to one another out of everyone? Or, at least, they used to be?

It didn't help Catra feel any better that afternoon when Glimmer's boyfriend turned up. She almost laughed when she saw him – *as if this guy could possibly be straight!* But Adora frowned when Catra whispered a joke in her ear, the first negative reaction she'd gotten in response to anything she'd said that week. Maybe it wasn't the right hill to die on, not tonight.

After dinner, she went back to her spot by the window, leaning back to avoid being seen from the outside. Adora had learned by now to leave her alone when she was sat by the window. She wasn't sure if Adora had figured out what she was doing or why, but either way, Catra thought that playing dumb was probably better for both of them.

She stayed there watching until everyone else had gone to bed and was just about to ready herself for sleep when suddenly, she heard something slip under the front door. Catra trembled as she

picked up the thin envelope addressed to Adora; it was like ice had been poured down her back. She would recognise that handwriting anywhere.

The demand was simple – make sure Catra returned to him the following day or bear the consequences of doctored records he had personally produced, all keyed up to send to the General Medical Council. The outcome would be immediate and everlasting: Adora would never work again.

Catra knew from experience that if this was level one of his threat, far more than Adora's job would be at risk if she waited for longer than Prime said.

In Catra's mind, there was only one viable option. Adora couldn't find out; she had always had far too much of a hero complex for Catra to let that happen. She lay in the dark for hours, waiting until she knew for sure that none of Prime's lackeys could still be outside. At 5am, she checked she'd packed the last of her stuff. Bile rose in her throat as she realised that she'd need some collateral before handing herself over – she needed something, *anything* she could pawn off as soon as the shops opened. Her eyes fell on the laptop on the dining table. It wasn't the most advanced model, but it would do the trick.

Catra backed away from the sofa, Prime's letter now shoved in her back pocket. She paused at the doorframe.

Am I really going to do this?

She had never felt so stuck between a rock and a hard place – but the thought of Adora sleeping, calm and blissfully unaware of the life Catra actually led, steeled her. Deciding at the last minute to take some ugly token off the mantelpiece for an extra few coins, she tiptoed down the hallway, slipping out the front door as quietly as she could.

Catra hated doing anything without a water-tight plan. But when it came to keeping Adora safe, she'd jump through any hoop put

in front of her, even if she was wearing a blindfold.

Chapter 16

Chapter Notes

TW: non-graphic descriptions of violence

DAY ZERO

It had taken nearly half an hour to get Catra ready to leave their apartment, and Adora had kept a beady eye on how her contractions had significantly quickened since she'd found her sitting in the shower, having nipped out briefly to buy defroster for the car. There was no way she'd only gone into labour a few hours ago like she'd claimed; she'd been awoken in roughly thirty minute intervals throughout the night by increasingly regular grunts muffled into a silk pillow. She'd only kept quiet because she knew Catra needed to flag it herself to feel in control; if Adora wasn't so focused on furtively monitoring her girlfriend's progression, she would have laughed at how Catra was stubborn enough to think she could fool a seasoned gynaecologist.

She'd left Catra leaning on a lamppost in front of their building as she trekked through the overnight snowfall to bring the car around. But even though she'd thawed the windscreen, the car battery must have gotten too cold; nothing she did got the engine to start. Adora cursed herself for insisting Bow and Glimmer meet them at the hospital – they'd probably be halfway there by now.

She hurried back to the entrance of their building as carefully as she could to avoid skidding on the slippery frost. Even from a minor distance, Catra looked completely exhausted. Adora wished there was something she could do to help bolster her in the immediate, or at least fix this transport situation more quickly.

Adora spotted the alarm in Catra's eyes as she saw Adora approach her.

“Adora, where the hell is the car?”

“Battery’s too cold, it won’t start. But don’t worry, I’ll just call Bow and Glimmer, they can turn around and pick us up.”

“No!” Adora looked up at Catra in surprise; she saw panic had spread across her entire face. “They’ll take too long to come back. Just call a cab, okay?”

Adora rested her hand on Catra’s forearm – she could feel the muscles in girlfriend’s body starting to tense in anticipation of the next contraction.

“Are you sure?” Adora softened her voice, “You haven’t been in a cab since-”

“Of course, I’m fucking sure, Adora! Do you think Bow and Glimmer are going to want their kid born on the fucking pavement?”

“Catra, that’s not going to happen, you’re only six and a half centimetres dilated.” She moved round so Catra could see her face, “You don’t have to do this.”

“*Adora*…”

She knew that warning tone far too well. It was a red line, and Adora had been familiar enough with it since childhood to know that going any further was only going to end in disaster.

“Okay, okay! I’ll get one now.”

She rubbed soothing circles on Catra’s lower back as she made the call and fired off a quick update to Glimmer; her girlfriend started to whine as the next contraction set in, gripping the icy lamppost with both hands. Adora sighed anxiously as the confirmation text for the cab with its numberplate came through to her phone. This would have been difficult under the best of circumstances, let alone now. They didn’t talk much while they waited, Catra breathing steadily in and out as Adora continued to

apply sweeping pressure to her back and coccyx through gloved hands. Adora's stress only grew as she saw the cab approach just a few minutes later. At least it was a good sign that Catra hadn't had another contraction for over five minutes now; it had been just under six since the last one.

Adora stepped forward as the cab stopped in front of them, opening the front passenger door and helping Catra to make her way to the car. But as she was about to lower herself into the seat, Catra stopped, dropping her head into her forearms against the open doorframe of the car, a heavy groan escaping her mouth.

"Whoa, whoa, whoa. She's not sitting up front in this state."

Adora bent down to look at the driver, peering past Catra's rounded torso as she helped to steady her on the curb.

"Come on, it's just a fifteen-minute drive to the hospital."

"No, you can sit in the back together – I'm not gonna be the extra pair of hands if she starts pushing."

"She's not going to-"

"Look, love – the sooner you get in the back, the sooner I can get you there, okay?"

Adora exhaled, hoping that Catra was still so focused on her contraction – it was *slightly* worrying that this one had been going for well over forty-five seconds now – that she wouldn't hear her.

"Listen to me," she growled under her breath, "She was in a crash a while back and she can't sit in the back, okay? And she's nowhere close to pushing. Trust me – I'm a doctor."

"Have her waters broken?"

"Yes. But that's not an indica-"

“When my wife’s waters broke with our last kid, he was out before you could blink.”

Adora huffed internally. *Of course,* she’d get saddled with a mansplainer, today of all days. She put on her work voice, the one reserved for calming down agitated parents. “That’s really not so typical, especially given this is her first birth. Can you just do me a favour and let her sit so we can get her there quickly? Please?”

If this guy pushed back against her one more time, Adora wasn’t sure how she could possibly keep her cool.

“It’s fine, ‘Dor, I’ll get in the back.”

Adora was so shocked, she hit her head against the open car door as she jerked her head towards Catra.

“Babe, it’s really not necessary. Just give us a minute to talk.”

“Adora, I cannot have this baby in the street.”

“Catra. You are not going to give birth here, I promise you!”

“How do you fucking know? I’ve been at this for over nineteen bloody hours!”

Catra froze as Adora drew herself up to full height beside her, realising she’d given herself away.

“A-Adora-”

“Jesus, Catra. Did you really think I didn’t know that?”

Has everyone forgotten this is actually my job?

Catra blushed, rubbing the side of her belly.

“Just help me get in the back,” her voice had gone small and tinny, “I’ll be fine. I promise.”

Adora gave in silently, doing exactly what her girlfriend asked even though her entire body bristled at the sheer audacity of the two of them – Catra and the driver – thinking they knew better than her. Few things pissed her off, but this was definitely one of them.

They finally set off for the hospital, Adora checking Catra's seatbelt multiple times and repositioning the thick polyester strap around her expanded stomach as she breathed in and out shakily. Catra's hand gripped hers tighter and tighter as the car turned onto the main road; Adora could almost hear Catra's heartbeat going wild from her place in the middle seat.

She reassured her, hoping her irritation wouldn't seep through at all. "I've got you, you're alright."

Catra couldn't even open her eyes, a tear squeezing out the edge of her left eyelid.

"Do you hate me?"

Adora could barely hear Catra's hushed whisper but it sent daggers through her.

Where the hell is this coming from?

"Of course not, Catra!" Adora pushed Catra's curls behind her ear gently, "I… I'm just trying to reassure you that you'll have this baby in hospital like we all agreed and Bow and Glimmer won't miss a thing. Everything's going to be completely fine, okay?"

Adora willed every fibre in her being to convince Catra that they were going to get through this birth smoothly; despite their unusual circumstances, it would be as blissfully uneventful as a first-time birth could be.

"That's not what I'm…"

Huh? Adora studied her girlfriend as her words trailed off. She couldn't work out what Catra was getting at, why she'd ask that.

Maybe it's just the pain putting her in a loop…

Adora was grateful now that they were both in the back of the cab; she hoped to death that the driver hadn't been listening to their conversation.

"How could you ever think I'd hate you?"

Catra snivelled, about to open her mouth to speak before a grunt replaced her words, her face screwing up again. Adora checked the time on her phone – they were getting closer to five minutes apart now. Whatever this conversation that Catra was trying to start was about, it could wait until later.

"Deep breath. It'll all be over in a few hours. Just think how amazing you've been through this whole thing."

Catra didn't really respond – her eyes stayed clamped shut, one hand crushing Adora's while the other clung on to the car door handle. Her breaths were far shallower than they had been earlier, and nothing Adora said seemed to help her maintain a stronger breathing pattern.

Adora looked past Catra to see out the window, moving her free hand to rub the bottom of Catra's abdomen to try and ease the residual pain from her cramps and help her feel more grounded in her body. They were nearly halfway there now. She could only hope that the trauma of the journey wasn't going to have an adverse effect on Catra's mindset for the rest of the day. She wracked her mind for something she could do once they arrived at the hospital to build some routine back in for her, some distraction from whatever torture was tearing her mind apart. She'd get Catra settled in a private room (thank God she'd called ahead to ask her colleagues to keep the best one free), get her something to eat before she moved into the transition stage – they were probably looking at another hour or two to go before that, at least – and she'd make sure Glimmer and Bow kept their energies as chill as possible.

Yes. That's what I can do to help, to make this better.

All Adora wanted was to show Catra there was nothing she could ever possibly hate when it came to her. She'd waited too long for their life together: too long for them to reunite; too long for Catra to accept her feelings towards Adora; too long for this promise they made to Bow and Glimmer to break them.

Catra zeroed in on the feel of Adora's hand on the bottom of her belly, how she seemed to know exactly where to apply pressure through her jumper.

She'd been a real idiot, thinking her girlfriend actually believed her contractions had started in the early hours of the morning. An undercurrent of shame was threatening to spread throughout her chest, reprimanding her for shutting Adora – *let alone Bow and Glimmer* – out of her early labour. She didn't have a clear answer for why she'd done it.

But Catra knew now wasn't the right time to dwell on it.

Her right-hand fingers twitched on the handle of the door, just like it had done the last time. Her nervousness was different though; she remembered how she had started to feel the edges of liberation in her fingertips, how Drew had echoed Catra's cautious anticipation in her expression. The sore memory of how they'd come so close to a new life – how she'd finally let herself imagine waking up the next day in Drew's arms after months of covert contact – felt blurry. For sure, theirs was no great love story; their connection was one primarily of comfort and convenience. Catra was well aware that to Drew, she was the only person from her prior life who had fully accepted her true self; in return, Drew had become her sole protection from the sibling who'd done everything in his power to put them both in confining boxes.

Catra never would have thought all those years ago that the lame gamer kid who was obsessed with his older brother would grow up to become the woman she owed her current life to.

The cost of it had been too much.

She felt the cab stop at the traffic lights for the eighth time since their ride started – yes, she'd been counting – and it was impossible to suppress the memory of the driver's door being ripped open. Every time, she relived it: the way the driver was punched and dragged out of his seat, pushed into the next lane of traffic just as the lights turned from amber to green; how Drew had pleaded at her brother as he took over the steering wheel; the way Prime had screamed at them, accelerating well beyond the speed limit into the side streets, before he'd changed tack in a way she'd never expected.

Catra had wished for years she'd blacked out as fast as Drew had when he'd reversed them into concrete, the contents of the car boot jerking forward and thrusting them towards the seats in front. She'd blocked out a lot of it after that; her next memory was after she'd been cut out the wreck, overhearing the paramedics confirm there were only two living patients remaining in the crash. The court records had helped her fill in the gaps, as painful as they were to hear.

She opened her eyes, swallowing the vomit rising in her throat. Maybe it would be better to try and stay in the present. She could focus on Adora.

Adora.

She could see the cogs ticking in her girlfriend's brain even out the corner of her eye, her face giving away the fact she was in planning mode. Catra had gotten very used to seeing that over the years; sometimes when she didn't know what her next move should be, she'd think about the way Adora circled problems in her head, her thought patterns moving in spirals before something cracked and she made a snap decision out of nowhere. It was so

different to how Catra approached things: careful, calculated, considered.

Perhaps it was easier to jump if you had a safety net. After all, hadn't Catra become more spontaneous as the years progressed too?

Her body didn't give her much time to think about it: the next band of hot pain shocked her more than any had before; she could barely make a sound for the first few seconds. They'd arrived at the hospital while she was still riding it out, diminishing her relief at the journey finally ending.

By the time Catra had got out the cab and into a waiting wheelchair, clinging onto Adora's arm the entire time, she felt like she'd gone through some kind of baptism. For years, she'd viewed the timeline of her life through a simplistic lens: before Prime and after Prime. But after all this – the phone call she'd overheard the evening before, the long night agonising over mounting aches, the feel of Adora's deft fingers kneading her scalp as cool water riveted down her body – it was time for a new partition.

She thought of the infant trying to make his way out of her body to his parents, and the girlfriend she wanted so deeply to make into her wife, *if* after the surrogacy was over, she could convince her to stay. This would be the divider: the day her body completed the herculean task she'd demanded of it, the sole opportunity she'd had to dictate why and how it performed.

Today, she'd finally let go and leave her old self behind. She'd make this her birthday too.

Chapter 17

Chapter Notes

> This is a long one... finally the story of how Adora and Catra got together! I'd love to read your thoughts on it - please comment and kudos! ♡

See the end of the chapter for more notes

THREE DAYS AFTER

"Really? Sure you feel up to it, love?"

Catra nodded at Adora, her entire being thrumming with the need to do something, *anything*, that distracted from the sore exhaustion that still consumed her body.

She watched as Adora disappeared from the bedroom, listening to the soft padding of her girlfriend's soles echo off the wooden floorboards as she walked to the living room. It was strange, how quiet their flat seemed, even though nothing had technically changed.

Melog followed Adora back into the bedroom; Catra pushed herself up gingerly against the headboard, leaning forward slightly to let Adora straighten the pillows behind her with her left hand while she held Catra's guitar in her right.

"Here you go."

Catra hadn't even needed to ask Adora to fetch her microfibre cloth – she'd already pulled the crumpled material out of her pocket. Catra took it gratefully, sucking in her breath as Adora handed over the instrument, placing it in Catra's arms delicately with far more reverence than Catra had ever seen her show towards it before. Catra ran the cloth over the wooden body of

the guitar, bending her knees to cradle the base of it in her lap, her right-hand fingers already plucking at the strings. She exhaled a breath she never even noticed she'd been holding in.

Adora watched over her tentatively, adjusting the duvet covers around them to make it easier for Catra to find a comfortable position in which to play. Catra closed her eyes, letting the notes sink into her ears as she tuned the strings. The familiar scale felt like she'd taken her first gulp of water after spending years in a barren desert. Catra craned her head even closer to her guitar as she began to tease out the first bars of a song she hadn't heard in forever, that she had craved playing for months. Adora's gaze was still trained on her, her nervous energy only slightly lesser than it had been when they returned home the day before.

"Chill out a little, 'Dor. I told you I'm fine."

"Yeah?"

Catra felt Adora's thumb smooth over her cheek, not even realising her girlfriend was wiping away tears until she opened her eyes and saw fat droplets fall onto the glossy dark wood.

"Oh!" Catra exclaimed in surprise, feeling sobs bubble out her chest as her cries grew. "I don't even… I'm not upset about anything!" She grabbed the cloth to wipe her tears off her guitar, "I only just cleaned this…"

Adora leaned over to take the guitar from Catra's suddenly lax arms, placing it carefully at the foot of the bed; Melog snuggled into Catra's lap as the space freed up, just in time for Catra to notice the damp circles spreading on her chest, seeping through the cotton of her shirt.

"Shit."

A fresh wave of tears broke over her as the strain in her breasts amplified; she brought her left hand up to knead them to try and relieve the pain, but there was really only one thing for it.

Adora kissed her forehead, murmuring into her hairline.

“I’ll get the pump.”

Catra sighed as she leaned back, blinking, running her other hand through Melog’s fur. He stretched and moved up to rest on her torso like he had done so many times over the past months, his light weight adding some pleasant pressure to her still swollen abdomen. Melog cocked his head as he lay on her, as if he was looking up at her in question.

“He’s home now, Melog.”

The cat mewled – it reminded Catra of the baby; of the few noises she’d heard before they’d all left the hospital.

Adora returned; she soon slid between the sheets to hold Catra from behind, her chin perched in the hollow of Catra’s collarbone as milk dripped into wheezing plastic.

“How much is in the freezer?”

“Plenty. I’ll take it round tomorrow morning. But I think...”

They sat for a second in silence. Catra nudged Adora’s cheek with the side of her head.

“You think…?”

She could feel the nervous gulp Adora took travelling down her throat.

“I think it would be a good idea for us to let your milk dry up.”

“Isn’t breast milk supposed to be better?”

“I mean, it can be easier to digest, but-”

“I should carry on pumping, then.” Catra felt Adora tense behind her, the arms encircling her waist tightening. She continued

hurriedly, not wanting to fracture the fragile truce that had formed silently between them. “Just for a few more days.”

Catra didn’t want to think about the reasons why Adora probably wanted her to stop expressing milk; the hormones and emotions swirling inside her were too complex and knotted to rationalise anything properly. Instead, she focused on the guitar, still lying at the foot of the bed, its position only slightly skewed from their movements. It was, after all, a gift that had changed her.

SIX YEARS PRIOR

Catra didn’t want to admit how relieved she was that Adora was finally coming home the next day. It gave her a much-needed sense of strength, knowing that she’d insisted Adora should stay with her friends now that Glimmer had been discharged following her surgery. It was true that nightmares still crippled her, staining every attempt at sleep with cold sweat and angry red scratches that appeared on her arms by dawn. Nevertheless, Catra knew she didn’t need Adora to fuss over her anymore; now she could prove it too.

She’d fretted all day over whether it would be obvious that she’d started sleeping in Adora’s bed while she was gone. It had only been two weeks, but somehow the night terrors weren’t so bad with Adora’s scent surrounding her. Sometimes she even woke up with no recollection of how her nightmare had ended, though there was no forgetting how they always started. She planned to wash all the sheets as soon as she woke – she’d bought unscented detergent especially so it wouldn’t seem like she’d cleaned them – and Adora would be none the wiser.

Catra certainly didn't expect the bedroom light to turn on at 2am, jarring her out of her shallow sleep. She sat up bolt straight in a panic, her hand instinctively darting out to the bedside table for the pen knife she'd secretly taped to its underside. But her fingers crushed hard into the solid side of a small set of bedside drawers instead – she yowled as pain reverberated from her nails right up to her elbow and shoulder.

A confused voice from the doorway prompted a rush of realisations: she wasn't in Prime's bed; she wasn't in the hospital ward; she wasn't even in Adora's guest room. Adora was home early and she'd caught her.

"Catra? What…?"

Catra turned away and buried herself under the covers, curling around her throbbing arm and rubbing her nails to try and soothe the shock. Her eyes were still squeezed shut when she sensed the duvet being slowly peeled away from her head, the rough skin of Adora's palms gently tugging on her arm.

"Let me look at that."

Catra searched for irritation or anger in her friend's tone but she couldn't pick any up, not easily anyway.

She isn't mad at me?

She kept her arm close to her, not relenting until Adora's grip softened. It would be her choice to offer her arm for inspection; she was done with being forced to do things.

"Oh, Catra."

Catra's heart sunk as she realised Adora would be able to see the grazes from her sleep scratching, uneven red and purple scrapes that criss-crossed up her arms and on her chest. They stood out a lot more now her bruises were almost completely faded.

"I wish you would just cut your nails. Doesn't it hurt?"

Catra stayed quiet as Adora massaged her arm, trying to calm her shrieking nerve endings.

"Move over."

She shuffled in the bed to make room for Adora to climb in next to her, unsure as to why her friend wasn't just getting in the other side of the double bed or ordering her to get out.

"Mmm, thanks for warming it up for me."

Catra could feel Adora getting closer to her; the muscles in her stomach contracted as her heart rate picked up.

Adora took her arm in her hands once again, rubbing Catra's skin rhythmically. The pain had long since drained away by now but Catra couldn't bring herself to say anything. The feel of Adora's fingers was just too nice.

"Better?"

Catra nodded, finally opening her mouth. "I can go back to the other room. Sorry, I know I shouldn't be in here."

"No!" Catra's eyes flew open; she registered the alarm in Adora's face. "I mean, it's fine for you to stay here, we used to sleep together all the time, didn't we?" Catra watched as Adora became even more panicked at her own words. "Not *sleep* together, obviously! You know what I mean…"

Catra nodded despite her confusion; Adora visibly relaxed.

The light went off – Catra thanked the heavens that there was a switch next to the bed and she wouldn't lose the heat of Adora beside her – and she felt Adora shuck her jeans off under the covers. The ends of her ponytail tickled Catra's shoulder as she wriggled.

It didn't take long for Adora's breathing to even out but Catra lay wide awake. Her heart was still racing. She couldn't process how

she'd gotten away with it, why Adora was so okay with her being in her bed.

The minutes ticked into hours, and eventually Catra managed to drift off into slumber too. But she was soon jolted awake again, her arms restrained against her body.

"Catra! Wake up!

She could feel herself panting while Adora pinned her down, a familiar sheen of sticky sweat coating her skin.

"You're alright. You're just having a nightmare."

"No shit, Sherlock!" Catra practically spat at Adora. She hated this, how Adora had run into the spare room night after night to relieve her screams; it was fucking typical that they'd reduced so significantly while she'd been alone but resumed with a vengeance the minute Adora returned. It was utterly exhausting.

Adora's lip quivered; only then did Catra notice tiny beads of blood oozing from a fine line of red stretching across her right cheek. Catra felt terrible. She deflated, turning her face away from Adora's even though she was trapped under her body.

"It's okay, Catra. It's no surprise, after all you've been through."

Catra scoffed, not wanting to be reminded of how vulnerable she had become.

"Just do me a favour and cut your nails. Don't want anyone at work accusing me of getting into scraps!"

Catra spoke sparsely, Adora's joke not eliciting its intended response. "I can't cut them."

Adora rolled off her, clearly puzzled. Catra shivered from the loss of contact as cool air settled on her.

"Why not? You're hurting yourself, Catra."

Catra paused. *Am I really going to do this?*

"They remind me of her."

She knew Adora had no idea who she was talking about – it was her fault; she'd refused to open up over the past month. Catra flinched as she realised concealment was the last thing she actually wanted. It wasn't supposed to be some dirty little secret, like how it had to be under Prime's roof. There was only one way to course-correct now: she had to talk.

"She always kept them longer for playing the guitar. She didn't like using a pick."

Adora lay back down on her pillow, her hand open next to Catra's. She scraped one fingernail gently across Adora's palm, just like how Drew would when they were sat at the dining table, communicating soundlessly while Prime ate.

"Who are you talking about?" Adora spoke in a low whisper. Catra could tell how nervous she was to ask the question. "Maybe I can help you find her?"

"No. Drew's gone."

"*Oh.*" Adora's brow twisted in confusion. "The police told me Drew was a guy."

"Her records were wrong."

"And the two of you…" Adora's voice trailed off. Catra didn't know how Adora would take it. She wasn't sure why she cared so much, but her throat felt like it was closing up. "I... I didn't think you were into girls."

It only took a beat before Adora's hand closed around Catra's and what she'd lost unexpectedly dawned on her, more fully than it had so far. It was meant to be Drew's hand around hers; Drew's fingernails pressing into her palm; Drew's fingertips, calloused from plucking metal strings, massaging her skin in the night.

“She’s really gone, Adora.”

She left me on my own.

It was the first time they’d celebrated one of their birthdays together in five years. Catra could practically feel the excitement simmering in Adora even though her own birthday wasn’t for another month. In contrast, Catra had never much liked making a fuss; why celebrate a yearly reminder of how she’d come from nothing? She’d never even seen any kind of confirmation the date was actually her real birthday anyway.

Regardless, it was impossible not to let herself get carried away a little when she could see how much Adora cared. She and Bow had even convinced Glimmer to bake a cake for the occasion, though Catra wasn’t entirely convinced the tall maple-frosted ginger cake hadn’t been laced with arsenic.

Catra watched as Adora sliced through its four layers with expert precision, balancing a hefty slice on the blade of the knife as she transferred it to a plate.

“You’re weirdly good at that.”

Adora laughed at her.

“I’d hope so, I’m usually cutting into a person.”

Catra picked up her fork, carving her first mouthful.

“That good, huh?”

Catra didn’t even realise she’d let out a soft moan at the sugar spreading across her tongue. She was even more surprised when her arm reached out – completely of its own volition – to feed

Adora the second bite she'd piled onto her fork, her eyes unable to look away from how pink lips closed over metal prongs, beige icing catching on the side of Adora's mouth.

Shocked at herself, Catra held the utensil in the air for a few seconds too long for it to be inconsequential. She saw how Adora's eyes had fluttered to her own lips before darting away, a fist coming up towards her mouth as she cleared her throat.

"It *is* good."

They sat awkwardly for a few minutes, Adora instigating small talk about how the plans for Catra and Entrapta's business were shaping up, as if they hadn't already discussed it a million times. By the time they'd finished their cake, Catra couldn't bear it any longer.

"Why don't we watch a film? We used to do that when we were kids."

Adora nodded eagerly.

"Yes! We can huddle up in bed just like we used to!"

Catra wasn't expecting *that*; she hoped her reddening skin wasn't too visible. Luckily, Adora seemed distracted.

"Presents first, though!"

"What? Adora, I told you not to get anything!"

Catra's blush spread up to the tips of her ears. She'd felt bad enough about mooching off Adora for the past few months – it was almost embarrassing that she'd give Catra a present as well.

"Pssht. You always got me one."

Adora disappeared out the kitchen, calling for Catra to follow her. She rolled her eyes to the ceiling; at the very least, Catra could try to convince *herself* that she wasn't secretly delighted.

“Ta-da!”

Catra’s eyes widened at the deep mahogany guitar Adora had laid out on her bed, unable to move. *How could she possibly know…?*

“Do you like it?”

Catra stared at it in astonishment. She’d developed an obsession with looking up the model online, but never with any intention of actually buying it. It was just another makeshift coping mechanism she’d cobbled together. Catra could tell her unexpected silence was leeching Adora’s enthusiasm second by second, but she felt powerless to do anything.

“Is something wrong? I saw you kept looking at it online, so I guessed maybe you wanted to learn-”

“It’s Drew’s.” Adora gasped, her face falling in dismay, “She had this one.”

“Shit, Catra! I’m sor-“

Catra held her hand up to stop Adora’s apology, sinking onto the bed next to the guitar. She ran her hand up its fret board, the old familiarity of its feel defying how new it actually was.

“I don’t have any photos of her. That’s why I kept looking it up. Kind of a substitute, I guess.”

Adora joined her on the edge of the bed.

“I can take it back. If you want.”

“No… No, she taught me a couple of songs. Maybe it would be nice to remember.”

She'd never let anyone know, but Catra had fretted over this night for weeks. She had barely any money – by some grace of God, she had regained access to the meagre amount left in her account before Prime made her quit Google – and it simply didn't facilitate the kind of thing she felt Adora deserved. What's more, it wasn't lost on Catra that Adora's birthday had turned her entire life upside down the last time she'd been around for it, and it made her even more determined to rewrite the day's meaning.

It might not make up for everything, but maybe it can make up for that fight in the park.

Her nervousness had grown as she'd waited all afternoon for Adora to get home from work; now she could hear the key twisting in the front door, she felt like she would be sick. Catra took a deep breath and hauled the guitar into her lap, her fingers trembling as she began to play.

"Catra?"

She played a little louder, beckoning Adora into the living room.

This is it.

"What the…?!"

She could hear Adora enter the room and drop to her knees, the shuffling sound of her crawling preceding the gurgle of surprise that fell from Adora's throat when she finally found her way into the fort. Catra had to steel herself to keep playing. Something about Adora's windswept hair and reddened cheeks from her bike ride home pushed the memory of that moment in Crimson to the front of her mind. It had started to resurface increasingly often and Catra cringed at how it distracted her every time.

She carried on finger-picking the guitar strings, peering up at Adora in the hopes that her surprise would have the intended effect.

"Did you do all this for *me*?"

Adora's eyes swept the fort in amazement; Catra couldn't help but swell with pride. She'd spent hours creating a huge elaborate tent from all the blankets and bedding she could find in Adora's apartment, fabric swooping down from the ceiling with twinkling fairy lights. She'd covered overturned crates with white sheets and confetti, cramming their surfaces with candles, freshly baked cupcakes and homemade cocktails poured into salt and chilli-rimmed mason jars. It was a level of effort Catra had never gone to for anyone else.

"No, it's for the bloody tooth fairy."

Catra's deadpan comment was met with a kiss on the cheek; it was a miracle she didn't completely fuck up her strumming pattern.

Since when did we decide to start kissing each other like that?

"I can't believe you're actually playing in front of me."

Adora's smile couldn't be bigger – it almost made Catra embarrassed. It was true that she had so far refused to play in Adora's presence, always practicing as quietly as she could with her bedroom door closed. She'd overheard Adora joke to friends more than once that it was like living with a moody teenager.

"It's a special occasion, I guess."

Adora settled down next to her, so close that their crossed legs bumped despite the guitar being a little in the way. Catra's pulse spiked; the fort she'd made swallowed up most of the lounge but Adora still chose to sit *there*, as if they were restricted to the floorspace of a tiny raft floating in the ocean. She paused as one song came to an end, her fingers ready at the strings to resume the next, and tilted her head to watch her friend. Pleasure grew in her chest as she realised just how much wonder was displayed on Adora's face. And then she saw it: the shiny marquise stud fixed in her friend's helix, its five coloured stones glinting in the dim light.

"Hey, why'd you stop?"

Adora objected to the silence, her head whipping round to face Catra's, the space between them suddenly scant.

"You kept it." Catra whispered, turning her whole body towards Adora's even though it made the guitar tumble out of her lap clumsily, humming as it fell on the blankets.

"What?"

Catra brought her hand up to Adora's ear, hovering over the jewellery she'd gone to so much trouble to buy before throwing it to the mud in a rage.

"I didn't think you would, after…" Catra's voice hushed even further, "after all the things I said."

"Oh." Adora's hand came to rest atop hers. "I wear it every year on my birthday."

Catra's face twisted in confusion.

"It made me feel like you were still here. And look, I get it." Adora squeezed Catra's fingers, bringing both their hands to rest on her knee, "Internalised homophobia's a real bitch."

Internalised homophobia?

"Adora, I'm straight."

Adora's expression mirrored the bewilderment that had already formed on Catra's face.

"Catra, you realise you were in a relationship with a woman?"

"That was different…"

Adora cocked her head in displeasure.

"You know, Cat, that's kind of transphobic, just because Drew wasn't assigned fe-"

"No! Not like that. I mean, it didn't feel *gay.* We were just… us.*"*

Catra wasn't sure how to explain it the right way. In fairness, her relationship with Drew – if you could even call it that – had never gotten more physical than a few stolen kisses caught up in the adrenaline of planning an escape, and she'd never got to thinking about whether they'd last long once they got away from Prime. Back when her focus was making it out the front door, it was easy to put off imagining what it would feel like to be out in the real world; she'd avoided considering whether they'd ever hold hands in public or if she'd join Drew at the queer bars that she'd once told Catra about. There had been an undeniable tinge of guilty relief building in her gut ever since the crash.

"Sure, Catra."

Adora's disappointment rang loud and clear. *Have I screwed this up again? After everything she's done for me?*

"I'm sorry, Adora. It's just confusing, okay? I don't know how to say things the right way, I'm not like you."

"Yeah, you've made that very clear."

Adora moved to get up, her sight trained on the floor.

"Wait! Please. I don't want to fuck this up."

Adora sighed, screwing up her ponytail as she rubbed her scalp.

"What do you think 'this' is, Catra? What's *all* of this?"

She gestured at their surroundings. Catra followed the direction of her hand. *Maybe this is more romantic than I thought…*

"Please. I just want you to have a really good birthday. Make up for the last one."

That's all this is, it's just extra special, like birthdays are meant to be. Like we didn't have growing up.

Adora hesitated, unsure of her next move.

"You're the most important person in my life, Adora. *Please*."

Catra loathed how insecure she sounded. She hadn't begged anyone for anything since she'd escaped Prime, and it went against every instinct she had to be this vulnerable, to plead with Adora not to walk away.

Adora seemed to recognise her desperation. There was something in her eyes that looked raw – offended or dejected, Catra wasn't sure.

"Fine," she reclaimed her place next to Catra, not quite as near as before. "Pass me one of those cupcakes."

Catra obliged dutifully, pushing the guitar fully to the side to keep it safe. She'd slaved for hours over these cakes, unwilling to accept Bow's offer of asking Glimmer to bake them. Catra watched Adora intently under the pretence of checking they tasted alright.

Does everyone eat buttercream like that or is it just her?

It took Catra aback that these thoughts kept cropping up in her head, that everything was telling her to stop staring but she just *couldn't*.

"I wish you would sit closer."

"Hmm?"

Adora appeared to suddenly notice the hyper-focus on her rather than the cake as the hairs on the back of Catra's neck stood up. *Did I actually say that out loud?*

"Oh, um, I'll bring the laptop closer, we can watch that film."

"Okay..."

Catra got to work immediately, grabbing the laptop and setting up a film she knew Adora had wanted to watch for a while – she'd rented it especially – and blowing out a few of the candles to make it feel more like a cosy cinema. She nestled into the cushions next to Adora, barely able to pay attention as the opening credits began.

The whole way through the film, she felt like she was holding her breath; every time Adora shifted, she was so hyper-aware of whether she'd gotten closer or further away, and Catra couldn't help but echo every reaction Adora had to the film.

Why am I being like this?

By the time they'd reached a particularly steamy sex scene in the film, Catra thought she was genuinely losing her mind. Adora had gravitated towards her by this point, practically snuggling, and they glanced at one another nervously as the scene played out. The stirring low in the pit of Catra's belly was unbearable, worsening as she felt Adora's thighs pressed next to hers. She could no longer deny the wetness gathering between her legs as she clenched her pelvic floor muscles repeatedly to satisfy the tension there. Catra prayed her poker face was holding up.

It's just this film, setting me off because it's been so long... It's nothing to do with her.

Soon enough, Adora drifted off to sleep on Catra's shoulder, thankfully still oblivious (at least, as far as Catra could tell). All Catra wanted to do was run to the bathroom to resolve the situation – whether it took a cold shower or something a little more direct, she had to do *something*. She inhaled sharply as she formulated her exit plan, but she was too slow; Adora curled further into Catra in her sleep, an arm dropping over Catra's waist, fingers grazing dangerously close to her breast.

With Adora's dead weight on top of her, Catra knew she sure as hell couldn't go anywhere now.

This one, Smith, you're just going to have to ride out.

FIVE YEARS PRIOR

Everything was packed and ready to go, but it was proving harder than Catra expected to walk through the door and close it behind her. She stood before it, her knuckles white as she gripped her suitcase handle, guitar slung over her back in its case.

Deep breath in, and then you'll be on your way.

She was halfway through a slow exhale when a key unlocked it from the other side; Catra found herself face to face with the only person who was capable of derailing her plans.

"Catra…" Adora's eyes flew between her and the suitcase, "What's going on?"

Catra braced herself. This would spark the exact conversation she'd been desperate to delay.

"I'm moving in with Entrapta."

"What?! Why?"

Catra couldn't look Adora in the eye. She tried to sound casual, as if nothing she said had any real consequence.

"I've hung around here for too long – you can finally have your place back." Adora stared at her, mouth agape. "Besides, it'll be easier for us to work on our apps."

Adora gestured for Catra to retreat down the hallway; as soon as she shut the door behind them, her hand flew straight to Catra's

on the suitcase handle.

See? This is why you have to go!

"I *like* having you here. And I know you like being here too, Catra, so don't lie to me about it." Catra would have scoffed if she wasn't trying so hard to keep her composure. "Will you please tell me what's really going on?"

Catra sighed. It was the one question she couldn't properly answer without blowing everything up.

"It's for the best, 'Dor."

"Bullshit! You can't just decide that on your own!"

Catra wrenched her hand away from Adora's; the action seemed like it burned both of them.

"I'm not a child, Adora," even Catra was surprised by how cool she sounded, "I don't need your permission. I'm *telling* you that I'm go-"

"Please, Catra! Can you just stop running away from me?" Catra opened her mouth to object, but Adora continued before she could say a thing. "I can't cope with losing you again."

Adora's distress was breaking Catra's heart. This was what she'd been trying to avoid. It was next to impossible to leave the way she wanted now.

"I'm not trying to run away, Adora. I just… I really need some space." She looked up to the ceiling, doing everything she could to stop her voice from cracking. "I can't bear it anymore."

Even without looking, she could hear Adora's breath hitch in her throat.

"Did I do something?"

“It’s not like that.”

“Come on, Catra! If I’m doing something that’s irritating you, we can just talk about it. You really don’t have to leave.”

“Honestly, that’s not the prob-“

“Is it my shift times? I can be quieter when I get in late, I know it’s still hard for you to get good sleep.”

“Adora-”

“And if you really don’t want to play in front of me, I’ll stop asking, promise! I just loved it so much when you did on my birthday, and I thought maybe you felt better about it now, but please, if you really don’t want to play for me, then-”

It was like Catra’s body acted of its own accord without consulting her brain at all. The sensation of her lips on Adora’s, rough and chapped from the harsh weather, was more intense than she’d ever imagined. She could sense Adora’s heart rate accelerating as fast as hers was, and it made every inch of her cry out for more, her thirst impossible to quench.

Her nervous system was going completely haywire. But Catra’s actions seemed to have the opposite effect on Adora. She was unmoving, her hand still frozen in the air between them. Catra stilled, the adrenaline coursing through her morphing from exhilaration into unfathomable horror. She couldn’t bring herself to step back fully and accept the dreaded consequences of what she’d done. Her inner foes had been right all along – seeking distance really would have been the best thing to do. Nausea threatened to overtake her as the awful truth dawned on her: she’d ruined the best friendship she’d ever had, that she probably would ever have. Bitterness began to sink into her. In the end, it had only taken one impulsive moment of weakness after weeks of steely determination and excruciating restraint to destroy six months’ effort of rebuilding Adora’s trust.

She made some kind of choking sound – she wasn't sure how it even came out of her – and finally turned away, completely incapable of looking at Adora as she reached for her suitcase. It took all the strength she had to get herself to the front door, hesitating for just a second as she let the door slowly creak open.

"I've been wondering what that would feel like for nearly ten years."

And before she knew it, Catra could hear her suitcase being shoved out the way behind her, tipping over and crashing into the floor as Adora spun her round; the door slammed shut with both their weight against it as Adora leapt towards her, her guitar digging painfully into her back as Adora kissed her. It was simultaneously tender and fierce, a decade of longing poured into one simple interaction. They drank each other in, swimming in the scent of one another: coconut conditioner and citrus shower gel mixed with aloe vera hand sanitiser.

Catra's mind was pure white noise.

Her hand founds its way to rest on Adora's neck, pulling her in further, rewarded in kind with a firm pressure on her shoulders, her guitar case being shrugged off gently. Adora broke away as she eased it off Catra's back and balanced it against the wall beside them. Catra didn't even try to hide the whimper that escaped her lips, suddenly cold. How had it taken her so long to recognise that all the warmth in the world only had one true source, and she'd denied herself of it for so long?

The few seconds they'd parted were far too long; her body thrummed in pleasure and relief as Adora's lips returned to hers, somehow even more purposeful than before. No-one she'd ever kissed had tasted as salty-sweet as this.

They came up for air, foreheads still touching, chests rising and falling in tandem as they caught their breath. Everything Adora had ever said to her ran through Catra's head.

Has she been waiting for me all this time?

It was suddenly so *obvious*, the way they'd always surged towards each other like opposing magnets, even in their earliest memories; they never should have been forced apart.

"Adora…" Catra's voice trembled, her eyelashes fluttering, "I'm such an idiot."

"You're *my* idiot."

Despite everything, Catra couldn't help but smile at her possessiveness. Adora hugged her tight, and Catra snuggled into the crook of her neck, marvelling at how the same embrace they'd repeated for years suddenly felt so new, held such significantly different meaning.

Catra's phone buzzed in her pocket.

"That's probably Entrapta. She's come to pick me up."

"One more night. Please. Just let me hold you."

Catra nodded.

"One more night."

Catra left the following morning once Adora had gone into work, her limbs already sore from missing the touch of muscular legs intertwined with hers, and strong arms wrapped around her waist as she slept.

She left the guitar behind, knowing it would send Adora the message she needed to hear when she got home to an empty flat. Catra may have moved out, but she was no flight risk. Her heart would stay here, right where it belonged.

Chapter End Notes

Hope that was enough fluff to make up a little for the avalanche of angst we've dealt with so far! A little more is coming in the next chapter too, where we'll meet Glimmer and Bow's baby for the first time... :)

Chapter 18

Chapter Notes

> In my culture, the numerical value of the letters that make up the word 'life' is eighteen - so it's extra special to have the coincidence of Chapter 18 being the turning point of this story. Glimbow's baby is finally here!
>
> Please comment/review - it means so much to hear how the fic comes across to you, and I genuinely appreciate every note!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

DAY ZERO

Glimmer rested her hand on Bow's thigh to settle him; the vibration of his leg bouncing up and down was exacerbating her nerves. She focused on the double doors again, as if staring at them would make them suddenly swing open. She could see Bow refreshing his WhatsApp messages out the corner of her eye and she braced herself for the inevitable disappointment to prevent her own worry from worsening. As soon as his shoulders slackened – the small movement imperceptible to anyone but her – Glimmer knew he'd received nothing.

"I'm trying to find a positive spin on this, but I got nothing."

Glimmer squeezed her husband's knee in response, suppressing the shiver that threatened to ripple through her. They'd arrived forty-five minutes ago, but there was still no sign of Adora or Catra.

"They're probably just held up in traffic. I'm sure they'll be here any minute."

She surprised herself with how she'd been able to keep her voice so steady. Perhaps she shouldn't have been so impressed – the 'fake it 'til you make it' mentality had served her pretty well so far in life. For sure, forcing herself to believe that everything really was fine was much better than allowing the countless worse-case scenarios from overtaking her mind.

Could they have gotten into some kind of traffic incident, or was Catra giving birth on the roadside, or had an unforeseen medical complication threatened everything at the last minute?

Glimmer reminded herself over and over again that if anything was going wrong, there was no-one better equipped than Adora to make sure everything would be okay.

But what if it's Adora that's hurt, and Catra has no-one?

She shook the ominous thought from her head; she had to trust their son would be in her arms soon, finally ending his long journey to get to where he belonged. Glimmer took a deep breath, manifesting a positive outcome with all her might.

"We just have to be patient."

"Who are you, and what did you do with my wife?"

Bow laced his fingers through hers, his joke diffusing the tension. She smiled at him gratefully, knowing he saw right through her composed exterior. If anyone in the world could see her teetering on the edge of an invisible cliff, it was him.

I think I'm losing control. Do you feel it too?

Glimmer leaned into Bow, drawing his jaw towards her. She could feel his smile on her lips.

"Just think, Glim – this time tomorrow, we'll be home with him."

She kissed him chastely. *Don't jinx it.*

Glimmer hadn't disclosed the discomfort that had creeped up on her since they arrived at the maternity ward, not wanting to stifle Bow's enthusiasm. This was the first time she'd been there without Catra, and it had slowly dawned on her that she didn't feel quite able to represent herself as an expectant mother without a pregnancy to display. Glimmer had silently accepted that everyone who had seen them at antenatal appointments assumed she was nothing more than Catra's birthing partner. She'd suppressed the knowledge – gleaned from the way people smiled at and spoke to Catra when they were in public, barely acknowledging her – that she'd been consistently pegged as a mere support to her friend; a witness to rather than participant in the new family that had been forming for forty-one weeks. It was no different now. With just her and Bow at the hospital, there was no birth happening, no fundamental shift from partnership to parenthood taking place. The nurses' refusal to give them access to the birthing room that Adora had called ahead to reserve confirmed what Glimmer had feared all along: she and Bow weren't enough on their own. They were, for all intents and purposes, entirely inconsequential.

Over the years, Glimmer had convinced herself she'd come to terms with her lot. Her emergency hysterectomy and chemotherapy treatment, the egg extraction process and the winding scars across her own abdomen no longer felt quite so raw. Yet she couldn't dislodge an essential sense of inadequacy that had plagued her since she woke up groggily from surgery that first, pain-wracked time. If this ward was where women became mothers – where their bodies transformed them in a visceral rite of passage – she wasn't sure how her story fit in.

Glimmer leaned back uneasily in her plastic chair just as the doors ahead of them swung open unannounced. Bow's grip tightened on her hand; without a buzzing doorbell to request entry, whoever was coming through had to have hospital ID, and if the groan of pain accompanying the crash of the doors banging against the walls suggested anything…

Bow and Glimmer stood immediately. Sure enough, Adora was steering Catra into the ward, worry evident on her face as Catra hunched over in the midst of another contraction.

Glimmer's pulse quickened as she noticed how pale Catra looked, how her fingers trembled on the wheelchair arms. Adora was in go-mode; she corralled them all into their assigned room, a colleague of hers accompanying them as she rattled off information about Catra's labour. Glimmer felt like she was somehow underwater, the stats blurring in her ears.

"Contractions have sped up a little quicker than expected – down to around four minutes now. I mean, it could just be because of the stress getting here, but they're lasting long enough... We must be getting pretty close-"

Glimmer stopped in her tracks as Adora and Bow helped Catra out of the wheelchair; Adora was halfway through untying Catra's bootlaces when Glimmer finally spoke, distracting everyone aside from the hospital staff from what they were doing.

"What stress getting here?"

"You didn't get my text?

Bow cut in. "No, we didn't get anything."

"Shit." Adora stood up, rubbing Catra's back soothingly. She glanced at her girlfriend, almost fearful, as if what she was about to say posed its own risk of triggering something.

"We ended up getting a cab, *and* the driver wouldn't let her sit up front…"

There was no missing Catra's grimace; she began to retch, reaching out for Adora, who instantly grabbed a bed pan for her to throw up into, her other hand sweeping her girlfriend's hair behind her shoulders out the way. Glimmer rushed to their side, horror washing over her when she thought of what Catra had undoubtedly endured getting to the hospital. Her respect for her

former foe had grown exponentially over the past year, vastly surpassing the wary friendliness they'd slowly established over the years. How could she question her role here, when this woman was putting herself through hell to help her realise motherhood?

"Cat…" Bow's voice rang out over the background noise of the ward slipping through the partially open door, "Are you alright? Honestly?"

It happened as quickly as a flash of lightning: Catra wiped her mouth and looked up at the two of them, her pained expression shifting into one of determination, as if she'd never wavered at all.

"Course, Arrow Boy. Hurts like a bitch, is all."

Glimmer met Adora's eyes, unsure how to interpret Catra's sudden stoicism. She could tell that Adora wasn't happy, that she was more worried about Catra than she'd like to let on. But all three of them knew that Catra wasn't the type to spill her innermost feelings at the best of times, let alone under these circumstances. For now, they'd have to go along with the pretence.

They all busied themselves somehow, Adora claiming that she was going to check in with the consultant on shift and find Catra something to eat to replenish her for the final hours. It was clear that Catra did not want Adora to go anywhere, but she was so preoccupied by her next contraction that she missed her girlfriend leave the room.

"Hey," Glimmer tried to distract Catra as her contraction slowly ebbed away, "do you want to wear the hospital gown or have you got other stuff in the bag?"

Catra nudged her head towards the bag Adora had set on the bed, and Bow opened it up, pulling out another ginormous band t-shirt.

"How *original*, Smith."

“Shut the fuck up, Sparkles.” Catra smirked at Glimmer; it confirmed her suspicions – resuming their usual snark was exactly what was going to get both of them through this.

Glimmer sent Bow off to set up music and get some water while she helped Catra undress; it wasn’t ideal, doing this instead of Adora, but after waiting a good twenty minutes for her to return with Catra’s shirt clutched in her hand, it had become increasingly apparent to Glimmer that they had to get on with things, with Adora or without her.

“Can I…?”

Catra nodded and Glimmer eased her underwear off, supporting Catra’s entire body weight as she grunted to stand, the t-shirt skimming her trembling thighs. Catra tightened her hold on Glimmer, stopping her from lowering her back onto the bed.

“Glimmer… I think I can feel him coming.”

Her heart skipped a beat.

“Already?”

“It’s like he’s moving lower-”

Catra whimpered at the start of another contraction, her speech interrupted. She leaned over heavily, hands steady on her knees, her groan intensifying. Glimmer’s relief when Bow came back into the room with a midwife was palpable. She rubbed circles onto Catra’s lower back, a little at a loss of what to do despite their hours of antenatal classes.

“This is a long one, isn’t it, love?” The midwife smiled at Glimmer and Bow, snapping gloves onto her hands while the contraction came to an end. “Mind if I take a look?”

Catra seemed to panic for a second as she looked behind her at the bed, a little hesitant to move.

"It's alright, you don't have to get up there if you don't want to." The midwife turned to Glimmer, "If you can just help Mum perch on the edge of the mattress here," she tapped on Catra's knee, "and you can open up a little wider for me-"

"*She's* the mother."

Catra looked furious, one hand gripping Glimmer's arm defensively as the other stayed clamped to her thigh.

"Catra, it doesn't matter," Glimmer interjected quickly, desperate to find out that everything was going okay, "Let's just get you checked out."

"*Of course* it matters!" Catra practically screeched, "Adora promised it was in the notes!"

The midwife rushed to placate her, already moving to kneel in front of Catra.

"I'm so sorry, you're completely right – Dr Gray has explained the situation. Just a force of habit. But we'll avoid that from here on, yes?"

Catra softened as she nodded warily, slowly letting her legs open wider to allow examination.

"Okay, that's perfect, Catra. We're at around eight and a half centimetres, so won't be long."

"What? But he's already… it feels like he's so low!"

"He's on his way. But we don't want you forcing anything until your body is ready, alright? Shout if you feel the urge to push and we'll check you over again."

If Catra was dissatisfied, she didn't let it slip, staying quiet as the midwife carried on with her checks, monitoring the progress and health of the baby. Glimmer watched Catra's eyes dart from the clock to the door between every contraction and after every sip of

water they encouraged her to take. It didn't help that she'd started to throw up more frequently despite the essential oils Glimmer had brought to calm Catra; at least they'd convinced her to rest a little on the bed to conserve her energy, though it seemed like she couldn't find a comfortable position on her back or side. Glimmer felt utterly useless, and even more irrelevant as the locum doctor came in to check the baby's vitals, repeatedly referring to Catra as the mother. By this point, Catra was in so much pain that she didn't say anything, her focus trained on the gas and air mouthpiece she'd been given. Glimmer didn't feel comfortable asserting herself; while Bow did try to correct the hospital staff on her behalf, it almost seemed ridiculous to her, insisting on a title without doing any of the hard work to earn it. Anxiety that she wouldn't feel like a mother – that the child borne from her egg wouldn't recognise her if he hadn't come to life inside her own womb – mounted inside her.

What if I don't feel that connection, if he's already bonded with her and not with me?

Glimmer tried to squash all her negative thoughts into a box far, far away. This whole process was too bewildering for her to voice her fears in front of anyone. She sought eye contact with Bow; they spoke wordlessly with each other, doing everything they could to keep Catra motivated, hoping their texts to Adora went through as they wondered where on earth she had possibly got to.

They were watching the clock hand pass the hour when Catra's breathing suddenly became irregular, her sturdy façade crumbling as panic overtook her features.

Bow went straight to her, his voice calm and steady, words purposeful. Glimmer was so grateful now that her husband had such a strong bond with Catra – she hoped that his presence would be enough to help her. But it seemed like all hell had broken loose in Catra's mind. Her wails became louder and wilder, her emotional anguish suddenly bursting out. She twisted out of Bow's embrace as she panted erratically, curling on her side atop

the bed despite her earlier protestations that it had been too uncomfortable, her legs shuddering as she sobbed. The contractions were coming less than two minutes apart now and lasting for well over a minute each, but it was becoming harder to distinguish between Catra's spontaneous cries and her response to the labour pains. It wasn't until her knee began to bend and turn outwards up to the ceiling, her sobs becoming almost guttural, practically grunts, that they thought she might not be capable of communicating the one thing they really needed to know.

Bow squeezed Glimmer's hand, a brief nod exchanged between them. He didn't need to say anything – she would go to get the midwife, stat.

Glimmer pressed on the buzzer they'd been given to seek attention and ran to the door, flinging it open and ready to call out for help. But Adora was in the way; she nearly slammed into the blonde, who seemed completely paralysed, a terrible expression of shame painted all over her face. Glimmer's emotions were completely torn inside, the sweetest relief crashing into white-hot outrage.

Where the fuck have you been?

Practicality won out. She pulled Adora close, knocking her out her stupor. "I think she's starting to push. We need help."

It was like a switch had been flicked; Dr Gray took over Adora's place. She was suddenly taller, coolly composed, the bananas she held limply in her hand being thrusted into Glimmer's to set aside. Adora strode over to Catra like she was in charge of the entire world, taking her girlfriend's face in her hands as she pressed an urgent kiss to her forehead.

"I'm here, Catra, I'm so, *so* sorry."

"*You're here*." Catra barely managed to speak before her fist tightened around Adora's shirt, pulling their faces even closer together; she forced her words out through full-bodied moans, "I

need… I need you to get me to the bathroom." She interrupted Adora as she began to respond, her voice low and shaky, "Adora, I'm going to shit myself in front of *everyone*."

"No, love, it's the baby. He's ready."

Catra startled for a second, her eyes desperately seeking reassurance from Adora. Glimmer flinched at how scared she sounded.

"I'm so tired, 'Dor. I don't know if I can do it."

"You can, Cat, I know it. It's the final hurdle, alright?" Adora kissed Catra's forehead again, stroking her hair as her sobs tailed off. "Okay if I check what's going on?"

Glimmer felt out of place, watching the intimacy between them, the tears running down Catra's face. She found her way to Bow and nestled into his arms.

Is this how it would have played out if I could have carried, if I was in labour instead? Would Bow have soothed me like this?

Adora held Catra's hand for as long as she could before she had to let go to scrub her skin hurriedly in the small sink next to the bed. She settled on the edge of the bed by Catra's knees, lifting Catra's upper ankle onto her shoulder and snapping on gloves before examining her. Adora glanced at Bow and nudged her head towards the door; he ran out to find the midwife, pressing the buzzer again on his way. Glimmer immediately went to Catra, resting one hand on her belly and offering her other in lieu of the plastic bed railing that Catra clutched at awkwardly.

"Glim," Catra struggled to speak, her breaths deepening, "Glim, I think I need to push…"

"Shh, it's okay, just concentrate on your breathing. Bow's getting the midwife, she'll be here in t-"

But Catra was already squeezing her hand tighter than she could have imagined was possible, and Glimmer could feel her abdominal muscles tightening under her palm, Catra's groan reverberating throughout her entire body.

Glimmer could hear Adora guiding Catra through it in the background, but all she could do was concentrate on the beads of sweat rolling down her friend's forehead, her damp curls sticking to her skin due to the exertion. She barely noticed the midwife bursting into the room, replacing Adora between Catra's legs as Bow rushed to Glimmer, squeezing her shoulder.

This was it, finally!

Catra's hand sought out her girlfriend blindly; Adora climbed onto the bed behind her and propped herself up on one elbow, snaking her arm around Catra's belly to squeeze Glimmer's fingers quickly – their eyes met for a quick instant, the gravity of the moment dawning on them – before taking Catra's hand in her palm, murmuring quiet words of encouragement into her ear.

Catra pushed for twenty minutes, her energy depleting with every contraction. Glimmer didn't miss how the midwife caught Adora's eye. They can't have been making much progress.

"Love," Adora pushed Catra's hair behind her ear, "We need gravity to help us out a little here."

Catra whimpered, squeezing her eyes shut as if not being able to see Glimmer and Bow stopped them from hearing her.

"'Dor, I can't do it. I'm going to let them down. I thought… I thought I was better than this…"

"You're not letting anyone down, babe. Come on. You'll feel so much better soon, we just need to get you up."

Catra weeped as the midwife and Adora helped her shuffle off the bed, grasping onto Glimmer as her feet finally reached the floor, her arms looping weakly around her neck. Glimmer held Catra up,

her hands sturdy on Catra's lower ribs. She could feel Catra's whole body shift with each breath, the next contraction building up through Catra's back and torso until it reverberated at its peak.

"I've got you, Catra, you're doing *so* well."

Glimmer didn't have a clue if anything she said was helping, but she felt Catra grip her tighter, her resolve strengthening. Adora dipped her head at Glimmer encouragingly as she expertly applied pressure to Catra's lower back, stepping round to make sure the midwife had as much access as possible.

Catra quietened as she bore down over the next few contractions, her whines giving way to a silent resolve, all her focus on the task at hand.

"Okay, we're crowning now. I need a big push on your next contraction, okay Catra?"

Glimmer gasped as Catra sagged a little in her arms. Bow slipped his fingers into Catra's, one hand on Glimmer's waist to steady her as she held Catra up.

"You've got this, Cat, I know you do."

Catra grunted at Bow's words, her fingernails digging sharply into Glimmer's skin as she pushed as hard as she could, her legs bending further as she saw the contraction through.

"Well done, Catra, that's the head out now!"

Glimmer couldn't help a small yelp of excitement bubble out of her chest as the magnitude of it all fully hit her. There would only be a few more minutes until Catra made her a mother; only seconds left before everything changed. It was like time simultaneously stood still and raced ahead. She had barely recognised the sharp cry pouring out from Catra's throat before all the tension left Catra's body and Adora wrapped her arms around her girlfriend securely as she slumped, directing Glimmer towards the floor with an urgent nod of instruction. Glimmer dropped to

her knees by Catra's shaking feet, impervious to the puddle of bloodied fluids seeping into her jeans, right in time to hear her son's first shocked cry, his face screwed up in purple anger as the midwife checked him over. Bow crept beside her as her arms reached out for her child; the midwife handed the tiny squirming body over to Glimmer before guiding Bow through cutting the umbilical cord. The newborn's screams began to settle as Adora helped Catra settle back on the edge of the mattress as she sagged in exhaustion, her arms still wrapped around Catra's waist to steady her. Glimmer looked up at Catra in complete awe and disbelief, incredulous that she'd managed this impossible task of delivering her son to her; that she'd even taken on this responsibility in the first place. Their pupils finally met as a tiny hand clamped around Glimmer's finger, and all she could see in Catra's eyes was an undeniable satisfaction, a solidarity in sisterhood she'd never known to be quite so real before.

Bow curled around her on the floor, helping to swaddle their naked child in a clean towel, and Glimmer felt like the entire definition of family had been pulled apart and rebuilt in that split second. She choked back a sob as she grounded herself on the wet floor, gearing herself up to speak to her son for the very first time.

"Hi, Micah!"

They'd worried her late father's name wouldn't fit right, but there was no mistaking how perfectly it suited him now that he was here. Bow and Glimmer peered down, suddenly a mother and father, at his two wide eyes, all three of them drinking one another in. Glimmer let herself fall back a little against Bow's chest as her tears came, only just noticing how the quiver of his shoulders mirrored hers, and how their friends also cried as Adora peppered Catra's cheeks with kisses the same way Bow's lips grazed the side of her own face from behind. Glimmer marvelled at the strength of her infant's small fist, an overwhelming wave of love and protectiveness sweeping through her. She knew instantly that there had never been any need to worry about their bond.

“You made it!” Glimmer exclaimed to their child reverently as Bow laughed softly, his hand coming up to cradle Micah’s soft scalp. “Look who’s here…” She gazed up at Catra and Adora once more, revelling in the warmth of her husband beside her and the effort they’d all gone to in making this moment possible. “*It’s your family.*”

Chapter End Notes

Hope you enjoyed this chapter :) I did make a conscious choice to tell this part of the fic from Glimmer's perspective, though it's a bit of a departure from recent updates, to give more weight to the complexity of her experience. Hopefully that came across!

Please let me know your thoughts!
There's still more of this story to come and it has already evolved so much for the better in direction and depth thanks to previous comments! They really do give me so much food for thought ♡

Chapter 19

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

TWO WEEKS AFTER

Adora remembered how her father had held her in his arms when she was sixteen years old, and she'd finally admitted the secret she never thought she'd have the strength to share.

"I'm in love, Dad, but it's with a girl."

It had taken her three weeks to say it out loud even though she'd already tumbled unceremoniously out the closet during an awkward dinner conversation; she'd barely spoken to either of her parents since. He had grasped her hand as they sat next to one another on the sofa, the TV left un-paused, and he pulled her to him, tucking her under his arm.

"I waited so long to call you mine. And I love you."

She'd turned her face to him then, her tears spreading wet stains on the blue cotton of his shirt as her sobs escalated.

"She's never going to feel the same way."

"Someone will one day, kid. And she'll know exactly how much she's lucked out when she's with you."

Adora lay on her side, replaying it in her head. She found herself thinking of her father frequently during recent months. She'd hadn't called her parents so often over the past year, knowing they were worried about her and that they'd insist she was falling into bad habits of putting herself last again. It was partly why they'd been hesitant to support her aim of becoming a doctor

when she was younger, fearing that the self-sacrificing tendencies that had driven her to burnout frequently in her teens would resurface. They'd lost a child years before adopting her and sometimes she could feel his weight on her shoulders, how all the love they'd had for their biological son had been channelled into her. She suspected that it was her love of running that had drawn them to her; he'd also been an athlete, a swimmer whose potential was extinguished by an undiagnosed heart condition, his life stifled silently in his sleep. It had been normal for her parents to check on her in the middle of the night or in the early hours of the morning when they had first fostered her, their breath held until they could tell she was still living. Adora had never let slip she'd known; that she hadn't always been asleep. But once they stopped tiptoeing into her room, she missed the comforting warmth that would grow in her chest when she heard the floorboards creak in the dark, knowing that there were people who loved her this much, that she meant something to someone.

She gazed at Catra, still sleeping beside her, one hand fisted into Adora's nightshirt. Her dad had been right in the end. Someone did reciprocate her feelings – though it turned out to be the same girl she'd been in love with all along.

They'd been together officially for six years now. Six years exactly since Catra had impulsively pressed their lips together with unrestrained urgency, sparking fireworks that had waited a decade to launch in the pit of her belly. Gazing at her girlfriend now, Adora knew the firecrackers and pinwheels had never quite settled. It didn't matter whose bed or which apartment they laid in – all that mattered was that she woke each morning to the same blissful sight, admiring how Catra fit so nicely by the curve of her breast, her fingers always seeking connection with Adora in her sleep. It took everything Adora had not to wake Catra there and then and present her with the ring currently hidden amongst her medical journals.

Patience is a virtue, 'Dor.

She knew it wasn't time, not yet. She had a plan.

Adora dipped her head and pressed her lips to Catra's temple. It was so nice, both of them waking in position for her to able to do that again. The autumn and winter mornings had seemed so much harsher without it. Catra stirred, moving closer towards Adora until they were pushed against one another, Catra's leg sliding between hers so it applied pressure in just the right place.

"Mmm, good morning to you too."

Adora could feel Catra's lips curl into a smile at the base of her neck, her eyelashes tickling Adora's skin.

"Well, it's been a while, hasn't it?"

She moved her hand to Adora's hip, encouraging her to take advantage of the tactical placement of her thigh. Adora slipped her fingers past the waistband of Catra's shorts in return, only to find them being batted away.

"Would you let me, for once? I've wanted to for long enough."

Adora rested her hand on Catra's waist instead; at least it would give her a little leverage. Amusement tugged at her lips as she recounted how Catra had begged a million times in her third trimester to go down on her, but after her first attempt kneeling between Adora's legs ended in Catra flinching at uncomfortable twinges in her back and belly, Adora had denied every new and ludicrous position she'd come up with.

"For the last time, babe, we were right to be careful and it wouldn't have worked."

"It would have if you would have just-."

"Catra, I was not going to sit on my heavily pregnant wife's face."

"Huh?"

"I said, I was not going to sit on-"

“You said ‘wife’.”

Catra’s thigh shifted, pushing harder against her groin. Adora fought the irresistible urge to tilt her hips and drive down, replaying the sentence in her head. *Shit, I did.* She decided to play dumb. *This cannot be the way this plays out. It’s meant to be special!*

“No, I didn’t.”

Adora squeezed Catra between her thighs, every muscle twitching in anticipation. But Catra didn’t respond to the wetness quickly seeping through Adora’s underwear onto her skin like she always used to, stilling her leg instead of gripping Adora’s ass in her hand.

“You *did*.”

Adora groaned, needing Catra to give her the satisfaction she’d craved for months now that her desire had finally superseded the caution she’d previously exercised. She grabbed Catra’s hand and moved it to her breast, but her fingers remained unbearably limp.

“Catra, *please*!”

“Don’t you want it?”

“What? Yes! Please, I want it so badly, *please* just finish what you started.”

“Not that.” Adora tried again to grind on Catra’s thigh, but it had morphed into dead weight. The ache between her legs was too much to bear, but Catra’s voice held a trepidation that Adora couldn’t ignore. “Wife. Is that what you really want?”

Adora didn’t know how to answer. She really didn’t want this to be the way they took this step, not after everything they’d been through. She’d spent hours thinking about how she’d ask the question, how she’d make the moment memorable, so perfect that Catra couldn’t possibly say no.

She took too long.

"Fuck. I knew it." Catra practically flew away from Adora, pulling her knees up to her chest with a grimace. Adora knew it must hurt; it had only been a couple of weeks, and Catra could still barely bend without exacerbating the tenderness of her stomach. Her voice cracked as she spoke, betraying her devastation, "I ruined us, didn't I?"

She wasn't sure whether it was her early morning brain fog or the distraction of how cruelly turned on she was, but Adora had no idea how their conversation had taken such a dramatic turn so quickly. She reached out for Catra, but her girlfriend had already swung her legs off the side of the bed, sitting up with her head held in her hands, purposefully turned away from her.

"Catra…"

"I pushed you too far and now even your parents hate me."

What? Where is she getting all this from?

Adora thought back to the previous day; Catra had been so withdrawn when her mum and dad visited to drop off pre-cooked meals and see how they were doing. She'd spent barely half an hour with them before claiming she needed to nap, and even though Adora knew she'd been resting all morning and had previously seemed perfectly content with the prospect of her parents looking after her while Adora returned to work, she'd become awfully shifty about the arrangement since giving birth.

Adora hauled herself upright, cursing her grogginess. She shuffled over to Catra on the edge bed, wrapping her arms around her shoulders.

"They love you, Catra, what are you talking about?"

Catra scoffed bitterly.

"I heard you on the phone, Adora, when I was going into labour. I know you. You wouldn't have gotten mad at them if they didn't have a problem with me."

Adora groaned, unsure what part of her argument with her mother Catra might have overheard. She sighed deeply, Catra's uncharacteristic defensiveness and constant yearning for reassurance over the past fortnight starting to make more sense. She'd thought it was just the hormone rush, but apparently it was much more than that.

"They were mad at me, not you."

"Because you let me hurt you."

Adora stopped herself from pointing out that it was Catra's repeated attempts to paint herself as a villain that hurt her more than anything else; it made it seem like she had no agency of her own. But Adora had been responsible for her own actions in this whole arrangement. She'd been the one who'd chosen to go along with it all, who refused to admit how she really felt, and who let the agonising inconsistency of her emotions impact all of her relationships.

"No. Because I wasn't communicating. They think what you've done is incredible. It *is* incredible."

Catra quietened, a question dancing on her lips that she was too scared to voice. Adora pulled her back into bed, yanking the covers tight around them and folding herself into the curve of Catra's body. She ached with the realisation that by pretending everything was always okay, she'd compromised the trust that it had taken her and Catra years to rebuild.

Maybe now you can fix it, if you just stop worrying so much about upsetting other people.

Adora took a deep breath to steady herself.

"They were upset that I wasn't being properly honest with myself, or you. About how much I wanted kids and what it was like seeing you pregnant. But I really didn't think it would be so hard, you know? And I know Micah isn't ours, but I kept forgetting that and then every time I remembered, I couldn't…"

Adora's resolve gave out. She'd spent months pushing all her feelings down; relinquishing them to Catra was extremely hard work. It felt like too much too late, and she was terrified that she could have left it too long to save them.

"You wished it were different."

She burrowed further into Catra's arms in response to her misery, skimming her fingers over the pliable raised skin of the stretch marks embossed on her girlfriend's distended abdomen. It had been so long since she had been the one to be held. She'd missed this so much. Catra felt so strong, soft and firm at the same time. The burgeoning dampness on her girlfriend's chest threatened to break them up – she knew Catra would need to relieve her milk sooner rather than later – but for now, she couldn't bring herself to put any space between them.

"So, what does it mean? Is this…" Catra's speech was no longer small and timid – she'd moved into that familiar problem-solving mode she'd depended on her whole life to survive. She spoke calmly, her words perfectly measured. "Is this as far as we can go?"

It was like a knife through Adora's heart. How had she woken barely thirty minutes ago, hardly able to stop herself from proposing, only to end up here?

"No, Cat-"

"I won't be the person who stops you from getting what you want, 'Dor. I can't live with it, being the reason you're unhappy."

"*You're* what makes me happy. I want this."

Catra sighed, her fingertips teasing Adora's scalp.

"But do you want more?"

There wasn't a simple answer to her question. But Adora knew what was absolutely non-negotiable, what and who she'd choose time and time again. She just couldn't work out how she could possibly convince Catra of it. Adora had spent so long saying what she thought everyone around her needed to hear that she didn't know how to share her genuine desires in a way that prevented others from doubting her truthfulness. And then it dawned on her: she'd always had the words; she only needed to borrow them. Her father had gifted them to her so many years ago, and there was no-one else she would think to say them to.

"I waited so long to call you mine. And I love you."

She pushed herself up, taking Catra's face in her hands and forcing their eyes to lock onto one another's. It wasn't right, never looking at each other during the hardest conversations. She wanted Catra to see all of her – her pain, her hopes, her wants. She wanted to see all of Catra.

"I promise you, there's nothing that I could want more than I want you. And I can't wait any longer, living without you being my wife."

"You said 'wife' again."

Adora nodded, never more resolute. She willed Catra to see it, that she was Adora's future, kids or no kids. There never was and never could be anyone else. She'd known it her whole life, and finally, she realised she didn't need some elaborate proposal scheme to prove it.

"Kids might make me happy, but I'd have nothing to give them if I didn't have you."

"Adora…" Catra quivered, every minuscule movement giving away her apprehension.

“Catra, love. Please will you believe me, when I tell you you’re enough?”

“You said ‘wife’.”

“Yeah, I said ‘wife’. What are you?” Adora trembled as she spoke softly, her heart in her mouth, “Some kind of broken record?”

Catra’s eyes wandered Adora’s face, as if she was tracking every pore and wrinkle, searching for something that she hadn’t seen before.

“I really thought I’d lost you.”

“No,” Adora frowned, sadness bleeding into the anticipation swirling inside her. “I’m so sorry, that I ever let you think-”

“This *isn’t* the end for us?”

“Catra,” Adora leaned in, hovering over her lips, “If you’ll have me, it’s only the start.”

This time, Adora didn’t wait for Catra to come to her. She didn’t have the patience to spend another ten seconds – let alone another ten years – wandering the earth with her heart outside of her body. She captured Catra’s lips with hers, pouring every ounce of emotion into the kiss, somehow familiar and unprecedented all at once. She could feel the goosebumps rise on Catra’s skin as they fell back against the pillows, wrapped up in one another as if they could become one person, never to be pulled apart again.

They lay there holding each other, the thumping of their hearts pushing against the silence. Adora stroked her girlfriend’s cheek with her thumb as Catra leaned her forehead against her own, whispering into the air around them. “Aren’t you going to ask me properly?”

Adora smirked, borrowing one of Catra’s most frequent expressions. “I didn’t think you were so traditional.”

"*'Dor…*" She would have laughed at Catra's whine if she didn't want to get it right so badly.

Adora brought one hand up to cradle Catra's head, her fingers weaving through her curls to ease them into place behind her ear.

"Catra Smith, you remarkable woman. Will you marry me?"

"I suppose, if you *really* want me to."

"Yeah?"

"Yeah," Adora's chest swelled as Catra met her lips again. "Us against the world, right?"

"I always told you, didn't I? Nothing can keep us apart."

Chapter End Notes

This wasn't how I originally imagined this scene, but it kind of took on its own direction. I hope you liked it!

Chapter 20

SIX MONTHS AFTER

Glimmer switched her crossed legs for the third time, her fingers drumming on the side of her laptop restlessly. She scanned her inbox again, cursing when she accidentally deleted an important email with the slightest touch on the screen. She fucking hated these new notepads they'd rolled out across the company while she was on maternity leave with Micah. Not for the first time, Glimmer thought about asking Catra to play around with it and change the settings and capabilities for her. But she was sensible enough to know she couldn't exactly role model computer hacking to her team, and besides, things hadn't been good between her and Catra for a while now.

She sighed, irritation prickling at her brain. Glimmer knew neither Bow nor Adora liked playing go-between the two of them but given what had happened when Micah was a newborn, it was hard for either of them to rise above it all.

The chiming of a clock in the corner of the coffee shop brought her back to the present. Her interviewee was now nearly half an hour late and she'd probably have to push her internal meetings back; if Bow couldn't leave early to pick Micah up from nursery, she'd have to skip lunch too.

"Great," Glimmer muttered bitterly under her breath, "absolutely fucking perfect."

Her return to work over the past month had been challenging, to say the least. If she wasn't driven to exhaustion picking up the workload that had slacked thanks to her useless maternity cover, Glimmer was wracking her brains with worry that something could have happened to her six-month-old while she was in some pointless teleconference call. There could have been something

she'd forgotten to tell the nursery managers, or an intolerance they didn't know about yet. She'd had plenty of minor allergies when she was little – what if Micah had inherited something they had no idea about until it was too late? She wouldn't even be there to intervene if tragedy struck, and it felt far too familiar for comfort. Glimmer had spent nearly ten months watching from the sidelines as someone else carried her child, and the slow-burning shame that she was continuing a trend of pushing responsibility for him into other people's hands was bearing down on her heavily.

Was that why I picked a fight with Catra in the first place?

Glimmer shivered, plastering over her never-ending worry with growing frustration at the no-show she'd wasted her time on. She was dangerously close to giving up on this entire meeting – it wasn't an angle she was particularly comfortable chasing anyway.

Ten more minutes. That's all I'm giving him.

If Glimmer hadn't been absent from work for most the past year, she'd have left the coffee shop long ago. But at this point, she knew it wouldn't help her get settled back in if she pissed off one of her top clients. Ironically, her job in PR had led to her working with the government department she'd been previously fired from almost eight years ago. She wasn't quite sure whether she was grateful for never running into one of her old Ministry of Justice managers, or if she wished she had the opportunity to show off how far she'd come; she knew she probably earned much more than those who'd sacked her did. Perhaps it shouldn't give her so much pleasure to know it, but Glimmer had never been one for letting things go. She'd felt pretty scorned at the time for being held solely accountable for the theft of her laptop, even if she had known that it was her own fault for getting caught taking her work kit home anyway.

The project she was working on for them now, though, didn't sit entirely right with her. She'd been tasked with building a campaign

publicising a new pilot that had minimised jail time for a range of lower-risk prisoners in favour of tailored therapy treatments, community volunteering and a monitored return to work program. In theory, it aligned with everything Glimmer believed in. But she'd seen the breakdown of what 'lower-risk' included, and among the pilot participants she'd been asked to interview for inclusion in the campaign materials were those formerly convicted of rape, domestic violence and various forms of manslaughter. It was complicated for Glimmer to come to terms with.

It made her think about Catra more than she really wanted to, and she'd purposefully not mentioned the assignment to Adora or Bow for that very reason. She knew they both had a much clearer picture of what Catra had endured; the fact that neither of them had ever told her the full story, prioritising Catra's privacy above all else, cemented the suspicion that it had to be something – or someone – really bad. Glimmer had put together some pieces of the puzzle herself: she knew from vague court reports released in the press that Catra had been forced to carry out some illegal cyber activities by a toxic ex and that after several years of forced isolation, a botched escape attempt had resulted in the nasty car crash that happened barely two months before her hysterectomy.

Glimmer knew she'd never forget the faded scars on Catra's left shoulder and back that were revealed when she was in labour with Micah and needed help changing. Before then, she'd not reflected much on why Catra always stuck to her uniform of modest band and print t-shirts, high-waisted jeans and crisp suits, apart from to wonder why she didn't want to show off more of herself. Sure, she'd seen a few old photos of Catra and Adora as teens displayed in their flat, clad in revealing party clothes and close-fitting running kit that left barely anything to the imagination, but Glimmer had spent much more time thinking about what it would be like to have the kind of figures Catra and Adora had, never having to account for bountiful thighs or the deep curve of a hip that clothes rarely skimmed over as intended. But the disfigurements Glimmer had seen as she laboured had made her query whether the wounds of Catra's experiences were

still as far (or further)-reaching internally as they were on the surface.

And now she was supposed to help advocate for people who'd victimised others – including men who'd damaged women like how Prime had harmed Catra – to be perceived as safe to return to society, as worthy of a kinder path to redemption. Her stomach had been in knots for days, balancing her long-held support for prison reform with the overwhelming anger that the society they lived in gave such little weight to female trauma. It was an impossible weigh-up, and Glimmer was far too opinionated about both issues to settle on an acceptable middle ground. For now, she'd just have to knuckle down and try to be open-minded to whatever came out of her interviews. *If* – she sulked – *any of them actually happen.*

Glimmer distracted herself from her impatience by scrolling through photos of Micah that Bow had emailed to her work address when she was really struggling to motivate herself in her first week back from maternity leave. She ordered a second coffee when the barista came over with her croissant, taken aback when a deep voice rang out.

"Hey, can you add another one to that order?" A tall, broad-shouldered man in his late thirties – *maybe even early forties* – towered above her, his golden hair twisted into a top-knot that exaggerated his height even further. "Glimmer, right?"

She nodded, examining his pressed jeans and the textured crew neck jumper layered under a perfectly distressed leather jacket. *This guy is a convict? Looks more like he spends all day making beard oil and growing organic veg…*

"Dave?"

"Guilty as charged! Sorry to be so late – a bus broke down by Dryl Park, so the traffic's backed up for days."

Glimmer cringed a little at his joke – she knew he'd become some kind of motivational speaker since he finished the pilot programme a couple of years ago (that was why the Ministry insisted he be involved in the campaign), but surely there was no need to be so light-hearted about it? *Am I just being oversensitive?*

She waved her hand casually to accept his apology, keen to get on with the meeting. Maybe, if she could get what she needed out of him fast enough, she could recoup some of the time she'd lost.

They rattled through her questions pretty quickly; she couldn't help but relax slightly when he revealed he'd been imprisoned for minor crimes against national security and two counts of manslaughter – seemingly just some stuff on the internet and causing a car crash. His actions and imprisonment had fractured all his relationships, and much of his public speaking platform revolved around self-forgiveness, entrepreneurship – he'd set up a charity that promoted gaming as a therapy for anger management for at-risk youth – and mentoring kids in the care system. Glimmer mentally ticked off the options for how they could feature him in the campaign; it was an impressive story, and he was handsome enough for any images they took to land well across socials.

All that was left to do was take him through the branding plans for the campaign and get him to sign the digital consent form to participate. She pulled up the paperwork on her laptop and twisted the screen round, handing him a stylus to sign at the bottom of the form. But before he even took it from her hand, he looked up at her in shock, his pupils widening as they flitted between her and the screen.

"What?" Glimmer had no idea what could surprise him about the contract; she turned the laptop screen back towards herself and saw that the touchscreen had been triggered, the paperwork minimised in favour of a partially candid photo Bow had taken on the day Micah was born. It showed her and Adora squeezed next to Catra on the hospital bed, Micah held in his surrogate's arms as Glimmer gazed down at her son, while Adora pressed her lips to the side of Catra's head. Only Catra had noticed the photo being

taken and looked straight at the camera lens, her eyes shining with tired accomplishment. Glimmer paused for a second, remembering the overwhelming gratitude and awe that she'd felt towards her friend that day. She'd avoided looking at that photo for a while; it made her feel even worse about the current situation. She cleared her throat, realising her thoughts were delaying them from wrapping up the meeting.

"Sorry. I was looking at that before you arrived, I must have not closed the window properly."

"Is that…?" Glimmer made sure the contract was displayed on the laptop, not realising Dave was still staring at her. "God, I haven't been able to find out anything about her for years."

Glimmer looked up at him, eyes narrowing. *Is he talking about Catra?*

"Just tell me, did she have the kid? I mean, I assumed she lost it, but she has to know how much I hated myself for it, how much I loved her – both of them – even though it was early. No-one would tell me anything once I was in custody, they said she'd refused to-"

Glimmer's blood ran cold as he rambled. *Was this part of the detail that had been kept from her?*

"*Prime?*"

Her voice sounded more fearful than she'd wanted it to. Recognition sparked in his eyes as he choked back strangled acknowledgement of the name; clearly, he hadn't used it for a long time. Glimmer felt like she could throw up right in front of him. She snapped the laptop shut – *no way was he going to be part of this campaign* – and stood to pack her stuff up, wholly unable to keep her hands from trembling in both fury and fright.

"Please. You know her, right? Is she doing okay?"

"You don't get to ask that."

She threw a twenty-pound note on the table – it wasn't the time to care about receipts and expenses – and rushed out the coffee shop as quickly as she could. He followed her, grabbing onto her hand as she made it out the door, stopping them both on the pavement.

"*Get your hands off me*." Glimmer couldn't control the rage and disgust pouring out of her. She didn't need to be on good terms with Catra at the minute to hate this man with every ounce of energy she had.

He jumped away immediately, holding his hands up.

"I'm sorry! Sorry. I just… Please, she was the love of my life and I screwed it up so badly. I need… All I want is to apologise. I know I could have treated her better, and I've wished I could make amends ever since I was released."

"Screw you," her hiss felt poisonous, "they never should have even let you out!"

Glimmer turned away from him and stormed off, hardly stopping to breathe until she was back on the subway, speeding her way towards the office. But she was so caught up in her thoughts that she didn't get off at her stop, not realising where she was until the train drew up to the platform a few stations further. She came to just before the doors closed, racing out, pulling on her scarf quickly to stop it from getting trapped and making this hellish day into even more of a nightmare.

Glimmer exited the station, staring up at the towering offices ahead of her in the west end of Bright Moon city centre. Before she knew it, she was striding through glass doors, past receptionists and straight into open office space, unsure if it was the right thing to do but definitely sure that something – fate, madness or something else – was driving her there.

"Glimmer?"

Catra had stopped mid-sentence while addressing a group of employees, her brow furrowed in confusion. It was the first time they'd seen each other in person in five months. Glimmer could see instantly that Catra had returned to her pre-pregnancy self; her olive suit and cream shirt were nipped in narrowly at the waist and her previously unruly mane was nursed into shiny, defined curls that cascaded down her back, even longer than before.

Glimmer didn't know what to say, shocked at herself for interrupting. Not bothering to wait for a response, Catra dismissed her team, leading Glimmer into a private meeting room – she knew that no-one at the start-up had personal offices, not even Catra – and flicking a switch that activated a privacy blind to descend and block the glass wall.

"What are you doing here? You can't just show up in the middle of the day for no reason, Glimmer – we're done with that now, surely?"

Glimmer struggled to pull any comprehensive sentence out of her brain, the harshness of Catra's tone insinuating that all the packed lunches and impromptu lifts home from work during her pregnancy with Micah may not have been as warmly appreciated as she and Bow had believed before. The realisation sapped her adrenaline and all of a sudden, Glimmer couldn't get past how absurd this whole thing was. What did she think she was doing? Shirking off her own responsibilities at work, tanking the most important recruitment exercise for her project and barging into Catra's office, ready to dredge up some of the most painful parts of her past. And for what? To make their strained relationship even worse?

"Just spit it out, Glimmer. Aren't you meant to be back at work now?"

Glimmer gulped as she caught Catra's eye, still torn over whether it was the right decision to be there at all. She had to make up a viable excuse, fast, if she wasn't going to spill what had happened. Catra seemed to pick up on her internal distress, her

whole demeanour softening as she reached for her phone in her pocket.

“Is it Micah? You want me to ring Bow?”

The last thing Glimmer wanted was Bow to get involved – she wasn’t sure he’d take her side in this, that he’d agree she should have come here, and her conflict with Catra had already created enough tension between them.

“No, no. I… Something happened this morning.”

“Okay…”

“I think we should sit down.”

Catra nodded cautiously, sitting down at the conference table and pushing out a chair for Glimmer. They both settled down, and despite herself, Glimmer grabbed at Catra’s hands on the table; the other woman startled, her pupils contracting in surprise as they finally made eye contact.

“Glimmer, are you sure we shouldn’t ring-”

“I met Prime today,” Glimmer kept going, knowing if she stopped at the strange breath that had stopped in Catra’s throat she’d never get any further, “It was a work thing, and I didn’t know who he was in advance. He’s calling himself-”

“David Jones? It’s his real name.”

“You know?”

“I was practically a professional hack, Glimmer. Don’t you think I keep tabs on people? I know all about the reduced sentence and his shitty little speaking gigs.”

“Oh. Well, it’s just… he saw that photo of you and Micah on my laptop, completely by accident, I promise. And, he… he wants…”

Catra's voice dropped to a low murmur, her jaw locked in thinly veiled ire, "What does he want?"

"He wants to meet with you to apologise. And… and he's asking whether his kid survived."

Catra's shoulders fell, her hand tearing out of Glimmer's grasp to fly to her brow.

"Fuck. I didn't think he'd ever find me – I've deleted all the public data on me I could scrub, hacked his search engine results, I've got no social media… Shit!"

She stood up as her palm collided loudly with the table, pacing the room as she shook the sting out her hand. Glimmer watched in standstill, as unsure of herself as she had been before she broke the news. The question slipped through her lips too fast.

"Were you really pregnant, back then?"

Catra stilled, turning to stare out the window.

"No, not… not when he actually thought I was." Glimmer rose, readying herself to approach Catra, but she continued speaking before Glimmer got anywhere close to her, a sad craving for approval leaking out through her voice, "I would never have brought a child into that kind of environment. It's why I finally left, because I knew… I knew I wouldn't be able to deal with it safely if he did get me pregnant again…"

"Catra-"

"I'd have been terrible at the whole mum thing anyway. I'm way too fucked up to raise a kid."

Glimmer finally reached Catra, her fingers resting tentatively on her forearm; Glimmer hoped it came across as caring rather than intrusive.

"Don't let what happened with him screw with your head. You'd be an excellent mother, Catra."

She knew it was a mistake as soon as the words passed her lips. Catra lurched past her to the doorway, pausing for a second before she retracted the privacy blind.

"We both know that's not what you really think." The air froze between them rapidly, just as fast as it had the last time they'd spoken. "Now if you don't mind, I've got a shit ton of work to get on with. And do me a favour – not a single word about this to Bow or Adora, got it?"

Glimmer barely forced the "Got it" out her mouth before Catra thrust the door open with such force it shook the wall. Glimmer scurried out after her and left the office as quickly as she could, only looking back for a second to see Catra watching after her, a stony expression settled on her face.

She could barely concentrate the rest of the day, faking a sick call from the nursery to get the rest of the day off work, and picking Micah up early so she could spend the afternoon with her son in her arms, his happy babbling and slobbery kisses acting as the only antidote to the aching anguish that shredded her insides. It wasn't until she lay in bed, still awake at 3am as both her husband and son slept in the pitch-black room, that the screen of her phone lit up with the first message she'd received from Catra in months.

Set the meeting up. Don't tell anyone.

The instruction made Glimmer's hair stand on end, but even if she hadn't screwed their friendship over, she didn't really know enough about what had happened between Catra and Prime to know how to talk her out of it.

She snuck out of bed, gripping her phone in nervous clammy hands, and fired off a quick email. The response was

instantaneous; Glimmer guessed Prime – or Dave, whatever she was supposed to call him – had been up all night too.

It's sorted. Tomorrow at nine, that coffee shop on the corner of Thaymore Street. I'm coming with.

She watched as three dots came up in the message thread under Catra's name, disappearing and reappearing over and over again in the space of a few minutes. Until finally -

Fine. I'll see you there.

All the air left Glimmer's lungs. She crawled back into bed, turning into Bow's warm body, so blissfully unaware of the secret she was keeping from him. Both he and Adora would be livid when they inevitably found out, she was sure of it. But maybe if this helped her thaw the animosity between her and Catra, they would see the silver lining. Glimmer was desperate to convince herself of it: perhaps dealing with Prime for good was exactly what they needed to bring the four of them together again.

Chapter 21

Chapter Notes

> This was possibly the hardest chapter to write yet - but we finally get that scene between Catra and Prime!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

FIVE YEARS PRIOR

Catra traced her finger over the artwork that slithered across her collarbone, almost as if she expected the black ink to feel different to the freckled canvas it stood out against. She didn't think about it much usually, but last night Adora had been completely fixated on how the ink slicked against her skin; she'd murmured under her breath how sexy it was, how she hadn't stopped thinking about it ever since they first clumsily reunited under fluorescent bathroom lights. Catra suspected Adora thought it added some kind of edgy mystery to her, the audacity of it so far removed from the goody-two-shoes life of being a perfect unblemished, blue-eyed doctor. Adora had asked her frequently when and why she got it, but Catra always managed to fob off her queries, changing the subject or giving purposefully vague answers. The truth wasn't something she wanted to put in Adora's mind, not when she liked it so much. She'd be horrified if she knew what the tattoo actually symbolised to Catra, how she'd glorified the permanent evidence of the control Prime had once wrought over her.

It'd break her if she really knew.

Catra filled up her glass at the kitchen sink, the early morning light filtering over her naked body through the slats of wooden blinds. At times like this, she was thoroughly grateful they always had the space to themselves. There were no witnesses to their time together; no-one else to think about or account for. She

could subsist solely on the taste of Adora's lips on hers, on her scent that filled Catra's airways and soothed her mind. Catra skimmed her palm over her ribs as she gulped down cool mouthfuls of water, her Saturday morning drowsiness giving way to slowly sharpening senses. The bruises Adora had left on her last night were clearer now too: they trailed from the inside of her right thigh up through her stomach, on the underside of her tits and by that sweet spot where the curve of her breast met the edges of her armpit, clustered around the outskirts of her ink. She shook her head at the empty kitchen, silently berating herself for thinking too much about it, for letting urgent dampness pool between her legs again. They didn't have time this morning for that; they had a wedding to get on with.

All hell will break loose if we fuck with the schedule.

The stress of the lead-up to this day – and the discomfort of how she and Glimmer still tiptoed round each other – could have ruined the whole thing. But Adora's uninhibited excitement made it impossible to stay tense for long. She didn't have to see Adora's face to imagine the sly smile spreading across her lips when she wrapped her arms around Catra's bare torso from behind, one hand creeping south until her fingers met gratifying stickiness.

"I hope it's not the neighbours having this effect on you."

Catra reached over the sink to close the window blinds, double checking that no-one could actually see them from the block of flats next door. The silk of Adora's dress pressed against her back, so gentle against her faded scars, as an impatient foot rubbed softly against the inside of her calf. Catra squeezed her thighs together, betrayed by the evidence of her own arousal.

"Careful, 'Dor. I don't want to ruin your dress."

"How on earth, Catra," Adora spoke with mock ignorance, her voice thick with desire, "Could you possibly ruin this dress?"

Catra pushed Adora away emphatically, but not enough for it to actually work. Adora nibbled at the base of her neck, teasing her for being so cautious.

“Adora, we can’t be late. We’d never hear the end of it!”

“I thought *you* were supposed to be the naughty one… Remember how you used to drive all the teachers nuts?”

Catra chuckled lightly, unsure whether it was her memories of being the class smart-arse at school or the tickle of Adora’s breath on her skin that sparked it.

“Still got top marks, though.”

“Yeah, you did…”

Catra’s head fell back as Adora began to work her magic; she kept raising her hand to intercept Adora’s touch – she really needed to go and get ready herself – but she kept faltering, never quite able to move Adora’s fingers away. She dropped her glass into the kitchen sink with a clatter, clamping onto the edge of the counter as the waves built and built inside her until-

“Fuck, Adora... seriously, your d-dre-“

Catra couldn’t control the deep convulsion tearing through her body any more than she could stop the short, irrepressible spurt of fluid soaking into pristine silk. She dropped her head to her forearms as she bent over to catch her breath, dread seeping into her bones as Adora wiped her fingers off on Catra’s hip.

“Wow, you really *did* ruin my dress.”

“Glimmer’s going to kill me. If she didn’t already hate me enough…”

Catra heard the dull slap of wet fabric hitting and sticking to Adora’s thigh as she moved to Catra’s side.

"Hey, she doesn't hate you. Things have been a little better lately, right?"

"Not better enough to get away with ruining her bloody bridesmaid's dress."

"Well, it's a good thing we didn't then, isn't it?"

Catra twisted a little to look at Adora out the corner of her eye, relief flowing through her as she saw Adora was not wearing her bridesmaid's outfit after all; instead, she'd put on a long slip nightgown that Catra had only ever seen her wear once.

If this is her idea of a good prank, on today of all days…

"Oh my God, you bitch, you really decided today was the day to fuck with me, huh?"

"Well, just to fuck you, really." Adora giggled as Catra swatted at her, pulling on Catra's arm to bring her in close enough to purr in her ear, "It was worth it though, wasn't it?"

Catra wasn't going to give her the satisfaction. She drew the wet fabric away from Adora's skin coyly, noticing how goosebumps began to rise on her girlfriend's shoulders in eager anticipation of her touch, before letting it fall back with a sharp smack.

"Catra-!"

"Get this off and put it in cold water. I'm not dealing with that stain for you while you run bridezilla interference."

She pretended not to realise she'd left the bathroom door open when Adora soon slipped into the cramped space with her; Catra imagined that if – *no, when* – they lived together again, she'd insist on a huge walk-in shower, one with enough room for both of them (though, as Adora often reminded her, the squeeze wasn't all that bad).

When they returned to the bathroom in the early hours of the morning, still slightly drunk and dizzy with the dew of cooled dancefloor sweat sticking to the backs of their necks, Catra pressed Adora against the tiles as she sunk to her knees, pushing dusky lilac silk up past her thighs.

"Adora, you're not wearing any-"

"I know."

"Thought you'd get lucky, did you?"

"Mmm, I don't usually have to wait so long for my turn..."

Adora bit down on her lip as Catra blew a steady stream of warm air onto her vulva. She was too tipsy to hold back; the second Catra made physical contact, her mind short-circuited and she couldn't help but beg for more.

"Give me a minute to get started, 'Dor…" Adora could hear the snicker in her speech, "God, you're demanding when you've had a drink."

She whimpered as Catra's voice bounced off her clit, soon followed by the flat of her tongue, sweeping back and forth, randomised patterns of touch quickening the tension curled in the pit of her belly. Adora could have congratulated herself on how well she'd taught her girlfriend, though she'd needed little encouragement to practice once they got past the first few shaky attempts. Adora would never have thought Catra would be the one who'd want to give more often than she got, though she sure as hell wasn't going to complain about that.

The whole event had completely intoxicated her, and she'd barely been able to keep her hands off Catra, much to their friends' amusement. Even Catra had raised an eyebrow, teasing her for being cliched enough to get so sappy at a wedding. She fixated on the thought of how Catra looked in her new suit at the reception, how its deep navy cashmere complimented her tan skin, and how her blazer fell off her shoulders now, revealing skin

that was only ever exposed to her. If Catra was a closed book – and she was to so many people, in so many different ways – Adora knew that she was the only person trusted with learning the language to read every page of her. It was all she'd ever wanted, to be to Catra what Catra had always been to her.

Adora was sentimental enough in her boozy state for the overwhelming feeling of love for the woman between her legs to send her hurtling over the edge. Her pulse raced as she inched closer and closer to her climax and she zeroed in on the feel of tiny pre-shocks lapping at her insides, getting stronger and stronger as Catra continued. She threaded her right-hand fingers through Catra's hair, wordlessly pleading for more, slamming her left palm against the tiled wall behind her in the hope it would help steady her trembling legs. The difference in temperature between the cold ceramic and Catra's suck on her clit made her feel wild, like she was living on two separate planets at the very same time.

She tumbled into Catra's lap as she came, her skirt pooling around them as she cried out in pleasure. Catra trailed kisses up Adora's neck, her fingers still inside her, kneading tenderly to soothe the ripples of pressure that were only just starting to subside. Adora shucked Catra's blazer off her shoulders entirely as she recovered from her breathlessness, grounding her body as she regained full awareness of her surroundings.

"I don't know how you could bear to keep this on all night."

"Beauty is pain, right?"

"Oh," Adora inhaled deeply through her nose, her eyes crinkling at Catra's words, "you're so beautiful without it, though."

Catra shivered against the cold air as Adora smoothed her palms across the uneven terrain of her upper back and shoulder, the smug accomplishment that had painted Catra's face fading a little into wistfulness. Adora changed tack, dragging her fingers forward

to Catra's collarbone, leaning in to kiss the expanse of skin in front of her, her lips pressing into freckles and ink.

"Is it crazy that I kinda want to get one to match?"

Adora felt Catra's breath catch under her cheek before she heard it.

"Please," Catra lifted Adora's chin with her fingers, "Promise me you won't do that, 'Dor."

"Why? You don't think it'll look good? I'm not so straight-laced, you know."

Catra smiled a little sadly, her hand coming up to cradle Adora's face.

"I know that. But I'd rather you get something for yourself." She leaned in to peck Adora's lips. "If you even remember this."

"Hey! We're not that drunk."

"If you say so."

"I say so."

"Okay."

Adora leaned her forehead against Catra's, blowing wisps of hair out the way, "I'm going to get something though... Ah! A cat! I'll get a cat, because you're Catra!"

"Mmhmm." Catra kissed Adora lazily, her arms laced around the blonde's waist. "As long as it makes you happy, babe."

As long as it's your choice.

SIX MONTHS AFTER

Sometimes Catra wondered why, ever since she'd reunited with Adora, the big moments in her life seemed to map onto important milestones in Bow and Glimmer's. It was like their worlds circled around the sun on the same trajectory at the same time, racing to get to an invisible finish line that she still couldn't see. First Glimmer's surgery, taking place only weeks after her own hospital stay; their engagement news shared the day after Catra and Entrapta decided to start their business; their wedding, barely a month before Adora asked her to move in; then Adora's proposal, just two and a half weeks after Micah's birth – though in fairness, that one was far less of a coincidence. And now… Now Glimmer's return to work had led her to this over-stylised coffee shop that displayed cakes on rectangular slate instead of porcelain trays and sold so many complicated specialty roasts that she'd ended up ordering ginger tea on principle.

She sighed as she watched Glimmer pour milk into her coffee – Catra had no idea how she'd known what to pick – in the far corner of the shop, her seat strategically placed to give her a clear view of Catra without being able to overhear. Catra wasn't sure why she expected anything else; even though she knew Glimmer had never gotten the full picture of what happened between her and Prime, she was still the kind of woman who'd go to bat when she thought one of her people was being threatened. Catra guessed that despite everything – the way they'd raised their voices at one another, the weeks of refusing Glimmer's calls, how she'd declined every invitation from Bow to visit and dismissed Adora's pleas to just tell her *what the fuck had happened* – she was still the surrogate who'd birthed Glimmer's son. Maybe, after all these years, she'd even become more than that.

Shit, the door's opening. Is it…?

Catra's chest constricted as Prime came into view, and for a split second, all the feelings she'd slogged to blank out for eight years

came hurtling back. She couldn't sort the heartbreak of how it had all ended from the crippling fear that she was letting him have her again.

What if he does it again and I end up trapped with him and this time, there's no way out?

She squeezed her fist open and closed again under the table as he approached, counting the droplets of tea scattered on her saucer. For a split second, she caught Glimmer's eye and the woman's reciprocated look of alarm immediately told her she was doing the one thing she always promised herself she wouldn't.

Numero uno: Don't let anyone know you're scared.

Catra hardened her stare as Glimmer began to rise out of her seat, silently threatening her to stay exactly where she was. She swung her head back towards Prime just in time for him to reach her, shifting his weight on his feet nervously. For a second, it gave her the confidence to hold her head up that little bit higher, to feel a little more secure.

Ha! He thinks he's the one on the backfoot!

He was just as tall as she remembered when he settled down opposite her. But his hair was long now, and it made her think of his sister. The concrete wall she'd conjured around her heart started to crack, and suddenly it dawned on her that maybe she wasn't actually strong enough for this after all. The turn of emotions inside of her was maddening. Hadn't she spent years psyching herself up for this very conversation, readying herself for confrontation she never imagined would actually take place? Would it really be worse to stay, to give him the satisfaction of a hello?

She set her jaw and forced her hands to steady, stretching out her palms and placing them firmly on her lap. It was useless thinking she'd actually leave. He'd sat down and she was barely two sips into her tea, and if Catra had picked up any habits in her life, it

was not to waste good money. His fingers flexed as he uttered his greetings, like he was taking her hand in some other shadow life, one where their whirlwind beginnings never led them to the bloodied end. She folded her arms over her chest. She didn't live in the shadows anymore.

"Thanks for agreeing to this. I didn't think you…" Prime seemed more unsure of himself than Catra expected. "I'm sure it isn't easy."

His uncertainty should have made her feel better, but it didn't. His insecurity didn't match up to her anger, and irritation swept through Catra as she struggled to see how she could feel powerful taking him down a peg or two if he was just going to be so frustratingly *weak.*

"What do you want, Prime?"

He flinched at the sound of his old name, "I don't go by that anymore."

She squeezed her shoulder blades to square her shoulders, her arms still tight over her chest. Her finger twitched over the tattoo she knew hid under her clothes, that she'd been hiding from herself for so long. It was just another scar on her body that he'd forced her to carve in the name of a delusional type of love, an impression his actions would leave on her forever.

"I'm not here to talk with 'Nice Guy' Dave. Did you think I came to make friends with whatever this," she gestured at his carefully constructed outfit of wool knits and denim, "is?"

He sighed heavily, mirroring her stance.

"Why did you?"

Catra furrowed her brow. She didn't expect him to ask her that, and she wasn't sure if she could even put her finger on what exactly had made her mind up.

To show you how you didn't break me. How I'm more successful than you could have ever been. And so you feel shame, like the way you made me ashamed for so many years, when I had no-one. I'm reclaiming the last word you stole from me, and here to make sure you never, ever look me up again. But maybe most of all, I just want to be done with you.

She wouldn't give any of it away. Deflection was her next best move.

"You didn't answer my question."

Catra was surprised by how much she genuinely wanted to hear Prime's response. She'd monitored all his internet activity and tracked his movements since she got the victim notification message that he'd been released after only four and a half years. Even before then, she'd done everything she could to block him from ever finding her, insisting that Entrapta be credited solely as the public head of their company, her own profile never displayed on their public materials. Entrapta had negotiated that if she agreed, and if she helped Catra build exceptional security mechanisms around her and Adora – later extended to Micah when they built the baby monitors – Catra had to give up on enforcing company-wide NDAs. It was no way to onboard investors, after all. Their pact agreed, Catra had become the silent boss who actually ran the show, who no-one met until they got to their first day on the job. She was fucking formidable for it.

Prime sighed heavily as she narrowed her eyes at him.

"I just wanted to explain. I know I was terrible to you, beyond terrible. But I've made a career out of helping people now. And I want you to know that I'm making better choices. So that it doesn't happen to other people. And I… I wanted to find out if you were okay. Apologise."

"Are you serious?" Catra's acerbic tone cut through the air sharply, and she inhaled deeply to stabilise herself before continuing, her

voice quieter than before. “Think your sister is dead just because you didn’t make ‘better choices’?”

You think all these scars I have are just because of some bad decision-making?

“I’ll never forgive myself for his- for *her* death. I think about it all the time.”

“Good for you.”

Catra sipped at her tea, determined to calm the fire raging inside her. She wasn’t going to be the first to snap, to fully lose her temper. And she was an expert when it came to concealing emotion. She almost felt victorious when she noticed a sore expression fall over his face, revealing his trepidation.

“Did you love Drew?”

“No,” Catra continued before Prime could turn it back on her, “But she knew that. You wouldn’t understand. You have no idea what it was like.”

“Tell me.”

“What do you want me to say? You heard it all in court, didn’t you?”

“Not from you.”

Catra sighed, leaning back in her seat. “Do you *really* want to do this? Because if it’s fodder for your sick little speaking gigs, I’ll make sure you’re shut down so quick you get whiplash.”

She could tell he was taken aback by her aggression; it wasn’t a side of her he’d witnessed before. Catra had never had the currency to risk it.

“You’ve changed.”

“What did you expect? You made me the way I was then. It was never who I really was.”

Prime dipped his head in acknowledgement.

“I’m sorry.”

Catra raised an eyebrow. “For what part? You didn’t even get time for half of it.”

“For all of it.”

They sat in silence for several minutes, mulling it over.

“If you’re looking for forgiveness, you’re not going to get it. If I have to live with this, so do you.”

Catra saw how his jaw hardened at her words; he didn’t like what he was hearing. Maybe he hadn’t changed that much after all. She forced herself not to flinch, to stop familiar fear from setting in.

“I really did love you, Catra.”

Prime’s words had a bitter edge, like she’d been the one to let them down, like it was her who had destroyed their chance at happiness. Catra shook her head.

“You loved power.” She sighed irritably, fatigue starting to wash over her. “Look, it’s Saturday morning and I have plenty of places I’d rather be. We done?”

Catra reached for her cup, ready to drain the last few drops of tea.

“Wait!” She startled at his urgency, raising an eyebrow as he geared himself up to continue, “I know you probably don’t want to talk about it, but can you tell me what happened with the baby?”

Catra would have laughed if it wasn't all so tragic.

"There wasn't one. I just needed you to think there was."

He reeled as he realised the subtext, that she'd made it up to protect herself. She thought about telling him the full truth, that there had been a real pregnancy, but even if it would help her drive the knife in further, the idea of giving him more of herself was unbearable.

"But you've got kids now?"

He was hopeful, searching for the proof that he hadn't ruined her, that she was still on the trajectory he'd wanted for her, that he thought equalled happy ever after.

"No."

"I saw that photo-"

"He's not my kid. Drop it, okay?"

"What d'you do, put him in the system? How could you, knowing-"

Catra was set ablaze as the accusation sunk in; she rose from her seat, her entire body flooding with rage.

"If I had a kid, I couldn't 'put' it anywhere because I'd be petrified out my fucking skin that you'd get your hands on them."

"Cat-"

"I've nearly ripped myself apart – my partner apart – because I can't bring a child into a world in which you exist. Because the threat of you will *always* be bigger than the bubble I can keep them in. And what kind of life would that be? Tiptoeing round because I can't bear to let them out of my sight?"

Catra clamped her hand over her mouth as a strangled sob left her, shocked the words had formed at all. It was the truth she'd

never fully confronted, that her subconscious knew hurt too much to tell anyone – not Bow, not Entrapta, and especially not Adora. Once it was out there, they'd exhaust themselves trying to convince her that it would be safe, that her fears could be overcome. They'd never understand how the risk was too great, how protecting a child of hers well enough was a task she could never rely on anyone – not even herself – to perform.

"We're done here."

She turned slowly away from Prime, pulling her coat on over her sweater, so calm and controlled, like she still had her shit together. He stood up too, stepping back as if he knew she couldn't stomach seeing him tower over her like he used to.

"You'll never see me again, I promise."

Catra held his eye contact coldly. She didn't need to speak out loud for him to understand her: *As if I'd believe anything you say.*

She strode out the coffee shop and set off down the street, ignoring the sound of Glimmer chasing after her. It was like nothing else existed; it was just her and her emotions swirling in her head as the thoughts she'd locked away made their way to the surface. Is this what it all came down to? That she was still governed by fear rather than survivorship?

She shook Glimmer off as she felt her catch up, laying a hand on her shoulder to catch her attention.

"Leave me alone, Glimmer."

"Catra, you shouldn't be on your own-"

"Will you stop it? Just go!"

Catra didn't wait for Glimmer's response, turning the corner sharply and charging ahead, faster than she knew Glimmer would be able to keep up. She caught sight of a building ahead that drew her attention, and she found herself gravitating closer and

closer to it until she was right in front of its gates. Catra stared up at the foreign inscription on the building's facade, its words spelled out in an intricate mosaic that glinted in the morning sunlight.

Is this where I'm supposed to be, where my people are?

She'd never thought to look for one of these temples, but it seemed like it had revealed itself to her with purpose, like it was fate for her to find it in this moment. Catra inhaled a deep breath before she passed the security guard at the entrance, pausing for the heavy doors to be opened in front of her.

Catra didn't know what she'd find inside, or whether it would make this bewildering day better rather than worse. All she knew was that for the first time in months, she'd chanced upon a feeling that she might have found somewhere that could help her, where she could make sense of the life that she'd been striving for so long to survive.

Chapter End Notes

> What did you think? I'd love to hear what you thought of this interaction, please don't hesitate to leave comments and share your thoughts!
>
> More info on where Catra is and what she's doing coming up soon! Plus the truth of what went down between Catra and Glimmer after Micah's birth...

Chapter 22

Chapter Notes

> This is kind of a long one, with a few milestones to reveal... I hope you enjoy! I'd love to hear your thoughts, please leave kudos and comments (they really do bring joy to my day)!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

FIVE MONTHS PRIOR

Catra sucked her gut in, grunting in exasperation as she tried to do her trouser buttons up.

"I told you this would happen."

She stuck her tongue out at Adora in the mirror, who was still sprawled in bed with Melog amongst the entirety of Catra's work wardrobe, amusement clear on her face.

"I'm not even five months, this is ridiculous."

Adora snorted.

"You basically are, it's what? 19 weeks?"

"You know exactly how many weeks I am. Stop being so dense and help me over here!"

Catra huffed as Adora hauled herself out of bed, wrapping her arms around Catra's shoulders.

"What did you think would happen? You'd have a flat stomach for the whole thing?"

Adora chuckled softly as Catra's eyes rolled into the back of her head.

"*No*. I'm not an idiot." She scowled into the mirror as she pulled on the material around her waist.

"You should have let them buy you those maternity clothes."

"Ugh. It just feels so weird, having people buy me clothes like that."

"It's not people, it's Bow and Glimmer. And we agreed that it would be fair, for them to get the supplements and pay for this kind of stuff."

Catra deflated, finally giving up on her buttons. She slumped, her belly protruding further out of her suit trousers as they dropped to her hips. She raised a hand, resting it on the slope of her abdomen.

"It's going quicker than I thought…" Adora didn't miss how Catra's mood moved from pensive to panicked as she glanced at the pile of discarded clothes on their bed, "What the fuck am I going to wear now?"

Adora's arms shifted around her shoulders, tightening a little to calm her. "I can order you some stuff before I go in today, I'm not due into the clinic until eleven."

"Thanks," Catra leaned her head sideways to nuzzle Adora's bicep, "But that doesn't solve my problem now."

"It's warm out. One of my looser sundresses will probably fit you?"

"*Adora…*"

"You want to wear your pyjamas to the office?"

Catra practically winced as Adora sifted through the wardrobe and pulled out a pastel yellow linen dress.

"What? You love this one!"

“I love it on *you*. I don’t do dresses, Adora.”

“You got yourself into this mess, babe. This is what you have to work with.”

Catra moaned in frustration, letting the trousers pool around her ankles as she stepped towards Adora, snatching the dress from her and unfastening her bra.

“What are you taking that off for?”

“You don’t usually wear a bra with it.”

“Yes, but as you so frequently like to remind me, I’m white as rice. Your nipples, however, are much more…”

“You wanna finish that sentence?”

“Much more *gorgeous.* And they’re gonna show through.*”* Catra smacked Adora’s cheek lightly to wipe the beaming smile off her face, but she didn’t stop her from leaning in for a kiss. Catra sighed contentedly as Adora pressed against her, reaching behind to redo her bra clasp.

“You’re usually much more interested in getting that off than on, ‘Dor...”

Adora squeezed her ass, giving her a final kiss before turning to begin putting all of Catra’s clothes away.

“You’re late for work.”

Catra pulled the dress on over her head, smoothing the fabric where it stretched taut over her stomach. “I guess it’ll have to do. Can you pass my grey blazer?”

“It’s really hot outside, Cat.”

“Fine… you still got one of those oversized shirts?”

Adora nodded, helping Catra pull the light fabric over her shoulders and rolling the cuffs to her elbows. Catra turned round, seeing if her skin was still visible through the thin cotton.

"You can't see anything, don't worry."

Catra nodded, resting her hand on her lower back as she shoved her feet into slip-ons. She'd never seen herself look this soft before; even when she had worn the odd dress as a teenager, it was always hard and black, angular rather than flowing.

"You look beautiful. Now get to work."

Catra kissed Adora's cheek, her fingers lingering on the drawstring of her pyjama shorts for a few hesitant seconds before she turned to leave, scratching behind Melog's ears and swinging her bag over her shoulder. The summer breeze felt unexpectedly pleasant on her usually concealed decolletage, though she pretended not to notice the surprised looks she attracted from almost every single one of her coders when she reached the office. It didn't help that Entrapta observed in front of all their staff that it was impressive how much Catra's breasts and belly had suddenly grown over just a few weeks; she abruptly shut up when she saw the threat in Catra's pointed stare.

By the end of the day, Catra was thoroughly exhausted from projecting an even tougher façade than usual. She'd felt she had to compensate for the cottage-core vibes, the now visible baby bump and the reveal of her collarbone tattoo. She was convinced she'd not be taken seriously by anyone otherwise. Now they'd left the office en masse, Catra lamented how her favourite team-building activity of company drinks at a nearby pub had fast become the bane of her existence, frowning as the barman set a tall beer for Entrapta and a glass of lemonade in front of her. It really was shit when you were sober, and the smell of all the ales around her was tortuous.

"Should you really be drinking that, Smith?"

Catra turned in surprise towards the voice off to her side – she hadn't heard it in years.

"Lonnie! Shit, what are you doing here?"

Her old roommate grinned back at her, one arm resting on the bar. She was more built than Catra remembered, years of service having clearly honed her muscles.

"Shouldn't I be asking you that?"

"Ha, I'm only holding it for a friend." Catra slung the beer towards Lonnie, "You want this?"

"Sure."

They paused to look at each other for a minute, and Catra wasn't sure whether it was nostalgia or hormones or both, but she couldn't help but throw her arms around Lonnie, their bodies colliding.

"Man, you really have changed. Never thought I'd see you in a dress, let alone..." Lonnie gestured at Catra's burgeoning stomach; it made her kind of defensive.

"Hey, I told you I was holding it for a friend." She was unsurprised by Lonnie's confused expression as she ran her hand over her belly; she'd had to explain this to her team repeatedly, batting off their excitable wishes of congratulations all day. "I'm just a surrogate. For Adora's friends."

Lonnie whistled.

"Wow. That's… that's awesome, Cat."

"Eh, it's not a big deal. A lot of people do it."

She watched Lonnie raise a cynical eyebrow, the movement bringing back countless memories of the two of them teasing each other.

"Erm… I don't think they do, Catra." Lonnie scratched the back of her neck awkwardly, "You wanna sit?"

They found a table in the corner of the pub, as secluded as they could get given the Friday evening rush.

"So, this is for Adora's friends? You're gonna have to get me up to speed – she said you fell out years ago?"

"Oh. Yeah. We're kind of… together."

She steeled herself for Lonnie's reaction – true to form, she punched the air a little too triumphantly for Catra's taste.

"I fucking *knew* it! How long?"

Catra grimaced as she spoke, knowing she was in for another roasting.

"Like, around five years..."

"Oh, so it's *serious*! Ha! Took you long enough, the two of you were fucking disgusting back in the day-"

"Alright, calm the fuck down."

"Dude, you made me feel like a pretty major dick when you got with that older guy – let me milk this! What was his name again?" Catra shrugged dismissively, willing Lonnie to move on quickly, "But look how the tables have turned…"

"Yeah, you're shouting at a pissed off pregnant lady in a pub filled with shit she can't drink."

Lonnie barked in laughter, the sound so familiar to Catra, like they hadn't lost contact for all this time. They caught each other's eyes, chuckling softly with an intimacy they'd rarely allowed themselves growing up.

"For real, I'm glad you guys finally got your act together."

Catra offered Lonnie a small smile; but neither of them had ever been much good at honest emotion and the atmosphere around them tensed for a second before Lonnie cut through it.

"You know, I've been back from my tour for a good while, but I couldn't find you anywhere. I even reached out to Google HR when I first got home to see if they had your details – like maybe seven-ish years ago?"

"You left the Army that soon?"

"Stop deflecting, Smith." Lonnie listed her history off matter-of-fact, "Multiple gunshot wounds, PTSD, now training cadets. You gonna tell me where the hell you've been?"

"It's complicated. I was in a... a difficult situation. I wasn't around for a while."

Lonnie trained one eye on her as she took another long sip of her beer. Catra knew that for all her faults, Lonnie was tactful when it mattered; she'd back off when she realised Catra wasn't up for the discussion.

"You hear from the care home while you were gone?"

Catra narrowed her eyes in question, cocking her head.

"From the Fright Zone?"

"Yeah, they discovered a load of old records that got lost in one of the manager switchovers. Adora never mentioned it either?" Catra shook her head, "I got access to mine."

"You did?"

"Yeah, I… I actually found my birth mum. She died pretty recently, though. Cancer."

"I'm sorry."

“I got to know her for a few years. It was better than nothing.”

“I didn’t think this could even happen, that there might be more information about us.”

“It’s wild, isn’t it?” Lonnie watched Catra for a few seconds; she’d caught a distant look in her eyes as she trailed her fingertips across her rounded middle. “I can connect you with the right people, if you want. I’ve still got the email address somewhere.”

Catra snapped out of her thoughts, furrowing her brow as she thought through Lonnie’s offer.

“They probably don’t have anything on me. I don’t even have an original birth certificate.”

“You never know. Offer’s there if you want it.”

Catra nursed her lemonade, swilling its final dregs in her mouth. The rest of the evening fell into an easy rhythm; she introduced Lonnie to Entrapta and some of her employees, all of them finally loosened up enough to take the piss out of Catra’s outfit. Still, it felt even sweeter than she anticipated to wrench the shirt and dress off when she got home far later than originally expected, her back and shoulders gratefully embracing the air she’d kept them from all day. Adora was already reheating leftovers in the oven for her, glancing at Catra appreciatively as she fell onto the sofa topless, wearing only her underwear. She stretched out as Melog curled into her side, grunting as she flexed every toe and finger.

“You want me to open a window?”

“I’m so hot, ‘Dor.”

“Full of yourself today, aren’t you?” Adora giggled as she pushed open the window to expose the orange pinks of a late-night summer sunset. She crossed the room to sit in front of Catra on the floor, one arm resting on the sofa cushions to stroke the cat. “Dinner will be ready in ten.”

Catra blew air up to her forehead to cool herself down.

"You ever try to get your records, 'Dor?"

"Records? Like pre-adoption stuff?"

"Yeah. I randomly bumped into Lonnie at the team drinks, she was at our usual spot. She said she found her birth mum."

"Wow. It's been years since I heard from her! How is she?"

"Good. She's unbearably smug about us being a thing."

Adora sniggered.

"She did call it, to be fair. Like more than fifteen years ago."

They rested in silence briefly, the outdoor breeze easing Catra's body heat.

"You're not interested in looking into it, though?"

Adora tilted her head towards Catra, contemplating it.

"I have parents, Cat." She sighed heavily. "I don't really want to find out I have more in common with people who never wanted me. What are the chances they have anything useful for us, anyway?"

Catra took the ponytail out of Adora's hair, kneading her fingertips into her girlfriend's scalp.

"That makes sense. And you're probably right – I doubt there's any real info on either of us."

Adora turned round to take Catra's palm in hers, leaning over to kiss the back of her hand. Catra focused on their intertwined fingers as they rested on her bump.

"It's incredible, isn't it? How much Glimmer and Bow want this kid?" She paused, her expression sobering. "It's never going to

feel how we did."

Adora stared at her with curiosity, clearly at a loss of what to say. She hid the melancholy washing over her by bringing their hands to her lips, kissing Catra's knuckles. "Yeah. It's pretty amazing."

Catra watched as Adora stood to get her dinner from the oven, unable to ignore the fluttering in her stomach that had started to occur more frequently over the past few days. It definitely wasn't kicking – there's no way she'd keep that to herself – but it was *something*. A life within her, that she'd been entrusted to nurture and protect. She considered how it was such a departure from the way she'd experienced her first short-lived pregnancy, which had been so absent of any positive sensation.

The reminder that – despite the recently visible changes in her body – she was not at risk of taking on the responsibilities of motherhood calmed her. Her thoughts turned to the email address that she'd asked Lonnie to forward to her before they parted. She had no idea what she'd find, but it was worth it wasn't it? What was it Lonnie had said?

Better than nothing.

Catra didn't want to get her hopes up. But if she had even the tiniest shot at 'better than nothing', she knew for sure that she wanted to take it.

THREE MONTHS AFTER

Adora watched the front door close behind Catra, gazing a little too long at the space where she had been a few seconds prior. She cocked her head in thought, wishing she knew why her

fiancée was still being so ridiculously cagey. They'd gotten much better at communicating their feelings, especially in the immediate aftermath of Micah's birth. But something about this most recent fight with Glimmer had set Catra's progress back light years.

It was the absolute strangest thing – Catra behaved like nothing had happened at all, like there was nothing to tell. She was completely detached, minimising or dismissing Adora's concerns every time she tried to probe Catra's feelings, seemingly incapable of acknowledging the gravitas of the argument. It was in such contrast to her usual habits; Catra had always acted like the world was burning down when she'd fought with Glimmer in the past. Neither of them had ever held back when it came to explaining why the other had so thoroughly pissed them off, to the extent that Bow had joked several times to Adora that he thought the two of them actually quite enjoyed the drama. Their quarrels usually died down after a couple of days, giving way to an almost cheerful rhythm of light-hearted bickering – once Glimmer had finally accepted Catra wasn't going to skip out on Adora, it had become clear that there was never really any love lost beneath their performative enmity. But now, it seemed like Micah's arrival had changed everything. And after three months of radio silence, Adora was getting to the end of her tether.

It wasn't that she hadn't tried to find ways to fast-track a fix. She'd broached the topic with Glimmer, but she wouldn't open up to Adora any more than Catra had (though she was at least willing to admit how horrible the whole dynamic had become). Bow was in the dark as much as Adora – all he knew was that Glimmer had sent him out to buy new baby monitors the day after the fight and declared that Catra was not going to donate breast milk any longer.

It broke Adora's heart, how she always visited Bow and Glimmer alone now, and that Catra found a convenient reason to make herself scarce every time she organised for Bow to bring the baby over. She knew Catra had only spoken with Bow a few times since the birth; Adora could see that he was hurt, that part of him blamed his wife for the sudden decline of one of his closest

friendships. It was clear to Adora every time that he asked after Catra's wellbeing (which he did frequently) that he was desperate to reconnect with her. But Catra was off somewhere in her own world, and she wasn't willing to emerge to address the conflict at hand.

The doorbell ringing distracted Adora from her mental deep dive; she hurried to the door and pressed down on the intercom.

"I forgot my keys," Catra's voice echoed through the hallway, "Can you let me back in?"

Adora buzzed her in, putting their front door on latch ready for Catra's arrival and wandering towards the kitchen to fetch her set of keys from the dish they threw them in each night.

Catra came into the flat before Adora made it back to the hallway, her hair already tussled from the spring wind. Adora dropped the keys into Catra's outstretched palm, moving closer to pluck a fallen blossom from her curls.

"Thanks," Catra pecked her lips, "I seem to forget everything these days."

Catra made to leave again, but Adora caught her wrist just in time, pulling her back in for a second kiss. She knew she was buying time to build up the nerve to say what she really wanted; she'd kick herself if she didn't ask one more time.

"Are you sure you have to go into the office? I really wish you would come with me."

"Adora-"

"You've worked every Saturday for a month. Is Entrapta doing that?"

Catra crossed her arms, easing out of Adora's embrace.

"It doesn't matter what Entrapta's doing, 'Dor. I've got shit to get on with before this year's accounts close, okay?"

Adora huffed grumpily as Catra used the end of financial year excuse again – she was pretty sure the company had an accounts team to deal with the bulk of it, and she'd bet good money that Catra was taking on unnecessary work to avoid seeing their friends. Her belligerence didn't go unseen.

"For God's sake, Adora, is it really that big of deal?"

Adora thought back to the weeks of missed interactions with Micah that Catra had worked through, the disappointment in Bow's eyes when he saw that Catra was absent yet again, and the unspoken anxiety that she could see was brimming under the surface whenever Catra came up in conversation around Glimmer.

"Yes, Catra! It is a fucking big deal! You've refused every time to talk about it, but this fight between you and Glimmer is tearing us all apart! I hate it! Will you just come with me? *Just once*?"

Catra startled at Adora's outburst, shuddering a little in surprise. Adora braced herself for the backlash, for Catra to lose her temper – she had always been the more hot-blooded of the two of them – but it never came. Instead, Catra's shoulders fell, her frame shrinking a little as she stooped.

"I'm sorry, babe," she spoke sadly, the first hint Adora had seen that Catra had actually been affected by the fallout, "but I can't do it."

Adora grabbed Catra's wrists in her hands, forcing her to make eye contact.

"Why? I don't understand. It's been three months and they don't even know we're engaged!"

"So tell them. Or wear your ring. They'll figure it out."

“Catra,” Adora’s voice squeaked as she tried to hold back a sob, “I want us to do it together. It’s supposed to be *our* news, not mine.”

“I have to go.” Catra almost sounded like she was pleading, “I’m sorry.”

Adora wouldn’t let go of her; she tightened her grip with one hand, bringing the other to smooth her thumb across Catra’s cheek gently.

“How long is this going to go on for?” She spoke almost in a whisper, her despair suspended in the air between them, “Bow really misses you, and you’ve barely seen Micah since he was born. Don’t you want to see them?”

Something seemed to snap in Catra – her speech cracked a little – but it wasn’t enough.

“*Of course, I want to see them!*” Catra’s eyes flashed with outrage, her pain so obvious for just a split second before she tore away from Adora’s hold, “But it’s... it’s not a good idea, okay?”

Adora angered as Catra made to exit, and she pushed past her to close the front door before she could leave.

“No, Catra. It’s not okay. What’s going to happen here? We get married and they’re not allowed to be there? I’d wait for you guys to sort your shit out, but how long is that going to take? Another month? A year, two years?”

“I don’t know, Adora.”

Catra tried to reach for the latch, but Adora laid her weight against the door, driving it shut again.

“Adora!”

“Catra. You’re being a dick.”

"Yeah well, at least you and Glimmer agree on something. Why don't you fuck off to theirs like you normally do and give *her* a hard time instead?"

"Wha-?"

Catra took advantage of her fiancée's baffled state to yank the door open and slip out before Adora had the slightest chance to react, slamming it behind her angrily.

Shit!

Adora pinched the bridge of her nose. She should have known that wouldn't go well, but she didn't expect to be even more exasperated and confused than she had been prior. She caught sight of Catra's home office at the end of the hallway, the door slightly ajar, and before she knew it, she'd charged through the flat and rushed in, looking through all the crap that Catra had left out for the slightest sign of something to do with Glimmer. Adora knew she was highly unlikely to find anything, but the spat had gone on for long enough and she had to do something, *anything*, to feel like she was making some kind of headway into finding a solution for the mess they'd ended up in.

She opened drawer after drawer, fumbling through old, discarded smartphones and broken tablets, concertina folders full of business contracts (Adora was surprised Catra had printed any of them given her dislike of wasted paper), and empty pill bottles of prenatal supplements. The rubbish Catra hoarded made Adora groan with displeasure; if she wasn't completely out of order searching through Catra's office unannounced, she'd have recycled most of it then and there. She dropped into the swivel chair dejectedly, leaning forward to rest her elbows on the desk and sink into her misery.

Adora had only shifted part of her weight onto the wooden surface when she felt something bump into her stomach – she looked down to see that the keyboard tray under the desk had rolled out, a series of envelopes stacked on top of Catra's

trackpad. She stiffened, scared suddenly that she was actually crossing a serious line; it could be nothing, but Adora had a feeling that these envelopes were definitely *something*. Cautiously, Adora kicked out with her legs against the corner of the desk, leaning back to peek down the hallway to check Catra definitely hadn't come home to finish hashing things out. When she had fully assured herself that her fiancée was well and truly gone, she inhaled deeply, picking up the envelopes with trembling hands.

She opened the first, pulling out the documents inside. Adora's whole body drooped with relief; she recognised these. They were the records Catra had picked up nearly half a year ago, the existence of which had essentially caused her to disassociate and regress into her teenage self, shivering under a tree she hadn't visited for over a decade.

Adora scanned her eyes over the information, struggling to take it all in for a second time while her memories of how Catra had cried in her arms for hours took over. She swore as a teardrop fell from her face onto the paper. She scolded herself – it wouldn't do to leave water stains all over Catra's paperwork.

The whole thing had been so painful the first time; how many hours had Catra spent poring over this again, looking for subtext that didn't clearly exist? She remembered how cold the words had felt when they were new; they were practically unpalatable, exposing Catra's birth in a refugee camp to a young Syrian woman, revealing that her name wasn't what they'd thought it was at all.

"Cantara Shemaya..." She'd never forget how Catra had uttered the words, her breath shaky, "born to Lea Shemaya? Did they just call me..." her voice had faltered and skipped over the name she'd lived with her whole life, "...because they couldn't be bothered to pronounce it properly?"

Catra had dropped the papers then, and Adora had squeezed her quaking hand, wishing she knew how to react to the revelation, how to make Catra feel better. She'd kissed Catra's forehead,

laying a comforting palm on her swollen stomach as the baby kicked hard inside her, pulling Catra closer to her. Adora hadn't been able to stop a deeply painful thought from ripping through her head.

I thought we were Smith because they thought we were the same, that we were both abandoned. But what if that's just something I made up, and no-one ever thought we were the same at all?

Adora had worried for weeks that it all related to why Catra had never been adopted and she had – because all the staff could have known that Catra was *other*, and thought her lucky enough to have been born at the end of an arduous journey and not in her mother's home country; that she should have been grateful enough that her birth happened to grant her Bright Moon citizenship. It was hard to trust that the weary people who'd been paid to rear them could have risen above the societal biases that had landed most the kids in the care home there to begin with.

Adora eased the documents back into their wizened envelope gently, smoothing its creases. It had clearly been opened and closed a million times over, but it wouldn't hurt to give it a little bit of care. The envelopes she'd yet to open were not quite as wrinkled; she'd have to be more careful with those.

She picked her next victim at random, retrieving grainy printouts of documents written in what Adora assumed was Arabic and Hebrew, as well as translations that Catra had only recently commissioned, her own annotations spread across the English transcripts – circled locations, underlined dates, highlighted names. Catra seemed to be piecing something together: why her mother had needed to leave Syria and how she'd ended up in the camp without the rest of her family.

The following envelopes held different parts of the puzzle – Catra's mother had been part of a scheme to evacuate a group of single women seeking escape from violent local hate crime against ethno-religious minorities. It didn't look like Catra had found much

information on where most the women had ended up (it appeared that their months-long journey to Bright Moon had weathered several obstacles, taking far longer than planned and leaving many data gaps), but she had managed to obtain a death certificate for one Lea Shemaya that cited post-partum complications. Adora nearly started crying all over again when she found receipts for donations Catra had made to charities that supported increased access to emergency obstetric care in camps, hidden amongst research on her mother's faith community.

Adora was quickly connecting the dots: Catra's recent withdrawal had been about so much more than her clash with Glimmer; she was shouldering the strain of her recovery from pregnancy while learning that the circumstances of her own birth had led to the death of her mother at less than a week old.

There was little indication of where the rest of her family could be in Catra's documents; there was neither proof that they'd stayed in Syria, nor evidence that they had followed Lea to Bright Moon or gone elsewhere as part of other community escape attempts. It was even less clear if any of Catra's family members had known her unmarried mother was pregnant, that Catra existed at all. The question of who her father could be was beyond comprehension.

Adora reeled from all her discoveries.

Is this what she's been doing these past couple of months, claiming that she's always working?

Why is she doing this alone?

A heavy feeling of shame settled on Adora as she realised it: she had definitely gone too far. She'd been so desperate to get to the bottom of Catra's fight with Glimmer that she'd completely lost respect for any boundaries. Adora didn't understand why Catra hadn't brought her into it, but she knew that she'd have to fess up. There was no way she could secretly carry the knowledge of this around without driving a terrible wedge in their relationship.

She called Bow and cancelled her visit, busying herself with tidying the office up and getting ready to leave the flat. An hour and a half later, she was at Catra's office with a ridiculously over-priced sushi platter in hand, her feet itching nervously as the lift took her higher and higher through the building. Adora found Catra easily when she rang the company intercom, her fiancée being forced to come and let her in because all the reception staff were off for the weekend.

Catra watched Adora as she opened the security doors, warmth overtaking her defensive stance as she saw the lunch Adora had brought for them to share.

"I thought you were going to Bow and Glimmer's?"

"You're more important."

Catra took the sushi platter from Adora, leading her through the open-plan space to the desk she'd been working at, where multiple screens were filled with mind-boggling spreadsheets. She clasped Adora's hand as she pulled over a nearby chair for her to sit on, rolling them together to meet Adora's lips in the middle.

"Thanks for this. I didn't mean to blow up earlier."

"Me neither."

Catra exhaled heavily, turning to remove the clear plastic lid from the platter.

"I know it's hard on you at the minute, and I know it's shitty of me. But I'll talk to you about it soon. I'm just not ready, I need more time to think."

Adora bit her lip as shame reddened her cheeks, a warm flush rising up her chest and neck.

"I love you, Catra."

Catra peered at her curiously, reaching over momentarily to squeeze Adora's thigh gently.

“You know I do too, ‘Dor.”

Adora watched as she tucked into the sushi, shaking her head as Catra lifted a roll between her chopsticks, dipping it carefully in soy sauce and holding it out to her over a cupped palm.

“You don’t want any?” Catra’s eyes widened at the huge display of food in front of her, “I can’t eat this whole thing on my own!”

Adora blinked, screwing her face up.

“I’m not hungry anymore. I feel terrible.”

Catra dropped her chopsticks on her desk, moving to rest the back of her hand against Adora’s forehead.

“You feel sick? Should we get you a car home?”

“No, no. I... Oh, Catra. I’m really sorry, I did something bad-”

“I think the platter makes up for it, ‘Dor. Let’s just forget about this morning, honestly.”

“No, that’s not it... I searched your office. I had some stupid idea I’d find something out about this whole thing between you and Glimmer.”

“That *is* stupid, why would you find anything about that in my office?”

“I know. But I found all your papers,” she paused as realisation spread across Catra’s features, “the stuff about your mum.”

“Oh.”

Catra’s face fell a little, but for once, Adora didn’t have the faintest idea what could be running through her mind.

"I'm so sorry, Catra. I don't know why I did it."

"I've been cutting you out of things. It was bound to happen eventually," Catra's chest heaved as she sighed, "I should have told you what I was up to."

Adora couldn't bear the disappointment and self-reproach spreading across Catra's face. She reached out for her fiancée's hand.

"You don't have to tell me everything. But I really, *really* want to be the person you feel you can share anything with."

Catra looked up at Adora then, her eyes crinkling with an emotion Adora couldn't mistake for anything other than pure, unbridled love.

"You *are*. That's always been you."

Adora leaned in, capturing Catra's lips in hers.

"Let me help, then. You don't always have to deal with everything on your own."

Catra nodded, her fingers scratching the base of Adora's scalp through her ponytail as she leaned in to reciprocate her kiss.

"I'll try, I promise."

Adora knew it wouldn't be as simple as that – it would take a lot more than a simple promise for Catra to genuinely accept that a burden shared could be a burden halved. But she hoped that their conversation could be a path to some change. Adora knew that Catra would be so much happier if she learned to release the hurt that was constantly bottled up inside of her – all she could do now was wait for Catra to believe it.

SIX MONTHS AFTER

Glimmer dialled home, half hoping her call would divert to answerphone before Bow picked up.

"Hello?"

No such luck. She put on as bright a voice as she could muster.

"Hey, hon."

"Glim? Did you get what you needed in town?"

Glimmer pursed her lips together, swallowing the discomfort that came with lying to her husband about what she'd been up to that morning.

"No, I'm going to have to look another time. Just a quick question though - you don't happen to know if Catra's ever been, like, into religion before?"

"Religion? Are you guys talking again?"

"I'm just wondering… She never mentioned anything about it to you before?"

She heard Micah cry out in the background, seemingly in the early throes of a hissy fit.

"You know what? Adora just got here five minutes ago, why don't you ask her?"

"No, Bow-!"

Glimmer sighed as she heard Bow call out for Adora, tutting as she waited for her friend to take the phone. It was going to be hard work keeping everything under wraps now – unlike Bow,

Adora wouldn't stop until she got the full picture of what was going on; she'd continued to question her for months, long after Bow gave up asking what had gone down between them.

"Hey, Glim. Bow said you had a question about Catra?"

"It doesn't matter."

"Come on, what is it? She's not here with me, obviously." Glimmer didn't miss the veiled accusation in Adora's tone, "We can talk."

"I don't think I should-"

"Glimmer, please. The last few months have been really shitty between you guys. If there's something I can do to smooth it out…"

"Don't swear around my son."

She heard Adora suck in a sharp breath. "Sorry. But seriously, the pair of you are so stubborn. Will you just throw me a bone?"

Glimmer paused, her eyes lifting up to the temple again. She knew the security guard had been eyeing her suspiciously for a while as she paced up and down the street waiting for Catra to come out.

"It's just, she's been inside this temple for over an hour."

"Temple? She's at some meeting with some investor who said he's in town."

"She isn't, Adora. I've been with her all morning."

"Wait, you guys met up? Are you sorting things out?"

Glimmer cringed at Adora's excitement, knowing she was about to bring it all crashing down.

"I'm not supposed to tell you. But I'm worried about her."

“Worried?”

“Has she been to church, or to a temple before, Adora? Is this a thing she does?”

“What kind of temple is it?”

“I don’t know, like a Jewish thing?” She peered up at the unfamiliar alphabet emblazoned on the building in front of her, “A synagogue?”

Glimmer waited for a response from Adora, but the line had gone eerily silent.

“Adora?”

“Sorry. Yeah, um… I don’t think she’s been before. Did something happen between you guys today?”

Glimmer ran her hand through her hair. She wasn’t sure what Adora was holding back but given what she’d seen in the coffee shop and the blind determination in Catra’s body language when she’d approached the temple, there was definitely something happening that was significant in some way, that Catra should absolutely not be dealing with alone.

“Promise me you aren’t going to kick off.”

“What?”

“Promise me.”

Adora’s exasperation was clear as day, “Yeah okay, Glimmer, I promise,” her voice dropped to a whisper, “what the hell is going on?”

“She met with Prime. And I’m not sure-”

“She *what*? How could this even happen? I mean, we knew he’d been released, but-”

“Adora-”

Glimmer knew what was coming, and Adora’s voice was already rising, loud and shrill.

“You knew she was doing it, didn’t you? And you let her? What the fuck is wrong with you?”

“Adora! Not around Micah!”

“For God’s sake, he’s six months old! He’s not going to pick up a bloody thing.”

Glimmer collapsed onto the bench she’d been circling for ages, her energy well and truly sapped. This was exactly what she knew would happen when Catra swore her to secrecy. She’d never been much good at keeping quiet, especially not when she thought something bad was about to happen. And to make it worse, now she could hear Bow and Adora arguing on the other end of the line.

“Glimmer, what is going on?” Her pulse slowed a little as she heard Bow return to the phone, but it picked right up again when she saw Catra emerge from the building ahead of her.

“Bow, we’ll talk when I get home. Just tell Adora to stay with you, okay?”

She hung up before Bow could respond, raising her hand to catch Catra’s attention. The other woman seemed surprised, a little dazed even, but she wandered over, dropping onto the bench beside her.

“You waited?”

“Of course. You alright?”

Catra nodded slowly, staring up at the synagogue.

“I’ve never been to one before. It’s not how I imagined it.”

“No?”

“You ever been into the whole church thing? Adora said it was kind of a big deal for your parents.”

“It used to be, I guess. My mum stopped going after my dad died. He was Greek Orthodox, so I don’t think she felt like she belonged there much without him.”

Catra mused on the information, her eyes unmoving from the building ahead of them.

“I thought if I went, I’d feel some kind of belonging. But I was too scared that I wouldn’t. Seemed like that would be worse than not going at all.”

“Belonging?”

Catra sighed; Glimmer wondered if she’d spoken about whatever this was to anyone besides Adora.

“I got my birth records, that day I ended up in the park,” Catra spoke tentatively, “and it turns out…”, she shrugged, gesturing feebly in the direction of the building.

“You’re Jewish?”

“Apparently. It’s not all super clear, but the Jewish thing seems to be legit.”

Glimmer exhaled slowly.

“So? What was it like?”

Catra cocked her head to the side, deep in thought.

“I don’t know. I don’t understand anything they’re doing in there. But I feel kind of calm? And I really needed that, after…” Glimmer nodded, relieving Catra of finishing her sentence.

“You’re sure you’re okay, after seeing him?” She reached out tentatively, wrapping Catra’s hand in hers carefully; her whole body swelled with hope when Catra squeezed back.

“Yeah. I think… I think it might really be over.” Glimmer shivered as tears began to roll slowly down Catra’s face. She had only ever seen Catra cry when she was in the final stages of labour, and those were such starkly different circumstances, “I didn’t think it ever would.”

Glimmer inched closer to Catra cautiously, incrementally seeking more and more contact until she had enveloped her fully in her arms; Catra brought her arms up around Glimmer in response, grasping her tightly – more firmly than she’d ever done so before – her cries of relief pouring into Glimmer’s embrace.

The two women held each other for what felt like an eternity, the rollercoaster of their volatile friendship speeding past them. For years, it had felt like the inevitability of a sharp drop overshadowed every slow climb to optimistic heights; now, neither of them felt the same twist of nervous anticipation in their gut. All they’d battled through had brought them to an unprecedented plateau. They both had to accept the ground under them might not always be completely level, but it was finally steady enough for the scaffolding of mistrust they’d been building around themselves to fall – this time for good.

Chapter End Notes

> Okay, the Glimmer/Catra fight reveal will come soon, I promise... But there's some foreshadowing here that sets the path to where we go next! :)

Chapter 23

Chapter Notes

> Okay, it's actually here now - the big fight, and how we got there. I hope it measures up to your expectations!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

FOUR DAYS AFTER

"I'm fine, 'Dor, stop fussing."

Catra glared at Adora as she retrieved the cool bag from the back seat of the car, suppressing the grunt of exertion that would have otherwise escaped her. She sighed as Adora insisted on taking the bag from her, ignoring the cramping in her stomach. She'd been bleeding ever since the birth, all perfectly normal, though she didn't like Adora knowing it freaked her out a little. Catra shook off the embers of anxiety disfiguring her mind as best she could, objecting to Adora's actions for her own mental benefit as much as her girlfriend's.

"Come on, it's been nearly a week."

"It's been *four days*, Cat. This is the first time you've left the flat-"

Adora jumped a little as Catra slammed the car door shut with unexpected force – admittedly a bit too much force; her muscles shrieked from the swift movement – and braced one hand on the car roof.

"Women have literally been giving birth since the start of time, Adora. Aren't you of all people meant to know that?"

"Catra, we've been through this before. We've no idea what the chances of complications are-"

"Because I've no family medical history, I know." Adora winced at the emotion in Catra's voice, a strange blur of vulnerability and irritation, "But I'm fine. Okay?"

Adora opened her mouth to respond but Catra got there first. "*And* I'll tell you if I feel even the slightest bit off." She reached out for Adora, squeezing her forearm with a gloved hand, "I promise."

Adora dipped her head, her exhale visibly white in the air against the frosty blue sky.

"Okay. But no heavy lifting! I'd say that to any of my patients."

"Fine. Though I'm not sure a cool bag is much of a workout."

"Shhh." Adora shut her up with a quick peck, "Humour me, okay?"

They made their way up the road, careful not to slip on the icy pavement, their cheeks reddening from the cold as they waited on Glimmer and Bow's doorstep to be let in.

Catra's heart rate picked up a little as the door opened, her stomach falling in disappointment as Bow whispered that Micah was sleeping; they hadn't expected him to stay asleep for so long and were determined to milk every last minute.

"Well, on the subject of milk..." Catra tipped her head towards the cool bag in Adora's hand. "Are you gonna let us in to put this away or will we be freezing to death on your porch?"

Bow jumped back to let Adora and Catra in, shutting the front door as softly as he could behind them.

"Sorry, I'm practically asleep myself." He wrapped his arms around Catra, "How are you doing, you feeling okay? Come and sit down – there's some stuff in the fridge we can warm up if you're hungry?"

Catra rolled her eyes as she tugged off her coat and gloves, matching Bow's hushed speech.

"Not you as well. I get enough of that from this one!" She jerked her thumb towards Adora, who had already rested a supportive hand on her hip while she bent over to take her boots off.

"Yes," Adora teased, "But it *is* your first time on your feet for more than two minutes, so you really should be giving me a break for being a little cautious!"

Catra scoffed and tilted her head back in frustration, leading them all into the kitchen and lowering herself – a little gingerly, Adora noticed – into a chair at the table. Bow moved out to take the cool bag from Adora, but she held it out of his reach.

"Sit, I can tell you're knackered."

Catra snorted as Bow sank with a thump into the chair opposite her, the bags under his eyes even more obvious under the bright kitchen lights.

"You look fucking awful, Arrow Boy."

Bow glanced up at her, the side of his mouth curving into a bemused smile.

"I've always appreciated your gift for kindness, Cat." Bow's words dripped with well-worn sarcasm, "You express it with such grace."

"Ha! You try squeezing an eight-pound baby out gracefully!"

A tender silence fell between them as Catra's joke failed to evoke the light-heartedness she'd wanted from it, the noise of Adora shoving zip-lock bags of breast milk into the freezer suddenly thunderous. Bow rested his hand over Catra's knuckles, holding her eye contact. She saw something new in the black of his pupils – gratitude, love, admiration, maybe a mix of the three. It wasn't the kind of gaze that Catra was used to feeling on her from anyone apart from Adora.

"I don't even have the words, Catra. To thank you for what you've done for us."

Discomfort prickled at the base of her neck, adding to the slow ache of her cramps.

Is this where our conversations are always going to end up now? How am I supposed to respond when he says shit like this, when I don't know how to draw a line under it?

In her heart of hearts, Catra knew the significance of her surrogacy, but she didn't want to spend the rest of her life on a pedestal like she was some kind of Mother Teresa. She'd had her reasons for carrying Bow and Glimmer's child, and that was that. It wasn't meant to be some kind of heroic act. Just something she'd wanted to do – that she had the means to do – and so she'd done it. Catra cleared her throat awkwardly, pulling her hand away from Bow's into her lap.

"You don't have to make such a big deal out of it."

She broke Bow's eye contact, widening her eyes at Adora as she turned towards them; she'd be able to tell how uncomfortable she felt, she'd intervene. But Adora's eyes narrowed quizzically in response, not fully understanding where Catra's aversion came from. So Catra had to steer the conversation all on her own, wishing she could go back to the way it used to be between her and Bow when they'd goaded each other over craft IPAs and bowls of hot, salty pub chips.

"Where's Glimmer, anyway?"

"I'm right here," Catra twisted around to see Glimmer enter the kitchen, a full basket of laundry in her arms. Glimmer squatted in front of the washing machine, shoving blankets, cloths, t-shirts and countless babygrows into it, "though I'm already going stir crazy keeping on top of all this bloody washing." She slumped against the counter next to Adora, her dishevelled t-shirt and tracksuit bottoms looking even more askew next to the blonde's

cream knitwear and tight jeans. "*Four days*. He's been in this world for four days and we've amassed more housework than I think I've ever done in my entire life!"

"Don't tell me you're leaving it all to your wife, Bow," the tease slipped out of Catra's mouth, "in this day and age?"

She laughed at the flabbergasted look on Bow's face, blush spreading up his neck to his cheeks. Adora admonished Catra as she came over to the table and drew up a chair beside her, though she took her hand affectionately under the table.

"He's pulled his weight plenty, don't worry." Glimmer winked at Bow as she filled up the kettle, "You know I'd be bitching about it if he wasn't. Tea?"

Bow jumped up to help, insisting that Glimmer sit with Catra and Adora in his place. The rising hum of boiling water seeped into Catra's skin, intensifying with the growing ache in her stomach. It wasn't nearly as bad it had been the previous couple of days, but she was starting to think that her demands to join Adora when she dropped off this second batch of milk might have been a little premature.

"Hey," she squirmed in advance, knowing her request would probably set everyone off, "You don't happen to have a hot water bottle, do you?"

Glimmer and Bow looked at her in alarm as she attempted to massage her abdomen subtly under her jumper with one hand, though Catra was grateful that at least Adora's reaction was more measured; their fingers tightened around each other.

"Don't worry, it's only cramps." Adora explained with an oddly tempered tone Catra assumed was usually reserved for patients, "Totally expected, we're just keeping an eye on them."

Catra closed her eyes, not trusting herself to abstain from retorting with some flippant quip about how they were much stronger than your average monthly cramps, thank you very

much. She stood to find her way to the bathroom, still holding onto Adora. The air became even more tense.

"What?" Catra's heart sunk as she noticed a bright smear of blood staining her seat. "Shit. Sorry, I forgot to change my thing before we left. Just give me a couple of minutes to sort myself out and I'll clean it up."

"Don't be silly," Glimmer forced a smile, pasting over her concern unconvincingly, "We'll wipe it down."

"Come on, love," Adora rose too, a reassuring hand placed on Catra's arm, "I packed you a few things in case."

Catra nodded, barely able to look any of them in the eye. She slipped into the bathroom, leaving the door unlocked, and sat on the toilet, groaning as she saw the blood clots in her soaked pad. Adora crept in, sanitary towels and clean leggings in hand. They stayed silent as Adora checked the size of the clots and disposed of the used pad, affirming nothing was wrong with a small smile and a grasp of Catra's hand.

"This is like the worst period ever."

"It's all going in the right direction, the bleeding's already much lighter than yesterday, isn't it? Just need to watch the colour. This is still kind of red..." Catra gulped, her apprehension obvious for a split second. Adora kissed her on the forehead, untucking the new pad and Catra's clean leggings from under her arm to hand them to her, "Don't sweat it. We'll see where we get tomorrow – should be much easier on you by then."

"I bloody well hope so." Catra shot daggers at Adora as soon as she said it, interjecting before any pun-based jokes could be made, "Do *not* rise to that, Adora."

"I would never!"

Adora chuckled as she finished washing her hands and left the bathroom with Catra's stained bottoms, allowing her to finish

getting dressed without an audience. By the time she made it back to the kitchen to take her seat beside Adora, it seemed like the three of them had come to a consensus without her.

"Why don't you lie down for a bit, Cat?" Bow spoke too gently, cautious to avoid causing offence. "The sofa's a bit of a mess but we just changed our sheets."

Catra raised her eyebrow.

"It's a good idea, babe." Adora was ganging up on her now too, "You'll feel better after a couple of paracetamols and a rest."

"What about Micah? Isn't he sleeping in your bedroom?"

"Oh, he'll probably wake up any minute. I can't believe he's been down for so long, to be honest."

Catra was kind of surprised Glimmer was so assured. For a first-time mother, it seemed like she was taking everything in her stride. It wasn't what she'd expected, but she supposed Glimmer had always been nothing if not hardy and determined.

The muscles in her stomach contracted again, and all of a sudden, the idea of curling up in a warm bed sounded like the best thing she'd ever heard. Not that Catra would admit to that.

"Fine," she drew out the word as if she was doing them all a huge favour, "But when I say I'm done, I'm done, okay?"

Adora nodded in agreement and turned back to her tea, knowing Catra would hate it if she fretted over her any further; Glimmer grabbed the freshly filled hot water bottle from the counter and fished through the first aid kit above the fridge for paracetamol, nudging Catra down the hallway with a glass of water as soon as she found the pills.

Catra took the pills as they got closer to Bow and Glimmer's bedroom, trying to hide the hope building in her chest that she'd finally get to see Micah, if only for a minute. But Glimmer went

straight over to the cot and mouthed in surprise across the dim light of the bedroom that he was still sleeping and ushered Catra onto the mattress before she had a chance to look at him herself, tucking her into bed with the hot water bottle.

Catra couldn't deny how heavy her eyelids felt as Glimmer left the darkened room, the soothing warmth of the furry bottle spreading across her stomach as the soft whistling of Micah's breathing lulled her into slumber.

It couldn't have been more than twenty minutes before her body stirred, instinct pulling her out of bed over to the cot. Micah was wide-eyed and fussing, and before Catra even thought about it, she'd lifted him up, curling around him awkwardly as his tiny hands grappled at her chest. She lowered them back into the bed carefully, laying the baby on the bedding for a quick minute as she pulled her jumper and top off hurriedly, undoing the front clasp of her bra on autopilot. Her breasts felt so unbearably full, and as she picked Micah up again, she contemplated how it felt so bizarrely normal to be doing this, guiding his lips to her left nipple until he finally latched, the strange sensation of gently flowing milk so different to forced pumping. Even her cramps started to ease, and she could have sobbed with relief as the aches and tension in her body began to dissipate.

Who'd have thought something so simple could make everything feel so much better?

It was hard not to fixate on the intimacy of the moment between them, to deny her incredulity at the fact that this living being had been inside her for so long – his fluttering eyelashes all the way to his scratchy fingernails – and that he could reunite with her body so smoothly, his short difficulty latching the only barrier between them. She wondered if this same calmness would have settled over her if she'd ever entertained the thought of motherhood, if she'd been able to shine light through the shadows that Prime had permanently cast over her.

Catra sat with Micah for just over twenty minutes, switching him to her right side halfway through, only stopping when she could hear noise approaching from outside. She fixed her bra hastily, throwing her t-shirt back on and scooping Micah up again right as the door creaked open, light from the hallway landing on them as she shielded Micah's eyes to ward off a cry.

"Hey," Bow cooed as he came into the bedroom, "Looks like someone is up."

"Sorry, he started to fuss and I was right here so I just-"

"It's okay. Can you hold him a little longer while I get a bottle? He's probably hungry."

She agreed tight-lipped, barely speaking as Micah refused the bottle over and over again, nodding as Bow explained Micah only really fed properly when Glimmer was doing it; she had some kind of magic touch already and he'd been so relieved that his wife had bonded so quickly with the baby – they'd both been so worried about it, that Micah might only be comfortable with Catra.

The lie came out too quickly, that she'd not bonded with him much at all, that she'd done everything she could to avoid it. She was just so happy that they were finally a family, that Micah couldn't have two better parents.

At least that part is true.

It didn't take long for the pride she felt for having made Bow and Glimmer into a mother and father to fade out in favour of guilt and shame. She knew she'd crossed a boundary by breastfeeding Micah and had broken the most important of the post-birth agreements they'd made. But now it had happened once, Catra couldn't bear to tell herself she'd never do it again. There was too much at stake – she'd justified pumping to Adora for so many of the same reasons, citing article after article even though her girlfriend knew it all inside out anyway – and she couldn't foresee a better alternative.

It's only because you want the best for him – and that's all anyone wants right? There's nothing wrong with that.

The desperate need to nourish Micah, to make sure he got everything he needed to thrive, was all-consuming. There was no way around it; it was like nothing Catra had ever felt before.

FOUR WEEKS AFTER

Glimmer marvelled at the feel of cool air brushing across her cheeks, her hair blowing slightly in the wind. It felt undeniably good to get out the house, walking at her own pace instead of scanning every path ahead for a loose pavement slab or thick twig that threated to wake her newborn if caught under the pram wheels.

She almost couldn't believe she was doing it, especially given Bow had returned to work after his two weeks' paternity leave. But since Micah had been born four weeks ago, Catra had moaned that she was dying of boredom while recovering from the birth and pumping, and she'd suggested – Glimmer and Bow would have perceived it as begging if they didn't know Catra would kill them for even thinking it – that she could come over to keep them company while she waited to return to work. They'd been hesitant at first, unsure if they really had the energy for it, but they couldn't deny how helpful it had been to have a third pair of hands around the house when Catra did visit. She'd ended up coming over several times a week to keep an eye on Micah as Glimmer showered or slept and Bow ran errands, or vice versa. Today marked a first, the closest they'd gotten so far to having a babysitter: Glimmer had tentatively popped to the shops to top up

the fridge while Catra stayed home with Micah. Glimmer repeated her mantra to herself under her breath:

It's only for half an hour, and I'm only round the corner. It's completely fine.

She was barely a few minutes away from home by now, and given that she'd not received a single message from Catra while she'd been out, she was sure that everything was okay. But as Glimmer waited at the traffic lights to cross the road, all manner of terrible scenarios marred her thoughts.

Maybe something's gone horribly wrong and Catra's hurt herself, or Micah's sick, or he needs changing and she doesn't realise, and I get home and he's miserable and it'll be proof that I'm a terrible mother, that I should never have left him alone without me, and then we'll all realise that I was never good enough to do this in the first place!

She rocked on the balls of her feet anxiously, willing – *needing* – the lights to turn red, but they hadn't even gone amber yet, and mounting worry was tearing through her entire body. Glimmer pulled up the app Catra had installed for her on her phone, still synced to both the satellite cams that she and Entrapta had made, and whimpered impatiently while the video loaded up.

As soon as it did, Glimmer didn't quite believe what she saw. Was that really what she thought it looked like?

Is she breastfeeding my son?

Cars waiting at the newly red lights beeped at her to cross the road, and she dashed across it in a daze, a thick wave of sadness crashing into her.

The one thing... the one thing I didn't want her to do. That we'd agreed she wouldn't, not after all the things she could do for him that I couldn't.

She stormed down her street, her heavy grocery bags swinging violently as her dismay mutated into blind outrage.

What the fuck does she think she's doing? He's my son! I'm meant to decide how he feeds, who does it, when, where! It's supposed to be my choice, not hers!

It was all the more painful given that Catra knew Glimmer had researched whether she could induce milk herself, like some other women who'd had babies via surrogacy had. But despite Adora's and her trusted consultant's assurances, Glimmer didn't feel confident that with all the post-hysterectomy medications and anti-depressants she already took, it was really the best option for their family. The risks were low, but Glimmer had long ceased to be one to take chances after everything she'd been through to get to this point. Hadn't Catra remembered how tortuous a decision it had been? Didn't she realise how difficult it was, to accept there was yet another thing to come that Glimmer couldn't do for her own child as she watched the swell of Catra's belly grow?

Glimmer's hands shook as she jammed her key into her front door, shutting the door behind her and barging into the living room before Catra could possibly hide what she was doing.

Seeing her nursing Micah was even worse in the flesh. Glimmer drank in every detail of how her child melded to Catra in a way that he never had to her. She'd never felt more inadequate in her entire life.

"Glim!"

Catra looked up, jolting in surprise. Her nipple slipped out of Micah's mouth and he began to cry immediately, his hands grasping at her breast. Glimmer didn't know what the next best step was – for Catra to finish his feed, or to rip him out of her arms and prove she could soothe him herself, just like she had been doing perfectly well since he was born.

They stared at each other, frozen in time, until Micah latched onto Catra again and the small, intuitive movement of her hand ghosting over his scalp with reverential care – just as she and Bow had done a million times – slammed Glimmer back into herself. Fury bled out of her every word.

"What on earth do you think you're doing, breastfeeding my son?"

Catra seemed to shrink into herself, a war of shame and defensiveness battling behind her gaze.

"It's just, he's always so much more settled after I feed him-"

"*Always*?"

Glimmer's mind reeled, realisation dawning on her as she recalled how their frozen stock of breast milk seemed to be depleting slower since Catra started coming over, even though she still brought the same amount of pumped milk each time.

Has she been feeding Micah in secret every time she's here?

She dropped her shopping on the floor, ignoring the dull crack of eggs spilling their contents on the floorboards, and approached Catra, easing Micah away from her. Glimmer grimaced as her son began to wail in her arms, squirming as if all he wanted was to leave her and go back to the comfort of Catra's breast.

"He doesn't seem that settled now, does he?" She practically hissed at Catra, contempt flowing freely out of her. "How would you know what he's normally like, anyway? It's not like you've been here watching him all the time!"

Catra adjusted her clothes meekly, pulling her legs to her. But Glimmer didn't miss the momentary jerk of her eyeline towards the satellite cam. She turned towards it and spotted Catra's phone, throwing it at her on the sofa when she realised that she couldn't unlock it.

“Oh my God - you have been, haven’t you? It’s on your phone too!”

Catra’s eyes widened in fear, and Glimmer knew she’d hit the nail on the head. She felt like she could be sick. She couldn’t even look at her, Catra’s frenzied explanation wobbling around her head like jelly.

“I only wanted to make sure he was okay! And I noticed that he got to sleep so much faster after I fed him, and his breathing would be steadier, and he’d wake less. I didn’t mean it to become so frequent, I just thought we all wanted him to have the best, and maybe-”

She stopped listening to the desperate ramble. There was a level of detail Glimmer never imagined anyone other than she and Bow would know about their son.

“You think you’re what’s best for my child.”

Catra stammered, clearly unsure of what to say to avoid digging herself into an even deeper hole.

Glimmer held Micah closer to her and breathed in his scent, her hand rubbing soft, easy circles on his back that defied the territorial rage that had overtaken her, that had grabbed the steering wheel of her mind and her mouth.

“Do you really think with your track record that you could *ever* be what’s best for a baby? Tell me. What do you think you could give Micah that would benefit him? Lessons in running away, so he can leave everyone in the lurch no matter how much it hurts them? How to steal? How to get himself into ridiculous situations that bring the police to our door?” Glimmer could feel the spite blazing out her mouth as it targeted Catra’s ears, “I mean, would you ever have got your shit together if it wasn’t for Adora? What if she hadn’t had been enough for you? Would you have sucked the life out of some other poor soul until you took everything they had to give as well?”

It felt so good in the moment to throw all of the things she'd ever hated about Catra in her face, liberating the pain and jealousy she'd felt when her old flatmate suddenly had a new favourite person, and that person had robbed her of her job and her most important possession, and how terrible it was to watch Adora crumble when she'd run away, and how Glimmer had been left alone to pick up the pieces, one jagged shard at a time until Catra came crashing into their lives again. For that one moment, it was like the surrogacy – and the friendship that had grown between them during the long journey to her son's birth – had never happened.

Glimmer waited for victory to strike her, for the self-assuredness of a speech well-spoken to sink in. But the feeling never came.

Catra's expression had hardened, and Glimmer knew right then that any bridges built between them had burned to the ground. The other woman spoke coldly, gathering her things as she prepared to leave, the soft afternoon sunlight that streamed through the window catching the glint of a jewel on her finger and splitting out into rainbow dots on the ceiling above her. Glimmer was distracted for just a second. It wasn't Catra's style to wear rings, *is that*-?

"I'll get Adora to bring you the milk from now on, then."

Glimmer didn't want anything to do with her coming into their home.

"We'll get formula."

She caught the sting in Catra's eyes as she passed them, the pit of her stomach sinking in nauseating horror. The cruelty of her words hung in the air around the three of them; the baby cried as Catra left the room, his shrieks surging as the front door slammed shut in the distance, shaking the entire floor of the house a little. Glimmer cringed in fear that the neighbours living in the flat above them might kick off – they'd made their displeasure at living above a newborn clear before.

A part of her wanted to run after Catra, to beg her forgiveness and take it all back, but Glimmer was so shaken by the whole excruciating thing: leaving her son for the first time without his parents; watching Catra look like she was Micah's real mother, the honeyed shade of her skin so similar to the baby's even though they weren't biologically related; the feeling of her tiny son's rage pelting into her shoulder with no way to soothe him the way he really wanted.

The conflict of anger, jealousy, agony and regret paralysed her.

Glimmer rocked her son around the room, his cries finally trailing off as he calmed and settled in her arms. She stared at him for what felt like decades, studying every inch of his face for proof of her likeness, proof that she was definitely his mother.

The insanity of her insecurity was maddening, and it triggered her memory that Catra had never even apologised for what she'd done.

Enough is enough.

She'd spent enough time nursing remorse for the way she'd treated Catra in the past, but threatening the primacy of Glimmer's relationship with her own child? It was beyond the pale. It couldn't stand.

She said nothing to Bow when he returned from work to a sullen atmosphere, not bothering to explain why there was sticky, dried egg yolk on the wooden floor that she hadn't had the energy to properly scrub, or why she sent him out to get formula and new baby monitors, the gifted black orbs now buried under junk cables and discarded tech at the bottom of a rarely opened drawer.

She and Catra had drawn a deep line in the sand between them, and now they both had to wait for the tide to come in and wash it away.

Chapter End Notes

We're drawing closer to the end now, and I have a pretty firm idea of where we will end (I may have to add a couple of extra chapters to get it all on paper)!

I'd love to know your predictions for the conclusion... ♡

Chapter 24

Chapter Notes

> Warning: Things get worse before they get better. But genuinely, I promise you, there is an end to this story that *will* warm your heart. We just gotta get there first...

SIX MONTHS AFTER

Bow tightened his hold on Micah as Adora's voice rose even higher, shielding his son's small head with his hands as he turned into his father's chest. Even though he was only six months old, the boy was ridiculously sensitive to tension – more so than the other tots in their parent and baby group – and he could tell that Micah was getting distressed just being around the commotion.

"You did *what*?"

Adora was on her feet and practically shouting now, her eyes burning into Catra, who had shrunk further into the couch than Bow even thought was possible. His own head was swimming; he could barely make any sense of what was going on. First, they'd been talking about Glimmer connecting Catra with Prime – *enabling*, Adora had accused her of being – and then all of a sudden, Catra had leapt to Glimmer's defence in the strangest of U-turns, and it all came tumbling out. The hostile dynamic between his wife and Catra had been mind-boggling for months. But Catra *breastfeeding Micah* behind their backs and the pair of them covering the whole thing up for absolutely no good reason, then risking both their safety by secretly meeting with Prime that very morning? Bow didn't know what he thought had been going on, but this *really* took the biscuit.

It had set something feral off in Adora, that was for sure.

Bow could feel the vibrations of his son's whimpers humming through his shirt; Glimmer's entire body flinched as she saw Micah teetering on the edge of tears, silently beseeching Bow to get him the hell away. He took the exit she'd given him keenly.

Adora's yelling and Catra's sobs – such a strange combination of sounds that he was so unaccustomed to hearing – bled down the hallway, and even before it happened, Bow knew he'd acted too late. Micah wrenched a full-bodied scream from his lungs, tears streaming down his reddening face, his sole two teeth visible at the front of his bottom gums.

"Oh, Micah." Bow rocked the baby in his arms, shutting the bedroom door behind them, "I know. It's not nice, is it?"

He pressed a kiss to Micah's forehead and stroked his scalp in tiny soothing circles, burrowing his fingers into his son's coarse curls – so uncannily similar to the texture of his own – and sung under his breath. It was an old tune that usually settled Micah, that Bow's Zulu grandmother had crooned to him and his brothers when she visited.

Thula thul, thula baba, thula sana

But the baby was not settling, his little fists thrashing against Bow's body, pushing away from his father, away from all the noise around him. Bow quietened and rubbed Micah's back, yet the tantrum continued. It was one of the worst Micah had had in a long time; Bow wasn't sure he'd seen him get so angry since he was a tiny infant, only four or five weeks old, and he'd raged for days on end, seemingly dissatisfied with the bottle, his cot, even with Glimmer and Bow themselves. He froze in realisation, dots connecting before him.

Was that when Catra stopped coming over, when she stopped nursing him?

Bow groaned. How many twists and turns in Micah's psyche had he missed, not knowing the presence and sudden withdrawal of

Catra's breast could be having any impact at all? He and Glimmer had read so many blogs about the importance of consistent feeding and gradual weaning – it can't have been psychologically or physically easy on either the baby or Catra.

Maybe this is why Glim never told me – she thought I'd take Catra's side, that I'd push for whatever I thought was best for Micah, even if that wasn't what she wanted.

Bow balked at the notion that his wife could possibly think he wouldn't have had her back, that he'd ever think she wouldn't know what was best for their child. The whole thing was just so fucked up, and the echoes of Micah's screaming, Adora's uncharacteristic anger and Catra's pleading bouncing off the walls of the flat was driving Bow mad. It was impossible to think clearly. He made the decision quickly, jamming his feet into Birkenstocks and grabbing Micah's sunhat, making a beeline to the kitchen with the inconsolable infant on his hip to find the baby bag and fill up a sip cup with cool water.

"Is he okay?"

He spun round to see Catra behind him, an empty glass of water in her hand, her eyes raw red. Bow ignored her question.

"We can't stay around this – I'm taking him for a walk round the block. You guys need to sort this out before we're back."

"Okay." Catra stepped forward tentatively, her pupils flitting nervously between Bow and Micah, "I'm so sorry, Bow. I know I was completely out of order. I just... I lost control..."

He didn't miss the way her fingers twitched as if she wanted so badly to reach out to them, but she'd imposed an invisible straitjacket on herself and her arms stayed clamped close to her sides. For all these months, he'd craved his old closeness with Catra but in this moment, he wanted nothing less. He needed space. Micah needed space. Even if it was just for a few minutes.

"We'll talk later."

She nodded glumly, giving way so he could move away from the sink, taking his place to fill up her glass.

"I'll tell them you're going out."

He sniffed as he turned into the hallway, the sound cutting through silence now Micah had finally begun to calm a little. He was smart enough to know what the sunhat meant and was already stretching his small hands out towards the buggy as they approached it. Bow strapped him in and rubbed sun cream into Micah's skin, mirroring the sound of his soft babbles as he smacked his hands down on the plastic handle in front of him.

"You ready for a walk, Micah? Yeah!"

Bow pushed himself to shove it all to the back of his mind, and to make his voice sound as cheerful as possible. Micah would feed off his energy, and a happy baby was much easier to deal with than a miserable one. The sun shined on them as they walked round the perimeter of a nearby park, and Micah miraculously took a few sips of water from his cup without dropping it in the dirt, even managing not to warble in fear at the sight of every dog that came near. By the time they were walking home, both father and son were feeling much better.

Glimmer was there the minute the door closed behind them, her smile too bright and warm to be genuine. She forced a chuckle as Micah wriggled in his seat, impatient to get into his mother's arms, giving him a smattering of kisses as she scooped him up. But her hand gripped Bow's forearm with a sombre urgency that belied her enthusiastic demeanour.

"I know we haven't talked yet and I don't know how you feel, but take it easy on her. Okay?"

Bow nodded cautiously, observing that Adora's coat and shoes were no longer in the hallway. How many times had he said those words to Glimmer over the years, cajoling her into accepting Catra, into making space for her? And now, after arguably her

worst transgression – the one with no obvious excuse, no sacrifice for someone else's benefit – Glimmer was the one protecting Catra from him? The world really had turned upside down.

He rounded the corner into the lounge, his breath catching in his throat a little as he saw Catra hunched in a painfully tight huddle. Bow slowly sunk to the floor next to her, his back pressed against the front of the sofa. Catra sniffled, her arms wrapping around her knees even snugger.

"I don't know what I can say, Bow. To make it right."

"So don't try." Given everything, Bow wasn't sure what 'right' even meant. "Just tell me what happened."

She inhaled sharply, pressing her thumb and forefinger into her brow like she was tortured by insufferable tension right behind her eyeballs.

"It was an accident the first time. I was barely awake, and it was so soon after the birth. I think I was more out of it than I realised."

"That first time you came over?"

"Yeah. I was on some kind of autopilot – he was already latched before I even realised what I was doing... We just... It seemed right in the moment, and I..."

Catra paused, clearly unsure whether she should carry on. Bow stayed silent, waiting for her to continue.

"I kind of missed him. I was used to feeling him with me all the time, and then he was just *gone*." Catra shook her head, "I don't know if I'm explaining this right. It's weird."

"Go on."

"I started producing more whenever I was around him, and it was so painful if I didn't feed him." Catra hugged her breasts to

herself, as if she could feel it all over again then and there. "They'd get blocked, and I'd have to hand express, and Adora didn't know, so I couldn't ask her for help. I kept telling myself I would stop but after the second or third time, he already expected it. And I couldn't withhold it from him. I... I didn't know how."

"You should have talked to us. All this secrecy, Catra, you've got to stop with it, and learn to trust people. It's not good for anyone. For you."

"I didn't want to disappoint you, not after you thought I'd done this huge thing for you. I was scared that I'd lose you." She hung her head, like a scolded schoolgirl, "But I get it, you know. If you never want to see me again."

Bow mulled her words over, a still silence bleeding between them. He could see Glimmer coming into view ahead, stopping to watch from the hallway with concern. Micah clutched at the collar of her dress as he laid his weary head on her chest, tired out from the day's escapades.

"Catra, you *did* do this huge thing for us. There's no way of undoing that."

"I can't undo this either, though."

"I guess not." Bow sighed heavily. Part of him wanted to care more, but the other part was too jaded to get worked up. "Maybe I should, but I'm not sure if I have it in me to be pissed with you."

"No?" Even in one syllable, Catra's voice carried volumes of defeat and hope at the same time.

He studied his wife and son in the doorframe, thinking back over all the times they laughed at Micah's expressions, and were so tired they put uncooked rice in the freezer instead of the cupboard, and cooed with delight when he beamed up at them, droplets of milk or mashed avocado smeared across his cheeks. Sure, another surrogate could have given the same embryo a

womb to grow in, but it would have taken so much longer. Catra had given them time.

Bow dropped his head, pursing his lips.

“You made us a family, Cat. There isn’t anything that can cancel that out. And... I know you and Adora never got to know your stories. I want Micah to have every piece of the puzzle. I want him to know you.”

“Oh!” Her surprise was obvious, her eyeline jerking up to Glimmer ahead of them, who blinked in acquiescence. “I’d... I’d love that.”

“Maybe you and Adora can come over next weekend. Reset, yeah?”

Glimmer’s eyes widened at Bow urgently the second he said it; he wrinkled his brow in response. *What’s the problem*? *We used to hang out all the time.*

A terrible whine dragged itself from Catra, her body folding in on itself.

“She went home.”

“She’s probably just cooling off. You know she never stays mad for long.”

“Bow...” Catra’s voice barely held up, “She went home to pack. She... she’s leaving me.”

Her whole body shuddered violently as the words left her lips.

“What? Cat, no, I’m sure-”

“You were wrong. Years ago, remember? You said I couldn’t make her hate me...”

Bow was flabbergasted. He looked up again at Glimmer, his alarm reflected in her expression.

"...But I did."

NINE MONTHS AFTER

It was the fifth weekend in three months that Catra had stayed overnight on Bow and Glimmer's couch, and the fourth time that Bow had accompanied her to the synagogue in central Bright Moon.

Places of worship had never really been Bow's vibe – growing up with two fathers had written a lot of them off, and Glimmer had never been that interested in her father's Greek Orthodox tradition. He'd been taken aback when Glimmer whispered to him in the dark of their bedroom what she'd seen and overheard when she insisted on accompanying Catra to meet Prime that day, and that she'd followed her to a synagogue after, that Catra had learned something – Glimmer wasn't sure what the full story was – about her birth family, that they were Jewish.

Bow had never really thought much about Catra's ethnicity; he just knew from looking at her that she was also 'Other', and whatever kind of 'Other' she was didn't really matter. True, he'd always assumed that Jews were white, but the more he looked on the internet, trying to reconcile the image he had of his friend with the idea of nervy comics or pale, bearded men in black suits and tall hats, the more he saw that the picture wasn't that simple. There was a whole world of culture and colour beyond his assumptions that he'd never known about at all, and Catra needed someone to hold her hand while she made sense of it. He knew he was second choice, but her first wasn't there anymore. He was the best she had.

They'd spent hours over the past few weeks delving into the documents she brought over the first time she'd come to stay. It hadn't been that convenient; the baby didn't like having a stranger appear all of a sudden, especially not one that ushered such fraught emotions into the house. But Bow knew it had been Catra's first week alone in her and Adora's apartment, and that she'd probably only decided to tell him everything about her research so that she had an excuse to get out, a reason to avoid sitting in the silence of her shattered life. So, he'd rolled up his sleeves and balanced Micah on his knee as she told him everything, explained that her mother had died of post-natal sepsis in a refugee camp, an after-effect of bad hygiene following shoddy treatment for haemorrhaging in childbirth. He didn't miss how Catra tried to hide the way she glanced at Micah repeatedly, pretending that her own birthing experience had no connection to it, that she hadn't spent hours thinking about how it so could have easily been her, that she could have ended up giving her life so that Micah could live. Maybe she'd never have gone through with it if she'd known the risks. Maybe Adora would have actually stopped Catra from being their surrogate if she'd had that excuse in her arsenal. Would Bow and Glimmer have even let her do it, if they'd all been aware of the risks?

It was impossible to know. But all they could do at this point was move forward.

Before the separation, back when she was pregnant and they'd talked about all the genetic panels they could do to check foetal health, Catra had made a throwaway comment that she'd thought once about doing one of those genetic test kits to find out what her DNA revealed. Recently, Bow had arranged for Catra to do one – a late thirty-second birthday present – and she'd already been matched on the online database with distant cousins who shared splinters of her genes. He hoped it was only a matter of time before she'd find a link that was more immediate, someone who could illuminate her mother's story beyond the stark facts. Bow sometimes thought the whole thing would have been quite sweet – that she'd given him a family, so he was trying to help her find hers – if it wasn't all so tragic.

Nevertheless, being in the synagogue wasn't what he'd expected. It was some kind of progressive denomination, liberal platitudes and inclusive language peppered in every sermon given, and even the rabbi – a surprisingly young woman (he hadn't known that rabbis could even be women) in her early forties with thick red hair and round glasses that revealed a vintage aesthetic outside the pulpit – had a wife. Bow spent most the time they spent in services watching Catra out the corner of his eye, monitoring how she frowned when she scanned the indecipherable Hebrew alphabet and resorted to reading the English transliterations. Bow knew how her brain worked – she'd be wrestling with the notion that she'd been robbed of some birthright, frustrated each week that she couldn't crack the puzzle despite never being given the pieces to solve it.

He didn't miss the way Catra fixated on the children and families in the community either, her expression always a curious blend of soreness, trepidation and yearning. Whether she longed for a childhood she'd never had access to or was seeing a future that could have happened in a different life, in a world where she might have wanted different things, was harder to tell. But spending so much time in their home with Micah seemed to be softening the walls Catra had built around herself, and Bow had caught her nodding along enthusiastically to Micah's babbles when she thought no-one was paying attention, his son often stationed on Catra's belly as she slouched on the floor, his gleeful cackles filling the room when she praised him for playing peekaboo or for crawling across the room to pounce on her. It was a side to Catra that neither Bow nor Glimmer really expected to ever see, and it was so far from the guarded persona they'd spent years trying to break down.

Yet the more time they spent at the synagogue, and the more Catra began to loosen somehow, Bow wondered if it was the trauma that drew Catra further into the faith she'd discovered the most. He felt like the peoplehood Catra spoke about, that she said she felt some kind of kinship towards after all the nothingness, was so tied up in loss. For every celebration, there'd be a tragic memory recalled, reverently remembered: a burned temple; or a

forced fleeing; even a slaughtered generation. It didn't make sense to Bow, how Catra could take this sense of abstract collective pain seriously when she'd carried so much of her own, personal hurt. But she didn't seem to differentiate between healing the scars she'd suffered in years gone by and the ones she'd chosen to own on this new journey. And what did he know about it anyway? Both Bow and Glimmer were nothing if not sheltered, and they'd spent plenty of time discussing how neither of them really got it. Nonetheless, it seemed like this whole Jewish thing was really doing something for her.

He couldn't deny that Catra had been going through some kind of mental revolution. She still disassociated mid-conversation and was frequently lost to numb daydreams if she wasn't hyper-focused on work or her genealogical research. But Adora's abrupt decision to move out had finally convinced her to see a psychiatrist. He and Glimmer had had to bite their tongues when Catra revealed in whispers that she'd gotten a diagnosis of PTSD – they couldn't believe she'd actually been surprised by it, even though it was probably the most obvious thing anyone could have said about her. Catra hadn't done much about it yet, putting off the recommended therapy; she'd never liked talking things out that much, especially not with a stranger or if it would wrench the monsters of her mind out into the open. But still, it was a step. Something that – even if Catra wouldn't verbalise it to Glimmer or Bow – might bring Adora back.

FOUR YEARS AFTER

Bow knocked on the door of Catra's makeshift office, even though she'd told him not to bother meeting her. They hadn't missed one of their fortnightly lunches in over a year and given that she didn't

sound quite right when she rang to cancel, he wasn't going to break the habit now.

He didn't hear anything for a while; eventually he knocked again, peeking his head round the door. Catra was sat in her swivel chair pushed away from the desk, bent over as far she could go.

"Cat? What are you doing?"

"Trying to stick my head between my legs, obviously." *At least she's still as acerbic as ever*. "What are you doing here? I told you not to come."

"Honestly, I'm glad I didn't listen. Why are you...?"

"Ugh, I feel fucking terrible. I've barely been able to keep anything down all day. It's like the first trimester came back to bite me on the ass."

"You want me to call...?"

"No," Catra gave up, pulling herself to the desk and slamming her elbows on the surface to cradle her face in her hands, "I just need to go home. I think I'm getting a UTI or something, my back is killing me."

Bow winced on her behalf. Glimmer had gone through a period of recurrent cystitis when Micah was nearly three, and he'd spent enough time watching his wife in tears on the toilet, trying to keep their toddler distracted while she soaked in the bath to soothe her bladder and lower back. He was sure it'd be much worse for Catra in her state.

Bow gestured at the wide futon in the corner. Catra had never had an office before, but she'd converted a soundproofed meeting room into a temporary private office around the four-month mark so she could rest as needed, her morning sickness and fatigue being so much worse than it had in her pregnancy with Micah. She'd gained weight so much quicker this time round too, barely able to hide her bump by the time she reached fourteen weeks

and now stuck wearing lightweight dresses – tents, as she called them – due to how hot it had gotten at the height of summer. Catra had complained plenty that not much else fit her, even with five weeks still to go until her due date.

"Why don't you lie down for a few minutes? I'll have my car brought round and I can drive you home."

Catra grumbled, not particularly satisfied with the solution he'd presented her with, though unable to think of anything better in the immediate. She heaved herself out of her office chair with difficulty, refusing to take Bow's arm for support, and slowly lowered herself onto the futon, rolling onto her side as best she could.

"I hate to ask, but..." Catra rolled her eyes as Bow moved towards her enthusiastically, "Don't make me regret this, Arrow Boy."

"Come on, Cat. Stop deflecting and tell me."

"Just... can you rub my back?"

Bow obliged, digging his fingers into Catra's lower spine, doing his best to emulate the massages he gave his wife, that Glimmer had spent ages instructing him to improve.

"Jesus, you're shit at this. You're not doing it right at all."

Bow snorted. "Sorry I don't have the magic touch you're used to-"

He was distracted mid-sentence by Catra's throaty groan, far too heavy than was normal for a bothersome kick or nudge. His heartbeat picked up, anxiety plucking at his every nerve.

"Catra?"

She grasped at the material of her dress, screwing it up between her fingers for a good few seconds, the wrinkling cotton mirroring her scrunched-up face. Catra panted as she caught her breath, alarm evident in her expression as she caught Bow's eye.

“Something’s wrong,” Catra spoke shakily, insecurity loaded in every syllable, “This doesn’t feel right.”

“It’ll be alright,” Bow squeezed her hand, wishing that he didn’t feel the sinking weight of a lie in his stomach, “Give me a second to get help, and then I’ll be right back, okay?”

“Wait, no, Bow - don’t make a fuss!”

Bow pulled his hand out of her tightening grip and rushed to the door, not caring that it slammed far too loudly behind him, attracting the attention of half the floor. He spotted Catra’s PA approaching from the kitchen.

“Tim!” Bow ran the length of the floor between them, stopping short of a full-on collision, careful not to unsettle the cup of soup the red-headed man was carrying. He could tell members of Catra’s team were taking notice, muttering among themselves. Bow leaned in close to Tim, not wanting to be overheard and ignite widespread alarm, “We need an ambulance. And you need to get Catra’s wife here. Now.”

The man startled, his eyes widening at Bow’s instructions. “What? Is she okay?”

“Yeah, she’s great – I’m only asking for fun!” Bow cringed as Tim flinched in response to his tone, so unlike his usual relaxed manner. “Sorry. I didn’t mean to snap. But have you got this or am I going to have to cause a scene for someone to do something?”

“I’m on it.”

“Good. And get people away from her office, okay? She’ll be pissed if everyone’s gawking at her.”

He didn’t wait for Tim to respond before he rushed back to Catra and knelt before her, resting his hand on the wide swell of her abdomen.

“Alright, Cat. Tim’s calling 999 and clearing the area for privacy. We just need to make sure we time your next contraction, okay?”

“What?” She stared at him incredulously, tiny beads of sweat starting to break on her hairline, “I can’t be in labour. I start maternity leave tomorrow. And the birthing pool isn’t being delivered until next week.”

“Cat-”

“I’m only thirty-five weeks. It’s too soon.”

“I’ve seen you in labour before, Catra. I’m pretty sure it’s happening.”

“No, Bow,” Catra clutched at his shirt desperately, “I... I was forty-one weeks with Micah. And everything’s fine, she’s been kicking all day, just like normal.”

“Listen-”

“You listen to me!” She’d gotten angry, pushing herself upright with strenuous effort and planting her feet firmly on the ground, her hands pressing down into each of his shoulders. “This is just really bad back pain. That’s all it is. I just need to go home and lie down.”

“Catra, you said yourself that something isn’t right.”

“Yeah well, I was wrong! It wouldn’t be the first time, would it?”

Bow brought his hands up to grip the wrists that flanked his ears.

“I know this isn’t ideal. But you definitely just had a contraction, and it didn’t seem like a small one.”

They stared each other down, neither one giving in until Catra whimpered, her face crumpling.

“She’s not ready.”

Catra gasped as a second wave of pain overcame her, breathing heavily as she squeezed the shoulders of Bow's blazer, the navy silk blend creasing under her fingers. Bow pulled his phone from his suit pocket, starting the stopwatch as fast as he could. It lasted way too long – first thirty seconds, then forty. They were getting close to a minute when Catra's moan deepened, as if the pain was doubling down.

"Fuck, I don't... I don't understand, it's like a second peak." She panted as she forced the words out, clutching at his suit further, "Bow, I need you to get me home. That's where... That's where we agreed she'd be born."

"It's too late for that, Cat. The ambulance will be on its way."

"I've only had two contractions-"

"Two *long* contractions. They weren't much closer together when you delivered Micah."

Catra's expression hardened, something clicking in her mind. Bow couldn't count the number of times he'd seen this happen right in front of him, how the cogs in her brain would suddenly switch direction and turn counter-clockwise, blowing everything that had come before completely out the water. He'd seen it when she announced she wanted to commit to this pregnancy, a turn of events that Bow and Glimmer never foresaw.

"You better check me."

Bow gulped. "Are you sure? The paramedics will be here soon, they'll do a much better job."

"*Bow*. You're the only person I trust here. I'm not having fucking Tim stick his head up my skirt, and Entrapta's meeting suppliers on the other side of the city. I need you to deal – I can't do it properly myself." He couldn't help but wonder how the tactician in her was able to take over so swiftly, even in such pressurised circumstances. "You've seen it all before anyway, yeah?"

Bow nodded slowly, taking his jacket off.

“You got any alcohol?”

“There’s hand sanitiser on the desk,” She watched as he scrambled to grab the small bottle, rubbing liberal amounts into his skin, “Just a quick look, that’s all I need from you.”

He hated how the tables had turned, that she felt she had to hand-hold him through it rather than the other way round. He cleared his throat and pushed the skirt of Catra’s dress up to her hips, locking his fingers in the waistband of the maternity shorts she was wearing underneath.

“Ready?”

She nodded and exhaled deeply, her fingers trembling on the edge of the futon as much as his were on the black cotton. Catra lifted her hips a little as he pulled the shorts away, swallowing the dread that stuck in his throat when the bright blood smeared on her inner thighs was revealed. He could feel how much she’d bled in the weight of soaked material once he held her shorts and underwear, trails of crimson left on her legs from their removal. He glanced up to check Catra’s eyes were closed before he folded them quickly and wiped his stained hands on his trousers hastily, keen to hide it all from her view. He took a deep breath, easing Catra’s legs open further as she leaned back so he could do what she asked. Bow kept his voice as steady as he could.

“I don’t think she’s going to take long, Cat.”

Catra pushed herself upright faster than he thought possible and slapped him away hurriedly, slipping her hand between her thighs before Bow could hand her the gel sanitiser or do anything to stop her. A tremor of relief passed through Catra as she checked she wasn’t about to crown, though she became more and more tense as her fingers explored inwards, her brow furrowed in concentration until Bow could only see her knuckles from the outside.

“Oh my God.” She looked up at Bow in horror, stilling. “I can feel her.”

She removed her hand – it was now shaking violently, covered in red. Too much red. Catra stared at it, suddenly noticing the blood blurred across her inner thighs. Bow felt like he’d failed already at keeping her morale up; her composed façade was crumbling by the second.

“I didn’t bleed like this last time. Did I?”

Bow laid a reassuring hand on her knee, restraining the tremble that threatened to overtake him. “Don’t think about what it was like then. Let’s just take this one step-”

Catra’s arms shot out towards him as another contraction broke through her, bloodied handprints staining his shirt sleeves.

“They’re...th-they’re too close already, aren’t they? Fuck, she’s... Bow... Oh God, I’m really going to give birth in my office, aren’t I? We don’t... we don’t have anything...!”

Bow placed his hand on her jaw to focus her concentration, inhaling slowly and deeply in an attempt to get her to mirror his breathwork. He couldn’t believe it had come to this, that despite all the meticulous planning she put into these things, Catra was still stuck with him, labouring like this while the rest of the world spun on its axis, completely uninterrupted.

“We’ll get you through this. Someday, this will just be a funny story, and everyone will think about how brave you were, how amazing you are that you did this. Right?”

Catra’s breathing slowed as she listened to him, her pain ebbing away slowly. She supported herself with her hands still on Bow’s shoulders to straighten up a little again, rising temporarily to settle back into place more comfortably. But as soon as she did, a startled noise flew from her throat.

“Oh no...”

“Catra, what is it?”

“My waters... I think...”

He felt it then, the liquid seeping into his knee as she hovered over him above the cushions of the futon. *This is way too fast. Wasn’t she in labour for over twenty hours with Micah?*

“I can’t wait for a paramedic. You need to drive me.”

Bow stared at her in disbelief. “Catra, there’s no way-”

But she’d already tipped her entire body weight onto him, the torture of another contraction starting far too soon corrupting her whole being, seemingly stronger and more consuming than any she’d had yet. There had barely been two minutes between this and the last one – the relentlessness of it was overwhelming. Bow was forced to stand and lift Catra with him to prevent the two of them from toppling over. She attempted to stagger towards the door, ignoring Bow’s objections, as if she knew that he had no choice but to keep moving with her, that she could trust him not to let go. And just as soon as she’d taken a step forward, Bow could feel Catra’s weight going dead and dropping to the floor, the muscles in her legs completely wasting away. She was too heavy to hold up. All Bow could do was pull her weight on top of him as she sunk downwards, trying to do everything he could to cushion her fall. They found themselves sprawled on the ground, Catra’s back slumped against his chest, her hips jammed between his legs.

“Bow, she’s coming out... I can’t... I can’t stop-!”

He took Catra’s hands in his, absorbing the fierce clench of her fists as she wailed. He spoke into her ear from behind.

“Catra, it’s time. You need to push.”

“No... no. She has to wait.” Catra’s sweat was sticking to her skin all over now, the concentration in her face twisted in pure agony

as piercing cries bore out of her, doing everything she could to avoid pushing. “It’s not supposed to happen this way.”

“She can’t wait, you have to give into it.”

She let out a terrible sob. Catra ripped her right hand from his and thrust it under her skirt, finally following her body’s urges and letting out a loud guttural screech that punctured the air. Bow hoped to God that someone could hear them through the cladded walls, that someone would come to help. *Why the fuck did I tell Tim to get everyone away? Is this my fault, that we’re all alone?*

She panted as the briefest reprieve fell between contractions; her dress had risen up to her belly and Bow could see the head was out, that Catra cradled the scalp in her hand, her legs falling further open against his knees.

“Oh, Cat, you’ve nearly done it! This will all be over so soon.”

Bow could feel every part of Catra straining as she pushed again, her brow knitted in unwavering concentration until a tiny body slipped too fast past her fingers and slid onto the carpet, expelling more air from its lungs than he’d expected for such a small child, for one born this early. He let out a heavy sigh of relief as he realised the baby seemed okay; she could breathe, and she was crying, and her minuscule feet squirmed around the cord.

But Catra didn’t surge forward to take her like Bow anticipated she would; instead, she seemed to flop against his chest, her head lolling against his upper arm even when he tapped her left cheek, the skin clammy against his palm.

“Tell... tell Adora...”

He squeezed the loose fist still gripped in his left hand. *She’s cold. How is her hand cold?*

“Catra, stay with me, you did it! Look, she’s-”

“Tell her I lo...”

He could barely make out her slurred mumbles as she slid into unconsciousness, her words dissolving on her tongue.

This can’t be happening... Not like this. Not after everything we’ve got through, all four of us.

Bow bellowed for help, summoning all the energy he had to cut through the thick walls to the outside. But he couldn't hear if anyone was coming, if he'd caught anyone's attention. He watched powerlessly as a red stream coursed closer and closer towards the naked baby, finding himself trapped between the impossible choice of clutching the weakening woman close or protecting the helpless infant wriggling on the floor that she’d carried despite the odds.

Chapter 25

ONE YEAR AFTER

Adora was trying to listen, but it was damn near impossible to stop herself from zoning out.

"Hello? Earth to Adora?"

She blinked, her sight sharpening as Glimmer waved a palette knife in front of her. Adora leaned over to take it from her, licking vanilla buttercream off the lightweight metal with the tip of her tongue.

"Okay, well, I wasn't really done with that, but..."

Glimmer shrugged at the frosted cake on the kitchen table, fully covered but not quite smoothed, and turned to pull Micah out of his highchair, dampening a cloth under the tap to clean trails of porridge and raspberries off his face and hands.

"Looks like your birthday cake is finished then, Micah!"

Glimmer giggled as Micah smacked his hands together; Adora couldn't help but smile at the two of them. It had all been worth it in the end, for this. She had to keep telling herself that.

The stolen buttercream melted soft and sweet on her tongue, but it only made her feel more nostalgic for the cakes she and Catra had shared in their home, and how Catra's buttercream always had a teaspoon of honey whipped into it – almost imperceptible, but recognisable every time. It was crazy to think it had been a year already since she'd smoothed her hands across the rounded expanse of Catra's abdomen, held her hand through contractions, and wrapped her arms around Catra's exhausted body afterwards, the two of them curling together around an absence, an energy that now lived beyond them.

Adora had been nervous for weeks about what this day might dredge up, how she'd feel seeing her in this context. Part of her had hoped Catra would decide not to come, but the other half of her was desperate that she would. It was confusing to say the least, though ultimately Adora knew that if either of them was going to skip out, it would be her. Bow and Glimmer didn't reveal much to her when she occasionally met with them, but Micah had taken to repeating the three or four words he'd learned to say on loop, and one of them was undeniably an attempt at Catra's name. Somehow, the three of them had made up and Catra was playing a bigger role in Micah's life than Adora had expected. But ultimately, however bitter she felt about it, Adora had to remember that she'd been the one to leave this time; it was her who had pressed on a spider web of cracks and shattered the strings of glass holding them together.

What's more, she'd refused to meld them back to how they'd been before. Adora had almost gotten bored of seeing Catra in the same chair every week, wasting her Thursday nights in the waiting room of the obstetrics ward. Adora always ignored her; it hurt too much to admit that the fight in her had gone out. A couple of the midwives had asked Adora if she wanted them to talk to Catra and tell her to stop coming – it was easy enough to say that she was taking up space designated for patients, after all – but Adora hadn't given them the go-ahead. She'd just repeated the same old line to them for near on six months: Catra would stop eventually, she'd disappear like she always did. Part of Adora even believed it.

Still, Catra stayed.

"Hey! 'Dor."

Adora snapped to attention, only just noticing that the palette knife was still balanced between her lips, her elbow propped on the table surface. Glimmer stared down at her, holding her hand out for the utensil, Micah now balanced on her hip. Adora turned it over to her slowly, her gaze falling on him. Glimmer seemed to notice.

"You want to do me a favour and take him into the living room? I've got to clean up in here before people arrive."

She nodded dumbly, holding her arms out for the child and breathing in his balmy scent when his pudgy hands met her body. Adora stood up with him as he looked ahead of them with acute alertness, drinking in everything around them. They were only just crossing the hallway when Bow let a group into the flat, a few parents and their babies that Adora didn't recognise. Her heart fell a little as she realised Catra wasn't there – she buried her disappointment, reminded herself that she'd made her choice, she had no right to feel like this – signposting the guests to the living room with a plastered-on grin, waiting to see if she'd maybe missed her, if it was just a mistake. *No such luck.* Adora turned towards the living room just as the door creaked opened again, Micah twisting to peer over her shoulder.

"Ca! Ca-ta!"

Adora's heart drummed like a war band, blood pulsing hard in the hollows of her collarbones. Micah squirmed against her, grinding his feet into her stomach like he could walk right through her into Catra's arms. Slowly, she spun round, forcing herself to keep as neutral an expression as she could.

"Hey, Adora."

Catra seemed impossibly relaxed, her shirt half-tucked into wide leg light blue jeans, an unpredicted departure from the skin-tight black denim she'd always worn. Adora wasn't sure why it stood out so much to her, why it seemed to speak so loudly.

"C-C-Catra!"

Adora cursed herself for the stammer; it figured that she'd be the one to trip over her words the first time they spoke to each other.

"Ca-ta!"

Adora cleared her throat as Micah dug his feet even deeper into her – she wrapped her hands around his middle tighter, resisting his attempts to lean across the space between them. Catra lunged forwards just in time as his position became more precarious, Micah's torso falling onto her chest. Adora realised how suddenly close they had become: she was near enough to see tiny flecks of colour dancing in Catra's eyes.

"I've got him, it's okay."

Adora pinched her lips shut as Catra moved away from her, a thin flash of cold metal still on her finger brushing across Adora's hand as she adjusted her grip on the baby, who bobbed in delight as he tugged on Catra's long curls. Adora wracked her brain for something useful to say, something that might diffuse the awkwardness. But she had never been great at doing that, at least not when there was some kind of conflict with Catra, and what on earth was she supposed to say to her now anyway? She'd actively blocked any attempts at reconciliation that Catra had made for months.

Fortunately – or unfortunately, Adora wasn't quite sure – Catra was entirely engrossed in tending to Micah, beaming at the boy and responding eagerly to his incoherent chatter. He pressed his mouth to her face, leaving wet drool all over her cheeks, but instead of grimacing, Adora was shocked to see her laughing back at him, thanking Micah and marvelling at how clever he was to be so good at giving birthday kisses.

Catra glanced up at Adora for barely a second as she muttered that she would take Micah into the lounge where all the other guests were; Adora felt practically numb as she watched them interact, following them and settling on the other side of the room to watch as Bow and Glimmer sat beside Catra, the former smoothing his thumb over his son's cheek as he bounced in Catra's lap before crawling over to his parents, stretching his body out across them.

Adora didn't know what to do with herself. She'd spent a lifetime watching Catra from across rooms. When they were teenagers – kids, even – she didn't know what the flutter in her stomach meant until it started to hurt too much. But then it grew into something wonderful, a glorious warmth that spread throughout her body for years, bolstered by knowledge that her joy was reciprocated, and it felt like that warmth could never, ever be lost. But Adora wasn't so sure anymore of whether the unyielding spiral in her belly was closer to joy or pain or something hopelessly in between.

It struck her in the moment that the last time they'd both been in this room, she'd ended them.

Really, it was impossible for Adora to forget how everything always pulled her back to Catra and her omissions.

She'd sat where Bow was now, right next to Catra as she gripped her thigh with a trembling hand, begging Adora to let it all go, that she was safe from Prime – maybe safer than she'd ever been – but she still felt so shaken, and couldn't Adora *please stop asking to hear every little detail and just put her arms around her*?

But as the front door had slammed shut behind Bow and Micah and reverberated throughout the flat, Adora had come to the most painful realisation she'd ever had; when Catra had everything on the line, when there was no greater incentive to finally open up, she still wouldn't. There was no way Adora could deny it any longer. She'd pushed her greatest fear deep down inside her, the fear she'd spent her entire life trying to lock away in the tightest, tiniest box. But when it came to it, maybe the only way she could love Catra – how she needed to know her, to see every part of her, no matter how terrible or incredible or scary she was – was exactly what Catra could never accept. It had dawned on her slowly and all at once: maybe Catra's need to hide was greater than Adora's ability to love.

"You'll never do it, will you?" Catra had squinted in confusion, "We'll never be equals in this, not really."

“Do what?” Adora wouldn’t forget how bewildered Catra had sounded, her voice reedy from all the tears she’d already shed. “Adora, what are you talking about?”

The words had come to her like they’d been searching for her for years.

“I’ll always be looking for you, but you never wanted to be found. You’ve never wanted to be rescued, not really. It was just... it was just my stupid fantasy.”

She’d made eye contact with Glimmer then, whose eyes had widened in alarmed recognition of an argument they’d had so many years ago in a dingy gym, after the first time Catra had chosen to close herself off so significantly. Glimmer had slipped out the room then, shutting the door behind her, and the mood had changed so quickly as it became clearer and clearer that this was no typical conversation taking place between them.

“Rescued?” Catra had spoken so softly, almost as if she were afraid; her hand had risen to cup Adora’s face, “Adora, you’re not - we’re not - meant to *rescue* each other. We’re supposed to survive, right? Together.”

But Adora had turned away, breaking Catra’s contact as she shifted her weight onto her forearms, her hands clasped together tightly in the gulf between her knees.

“No, Catra. That’s the problem – you’re just trying to stay alive, but I want... I want to be *happy*. And I can’t do this anymore. Pretending that this is healthy, that I’m fine every time you shut yourself off from me, that I understand. Because I don’t. I don’t understand why you can’t give me all of yourself the way I’m trying to give you all of me.”

Adora had ignored the soreness that spread through her chest as she’d said it, knowing innately that she was getting closer to the cut that would sever them.

“There is nothing – literally nothing – in this whole world that I want more than being totally, completely, one hundred percent yours. But you’ll never be mine, not in the same way. Because there’s always going to be so much of you that you’re keeping locked up in other places or giving away to other people. And I’ve asked you over and over again to talk to someone, but you won’t get help.”

“Adora-“

“I thought that if you wouldn’t do it for yourself, you might do it for me. But I’m not enough, am I? For you to look after yourself.”

“No, ‘Dor, please. You're everything to me!”

“That’s not what I asked you.”

“Of course, you’re enough. You’re *more* than enough.”

“I’m sorry. But I don’t... I don’t think I believe you anymore.”

The rest of it had been a total blur. Adora didn’t know whether it even mattered, that she could barely remember anything she and Catra had said. The outcome was the same either way – she’d gone home and packed a bag, taken Melog to her parents’ place, and ended up staying there for nearly six months.

Adora couldn’t watch the game of happy families Catra, Bow and Glimmer were playing any longer. She slipped out the room as subtly as she could, splashing cold water on her face in the kitchen sink before she went to get her coat. She caught sight of the tattoo on her wrist that had haunted her every time she saw it – it was the first she’d gotten of the two she had, yellow and blue forget-me-nots that symbolised both her and Catra’s eyes.

A cautious voice rang out behind her.

“I’m really glad you came. I know it means a lot to Bow and Glimmer.”

Adora exhaled deeply, the familiar timbre of the words rolling across her skin. She wiped her wet hands on her thighs, taking her time before she turned back to look at Catra, a tense silence settling between them.

"Adora. Please, talk to me. It's been nearly six months."

"You have to stop this. And coming to the ward. It's not... We're not enough."

She approached Catra on her way to leave the kitchen, hesitating for the slightest moment as she passed her, Adora's entire body screaming silently at the other woman to disagree and use those unbeatable reflexes of hers to reach out and stop her from leaving, and capture her with her sweet lips, and ignore everything Adora was telling her, because surely they loved each other enough for her to know that Adora was lying through her teeth, and that they really were supposed to be together forever and it was still, after all this, them against the world.

But Catra remained motionless. Adora made her way out the flat into the icy street, her exit completely unimpeded. She'd never felt quite as cold her entire life.

It had been years since Adora worked the night shift on her birthday.

They'd been short of staff on the rota, and she hadn't really planned anything she was actually interested in doing. At least this way, she wouldn't have to deal with her parents' daily prompts that maybe she and Catra should put their place on the market, if they really were over. Their pitying faces were the last thing Adora wanted to see that day, a reminder that she was turning thirty-three and had been living at home for nearly a year,

still completely unable to come to terms with how she'd torn everything to pieces.

Doubt they thought they were getting themselves into this when they adopted me.

She snorted to herself, deep in thought as she made her way to the waiting room and ripped her scrub cap off her head, preparing herself to give her patient's family the good news – that the emergency surgery had been fine, and both mother and baby were doing well. Her eyes darted over to the chair where Catra always waited for those first six months apart.

She hasn't come since Micah's birthday party. Besides, it's nearly four AM, there's no way she'd be here just because-

Adora stopped dead in her tracks – right where she'd always used to sit, Catra was dozing, her knees pulled up to her chest as she rested her head on a jumper she'd fashioned into a makeshift pillow. She caught the horrified looks on her patient's relatives' faces as they saw her surprise, not realising her alarm had nothing to do with the surgery at all. She hurried over to update them, speeding through her explanations with a lack of professionalism she'd never stooped to, desperate for the conversation to be over. Luckily, it was easy enough for good news to placate them; it wasn't long until she was tiptoeing towards Catra, sinking gently into the adjacent seat.

She's actually here, after all this time.

Adora reached out for her, tucking a wayward tendril behind Catra's ear before she caught herself. She gasped as Catra startled, jerking awake in shock.

"Shit, Catra, I'm sorry."

"'Dor?" Catra's voice was groggy, heavy with poor sleep.

"What are you doing here? It's the early hours of the morning."

Catra groaned as she stretched her legs out, rolling her shoulders.

“You know why, Adora. We promised that we’d never spend our birthdays apart again.”

Guilt washed over Adora; she’d missed Catra’s birthday a month earlier, too sore to make a move.

“You should go home, get some rest.”

“Come with me, ‘Dor. Please.”

“My shift doesn’t finish for another few hours-”

“I’ll wait. I want to show you something.”

Adora was a little taken aback. Catra’s urgency was unfamiliar, and it wasn’t often that Catra had ever wanted to let her in on something completely of her own accord. Her agreement slipped out before she had time to think about it.

“Okay. I still have my key, though. I can let myself in if you go now.”

Catra shook her head vehemently.

“No, ‘Dor. I’m waiting for you.”

She’s been waiting for me all year, hasn’t she? She never stopped.

Adora had insisted on driving them home in the early sunlight. She’d loaded her bike onto its rack – she hadn’t realised Catra never took it off the roof – and had taken the keys from the sleepy woman, glancing at her as she drove, watching how the golden light streamed across her skin between the moving shadows of tall buildings. For the duration of their short drive,

Adora had imagined that nothing had ever gone wrong; that it was her wife sitting next to her in the passenger seat, and they'd already had months of marriage under their belts.

It was strange now, being back in their home. Nothing really looked that different, but it had a changed energy. It was the tiniest of things – the slightly deeper indents in the cushions of Catra's side of the sofa, the odd photo that had been replaced with an image of Micah, and the few ornaments that Adora didn't recognise, all inscribed with foreign letters.

"Are you sure you're not too tired? You can sleep in the bed; I'll take the office futon for a few hours."

Adora stifled a yawn, shaking her head. She'd never slept in their bed purposefully alone; not unless Catra had woken up sooner, or she was away for work.

"What did you want to show me?"

Catra frowned. "Sit."

Adora obliged, taking her old place on their sofa, curiosity overtaking her. Catra faced away from her and began unbuttoning her blouse, shimmying it off her shoulders until she was left in just her bralette.

"Catra, what are you-?"

Her voice stopped in her throat when Catra turned back around; the smooth black tattoo that had snaked across her collarbone for so many years had been embellished with a flurry of tiny blue and yellow flowers, the same ones that lived on Adora's wrist, the solid colour broken up with added texture, transformed into silver branches instead of hard black strokes.

"I never told you because you liked it, but he made me get it. It wasn't long after graduation, after he found out I'd gone to meet you on your birthday. He said I needed reminding that I was his, that I didn't belong to you."

“The flowers...”

“He was wrong. I always belonged to you.”

Catra dropped to her knees in front of Adora, grasping her hands.

“I’ve been living for so long with a noose around my neck, Adora, and I don’t want it anymore.”

Adora leaned forward, tracing a careful finger over the ink, still a little shiny while the skin healed.

“This is really new.”

“Yes. I talked about it a lot with my therapist, about how I haven’t fully taken control of my body back from him. She thinks... she thinks maybe that’s why I can’t talk about things so easily. Because there’s a lot that feels like it’s still his, not mine. And it’s hard to separate the things that feel like his from the things that have nothing to do with him. So, I’m trying to rewrite it. I thought... I thought if I reclaimed this, then maybe I could...”

Adora squeezed her fingers, encouraging Catra to continue.

“I could have enough of myself back to share with you. Because I want to. I’ve always wanted to. I just didn’t...”

“You didn’t feel like you could give what never felt like yours.”

Catra gulped, searching the terrain of Adora’s face. It felt like she was holding onto all the moments they’d experienced together, collecting their mutual happiness and grief, storing them behind those mismatched irises for posterity. She saw the jewel in Adora’s ear, the one that she only ever wore on her birthday in the past but hadn’t been able to take out for a year, a substitute for the ring that she couldn’t bear to look at while they were apart, even though she’d seen Catra still wore hers.

“I missed you, Adora.”

Adora tugged on her hand, pulling her on top of her on the sofa, Catra's legs straddling her thighs just like they had so many times before, fitting together seamlessly like two pieces of a puzzle. Adora craned her neck upwards, trailing kisses along the tattoo, noticing that Catra didn't tense at her lips pressing into ink, not like she had in the past. Her body groaned with fatigue and longing all at once, and she rested her forehead against Catra's collarbone, holding them close together in silence, as if she'd be able to turn back time if she finally did what Catra had asked of her all those months ago – if she'd just put her arms around her. Adora couldn't deny it to herself any longer – she craved a life with this woman who had driven her crazy with her obstinance, who'd fought through fire before she'd finally got the help she so clearly needed, whose absence Adora had never been able to tolerate since the minute they'd met as children.

"Catra..." Adora's voice trembled, her eyelashes fluttering shut, "I'm such an idiot."

She kept her eyes closed as she felt soft fingertips ease her chin up, guiding her to the gentlest of kisses meeting her lips.

"You're *my* idiot."

Chapter 26

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

TWO AND A HALF YEARS AFTER

If Glimmer had a penny for every time Catra did something unexpected, she'd be a millionaire. But today, she had really won the lottery.

"Is this a joke?"

She had watched Catra roll her eyes in annoyance, her fingers drumming on the handle of the pushchair.

"No, I..." she'd huffed, hesitant to continue, "I value your opinion, okay?"

Glimmer had raised her eyebrows in surprise.

"Really?"

"Jesus, Glim, don't be a dick about it. I've got the appointment booked, so are you coming or not?"

Glimmer had felt a profound feeling of warmth spread through her chest; even after all this time, she sometimes questioned whether their friendship really was as genuine as she hoped. Catra's request was welcome evidence that her fears really were unfounded, even if it was completely inconvenient.

"I really want to – but Micah's with us."

Catra had glanced down at the two-year-old in the pushchair, slumped in his seat as he slept.

“I’m sure it’ll be alright. Kid’s pretty chill most of the time.”

“Okay,” Glimmer had scratched the back of her neck apprehensively, “And you’re sure you wouldn’t rather take Bow? Or Entrapta?”

Her friend had practically flinched; Glimmer had known she’d misstepped immediately.

“Look, I can go on my own if you don’t want to – you can be honest with me.”

“No! No, I’d love to come. I’m just... I’m kind of surprised.”

It had been the second time that day Catra had asked for her help, and Glimmer wasn’t quite sure what to make of it. Now she found herself sat on a huge leather couch in the dressing room of one of Bright Moon’s most expensive tailors, watching Catra have alterations made to ivory silk. She’d seen Catra wear a million suits after work, at functions, and – since she’d gone public as the head of her company – in editorial features and on panels, always impeccably fitted. It was like she had access to some forbidden behind the scenes footage; some mystery insight into the work that Catra undertook to project the version of herself she was willing to let the world see.

Catra stared at herself in the floor-length mirrors as the seamstresses moved away, her chin jutting out as she inspected the suit. Glimmer gazed at how the fluid material flared out from Catra’s hips to the floor, tiny pearl droplets clinging to the breast pockets of the blazer, its notched lapels sinking to a deep V at the bottom of her sternum.

“You look incredible, Cat.”

Catra frowned, pressing her lips together.

“Can you give us a minute?”

Glimmer watched in confusion as Catra dismissed the staff; her arms tightened a little around Micah, who was fully engrossed in playing with their house keys on her lap, his fingers running back and forth over the metal grooves. Catra sighed heavily, rolling her shoulders inside the silk blazer and dropping onto the sofa next to them.

"What's wrong?" Glimmer laid a hand on Catra's upper arm, her gentle touch melting into the soft fabric, "It's really beautiful. Adora will love it."

Catra's nose twitched. "I always wear suits. She'll expect it."

"That's okay, if you feel good in it. But, Cat, you know you don't have to wear a suit if you don't-"

Catra cut her off, their eyes making contact sharply. "You've seen them."

Glimmer swallowed as she observed Catra's focus dart towards Micah for the briefest moment. It made sense now, why she'd been so insistent that she wanted Glimmer to come along for this. She had seen Catra's scars when she was in labour – but the true depth of her insecurity hadn't been so obvious before; Glimmer had never commented on the fact she'd seen them, and nor had Catra. It had never felt like an actual secret to her, but she wondered now if she had grossly underestimated the significance of it, assuming that their mutual silence surrounding her discovery of the scars was simply further evidence of Catra's fiercely private nature.

She wasn't sure if it was appropriate to ask the question that lingered on her lips. But Glimmer couldn't think of another response to give, and *surely* by now, after everything, they'd gotten to the point where they could just about say anything?

"If you didn't have them, would you have wanted a dress?"

Catra shifted in her seat a little uncomfortably.

“Not a dress, but... I don’t know. Maybe not this. Something more...” she searched for the right word, “...freeing.”

“Free!”

Catra smiled at Micah’s unexpected outburst, leaning in to stroke his cheek; the toddler still repeated a lot of words he heard frequently, and Catra’s tendency to snack on samples at farmer’s markets when she joined Bow and Micah for their Saturday afternoon shop was clearly rubbing off on the kid.

“We can find you something different.”

“I’ve paid for this already.”

“Come on, Catra – we both know money isn’t the issue here. You can wear it to one of your tech awards things or whatever.”

Micah wriggled out of Glimmer’s arms and scrambled closer to Catra to show her the keys – Glimmer sighed as Catra pounced on the opportunity to duck out of their conversation, turning all her attention to the boy. Glimmer wasn’t unused to seeing Catra be so affectionate with her son; it had taken time for them all to heal from the fallout of the breastfeeding fiasco, though the strong relationship between the two of them had built quickly. It didn’t concern Glimmer now the way it had done initially, her protectiveness surpassed by her husband’s relief at the improvement in Catra’s demeanour following her and Adora’s breakup. In the short months before Micah turned one, Catra had become a permanent fixture in their family unit, even without Adora. Perhaps it had always been inevitable; Glimmer hadn’t questioned Catra’s motives for being her surrogate after the birth, yet the pieces of information Catra had begrudgingly offered during her pregnancy didn’t always match up. Since they met with Prime, she’d increasingly suspected that the surrogacy had been an opportunity for Catra to play out an alternative reality she didn’t feel able to commit to herself, one that she’d decided bore too much risk.

She watched the two of them closely; the softness Catra displayed around Micah clashed with the extreme dislike of children that Adora had previously lamented Catra held. Glimmer couldn't reconcile the two versions of Catra, and she'd held her tongue for long enough on the matter.

"I never brought it up, but I overheard what you said to Prime that day, about how he's the reason you don't want kids. That, and this whole covering up thing, Cat – you can't carry on letting him affect you like this."

Catra avoided Glimmer's eye contact, her pupils still trained on Micah. Glimmer moved closer to them both, gliding her palm gently over Micah's curls.

"Is this something you actually want? Because if he's still holding you back, you have to know-"

"Glimmer, you don't get it. It's not that simple."

"It *can* be, Catra. And so can wearing what you want to your own wedding."

Catra's fists tightened around the keys, causing Micah's bottom lip to waver; he removed them from her reach warily, leaning back towards his mother.

"Keys mine."

Micah pressed his face into Glimmer's chest, the keys trapped safely between their bodies. Glimmer rubbed soothing circles on his back, though she knew she shouldn't be consoling him. Micah was perfectly happy showing people things, but far less open to the idea of sharing anything, especially with other children at his nursery.

Catra pinched the bridge of her nose between two fingers.

"I don't want to be one of those childfree women who just changes her mind like everyone says they will."

"I never wanted kids. Thought I was going to be some high-flying career woman and only answer to myself. But things changed. And literally no-one cared."

"I... It's different for me."

"Why?"

The same thought that plagued Glimmer years ago when Catra first resurfaced rose again, though her bitterness was gone. *What makes you so special?*

"You had a mother." Catra paused for slightly too long, but Glimmer had the feeling there was more she wanted to say. She just had to wait for Catra to voice it, and sure enough, she did. "I don't know how to keep someone safe, or make sure they're loved enough."

She looked up in surprise when Glimmer laughed, her brows narrowing unhappily at Glimmer's chuckles.

"Glimmer! I'm trying to be honest with you, and you're-"

"For God's sake, Catra – what do you think it is you're doing with Micah? Or Adora? Or any of us, really? You don't think that's love? Do you think we'd ever let you near him if we didn't think you could keep him safe?"

Catra spluttered, her mouth slackening. Micah beamed at Glimmer as she laughed, his mood starting to lift as the tension in the room broke.

"Look, there's really only one thing that matters. Whether it's getting a different outfit for the wedding or having a kid, it all boils down to the same thing. Would it make you happy?"

"It would make Adora happy."

"Try again, Cat." She kissed Micah's forehead, savouring his warmth as he nestled into her even further. "I know you're

working on it, and it's hard to open up," Glimmer reached out for Catra, resting her hand on her shoulder. "I see that, honestly. But I also think you're scared of accepting you might have changed your mind. And hey, maybe you're right. Maybe there's a million reasons why it's a terrible idea-"

"See? Even you-"

"*But* the only reason you shouldn't do it is because you genuinely don't want to. Not because you've convinced yourself you can't, or you're not good enough. And definitely not because of that man. He's taken far too much from you already."

Catra exhaled slowly, tired defeat forming on her face. She had wrinkles now that Glimmer didn't remember seeing just a couple of years ago, the magnitude of recent events clearly having weighed her down.

"Why Cat sad?"

"I'm not sad, Mikey. I'm just thinking."

Micah wriggled away from his mother once more, dropping the keys as he teetered on Catra's lap. He leaned in to press his mouth to her cheek, having learned that was what his parents did whenever he hurt himself.

"Magic kiss make better."

Catra chuckled lightly, holding Micah close and kissing his cheek in return.

Watching them together, Glimmer wasn't entirely sure whether her speech had really been that helpful or whether it would ultimately do more harm than good. Her own outlook on motherhood had changed so much over the course of her illnesses and lengthy recovery, and she couldn't deny the conversation had stirred up a lot of her own feelings as it progressed. Glimmer had kept it to herself so far, but her desire for a second child had been building steadily over recent months. Yet presuming they would

need to find another surrogate, the road to a sibling for Micah would be arduous at best. These sweet moments – in which she saw how caring her son was at such a young age, or how much joy he'd brought into the world with him – had become almost as painful as they were proud.

Adora had nearly had a heart attack when she saw Catra. Her shock had been visible to everyone, and even hours later, she had been able to tell the extent of her astonishment still played on Catra's mind.

"Are you sure you like it? I know it's a bit different."

She'd run her fingers along the uncovered tattoo like she had so many times before, her other arm wrapping further around Catra's middle as they had swayed, the intimacy of the moment between them preserved despite the attentive presence of everyone who had surrounded them.

"I love it. I love that you chose it."

"It was Glimmer, really. She found it."

"*You* decided to wear it. And you look beautiful in it."

Adora closed her eyes, the vision of Catra on their wedding day amplified by the new memory of how the heavy texture of rich duchess satin had felt under her palm. She'd thought it was a dress to begin with, the wide pleated trouser legs being much fuller than her usual suits. But the asymmetrical draped bodice was the bigger revelation – it was the first time Adora had seen Catra in something strapless since they were teenagers; the first time any of their friends would have seen her scars at all.

"I'm really proud of you, you know."

A small smile curled at the edges of Catra's lips on the pillow next to her, even though her words were seemingly out of context; Adora was relieved she hadn't made her feel self-conscious – her compliments still didn't always have the effect on Catra she hoped. She shuffled even closer under the sheets, brushing their cheeks together.

"You're holding out on me, wifey."

There wasn't time to react before Catra's face turned towards her, capturing Adora's lips in an instant. She could sense Catra's heartbeat as they moved against each other; she deepened the kiss, the bridge of energy between them growing. She couldn't believe it, that every kiss they had shared in the past week had been as wives. The renewal of their engagement had been short, only reconciling for a few months before they'd decided not to wait any longer. Adora's colleagues had joked about how fast it was, that they'd get whiplash from the back and forth if they decided to postpone again, but Adora felt like she'd waited forever for this moment. Afterall, she had, hadn't she?

How crazy is it, that we finally ended up here after all these years?

"You're thinking so loud I can practically hear it."

Catra's gentle tease tickled her. She remembered how she'd insisted over and over again she didn't want to do the whole father-daughter dance thing, given Catra would have no-one to participate with. She should have known that Catra's easy acquiescence wasn't evidence of the new approach she'd been taking to communication; she had no right to be surprised when her father had guided her to the middle of the room, the realisation of what was happening only dawning on her when she saw Catra perched on a stool with her guitar positioned on her thigh, a satisfied quirk of her eyebrow daring her to try getting out of it. So Adora had gladly given in to being held by her father as they danced, grateful when she saw her mother had stood by

Catra's side until the song was over, her hand placed comfortingly on the shiny, ridged skin that had caught everyone's attention.

It had transpired that Glimmer had been in on it too, reaching out to Adora's parents when Catra was too nervous to do it, helping the three of them to reconcile – though Adora knew her parents had been relieved that she and Catra had reunited, and were hardly judging of Catra in the first place. During her time back home, her mother had frequently reminded Adora that despite her job, she couldn't really understand why Catra might have behaved the way she had, how the hormones of pregnancy and the sudden lack of a child she'd been conditioned by nature to nurture could have affected her. It was a fair point – that they'd done the whole thing outside of typical frameworks, and there was no number of written contracts that could properly account for unexpected emotions – but Adora bristled at how she'd been excluded from her own pain, how easily her mother empathised with her ex purely on the basis that they had both experienced pregnancy and Adora hadn't. To her great frustration, it didn't seem to matter how many times Adora explained that her decision to leave Catra wasn't really to do with the surrogacy and its aftermath at all, or even how Catra had met with Prime. Her mother had only seen Adora's exasperation at Catra's inability to share as an excuse, a cover-up for not wanting to do the work that healing trauma required. Her father – who'd always been softer, less composed - had been kinder, more similarly accustomed to being a witness to emotional destruction than at the centre of it himself. He had always defended the choices Adora made and never fully divulged his true thoughts on the situation. But Adora was thankful now that her mother had been so protective of Catra, even if her new wife had never even known it. When she found out that Glimmer had brought Adora's mother to Catra's final bridal fitting, and the two of them had embraced for the first time since Micah's birth, Adora was overcome with relief that Catra's quiet fear of her parents' rejection had been laid to rest in time for their wedding. It had been so desperately needed, and when Glimmer had squeezed her forearm and let slip that she'd only wanted to help Catra accept the family she knew she'd craved, Adora didn't know

what to make of all the overt sentimentality that had come from the three women she'd expected it least from.

Adora slid her foot along the curve of Catra's calf, her mind finally clearing of all thoughts as she peppered kisses along her wife's jaw, the quick hardening of brown nipples against her pale skin made obvious when she pulled the two of them closer together. She brought a hand down, rolling the firm nub between her thumb and forefinger until a soft moan seeped into her ear, only then moving down to draw it into her mouth as her hand moved to her wife's other breast. Catra's ribs rose under Adora's chin as she arched her back, her thighs clamping tighter around Adora's leg. They moved against each other in near silence, their heavy breaths the only noise to puncture air. Adora had come to love the changed surface of Catra's breasts, how her fingers glided over thin, barely-there hollows of forgotten stretch marks, their past firmness gone. She moved further south, pushing her wife's hips flat against the mattress as she pressed her lips to trembling muscles, and took Catra into her mouth, not bothering to waste a second. Catra had never been much of a fan of teasing, not once she was already worked up. It took even less time than usual for the tell-tale twitch of Catra's left hip to jump; Adora sat up, ignoring her whimpered cries of outrage to fish an ice-cube out of the wine bucket by the bed, swallowing droplets of water as she sucked on it quickly.

"Adora, what the fuck are you doing? I'm going to have to divorce you if you don't-"

"Shh..."

Adora smirked, settling herself back into position, an accidental drop of ice water from Adora's lips eliciting a groan.

"Still want a divorce?"

"Shut up, Adora," Catra's voice was strangled, her fingers now tangled in Adora's hair, "It's still on the cards..."

Adora silenced her wife with two icy fingers, the warmth of Catra around her even more gratifying in its contrast; she could tell Catra was clenching every muscle, holding her breath as Adora moved inside her.

"Breathe, you'll get a headache."

Catra gasped for air on command, almost like she'd broken through water; Adora continued her efforts, the shock of her cold lips and tongue finally making contact with her wife's clit and triggering the beginnings of her climax. Adora withdrew slowly when the continuous tightening around her fingers started to ease, kneading Catra's hip as she returned to her place beside her on the bed, nuzzling into the side of her neck.

"You've never done that before..." Catra's breath was short, her hand coming up to rest on Adora's forearm, "Fuck. Ice. Who knew?"

"I spent a year in my parents' house without any of our toys. I had to use some initiative..."

"Mmm. Well, I'll have to hope you crack that one out again soon."

"If you want something, you only have to ask."

"That's all, huh?"

She smiled at Adora knowingly; Catra had been trying to express herself more openly when it came to her desires, but after struggling to find a sense of control and stability in her relationships for so long, it wasn't so easy just to say what she wanted out loud without fearing negative consequences. It was the total opposite to how Catra behaved at work – decisive, commanding, definitive.

"Yeah. That's all. It would be a lot easier for both of us, love."

Adora hoped she'd take it to heart – if she'd spent the past twenty-five years trying to figure out what would make Catra

happy, she wanted to spend the rest of their lives knowing and giving it to her, no mind games involved.

"I've already got what I wanted anyway, 'Dor."

"Oh yeah?" Adora propped herself up on one elbow, watching a slow smirk spread across Catra's face, "What's that?"

"You."

Adora snorted, rolling her eyes.

"Hey! I'm being totally serious!"

She chuckled, lowering herself down to peck Catra's lips.

"I don't doubt it, Cat."

"You shouldn't."

"Okay. But seriously – if you want something..."

"I know, I know. I'll ask you. Promise."

"Good."

It was a near unprecedented thought, but Adora realised she genuinely believed her wife. The therapy she'd undertaken for nearly a year and a half was doing Catra a world of good, and at this point, Adora had to believe that she really could stick to her promise; that when it mattered, Catra would want as much for herself in their marriage as she wanted to give to Adora. She took Catra's hand in hers, studying the simple gold band on her ring finger as she thought about how all their separations never stood a chance against the inevitable.

We actually got here. You're really mine.

"Yeah, 'Dor," Adora met Catra's eyes in surprise, not noticing she'd said it out loud, "I really am."

Chapter End Notes

I hope you liked this chapter :) If it wasn't obvious, fluff is not my natural forte, so I really struggled to write this chapter... Onwards and upwards now!

Chapter 27

FOUR YEARS AFTER

Catra wasn't quite sure where she was anymore, but it felt like the air was rippling in waves against her skin. She strained to open her eyes, to get a sense of what was happening to her, but it was no good. She barely had the energy to glimpse through her eyelashes.

There was some kind of commotion going on that she couldn't quite place – a shifting warmth and the power of a yell seeped into her spine and around the back of her neck. But the hum of it didn't match up with the shrill mewling that drilled into her and had stirred her awake, if only she could get a grip on her bearings. The blurriness was sickening, her brain unable to grasp onto anything that could make itself clear to her; she felt entirely helpless.

Catra could have sobbed as she thought about how, if Adora was there, she'd be able to snap her out of this – she'd make sure that Catra knew what was going on and that she was safe. The haziness simmering around her was close enough to taste and Catra wondered whether if she gave into it, the delirium that Adora was with her might feel real. She could almost believe that it was – how likely could it be that the faint tapping on her cheek and the hand squeezing her fist could be her wife? But as much as Catra tried to dive into the fantasy, she could tell the fingers clamped around hers weren't long and slim enough; they trembled in a way that Adora's never did, and the flat band of metal pressing against her knuckle was too wide and unfamiliar to be her wife's ring.

She gave up on the pretence, letting her mind fill with memories of Adora instead. She could imagine her stripping off in the kitchen, shoving her stained surgical scrubs straight into the

washing machine before snuggling into Catra's side on the sofa in just her vest and underwear. She remembered how flushed Adora always looked when she came back from one of her pre-work runs, her hoodie tied sloppily around her waist because she never listened when Catra told her to leave it at home, even though it was getting hot earlier in the mornings this summer. But most of all, Catra visualised the Adora she'd known years ago, when they were still so new to exploring each other and their initially urgent kisses had become strangely shy. Every nervous touch had made Catra shiver with anticipation in the beginning, the enormity of what was growing between them almost scaring her.

Catra could feel herself drooping, the task of holding herself up becoming increasingly arduous. It was futile pretending otherwise now – the vividity of her daydreams alone was a sure sign that she had become much too weak. She usually could fend off fantasies of Adora like this, suppressing her longing so that she could focus on the tasks ahead of her in the office. It was one of the few secrets she still kept solely to herself, that no-one else in the world knew about; if anyone knew how sentimental she'd become, she'd never hear the end of it.

She wished she was home in bed instead of being trapped in this fuzzy no-man's land she didn't recognise. It was easy enough, convincing herself she could go back in time, to that very morning when she'd woken in the early hours with a painful bladder after too few hours of sleep. She'd needed the bathroom badly, but it was hard to move. Adora's hand had been splayed across her hip, grazing the sore, stinging stretchmarks at the edge of her belly. She'd felt guilty for a short moment. The many difficulties of this pregnancy – from the near constant nausea and fatigue, to her itching skin and the baby's never-ending somersaults – had drained her of all empathy for months. She'd lashed out at Adora yet again the night before, bemoaning that they'd been stupid to convince one another she could do this. Her wife should have predicted it would be so much harder the second time, given all the training and experience she had. Catra had been furious – how could she have failed so miserably to warn her? Of course, Adora had taken it in her stride for the millionth time, so far

removed from the resentment that had forced itself between them during Catra's first pregnancy. Yet again, Adora had agreed how shit it had been and how unfair it was that Catra had gotten so much bigger and heavier than before. But she always chased her apologies with an enthusiastic reminder of how worthwhile it would feel when it was finally over. Catra could practically hear Adora's whisper in her ear now: *Remember how amazing you were? How incredible it was when you created parents and a son – a whole family – the first time?*

Catra knew that Adora had also swallowed complaints about her strenuous hours standing in theatre, wary of playing pain Olympics – and Lord knows that Catra never missed an opportunity to do that these days. Still, Catra had figured out that when she'd performed lengthier surgeries, Adora would flatten her palm against her growing abdomen instead of tracing lazy circles on Catra's bump with her steady fingertips. Her response was similarly wordless every time, quietly massaging her wife's hands while Adora nodded off to sleep, relieved to have a welcome distraction from the never-ending hurricane in her womb that kept her woefully awake.

Catra could tell she was drifting into sleep herself now; a long-lost tranquillity had fallen on her.

Why isn't the baby keeping me up now?

Catra's heartbeat spiked as her thoughts suddenly redirected to the child, who she'd struggled to carry for so many months.

How could I have forgotten her so easily, after all this time?

Despair crashed over Catra as her worst fears came to fruition right in front of her – she should have known that she'd been right for all those years, that she was never fit to do this, and she shouldn't have been trusted again with such a significant task. Adora would never have forgotten if she had managed to conceive; she'd have always put the baby first and never drifted from her presence.

She'd be so disappointed in me if she found out. She'd know instantly this whole thing was a mistake, and I was never good enough to take us down this path...

Catra's panic rose as she failed to ground herself. She'd developed a disturbing sense that these long hours of disorientation might only be as short as quick seconds; her sudden certainty that she must be stuck in a distorted continuum of time was galling. Catra knew for definite now that something was terribly wrong; it wasn't like her to have lost her handle on things to this extent. She needed Adora to know that whatever was happening – for whatever reason the life boiling fitfully in her stomach had dropped to a slow, painful simmer – that it wasn't because she didn't care or hadn't loved enough. It must have only been a moment that she'd dropped the ball, and despite all her grumbles, Adora *had* to believe that Catra's heart really had grown with each passing day she'd nurtured the child inside her and kept her safe. Catra had to make sure Adora believed it.

"Tell Adora..."

She yelled it as loud as she could, but the words crumbled like sand in her mouth, mealy and stale. Catra tried again.

"Tell Adora I lo..."

Tell her I love our daughter, even if I failed.

It was futile – the air closed in on her again and Catra felt an overwhelming breathlessness, as if all the oxygen in the world was dissipating right in front of her. She floated somewhere between the clouds and the carpet, her breathing so shallow it was almost still, every fibre of her detaching from the clammy cotton of her crumpled dress and the oozing wetness she could feel encroaching upon the backs of her thighs.

Catra realised then that the blood she recalled seeing hours before – or maybe it was only minutes, it was too hard to tell – had never been an illusion or a figment of her imagination. It was

real and growing in volume, pooling under her. Her insides quirked as a fleeting thought occurred.

Is this the closest I'll ever get to my mother, forced into her shoes?

A gentle weight settled on her leg, gripping her kneecap. Who was to say it wasn't some ghostly manifestation, that her mother hadn't come to greet her in a twisted echo of their first earthly encounter? She had spent a lifetime waiting for this touch, wondering if it were even possible. But now that Catra could feel the hand of history repeating itself, she wasn't convinced it was a fair trade. Was she foolish for convincing herself that she'd paid out all her allotted misery already, for believing that the universe owed her joy? She could have screamed out pure anger if it weren't for the sandpaper in her throat – surely it was her turn for things to go right, just like they always did for everyone else?

Catra reached out for the shadow on her knee, only just noticing that her other hand still dangled between her legs, her fingertips skimming a thick, silky rope. She'd barely had time to acknowledge it before she was hit again out of nowhere, a too-familiar pain spreading intently until there was no part of her left untouched. A blinding, unstoppable urgency was forcing its way out of her, her whole body cleaving on instinct to let it happen.

A burning rush of slippery movement surged past the pads of her fingers and Catra wondered how it was possible to experience such bewildering déjà vu. She wanted to cry, begging for someone – anyone – to let her know whether she was going completely mad. But she could sense a renewed hum of energy exploding in the space around her, and Catra was far too exhausted to witness or overcome it. She ignored the frenzy, the idea of it all trickling away too sweet not to pursue. She could hear a voice, words she'd wished for so long to hear.

Cantara, habibti. I've got you.

Her mother's words surrounded her, guiding her away soothingly from the ache that pulsed through her. Familiar curls tickled her cheek and hazel eyes reflected her own, conveying a fierce and unconditional love that was equally recognisable and unknown. Catra reached out, her breath catching in anticipation. She could see now how simple it could be, how easily she could fall into the deep embrace she'd always craved.

You have me, finally.

Calm fell on her like never before. Catra let herself sink into a slow bed of quiet, her mind emptying of all thoughts as the constant throbbing in her chest – the ache that had held her ransom for as long as she could remember – finally ceased.

Glimmer would never forget the worried looks on her colleagues' faces when they told her that her mobile had been ringing off the hook since she accidentally left it on her desk.

She'd been close to losing her shit when the team assistant knocked on the door of the meeting room in which she'd been presenting a new campaign strategy to her most important (and difficult) clients. It had taken her weeks to get this pitch scheduled in with everyone who needed to be there, and she'd moved mountains to make sure it would happen, even though it had to run across the time she'd usually pick Micah up from school. The last thing she needed was some minor request from her boss interrupting it. Still, Glimmer had swallowed her frustration with a tight smile and excused herself, delegating the final slides of the PowerPoint to her colleague until she returned.

She could have screamed when she stepped out of the room and was informed that Micah's school had rung the front desk – Bow had never gone to collect him from after-school club as planned,

and the kid had spent the past hour waiting on his own with the school staff. She couldn't decide whether she was more pissed off or worried, but when she got back to her desk to retrieve her mobile, the sheer number of missed calls and messages flooded Glimmer with dread. Glimmer couldn't quite work out what had happened in the garbled voicemails Bow had left her – but she could tell something was very wrong. She tried ringing Bow back, but his phone must have been turned off or drained of battery because it went straight to voicemail. There was no way she was returning to finish her pitch.

"Tell them it's an emergency," Glimmer barely recognised the solemn tone of her own voice, "and give them my apologies."

A tense quiet had cast itself over the area where she and her colleagues sat; she shook her head when her boss asked her if everything was okay, her arms feeling like they were moving in slow-motion as she gathered her things to go.

"I don't know. I have to... I need to go and get my son. I'll email you later."

Glimmer wandered out of her office in a daze, squeezing herself into a too-packed train even though she knew the heat of it would make her light-headed and dizzy. She needed to get to Micah as quickly as she could; it was the only thing she could focus on that would stop her from going into panic mode.

It was clear when she got to Micah that he'd been crying for a while; his eyes were tired and red-rimmed, and he sniffled as the teaching assistant who'd been waiting with him rubbed his back soothingly. She ran over to them, squatting in front of the four-year-old with her arms wide open so he could shuffle into the space between her legs. She held him close to her chest, her fingers kneading the base of his scalp.

"Daddy *forgotted* me."

Glimmer's stomach sunk as she remembered how excited Micah had been for his and Bow's special 'big boy night' – the two hadn't had much one-on-one time since her husband's most recent promotion, and it had only served to compound Micah's disappointment that Catra no longer had the energy to look after him as much as she used to, especially if Adora was on shift. It was true that the past six months had shrunk Micah's home life somewhat, the exhilaration of making new friends in his first year at school marred by his frustration that he only really saw Glimmer in the weekdays now. They'd been lucky if Bow got home in time for Micah's bedtime over the past few weeks, let alone for after-school fun, and Glimmer knew how much their son craved Bow's presence.

"Oh, darling. He didn't, I promise. He's probably just-"

"We was meant to have pizza dinner!"

"I know, Micah. We can still have pizza though – I even have some yummy sweetcorn at home for you to put on it!"

Micah sniffled, slightly appeased by the idea of his favourite vegetable.

They got ready to leave when Micah's tears finally dried up, and Glimmer apologised profusely to the school staff. She knew it must have happened to a lot of parents at some point, but she wasn't sure she'd ever been more mortified.

What must they think of us? He's only four!

The short walk home seemed to take even longer than usual, Micah dragging his feet despite Glimmer's repeated attempts to get him to speed up. When they finally reached the house, Glimmer saw Bow's car parked in its usual spot on the street.

Strange. Why would he be home and not have picked Micah up?

Her son had an entirely different response.

“Daddy’s home for big boy night!”

Glimmer winced at how optimistic Micah sounded – she was sure that it wasn’t a good sign, and that Bow may not be in the best mood for re-watching Micah’s favourite television shows. She opened the front door tentatively and called out to warn Bow they were home.

“Bow? We’re back from school!”

Micah tugged on her coat as he balanced on one leg to rip his shoes off on the doorstep – since they moved to this bigger property the previous year, he’d insisted on copying Catra and Adora’s no shoe policy and had developed an infuriating habit of taking his shoes off before they even got inside. She barely had time to stop Micah from running down the hallway ahead of her, his school bag and coat held in her hand.

“Micah! Wait...!“

She threw his stuff on the floor and shook her pumps off, eager to figure out what was going on with Bow before Micah fell headfirst into something he was too young to understand. Glimmer hoped it wasn’t as bad as the worst-case scenario in her head, that Bow had maybe just misunderstood their arrangement, and maybe they would find him covered in flour, rolling out the dough she’d made with Micah the evening before and let prove slowly overnight in the fridge.

“Daddy?”

Glimmer could already hear the trepidation in Micah’s voice. She hadn’t heard him sound so nervous before, especially not around Bow. She rushed to follow him into the living room and was immediately met by Micah wrapping himself around her leg, his face burying into her hip. Glimmer looked ahead towards the sofa, shocked to see Bow completely zoned out, bloodied handprints staining his brown skin and crisp white shirt. There were bigger blots of red on his trouser legs too, but Glimmer was more

worried by how his eyes seemed to have glazed over in shock, betraying that he was trying to process some traumatic event she knew nothing about.

She kneeled down cautiously and eased Micah's face away from her body so she could see him better.

"Micah, darling, why don't we get Mummy's iPad for you and you can watch some Peppa in your bedroom for a treat?"

"Why is Daddy got red on him?"

Glimmer gulped, unsure of how to respond. She decided to press ahead, to try distracting him again.

"How about we have breakfast for dinner *and* watch Peppa Pig in your bedroom?"

"Bedroom breakfast?"

Micah seemed to cheer up a little at that – since the sole time Catra and Adora had let him eat breakfast in bed when they offered to keep him overnight a couple of months ago, he'd been nagging Glimmer to let him have food in his bedroom for weeks. She'd been pretty pissed at the two of them because of it, though the misstep was playing in her favour now.

"Yes! Go and pick some pyjamas from your drawer and I'll be there in a minute, okay?"

"Is Daddy coming?"

"Maybe, darling. Go on!"

She gave him a quick squeeze, feeling the flutter of his eyelashes on her skin as she kissed his cheeks. Glimmer waited until he ran to his bedroom before approaching Bow, settling carefully on the sofa next to him. She spoke lowly, repeating his name until he jerked back into himself, his body jumping in surprise.

“Bow, what’s wrong?”

Glimmer couldn’t stop the tremble in her speech; she realised suddenly how scared she was.

“Catra, she... I...”

Bow’s voice cracked, his words breaking off. Glimmer furrowed her brow, her eyes fixating on the dark red stains on his clothes. She hadn’t had any missed calls from Adora, but she knew Catra wasn’t super close to her due-date – wasn’t she still working this week? Glimmer’s breath stalled as she remembered that Bow usually saw Catra every other Thursday; they’d switched their old beer meetups to working lunches since they’d settled into their respective realities of pregnancy, marriage and parenting.

“What’s happened, love? Is she okay? Did something happen with the baby?”

“I was only there for forty minutes, but it was all so quick... Adora said... She told me...”

He dissolved into tears then, more incapable of speaking than she’d ever seen before. A hard, sore lump had stuck itself in the space her tonsils used to be. Glimmer was willing herself not to jump to conclusions, but it was hard to stay positive seeing the state of him. She cleared her throat, drawing her shoulders back. She placed a hand firmly on his thigh, careful to avoid the still-drying blood.

“You’ll feel better once we get you out of these.”

Glimmer stood, easing him up with her gently, her hand holding his tightly as she led them to the bathroom and set up the tub. She left him briefly to undress as she went to check on Micah, helping him to change into his pyjamas and put his TV show on the iPad, promising she’d be back with dinner soon. When she returned, Bow was still stood dumbly in the same spot that she’d left him, not even a button undone. Glimmer did it for him, throwing the shirt and trousers into a corner of the room to be

binned, suspecting there was little she could do to get the stains out fully. She got her naked husband into the bath, his quiet tears dribbling into the steep water as he sunk deeper into it. Glimmer ignored how the water splashed a little over the side and wet the floor as he moved – she sat right by him on the puddled tiles despite her work clothes, squeezing a soapy sponge over his shoulders as if she was bathing their son.

"Please tell me what happened, Bow. I'm worried."

He finally made eye contact with her then.

"She went into labour, but it was really fast. She bled... she bled way too much. It was only the two of us, the ambulance didn't get there until after. And then Adora came... Fuck, Adora had to..."

He squeezed his eyes shut again, seemingly trying to block out the memory of it. Glimmer still couldn't stop a gasp from escaping her lips.

"She gave birth already? But she's okay now, yeah? The baby's alright?"

"I should have known what to do. I could have helped them more – I knew what happened to her mum, I could have read up on it, just in case. But I didn't think... I didn't think it could happen like that. God, I had the office cleared, it was my fault we were alone-"

"Shh, it's okay. You couldn't have known." Glimmer stroked the sponge in circle movements on his chest. "I'm sure you did your best. I know you did."

Bow opened his eyes again to look at her, his expression fearful.

"What if she started bleeding again, Glim? Adora made me go home to get changed after they stopped it. I mean, there wasn't any more room in the ambulance... I should have followed them to the hospital, but I got here and I couldn't move."

“Don’t worry, Bow. We’ll get the sitter to come over, we’ll go-”

“I let them all down, Glim. How will they ever forgive me?”

Glimmer watched the anguish spread even further on his face, his hands pressing into his eye sockets as if he could blind himself from the memories if he pushed on them hard enough. She pulled his hands away, holding them between hers, determined not to let her desperation for him to fill in the gaps to get in the way of giving him the care he so deeply needed in the moment. She couldn’t push him further right now – she knew that.

Her mind drifted to her son; he needed to eat, and he’d be inconsolable when he found out he’d be spending the night with a sitter instead of his parents. She stood and leaned down to kiss Bow softly, cradling his face in her hand for longer than she usually did.

“Just try and relax, love. I’ll sort everything out and we can leave.”

Glimmer felt like a zombie as she went through the motions, almost crying in relief when their sitter agreed to come over last minute at double her usual rate. She stayed in her damp skirt and moved swiftly to make Micah a quick dinner, spooning sweetcorn onto a plate alongside toast soldiers and scrambled egg, hoping the raisins and chocolate yoghurt she’d set aside for dessert would pacify him for the night. Her mind reeled from Bow’s partial revelations as she crept into Micah’s room, hugging him in her lap and helping him to eat like she’d done when he was much younger, even though she knew she really had to stop babying him every time she needed comfort.

It was hard to come to terms with it, that her baby was already getting so big. They’d tried for a sibling, but none of their remaining embryos had taken successfully. She’d realised it when it was already impossible - she had never wanted Micah to be an only child, not really. Glimmer hoped that Catra and Adora’s baby – she had to hold onto the hope that everything would be fine, despite the absence of any assurances from her husband – would

fill that gap a little. She knew there were plenty of other options available to her and Bow, but it was taking longer than she expected to let go of the disappointment that Micah would be her only biological child.

The doorbell rang, jolting her out of her thoughts in an instant. She'd have to face it now – there was no more time to prepare herself for returning to a maternity ward that would never have purpose for her again, even though she'd lamented how complicated her past experiences had been there during the surrogacy.

Glimmer reminded herself she was more resilient now than she ever thought she'd be. And so was Catra. They could do this. She insisted on it, demanding it from everyone – God, gods, spirits and no-one at all – that they'd all get through this safely. Their greener grass was waiting for them, and Glimmer was adamant they'd find their way to the other side.

Chapter 28

Chapter Notes

> Thanks for being so patient as posting has become less frequent recently - I am delivering a huge project at work and nearing my deadline, so I have significantly less spoons at the minute! Anyway, hope you enjoy the below (wild to think we are getting so close to the end of this fic), and as always, feedback/comments are hugely appreciated!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

THREE YEARS AFTER

Adora pointed at the flashcard on the carpet, a picture of a small plant drawn on it. She flipped it over, showing the toddler besides her the image of a tree on the other side.

"What happened, Micah?"

"Tree growed!"

"That's it, well done! The tree *grew*."

"I grewed in Catra."

"Yes, you did. In Catra's tummy, right?"

Micah nodded enthusiastically, pushing himself upright from his squat next to Adora.

"I three now."

"You're *nearly* three. We'll have a party next month for your birthday."

"Catra come?"

“Of course! We’ll both be there for you, little man.”

Micah beamed at her, his attention turning back to the flashcards on the floor. Adora carried on testing him with the flashcards, conscious that Glimmer was taking longer than expected. She glanced at the time on her phone as they continued, realising her mistake when Micah got distracted and wanted to look at the screen instead. Adora pulled up Spotify to divert his attention, found a song she knew Micah would happily listen to on repeat, and locked the screen. She’d made the error of letting him play on it before, losing half the apps on her home screen by accident. Luckily, he’d started bobbing along to the music, swaying his head and jumping around the room. It only took a few rounds of solo musical statues for him to begin to tire, compounding the fact that it was already past his usual nap time. Adora was starting to strategize how best to get him down for a rest without disturbing Glimmer when she saw her friend appear in the doorway of the bedroom. Micah ran over to her immediately, his hand tugging on the terry cotton belt of her dressing gown.

“Mummy!”

“It’s time for your nap, love.”

She nudged him closer to his bed as Adora shut the music off and gathered up the flashcards. Adora could see Glimmer trying to hide her discomfort from her son, stifling a groan as she crouched over the bed to settle him.

Micah yawned as he lay down, still clutching at the fabric tied around her waist.

“I tired.”

“I know, darling. But you’ve been having lots of fun with Auntie Adora, huh?”

“Played with Dora...”

“Mmhmm.” Adora didn’t miss Glimmer’s split-second grimace as Micah moved his hand, unwittingly pressing a little on his mother’s abdomen. His eyelids were heavy, his head drooping on his pillow, “Alright, sleepy-head. We’ll leave you to it.”

She moved his hand gently away from her dressing gown, smoothing her palm over his cheek before beckoning Adora out of the room with her, closing his bedroom door behind them.

“You alright?”

Adora could see Glimmer’s façade slipping as they made their way to the living room sofa, her pained exhaustion visibly seeping out.

“Yeah, it’s just annoying. This is like the fourth one in ten weeks.”

Adora squeezed Glimmer’s arm, passing her the purple water bottle left on the cushions.

“Just keep drinking. We’ll get to the bottom of it.”

“Ugh I hope so.” She gulped water, her face crumpling as she screwed the lid back on, “Fuck, I have to go again.”

It was the second time Adora had come over to help Glimmer with Micah since she started getting recurrent bladder infections. In the past, she’d only had the odd one here and there, but they had become increasingly regular over recent months, to the extent that she had to bring her laptop back most nights in case she needed to work from home the next day. Glimmer’s mood had slumped a little as a result – not only was being sick interfering with her career again, but she didn’t have the same level of energy to give to Micah.

Adora wandered to the bathroom after six minutes or so, having topped up the water bottle for her. She knocked on the door, perching on Micah’s plastic stool by the sink once she let herself inside. Glimmer stayed on the toilet, nodding in gratitude as she held her hand out for the water.

“This fucking sucks, ‘Dor.”

“I know, Glim.”

They chatted for a while about Glimmer’s next treatment plan, Adora listening to the guidance Glimmer relayed from her current specialist and offering her own advice.

“Thanks for coming over to keep an eye on him so I could sit in the bath. I know it was short notice but I didn’t want Bow to miss his catch up with Catra, especially not after the work week he had.”

“De nada.”

Glimmer smiled to herself for a second, “Remember how much I used to hate it when they hung out?”

“Yeah,” Adora grinned back, “God, you were a bitch about it.”

“Shut up!” Adora was glad to get a laugh out of her friend, “I suppose she turned out okay in the end...”

Adora’s thoughts drifted to her new wife. They’d been lucky Glimmer hadn’t had a flare-up a couple of weeks ago on their wedding day – that would have been shit for everyone.

“Micah’s talking a lot about Catra at the minute. Not that he doesn’t usually, but...”

“Yeah, he’s a little stuck on her at the minute. I think it’s just nursery – younger siblings are being born, so they’re doing stuff about families and some of the kids babble on about the baby in mummy’s tummy, and all that. Obviously, he knows Catra carried him, so he’s probably just a bit confused. He’s asked a few times whether there’s a baby in her tummy too.”

“You feel alright about it?”

Glimmer shrugged, "Just trying not to get too wound up. I can't exactly get pregnant myself, so it was bound to happen. We knew things like this would crop up eventually."

"I guess."

"Are *you* okay?"

Adora squinted at Glimmer, her head tilting towards her shoulder curiously, "Yeah, why?"

"Come on, 'Dor. Bow and I know that the whole thing wasn't..." Glimmer searched for the right word, "*great* for you. You don't have to keep pretending all the time."

Adora bit her lip, a little disappointed in herself that she hadn't maintained a happy front as well as she'd thought she had during the surrogacy.

"Oh. It's ancient history. Really."

"*Adora*... You can be honest. It's me."

Glimmer had the same talent that Catra did for weeding through half-truths – given her friend's tone, Adora knew there was no point holding anything back. She sighed, picking her words carefully.

"It's hard sometimes. But I accepted a long time ago that she doesn't want the same thing, and I don't regret anything. She's *it*, you know?" Adora paused, pulling at the skin around her nailbeds. "It's just funny, how close the two of them are. She doesn't think of herself as the type, but she's so brilliant with Micah. I catch myself now and again, thinking that she'd love having a kid if she changed her mind." Adora stopped for a second, hesitant to continue, "D'you think it's possible to mourn what you don't have and still be happy with what you've got? Genuinely?"

Glimmer hummed, bringing the bottle to her lips.

"I dunno, 'Dor. I love Micah more than anything, but I can't help wishing we had another one."

"Are you going to try for a second?"

"I want to. But we've only got a couple of embryos left, and it'd be a miracle if it worked the first time again. It'll take time to find the right surrogate too." Glimmer frowned, wincing from her position on the toilet. "Anyway, I can't look after a newborn without getting this cystitis sorted."

They settled into a comfortable silence together, their years of friendship holding them in the space. Their grown-up domesticity was a far cry from the clubs and late-night movie sessions of their university lives; neither of them would have predicted their paths would intertwine so intimately, even though their friendship in halls had formed hard and fast. But Adora knew, regardless of whatever happened in the years ahead, that her friendship with Glimmer was just as significant as her love for Catra. They'd held each other through countless highs and lows and survived the messiest of conflicts. Aside from her wife, Glimmer was the person who had taught Adora to recognise different ways of feeling and expressing love: adoration of her closest friends; protectiveness over their son; devotion to the career that saw her help other women.

Adora had come to appreciate Catra's past offer to carry Bow and Glimmer's child more in recent months than she had at the time. She'd worried then that it was an unnecessary sacrifice, that the threat it posed to their interpersonal dynamics was too severe. To some extent, her gut instinct had been right. But in the time since she and Catra had resumed their engagement – and partly due to the year in which Bow and Glimmer had sustained Catra at her lowest – it had slowly dawned on her. In contrast to what she'd feared, Adora's capacity for compromise and her ability to love had grown rather than shrunk. The unorthodox support unit they'd formed didn't only exist to form a defensive scaffolding around the child they'd each played a part in bringing to life. Instead, they'd built a fortress that kept their group of five safe

and content, and there was ample room for all of them to be vulnerable, to seek care and to grow.

Adora stood back to admire her handiwork, blowing hair out of her eyes as she surveyed the row of boxes in front of her. They'd decided to do this when they got back together, agreeing they needed a fresh start. Now they'd been married for nearly six weeks, it was finally happening. Everything had fallen into place.

It had come as a surprise to Adora when Catra suggested they look for a new apartment so quickly. She'd been so happy to be back in their shared home, it hadn't occurred to her that maybe they were outgrowing it. But while they looked for somewhere new, Catra complained increasingly about how they couldn't seat more than three or four at their small kitchen table, and they didn't have anywhere for guests to stay apart from the narrow futon in her office. It had never been a problem before, but since Catra had become more visible in her industry – not only was she one of a sparse handful of female CEOs, but her and Entrapta's company had won a plethora of awards – her network had gotten decidedly larger. Sometimes Adora would get home from a late shift to find Lonnie or one of Catra's tech friends passed out in the home office, empty bottles left on the living room coffee table. She'd shake her head in amusement as she burrowed under the sheets beside her drunk wife, knowing she'd be able to tell if Catra had gone for beer or wine by whether the cat had been let into their bed for the night. It was almost always wine these days – she practically expected the wrap of Melog's silky tail around her ankle. It didn't bother her much, though she wouldn't have guessed sleepovers would become a feature of their early thirties. Adora had coached herself to embrace all the changes in Catra's behaviour that came with her progress in therapy; and it was easy to see the direct link between her wife's growing ability to open up to others and the widening of their social circle.

Catra had found their new terrace house the day after it came on the market. She'd called Adora from the viewing, gushing about it in a way she wasn't used to hearing; Catra had asked her when she'd be free for a second visit with the estate agent, but in all honesty, Adora didn't feel that strongly about where they lived as long as there was somewhere secure to keep her bike and the commute wouldn't be too long. Seeing Catra get so excited about their future in a new home – that was the real win. When she insisted on at least video calling Adora from the house before she put in an offer, Adora couldn't help but agree that it really did seem like a good property for them, not least because the master bathroom had one of the biggest tubs Adora had ever seen in a Bright Moon red-brick. She'd started fantasising about sinking into scented water with Catra on lazy Sunday mornings before they'd even gotten halfway through the makeshift tour. They were only one week away from moving in now, and Adora could already smell the eucalyptus bath oil.

The two of them had made a plan for packing up the flat, starting with the home office and leaving the kitchen until the very end. But despite agreeing to start the next day – Catra was speaking on a feminism in tech panel at some women's magazine event that evening – Adora couldn't sit still, the flatpack boxes taunting her from the hallway. She'd gotten started right after work, music blaring as she packed up books and wrapped Catra's Judaica and ornaments in bubble wrap. There was only one cupboard left to tackle now she'd cleared the room of everything except its furniture. Adora started at the top, wondering why they'd always kept their extra blankets and bedding there instead of the ottoman in their bedroom, which only held stuff for the cat. When she got to the bottom shelf, she was surprised to see stacks of folded clothes. She pulled them from the cupboard curiously, catching sight of her old yellow sundress she'd thought had been lost years ago, among numerous oversized t-shirts, maternity jeans and elasticated work slacks. The breast pump Bow had bought Catra was shoved at the very back, barely stuffed into its box.

Why would she keep all this stuff? I thought she got rid of it when Micah was born?

Adora's insides twisted in confusion. Catra rarely did – or didn't do – anything without reason. Her pulse raced a little as she wondered, despite their previous conversations on the subject, if Catra had been open to being Bow and Glimmer's surrogate for a second time all along. Her mind immediately went to a recent interaction they'd had with one of Catra's clients. His newly pregnant girlfriend had overtaken their dinner conversation for most the night, pressing Adora for guidance on how to manage future symptoms. It hadn't taken long for Catra to interject, reassuring the woman that she hadn't minded pregnancy so much and that she should try and enjoy it before it was over. It was an unexpected comment – and undoubtedly intended to steer the agenda back to business – but Adora knew her wife well enough for it to convince her that Catra probably enjoyed being pregnant more than she'd previously let on, despite the tribulations of their arrangement.

The spiral started like it always did. Adora began by trying to suppress her anxieties, shoving them as forcefully as she could to the back of her mind. She pushed herself to start on the bedroom, mindlessly wrapping bin bags around hung clothes in the wardrobe, ready to be lifted away and easily relocated. But Adora should have known it wouldn't be that easy. She found herself drifting back to the office to stare at the small tower of maternity wear, her focus impossible to divert. The panic that Catra might want to put them through the whole thing over again – that maybe she was actually still as secretive as she'd used to be and Adora had been wilfully blinded by her optimistic desire for their future together – was burning a dangerous hole in her brain.

By the time the front door slammed shut and Catra's footsteps echoed down the hallway, Adora knew she had completely lost it.

"Hey, Adora," she jumped out of her thoughts as Catra's arms encircled her waist from behind, a kiss pressed to the side of her neck, "I didn't think we were starting on this until tomorrow?"

"Oh, I thought I might as well get ahead of things."

Catra squeezed her a little before letting go, making her way to the bedroom to get changed.

"I should have known you would." She spoke loudly from the other room, "I really have to stop accepting these magazine things, they're fucking exhausting. I don't know why they always have to bring up the fundraising stuff. They barely even ask about what we're actually doing with the apps."

Adora picked up the bundle of maternity clothes and followed Catra to the bedroom.

"I mean, you did commit the profits of your last app to domestic violence charities. It's pretty relevant to the demographic."

"*I know that*..." Adora didn't miss the aggravation seeping into Catra's voice as she pulled her shirt over her head, too lazy to undo her buttons, "But it would have been a free product otherwise, and it's not like I invented Corporate Social Responsibility. They just want to dig their noses into why I did it."

Catra exhaled in relief as she ripped her bra off, pink welts from its underwire branded on her skin. She flung the wardrobe doors open to hang her trousers up, groaning as she saw Adora had bagged most of their clothes.

"Jesus, 'Dor, we're not even moving until the weekend! What are we supposed to wear?" She finally turned round to face Adora, only then noticing what was in her arms. "What are you doing with those?"

"Why do you still have these, Catra?"

Catra's expression hardened as she walked to the bed and dug behind her pillow for her sleep shorts and top. "I don't know, I probably just forgot to get rid of them."

"You never forget things like that."

Adora stared Catra down, her fists clenching in the fabric as Catra shimmied out of her underwear and pulled her pyjamas on.

“Did you plan on carrying for them again?”

Catra didn’t respond, making heavy work of throwing the rest of her discarded clothes in the laundry hamper.

“We have to talk about this, Cat!”

“Adora, I’m too tired for this conversation.”

“Catra-“

“Can we just order some dinner, please? I can’t be bothered to cook.”

“I’m going crazy here.”

Catra paused then, moving closer to Adora to take the pile of maternity clothes from her and dump them on the bed.

“Don’t worry about things that aren’t problems,” Adora had to stop herself from rolling her eyes in frustration as she followed her into the living room – Catra knew damn well that wasn’t how her anxiety worked, “Let’s just get some food first, yeah?”

Adora grumbled, pulling her phone out of her pocket as she collapsed on the sofa, not bothering to hide her irritation when Catra sunk down next to her, tugging Adora sideways into her lap.

“Come on, you love it when I do this.”

Adora shrugged as Catra loosened her hair tie, working her nails into the base of her skull. They bickered over what to order – Catra seemed to change her mind every two minutes – but eventually put an order through, grateful that they’d finally made a decision and their dinner would arrive shortly. Adora tossed her phone to the rug, glancing apologetically at Melog, who bristled at the disturbance from his place by Catra’s feet.

She twisted in her wife's lap to face her stomach, her fingers slipping under soft material to rest on her navel. Adora tried to imagine another life growing there, and even though she thought she'd moved on from the cocktail of emotions the first surrogacy had roused in her, Adora couldn't deny that she felt an overwhelming wave of dread. She would never regret her choice to stay – she knew wholeheartedly that she could live without motherhood, but she'd never find happiness in a life without Catra. Yet in moments like this, it was hard not to feel the pointed sting of a lost dream. Adora inhaled deeply, studying how the muscles of Catra's abdomen twitched under the pads of her fingertips. They waited for their food in silence while Catra continued to play with Adora's hair, Adora tracing lazy doodles on Catra's stomach.

"I know I said I wouldn't before, but I think... I think I changed my mind."

Is she trying to be this infuriating on purpose?

"Really?" Adora groaned, screwing her eyes shut in exasperation, "They've probably already started making it, but I can see if-"

"No, not the food," Catra withdrew her hand from Adora's hair, resting it atop her wife's on her belly. "The maternity stuff. I want..."

Adora's throat tightened.

Does she really want us to put our lives on hold for their child again?

Silence fell between them and Adora couldn't decide whether it would be better to wish Catra's confession away or confront her desire to do exactly what Adora hoped she wouldn't. Adora figured they had to hash it out sooner rather than later. *Why not now?*

She spoke uneasily. "You want to do it again, Cat?"

“I want us to have our own.”

Adora could hear her heartbeat pounding in her ears as she replayed the sentence in her head.

“*What*?”

“I want-”

“I heard you.”

Catra laughed under her breath a little, almost in disbelief. “I thought saying it out loud would be scarier than that.”

Adora squeezed her hand.

“How long have you been thinking about it?”

Catra caught her eye; Adora could have sworn there was a lightness she hadn’t seen for some time cutting through her wife’s usual look of determination.

“A while.” She sighed deeply, “You ever heard of ghost lives?”

Adora nodded her head slowly, silence taking over them for a few minutes. Catra had slipped into that tell-tale glazed-eyeball zone she knew too well, but she blinked it away faster than normal, her words measured.

“I keep wondering what my life would have been like if it weren’t for Prime. Whether I’d be different without my scars, or if we’d stayed close after uni. I guess I always had this feeling there were these other lives I could have had. Like if I’d had parents, or come out sooner, or... I don’t know. It’s hard to explain, but I can see them all mapped out, like they’re actually happening.”

“That’s a lot to hold, love.”

“Yeah. We’ve been working on it, in my sessions. But I can’t let go of this idea that if things had gone down differently, I could have

wanted a family. Like what Bow and Glimmer have, or all the families we see at synagogue. And since I got that in my mind, these other lives...”

Adora’s throat was tight. “You have kids in them?”

Catra gazed down at Adora, more resolute in her expression. She pushed Adora’s hair out of her face, her thumb gliding over Adora’s cheekbone.

“You deserve everything you’ve ever wanted, ‘Dor. And I... I deserve it too. I know it's taken me ages to get here, but I can’t let him take that from us anymore.”

Adora stared at Catra dumbly, letting her words sink in. She’d suppressed the hope they might have a conversation like this for so long. She almost couldn’t believe it was real.

“Adora?”

The doorbell rang then, snapping them both out of it. Adora left Catra on the sofa, wandering to the front door in a daze. She pressed on the buzzer to let the delivery guy in, leaning her shoulder on the wall as she waited, deep in thought. Adora could sense Catra hovering by the living room entrance, watching her apprehensively. A knock resounded on the other side of the wood, right as an elated warmth finally began to spread throughout her chest.

Is this actually happening? Are we really...?

Adora opened the door, accepting a paper bag of hot containers from the helmet-clad man in front of her. Her words slipped out in astonishment, the realisation suddenly hitting her.

“We’re going to have a kid.”

The courier looked up at Adora in confusion.

“Uh... Congratulations?”

Adora beamed, closing the door once he'd turned to leave. She whirled around, finding Catra right behind her, so close they almost bumped into each other. She couldn't stifle the uncontrollable peal of laughter rising up her throat.

"You still want to?" Catra's face was so full of hope, her nervous anticipation obvious. "You're in?"

"Yes," Adora dropped the takeaway bag as she threw her arms around her wife and kissed her, ignoring the splashing of miso soup jostling in its container, "One hundred percent."

THREE AND A HALF YEARS AFTER

It had been an awkward discussion at first, admitting that in her heart of hearts, adoption wasn't the route she wanted to go down.

"I want us to experience it for ourselves," Adora remembered explaining to Catra, "and see one of us in our child. I can't imagine how amazing it would be, having that."

She'd known before she'd said it that Catra wouldn't be on the same page. She'd seen the NGO reports and press articles about unaccompanied refugee children when looking at screens over Catra's shoulder, and she'd been regularly donating to charities since she'd discovered her own history. It was ironic in some ways – Adora had been the one who'd benefitted from adoption, who had first-hand experience of how much it could transform a child's life. But she hadn't been able to shake her desire to build a family that was biologically tethered to one of them. She'd wanted to feel the genetic sense of belonging that she'd always wondered about, to see if a bond really could be stronger if sealed by blood.

There was a part of her that had felt selfish about it, guilty that she was denying a needy child a home and repeating the cycle that Catra had been through herself. But she'd told herself to be honest – after all, how could she expect her wife to be transparent if she wouldn't, especially when it mattered most – and she'd watched surprise register on Catra's features.

There had been pushback to begin with. Adora knew Catra had spoken at length with Lonnie about how she'd wanted to be part of a solution for the stateless kids she'd read so much about; she'd even questioned Adora's logic, given that she loved and appreciated her parents just as much as (if not more than) anyone else did. But after a few weeks of long, quiet conversations in the kitchen, or under the cosy cover of their bedsheets, Catra had come around to it. She'd understood when Adora murmured that she'd assumed she wouldn't have the chance to carry her own kids when she'd realised that she was gay – same sex parents weren't so common when they were teenagers – and the thought that it actually was in her reach made it impossible to move past. Catra had interlaced their fingers, leaning in to kiss her, and they'd decided: Adora would have the opportunity to go through pregnancy like she had, and they'd select a donor who resembled Catra and could share her heritage with their child.

Adora slumped in bed, inhaling slowly and pushing her stomach out as far as she could. It was far too early to be awake, but once Catra was up and running to the bathroom, Adora always followed, holding her hair back as she retched. Neither of them had expected it to be so severe, especially considering Catra hadn't suffered from much nausea in her first pregnancy. But at only twelve weeks gone, their child was making themselves loudly known. Adora hypothesized almost every day about whether she would have struggled in the same way, whether a foetus made of her cells would have had the same effect.

They'd only been trying for eight months before Adora had called time, disheartened by seven failed inseminations and double the number of heartbreakingly negative tests. Catra hadn't been keen

to change approach so quickly; they had the money to keep going, to try IVF if it came to it and find a good fertility specialist. But even though Adora knew they hadn't been trying to get pregnant for that long, and that it wasn't unusual for it to take years to conceive, she'd begun to notice pangs of jealousy sparking when she was around her patients. So, she'd decided for both of them. She wasn't willing to sacrifice her job – the thing primarily responsible for keeping her sane throughout her rollercoaster years of emotional turbulence – for the sake of the narrow path to motherhood she'd gotten attached to. She'd told Catra they had options; better options than ruining the work she loved.

When Adora had asked Catra about whether she'd ever got round to researching what a route to adoption could look like, she hadn't got the response she'd expected. Catra had reminded her that her motivations for wanting a biological child didn't have to end there – she could carry Adora's egg. She'd done it before, and this time she'd be able to bond with their child without the all-important restraint her pregnancy with Micah had wrought. Adora had taken Catra into her arms and said that she was her real family, and she'd love any child of Catra's as much as one who shared her own genes. So, they'd set a new strategy. They'd find a new sperm donor who matched Adora's physical profile and who had the Scandinavian background of her adoptive parents. Belonging could be something they designed – something unique to their family.

Catra had put forward conditions before the first insemination: if she got pregnant, she didn't want the whole thing to be as medicalised as her surrogacy. She'd look after herself properly, go to scans, let Adora monitor her progress within reason. But she wasn't willing to give birth in the maternity ward and risk losing control of the experience. Adora hadn't fully comprehended before quite how averse Catra was to hospitals. She'd pointed out that the greatest offences Catra objected to would no longer be relevant. She'd not be incorrectly identified as the infant's mother or interrogated by police in the wake of a traumatic event. But Catra wasn't having it, despite Adora's assertion of the risks and

her exclamations that it was absurd to be so distrustful of medical professionals while being married to one. Yet as far as Catra was concerned, she wasn't going to compromise on the autonomy she demanded, and Micah's uncomplicated birth was enough proof that she was no more high-risk than they'd thought the first time. Adora had given up fighting with her over it eventually; how could she say no to the woman who was giving her everything she'd ever wanted? Besides, they both knew Adora would helicopter Catra throughout the entire pregnancy; there was no way she wouldn't spot anything worrying.

Catra had gotten pregnant with the second insemination, faster than either of them expected. All of a sudden, the timeline in their head – which had stretched well over a year, considering how long Adora had tried to conceive – shortened significantly. They'd be parents before they knew it.

Catra emerged from the bathroom tired and grey. She dropped back into bed heavily beside Adora, one eye peeking open to examine her forcefully inflated belly. Catra wriggled closer to her and rested her hand on her own stomach, already noticeably rounded.

"If you're trying to make me feel better about getting fat, it isn't going to work with those abs."

Adora grinned softly in response, her stomach deflating as she expelled air. She closed the gap between them, hugging Catra to her despite the faint air of sour bile that lingered on her breath under mint mouthwash.

"Mmm, just imagining things, that's all."

Catra tucked her head under Adora's jaw, burrowing into her neck.

"You okay? I'm sorry, I know it's unfair that I-"

"God, Catra – don't apologise! I love that you're doing this for us," she snaked a hand between them, the heat of the blood rushing

through Catra's abdomen warming her palm, "I'm just thinking."

Catra pressed a kiss to her shoulder, her fingers moving from her belly to graze the back of Adora's hand.

"I'm all ears, if you want?"

Adora hesitated, pulling the duvet up a little around them.

"It's probably stupid." Catra tutted, waiting for her get to the point without disqualifiers, "I can't help thinking that you're going to know them for so much longer than I will. I won't even meet the baby until they're born. What if they don't recognise me? Or they only feel close to you?"

She felt Catra grip her hand firmly under the sheets, her other palm coming up to cradle Adora's jaw and draw her attention down so their eyes could meet.

"The baby knows you, 'Dor. Of course she's going to love you. You're her mother. Just think about how we wished we had mums when we were little, and how much you love yours now. You didn't even meet her until we were eleven! Besides, remember what you used to tell Glimmer when she was worried about it? Have you ever seen Micah look at anyone the way he looks at her?"

Adora hummed, her insecurities fading just a little.

"I didn't think about it that way. But I guess it's true."

"You should listen to me more often. Haven't you learned by now? I'm rarely wrong."

"Is that so?"

"Yup. You just wait until the ultrasound. I'm telling you, it's a girl."

"There's literally no scientific way to tell that accurately yet."

“Mmm... well, I’m probably right. Aren’t I?” She smoothed her hand over the curve of her belly, as if she were making space in their conversation for a response, “She knows what’s up.”

“More likely, she knows what’s good for her.”

“Same difference.”

Adora smiled, dipping to kiss Catra’s forehead. Her wife had become unusually sage in recent weeks, stepping into her maternal role with an ease that Adora would have been jealous of if she weren’t so thrilled by it.

“I promise you,” Catra’s tone had become serious again, “You’ll be the centre of her world.”

Adora clasped Catra closer, the slight swell of her wife’s stomach bumping against her hip.

“Just think, babe,” Catra spoke with quiet excitement, an increasingly regular occurrence, “This time next year, all being well, she’ll be teething.”

“We’ll have had our two-year anniversary.”

“Nine years, ‘Dor, don’t sell us short.”

“Nine then,” Adora could feel the edges of her lips curling up, “We might have got her on some solids, too.”

“And Micah will be halfway through his second year at school. God, can you believe it?”

“Not really.”

It was true – Adora couldn’t get her head around it, that this future actually awaited them. She was beginning to accept that it would all work out in the end; that after everything, this part would go smoothly. The obstetrician in her would have balked, but Adora grew more certain with each day that passed: she had

Catra, they'd manage her pregnancy on their own terms and, when the time came, they'd welcome their child in the warmth of their own home.

Knock on wood, it'll be exactly the way we want it. The way it's supposed to be.

Chapter End Notes

A note for the next chapter... I would very much recommend re-reading the birth scenes in chapters 24 and 27, and having a look at the ordering of certain events. There is something that has been hinted at / teased which will be explicitly revealed and I'm not sure anyone has picked up on it yet!

Chapter 29

Chapter Notes

> Thanks for your patience - it's been a rough couple of weeks for a wide range of reasons, but I was so happy to find the headspace to write this chapter today! Please feed me with comments... It would be so good to hear your thoughts as I sketch out the final chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

FOUR YEARS AFTER

Even if there hadn't been rush hour traffic, Glimmer was sure this journey would still feel like the longest she'd ever taken. She hated driving Bow's car – it was too big, and she'd never learned to fully get her head around the shift from manual to automatic – but her husband was in no fit state to drive. They stalled at a red light turning amber for the fourth time that evening; the lights always seemed to change just as she took her eyes off them to glance at Bow, and every time the car behind them would honk her into a panic.

She'd turned the air-con up as high as it would go, but it was fairly useless given that they had barely moved for the past hour. Even though it was only mid-June, Bright Moon was in the throes of a heatwave – and the last thing they needed was for one of them to faint. It was nearing seven o'clock, but Glimmer could have sworn that the oppressive heat was visible, her focus zeroing in on shimmering zigzags of hot, stale air above the windscreen wipers. She wriggled uncomfortably in the driver's seat, wishing that she'd changed into trousers instead of a summer dress before they left – despite the anti-chafe gel she'd smeared hurriedly on her skin, sweat itched as it trickled down her back and fused the insides of her thighs together.

Glimmer exhaled a short sigh of relief when they reached their turning to get onto the main road, finally on a direct path to the hospital; she craned her neck as she peered over the steering wheel impatiently, scanning ahead to see if it was worth switching lanes or if there was a shortcut she'd forgotten about. But it was no use – they just had to wait it out. Surrendering to the standstill, Glimmer reached out across the cup-holders and took Bow's hand in hers, interrupting the sharp scrape of his fingernails carving into his knee.

"Bow. Please. Don't hurt yourself."

He paused briefly, his reddened eyes meeting hers before he twisted away to stare out the window again. Glimmer was sure he was crying, his throat gurgling in the silence as he barely managed to stifle a swallowed sob. It wasn't a good sign that Bow was trying to conceal his emotions from her; over the years, Glimmer had come to recognise that he only did it when he was struggling to overcome guilt. She thought back, realising that the last time Bow had behaved quite like this was when he'd fretfully revealed that he'd lost their savings the previous year and was scared that Catra had only offered to be their surrogate because of his financial shortcomings. The memory of how Bow had obsessed over his guilt came flooding back too easily. Long after Glimmer had forgiven him for his omission of the truth, she would catch Bow cradling their son in his arms, a mixed expression of love and shame playing on his features. Deep down, she'd wondered whether he'd excused Catra so easily for breastfeeding Micah because of it. Glimmer remembered how Bow had stared at her and their child from across their old living room that day, his expression clouded with a sombre recognition that Catra had facilitated what he'd have otherwise failed to provide. The rock that had sunk in her stomach every time she saw the guilt in his eyes was heavier than ever now, weighed down further by the lack of clarity Bow had given her about the state Catra and her child had been in when Adora sent him home. It was becoming clearer and clearer as time passed that it would take a long time for him to come to terms with the trauma of witnessing Catra give birth in her office, particularly if he'd internalised his doubtful

claim that he'd mismanaged the situation. She couldn't help but think that it was strange, how his lowest of lows always seemed to involve Catra.

Glimmer squeezed Bow's hand, ignoring the unpleasant stickiness of their humid skin pressed together. She needed to make him feel better almost as much as she desperately needed to know if Catra and the baby were genuinely okay. She watched Bow as they waited for the cars ahead of them to move; his body language was so far removed from the very first time he'd leaned that little bit too close to her. Her chest had tightened then in a way that she hadn't noticed before, and after nearly fifteen years of friendship, Glimmer had suddenly seen him in a new light. She'd touched his arm to stop him from moving away – no different to how they always touched each other, except that unexpectedly, it *was* – and before she knew it, she couldn't stop the thought from consuming her: *I need to know how you feel against me.*

The moment had died when Adora came barging into their student flat, chattering excitedly that her old childhood friend had stuck around for a while after her race, though it had been the one time that no-one else was there to be introduced to her. Glimmer had barely listened, caught halfway between teasing Adora about whether this mystery friend of hers even existed and quashing the urge to scream at her for interrupting the most important thing that might have ever happened to her yet.

Eventually, Adora had left to shower and the two of them were alone once more. Glimmer had started to clear her throat, ready to smooth over the impending awkwardness, but Bow's fingers had tentatively traced her wrist, and he'd leaned in to whisper to her, "Can I...?"

She'd nodded, her pupils darting nervously between his lips and his eyes before they met in the middle. It had felt so right it almost hurt. It had all made sense then: why the hasty kisses and strained fumbles she'd endured during nights out or after mind-numbingly boring dates never really clicked. Glimmer had realised

over the following weeks that she never should have wasted time worrying about being cold-hearted or incapable of finding love. She'd never felt a thing for anyone because none of those other people had been him; the lacklustre love they'd offered had no chance of measuring up to the real thing.

They'd taken it slowly, one tentative foot in front of the other, checking in each time they crossed a new boundary. Yet there had never been any real hesitation from either of them, not after that first kiss. She still thought sometimes about the first time he'd moved inside her, how she'd suppressed her surprise at how hard he was, and how much he wanted her. For the first time, she'd believed it a little when he told her how beautiful she was, in a way that she hadn't when other people's hands had skimmed the dimpled surface of her thighs. Sure, Glimmer had read enough body positive blogs to know that external validation wasn't supposed to be the goal. But she'd felt different in that moment – special, even – and she'd liked it. Years later, when her body was bloated from chemo, and warped lines still rose purple-pink against the pale of her abdomen, she'd wondered again whether there was anyone else on earth who could have made her feel so safe; who would have walked through the looming forest of her insecurities alongside her like Bow had.

Despite how much she loved him, she'd still said no when he'd asked her to marry him the first time. She'd insisted he should find someone else who would be more likely to give him a proper future with a family, even though it had never been something they'd talked about wanting much before. But Bow had ignored her assertions that it was a stupid choice to marry her if she was going to spend the rest of her life flitting in and out of hospitals. Every time Glimmer tried to push him away, he never left. Instead, he'd reminded Glimmer of her impressive determination that he'd always admired and cradled her as she mourned the loss of her presumed invincibility. When she finally accepted his proposal, it was only because she had wanted so badly to be convinced that his delusions could come true; she'd wanted his words to be enough.

I don't care what the future brings, Glim. I just want us to be us for as long as we can. And I'm telling you – it'll be a long time. Okay?

As much as she'd appreciated his sentiment, Glimmer had also done her research. Marrying would make it easier if she didn't make it; legally, he'd have access to her assets and would be recognised by her father's religious side of the family. Glimmer told herself it didn't matter if their reasoning for getting married was different – after all, they were both motivated by love in some way. Telling their family and friends about the engagement had been a convenient distraction from waiting for the follow-up after her oophorectomy. She'd already convinced Bow that they should save up for a blow-out holiday which could now become their honeymoon, though Glimmer had confided in her mother that she'd thought of it as the last holiday she might ever get to take. Yet when her worst fears were realised – when yet again, a post-surgical appointment brought more bad news – her reaction had surprised her.

I'm sorry, but given your results, we will have to progress with chemotherapy too. There's a considerable chance that this could affect your remaining ovary and eggs. But we can afford to hold off shortly, if you want to explore fertility preservation?

The grey cloud that had overshadowed her for the past six months didn't seem to have grown significantly more ominous like she'd expected. Instead, a light switch had flicked in her head. There was a choice to make and a course of action ahead of her; she didn't have to sit around and let this happen to her body like she'd been forced to do so far. Thanks to that one question from her consultant, Glimmer had realised that she could give herself permission to think that maybe – *just maybe* – Bow's optimism could be worth investing in. And so, she'd decided to temporarily delay her cancer treatment, taken Adora up on her repeated offer of helping her find a good fertility specialist, and asked Bow if he'd agree to trade their honeymoon for a shot in the dark.

Just in case we want it, Bow. In case things really do work out.

Bow hadn't withheld his consent for a second, and that familiar wave of love crashed over her all over again. It eclipsed her practical justification for marrying him in an instant. In truth, Glimmer had never figured out if she'd fallen for him hard and fast or if the feelings between them had always lain there dormant, the longest slow-burn in history. She thought about it now as the car shrieked slowly over burning tarmac, wondering the same thing about Adora and Catra as she and Bow stayed suspended in traffic, trapped in the unsettling limbo of unknown outcomes.

By the time they finally cleared the queue and found a spot in the hospital car park, Bow had become so still, he could have been a statue. Glimmer spoke softly, moving her hand away from the steering wheel and laying it gently on his forearm. It was her turn now, to hold him at his worst.

"Babe, it's time to go in. Ready?"

She could feel Bow's muscles twitching with anxiety under her fingers.

"You go. I can't do this."

"Bow-"

"How is it fair, that nothing went wrong with Micah, but for her own...?"

"This is Catra, Bow. The woman is made of steel, she'll be fine." *She has to be*. "You said Adora came-"

"What if she's not? We'll have got our son from her, but they won't have her at all, and... And Micah! God, he'll be devastated if she's..." Glimmer fought to hold her own tears back as Bow's voice broke. "Glim, if she's gone, I don't know if I'll be able to live with it."

Glimmer's stomach warped as the implications of what he'd said seeped into her. It had all occurred to her already, but it hit differently when spoken aloud. Yet there was no denying it –

they'd gain nothing from procrastinating in the car. They had no choice but to confront the situation.

"I know. I can't bear thinking about it either. But no matter what happens, Adora and the baby will have us, okay? And it doesn't help anyone, thinking about how unfair it is. Remember what you used to tell me? We can't control these things, but we can control what we do."

He blinked at her dumbly, as if she lacked critical information and was completely unable to understand what he was trying to say. It was utterly baffling; she returned his gaze sternly, hoping that she was effectively communicating some kind of dogged resolve.

"You're coming with me, okay? We have to be there for them – and besides, you'll feel so much worse if you stay out here."

After a moment of silence, Bow nodded in resignation. They walked hand-in-hand through artificially bright corridors, their summer sandals squeaking on linoleum as they went. Bow seemed to have slipped back into his own head by the time they got to the maternity ward doors, his eyes glazing over as they waited nervously to be let in. If they weren't clasping each other so closely, she never would have heard what he said.

"She's my best friend and I let her down."

The doors buzzed as they unlocked, cutting through the sharp breath that Glimmer had drawn in response. She nudged him forwards through the entryway, her palm landing flat on the metal push plate as she ushered him in. The ward was noisier than Glimmer remembered – she couldn't determine whether it was busier than it had been during Micah's birth, or whether she had just been too preoccupied to notice the hubbub then. Bow stood behind her as she spoke to the receptionist; Glimmer could sense him tensing up as they were directed towards the hand gel dispenser, and she twisted around to face him, already cobbling together a makeshift pep talk in her head. But Bow stared straight ahead when she began her speech, his skin paling. Glimmer

followed his eyeline to find Adora tearing up as she spoke with a colleague, tracks of watery mascara half wiped off her face. The two of them stared at her, frozen in place as they studied their friend desperately for clues of what had happened – whether her tears were driven by relief or devastation, what the midwife's hand gripping her upper arm meant, or why her usual work attire had been replaced with surgical scrubs if she was off-shift.

Adora caught sight of them before they'd had time to pull themselves together, and Glimmer found herself moving faster and faster towards the blonde, pulling her husband with her as she near-on broke into a run until she caught Adora, her arms fixing around her torso in a vice grip.

"I'm so glad you're here."

Adora's voice was hoarse, as if she'd strained to keep it steady all day.

"Of course – we wouldn't be anywhere else, 'Dor! How is she? And the baby? They're both okay?"

Glimmer felt Adora pulling away from her, her face shrouded in confusion as she looked between her and Bow.

"She's stable, thankfully. But Bow didn't tell you?"

"He wasn't sure if the bleeding really stopped, were you, love?" Glimmer reached out behind her for Bow's arm, "He's been an absolute wreck worrying about her."

"No, about the babies."

"*Babies?*"

Glimmer furrowed her brow and stared at Bow in bewilderment, unable to make sense of the words. Adora laughed, drawing Glimmer's attention back to her.

"Catra, she... We didn't know, but it's twins."

“Twins?”

Glimmer didn’t need a mirror to know her mouth had dropped open wide in shock.

“Two girls – God, they’re tiny, Glim! I don’t know how they’re both holding up so well, but so far, they are!”

“Oh my God!” Glimmer surged forward to squeeze Adora again, incredulous laughter rising up her own throat, “Bow, how could you not have said?”

Glimmer expected him to wrap his arms around the both of them, like he had so many times in moments of celebration. But the gentle warmth of Bow’s body didn’t meet hers; instead, she turned to see him inching towards them hesitantly, wringing his hands.

“She’s really okay? The bleeding’s definitely stopped?”

Glimmer watched as a soberness fell over Adora, moving aside instinctively to let her friend approach Bow. Adora’s arms extended out ahead of her to wrench his hands apart and grasp them in her own.

“Bow, she’ll be fine. I know you did everything you could have done, alright?”

“She’s fine?”

“Uh huh,” Adora paused, her voice suddenly quiet and heavy with sincerity, “I’m so grateful you were with her. You’re the only person she’d have trusted to get her through it.”

Relief flooded through Glimmer as she saw Bow start to come back into himself, the positive confirmation of Catra’s health visibly lifting a weight off his shoulders as he pulled Adora to his chest.

“She’s okay,” Bow repeated it like a mantra to her, the two of them wrapped in each other’s arms, “They’re all okay.”

"Yeah, they are," Glimmer didn't think she'd ever seen Adora smile quite so widely, despite her obvious exhaustion, "Safe and sound, thanks to you."

Glimmer's heart swelled at Adora's words, and she longed for Bow to accept and absorb them fully. He rarely gave himself credit for it, but Glimmer swore to remind him more often that he'd been the primary reason she'd survived her own ordeals, the person who'd kept her afloat and made their current life seem attainable.

Safe and sound, thanks to you.

Adora jammed her fingers into the elevator button again, willing the doors to close faster. She'd seen the ambulance arrive at the glass-fronted building ahead of her, but her cab hadn't caught up in time to slip into the lift with them. The metal doors slid shut – *finally!* – and all she could do was hope to God that it wouldn't stop for anyone else before they reached the sixth floor. Adora fixated on the small black screen ahead, watching as the numbers scrolled higher and higher, past the third and fourth floors, onto the fifth, until she was stood so close to the lift doors she was almost touching them. The metal had barely parted before Adora squeezed herself out into the crowd that loitered in the sixth floor lobby. She started to push her way through, her heartbeat thudding as she noticed the entrance to Catra's workplace had been kept propped open; thanks to the building's internal glass walls, she could see the paramedic crew ahead of her, making their way through the open plan space towards the room that Catra had converted into a private office.

"Adora!"

She turned sharply to follow the voice behind her and recognised Jess, one of the colleagues that Catra had entertained at their

home over the years. There was clear worry on the red-haired woman's face; looking around, Adora noticed almost everyone was anxious in some way, their voices hushing as they realised who she was. Adora didn't have time for niceties. She had to get to Catra. She nudged her head towards the open door, beckoning Jess to follow her as she strode into the office.

"Jess, what the fuck's going on? Tim texted me fifteen minutes ago saying he was calling an ambulance and I needed to get here, but I've no info."

"We're all in the dark. The desks near Catra's office got cleared and the paramedics just turned up! But her friend – Bill or something? He's with her."

Acknowledgement barely slipped through her lips as she broke into a run and left Jess in the entryway, the distant sound of a shout cutting into the air as the paramedics opened the door to Catra's office. Over the course of her taxi ride, she'd run through all the worst cases she'd attended to at work, reminding herself of the right course of action for each and every eventuality. She'd tried calling Tim countless times to no avail, and even dialled Catra's number repeatedly, if only to hear her speak in the voicemail message. Adora should have known better, armed with the knowledge that she'd kissed her perfectly healthy, not-at-all-in-labour wife goodbye only four hours ago on her way to work, and that at thirty-five weeks along, their daughter had excellent survival stats on her side if Catra was having contractions. But it was impossible not to assume the worst given the traumas she'd witnessed and knowing what had happened to Catra's mother. And Adora had obsessed over the fact that she hadn't known whether the ambulance had been called *for* Catra or whether she'd demanded it herself because she was worried about their child. She'd had to be more honest with herself as time ticked by; deep down, Adora struggled to believe that Catra wouldn't have called her first if she'd been able to, or that she would have answered her phone if this was anything less than exceptionally serious. After all, Catra had been so adamant that hospitals

wouldn’t be involved in her second birth. The realisation had hit Adora hard as the cab pulled up behind the parked ambulance.

Something has to be seriously wrong for it to have come to this. She’s not okay. Our child is not okay.

A pained desperation had been spreading through her body since she received Tim’s text, and it burst into a crescendo as she pushed into Catra’s office. The first thing she saw was Bow sprawled on the floor next to the futon with his back to her, bloodied handprints littered over the shoulders of his shirt and Catra’s crimson-stained underwear folded sloppily nearby.

Please, God, not Catra. Not our baby.

A strange anxious dizziness threatened to overtake her, alien and unprecedented. She’d seen worse scenes than this a million times over. But as she stepped round Bow, introducing herself to the paramedic crew to try and prevent her shock from setting in, she realised the wailing that had torn into her ears wasn’t coming from Catra at all. Bow had been screaming for help. Adora could see now that Catra was limp in their friend’s arms with her dress jerked up to her belly, her head lolling as her breath hitched and her legs fell open wide in the gap between Bow’s knees. Adora’s head swam as she noticed the pallor of Catra’s cheeks. She dropped to the floor next to Bow as the paramedics snapped their gloves on, her hand resting on Catra’s knee as she caught sight of the squirming infant on the damp, bloodied carpet, whose angry cry beckoned her attention.

I missed it – she’s here, and Catra didn’t have me, and I missed it!

The birth they’d planned flashed into her head: a labour spent in dark, familiar rooms dimly lit with candles, where Adora would join Catra in the birthing pool and support her wife as partner rather than professional, their actions guided by Catra’s bodily instinct. Their daughter would have been born into warm water and held in her mothers’ arms before being placed on Catra’s

breast while they waited for the afterbirth to follow, her umbilical cord left uncut until it went white, having gifted all the blood and nutrients it could. And despite Catra's reassurances that their baby already knew both her mothers, Adora would finally greet her: the person she'd waited so long to meet, who was supposed to have the best of beginnings.

Adora only had a second to worry that their daughter seemed remarkably small given that Catra's fundal height had consistently measured a little higher than average throughout her pregnancy. She watched paralyzed as one of the crew scooped her up to check her airways and body temperature; Adora was immediately overwhelmed with regret as it dawned on her that she'd let her daughter be held by a stranger before either of her mothers. She had barely protested the quick cutting of the cord before she was distracted by a low whine, her head whipping back towards her wife.

"Adora," Bow finally spoke, his voice trembling, "I think she's still bleeding."

Adora gripped Catra's knee tighter, the grimace on her wife's face intensifying. She was gaining some kind of consciousness – typically a good sign – but Adora could see that Bow wasn't wrong. It was more obvious now: the darkening wetness in the carpet wasn't just amniotic fluid and normal blood loss. The second paramedic moved to Catra's side to check her vitals as Adora went to kneel in the space their daughter had laid. She'd started to groan now, her legs shaking.

"Bow, how long ago did Catra deliver?"

Bow spluttered in response to Adora's question, panic rising in his voice.

"A few minutes? I don't know, 'Dor. I'm sorry, I didn't know if I should try and move her, and then you guys arrived, and I-"

“Bow.” Adora could feel a familiar energy come over her as years of practiced calm kicked in, “Breathe. Do you mean a few minutes as in five, or has it been longer than that?”

“F-f-five. It was right before you got here.”

Adora frowned as she surveyed the tension in Catra’s body – it was too soon for her to deliver the placenta. But there was no time for examination before Catra whined again, her previously limp fingers twitching between her legs and grazing the severed cord that trailed out of her. The reality of what was happening hit Adora only seconds before she thrust her hands forward, just in time to catch a warm, slippery body forcing its way towards her.

A twin?

Adora could tell instantly that their second daughter was even smaller than her sister – but the urgent cry that she’d heard when entering the office wasn’t doubling now. This baby was quiet. Adora met Bow’s eyes in alarm as she held the tiny infant in her hands, jerked out of her stupor by the paramedic’s nudge on her shoulder.

“Do you want to pass her over to me?”

Adora leant over the baby, a sob bursting out of her as she heard minute breaths, shallow air pulsing over her thumb as she held it above the baby’s lips.

“She’s breathing!”

“Amazing,” Adora could tell even the paramedic had let out her own breath of relief, “Let me check her over, hmm?”

Adora nodded slowly, allowing the second umbilical cord to be clamped and cut before she nestled the baby into the paramedic’s arms. She leaned forward to stroke Catra’s cheek, desperate to keep her conscious.

"Come on, Cat! I've got you," Adora willed her words to come true, failing to hold back tears as she thought of what Catra had endured, "You've done so well – we just need you to hang on a little longer."

A lazy smile – or something like it – spread across Catra's face, but Adora could tell already that she wouldn't stay awake for long. She'd started to drift, her body dropping back against Bow's chest and falling further into a slump. Adora sighed as she noticed how the liquid on the floor had seeped into her trousers, even though the bleeding had seemingly started to slow; Catra had been so adamant that this wouldn't happen, as if she could bend nature through sheer will.

"We have to get her to a unit. There's not much we can do before the placenta comes, and she'll need an IV, probably massage too."

Adora wished it were different; that there had been signs this morning for her to read, that would have prompted her to insist they both stay home or go into hospital. But from what Catra had said and Adora had observed, there really had been nothing more to report besides her usual dull backache. She tried to quiz Bow on what exactly had happened, but her rattled friend had been unable to communicate much beyond the fact that Catra had apparently gone into labour and given birth all in the space of about twenty minutes.

She kept one eye trained on the paramedics while they cleaned up the babies, her focus skipping around the room as Adora tried to keep eyes on both her daughters and her wife. It gutted her, to think that she – and all the technicians who'd conducted their ultrasounds – had missed that they'd been expecting twins. Granted, she'd stared at their sonographs for hours, and she'd bet her life on the fact that the second, smaller baby had been hidden every time. But Adora could see now how the extreme nausea, fatigue, and excess weight gain wasn't just down to every pregnancy being different. Despite Catra's assertions, this had been a higher risk pregnancy all along. And worse – Catra had been measuring *under* for twins. There could have been all kinds

of things wrong with their babies that they'd never monitored or watched out for at all, including their assumption that Catra was unlikely to have a precipitous birth.

Adora shuffled back to watch over the babies while the paramedics freed Bow from below Catra, preparing to transport her to the ambulance. They mewled naked on cotton towels, fingers scratching at her palms. Adora was sure they were hungry – under other circumstances, they'd be nursing right after birth. It wasn't an option yet; skin-to-skin would have to be the next best thing until Catra regained consciousness. Bow approached her, clearly disorientated, but he had enough wherewithal to help her carry them over to the futon. Adora watched as they curled into each other, miniscule hands stretching out across the blue furniture fabric. She unbuttoned her shirt halfway and nestled each of them against her breastbone, her arms crossed around them and hands placed protectively over their exposed heads. She peered down at them, completely intoxicated by their newborn smell, the deepest feeling of love rushing through her as she studied the feeling of their soft hair under her fingertips, and faint breaths on her skin. Adora couldn't help but think how much Catra *had* to experience this – she couldn't entertain the notion for even a second that they'd fail to stabilise her.

The next few hours passed in a blur as they made their way to the hospital and ensured the babies got an extra boost of oxygen. She'd told Bow to go home and clean up – she couldn't bear to see the blood caked on his clothes and he clearly needed some recovery time – and had shielded the babies as best she could when she followed the paramedics out of the makeshift office room, brushing off the outpouring of concern when Catra's employees caught sight of her unconscious on the stretcher, their worry only slightly offset by the presence of tiny infants wriggling inside Adora's shirt.

Adora was grateful that Catra hadn't woken up until they'd got her settled at the hospital, only stirred by her need to deliver the twins' shared placenta, close to an hour after their birth. In the end, breastfeeding and fluids had been enough to stopper any

further bleeding and start rebuilding her strength, her body reacting as it should to every hormone.

Adora knew she'd never forget how Catra smiled shyly from her hospital bed when their daughters latched for the first time, her wife's relief evident in the way her shoulders dropped and sunk into the pillows.

"Two for one," she announced, still in shock at how events had unfolded, "I suppose I've always been time efficient."

Adora raised an eyebrow as she perched on the bedding in front of Catra, her hands ghosting over their daughters' scalps for the millionth time.

"I wouldn't go that far, love. I've been in love with you for near-on twenty years, and it took you long enough to realise."

Catra laughed softly.

"You're lucky I'm too tired to slap you," she gazed down, as if speaking to their daughters as well as Adora, "Besides, good things come to those who wait, huh?"

"Yeah," Adora leaned over across the pillows to kiss Catra, careful not to disturb the twins, "I'd say this wait was worth every second."

"Good," Adora moved away, but Catra's fingers stretched out to grip the scrubs she'd changed into, keen to sluice the fright of the twins' birth off her, "It was... I was really scared, Adora. I thought I'd let you both – *all* – down."

Adora studied the pain in her wife's eyes, bringing her hand up to rest on her jaw.

"You could never. Look what you did, what you've created for us."

Catra blinked, hesitant to respond, "If I'd have listened to you about the risks, it could have been different. You could have been

there for all of it. We might have known about both of them."

"No," Adora shook her head, "It doesn't matter – we are where we are, and you're *safe*. I'll tell you every day if you need to hear it, Cat," Adora continued, "I waited so long to call you mine. And I love you. All three of you."

"All three of us," Catra echoed her words, "We're safe."

"Yeah."

Adora settled back in place by Catra's thigh, giddy as she watched her wife nourish their children. None of it had been the journey she'd imagined, though it was typical of their relationship – never simple or run according to plan. But their story belonged to them, just like their newly formed family, finally free of the ghosts they'd fled in their pasts. Now, all they had to look out for was their future.

Chapter End Notes

Hope you enjoyed - let me know how it came across! x

Chapter 30

Chapter Notes

Wow - feels kind of wild that this fic is finally finished... I hope I did the ending justice! Thank you so much for joining me on this ride, I've loved getting to grips with these characters and developing this AU world.

This final chapter is a long one (the longest by far at around 10.5k words), but there was a lot I wanted to wrap up! So you can get the most out of it, I've included some descriptions/translations of Hebrew and Ivrit (modern Hebrew) terms and songs that are referenced below that I'm not sure everyone would be familiar with:

- Imma: mother/mum
- hinei: Hebrew for 'behold', part of a very famous hymn, 'Hinei Ma Tov' calling for peace and unity - there's a billion melodies it is set to, but here's one of my favourites, which includes an English translation in the verse so you could understand it: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=AtP3IDEY1ts
- Shabbat: holy day of rest in Judaism
- challah: traditional Jewish bread (it's beyond delicious, please try some!)
- matbucha: a Moroccan red pepper and tomato dip that is super common to eat in Jewish communities (at least in the UK and Israel)
- kiddush wine: ritual wine drunk while reciting blessings
- shalom: hello and goodbye greeting, also meaning 'peace'
- Shema: literally means 'hear', also the name of one of the most (if not *the* most) important prayers and typically sung. This is the version they sing in many Reform/Progressive synagogues, and children often learn the beginning of it in sign language as well, so a lot of little kids pick up the words pretty quickly when its paired with actions: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=n4Vy_t8Dco4

- Torah: the first part of the Jewish bible, and the most important document in the religion (the holy book)

Anyway, I really hope you enjoy the ending to this fic, and I'd love to know what you think. It would be wonderful to see how it lands with you x

See the end of the chapter for more notes

FIVE YEARS AFTER

"You promise you're feeling okay? You're not just saying it?"

Catra leaned into the hand Adora had placed on her jaw, her energy too depleted to reprimand her wife for fussing like she usually would.

"I'm fine, Adora."

"You're not too tired? It's only been a couple of days. This can wait until we get home."

Catra cracked her right eye open momentarily, scanning Adora's worried face.

"I'm good. I want to see them, okay?"

"Alright... Will you at least nap a little after? You're obviously knackered, love."

Catra could tell Adora wasn't entirely reassured – it was abundantly clear that they were both completely exhausted, but Catra was shaken enough to let Adora fuss over her a little. She nodded feebly, sinking further into her pillow.

"Here I was, thinking I looked a million bucks."

"You always look a million bucks," Adora smirked back at her, "Just some very tired bucks, is all."

“You and me both, babe.”

Catra snickered, shifting slightly in the hospital bed to make room for Adora. She whimpered a little when Adora’s arm wound around her sore body, steeling herself for the inevitable scream of her muscles as she stretched out to rest her hand across the tiny bodies that lay in the plastic cot at her bedside.

“Do you need more painkillers?” Catra felt Adora’s hot breath tickle the hollow of her collarbones from behind, “It’s been long enough since your last dose, I can call some in.”

Catra shook her head slowly, gazing at the babies.

“You’re really sure they’re okay, ‘Dor?”

“Uh huh,” Adora pressed a kiss to her shoulder, “They’re strong. Like you.”

Catra let herself fall a little limp, her fingers stroking the twins’ cheeks as lightly as she could. They had experienced a surreal two days – the shock of the girls’ birth and the unexpected presence of their second daughter, coupled with the fear that she could suffer a second haemorrhage – had been overwhelming to say the least. Catra had refused to let the babies be taken out of her sight, her stubbornness only growing once she learned that they’d been placed under oxygen hoods while she was unconscious. It didn’t matter how many times Adora explained that it was fairly common protocol for late preemies – in Catra’s mind, any health intervention deviated from the expectation she’d had for her child’s first hours of life. They could be grateful, though, that the twins’ low birth weights had been the neonatal nurses’ only concern, and the girls had seemingly latched well enough to get the sustenance they needed to start gaining mass. It was Catra’s health that had prevented them all from being discharged so far; Adora was so well-liked amongst her colleagues that no-one wanted to see her take the babies home alone while her wife was kept in for observation.

A tentative knock on the door distracted Catra temporarily from watching the girls' chests rise and fall as they breathed. She blinked, coming to terms with the fact that this moment – the meeting she'd thought about so many times since discovering she was pregnant – was actually about to happen.

Catra remembered how difficult it had been in the early weeks of her pregnancy to stop Micah from clambering all over her without giving it away. She'd made up all manner of excuses to try and prevent Bow and Glimmer from working it out: an old hip injury playing up, stomach aches and the remains of a hangover, among others. Catra hadn't done too badly; it wasn't until she had reached the nine-week mark that the news had come out. She'd been cuddled up with Micah on the sofa watching one of his favourite cartoons when he'd spontaneously begun to dance to the credits, jumping on the cushions a little too wildly. Horror had washed over Catra as she calculated the trajectory of his descent in slow motion, realising that his knee would drive right into her abdomen. Her arms had shot out in front of her to deflect his fall, a desperate "No!" escaping her lips just in time for Glimmer to enter the living room. Although it was fairly unusual for her to stifle any rough and tumble play, it was the fractured second in which Catra forgot herself, her hand instinctively drawn protectively to her stomach instead of around Micah's body, that gave the secret away. She'd frozen, scrambling too late for her usual strategy of readjusting her jumper to work.

"You're pregnant, aren't you?"

Despite the slight lilt of Glimmer's voice, it had sounded much more like a statement than a question. Catra had been totally unsure of what to say. She had little plausible deniability, considering she'd been unreasonably close to pushing Micah off the sofa to protect her own child. But she and Adora hadn't told anyone that Catra had agreed to try to conceive their baby, and they'd placed great importance on the need to keep shtum until the pregnancy had surpassed its first twelve weeks. Catra had looked up at Glimmer and placed a shaky hand on Micah's back, drawing him back into her embrace as carefully as she could.

“You wouldn’t believe me if I lied, would you?”

Glimmer had gaped at her open-mouthed, the ‘O’ formed on her lips opening and closing in quick succession. She had surged forward, her hand quivering above Catra’s stomach, waiting for consent before she made contact.

“There’s nothing to feel yet, Glim.”

But Micah had squealed, suddenly catching on, and he had laid his hand on Catra’s stomach next to his mother’s, exhaling a laughably theatrical breath when she confirmed that she did, indeed, have a baby in her tummy like some of his friends’ mothers.

Over the course of her pregnancy, Micah’s excitement had grown along with her bump; by the time she was five months gone, he had already developed a strong attachment to the baby. Micah would lay his head on Catra’s protruding belly when she visited, murmuring all the things he would show the baby once she was born, and describing the games they would play when she was big enough. Even though she tried to hide it, Catra had been able to tell it was taking a toll on Glimmer; she and Adora had known the chance of their friends having a second biological child was effectively non-existent, and Micah’s growing affection for Catra and Adora’s child was enough proof that the boy wanted a sibling as much as his parents did.

When Bow and Glimmer’s eighth wedding anniversary came around, Catra convinced Adora that they should take Micah for the weekend to give them a break. She’d joked that it was worth doing just for the sake of having a return favour to cash in one day, but there was a part of her that wanted the time alone with him. She’d known her relationship with the kid was about to change – soon, she’d have far less time to spend with Micah. She’d already become protective enough over her bump to know that he’d rarely be the sole focus of her attention again.

The sleepover had started well enough – Micah loved fingerpainting with Adora and had keenly devoured the dinner Catra had cooked for the three of them. But when they had all huddled together at night for his bedtime story, Micah had asked a question that Catra and Adora hadn't seen coming.

"Catra," Micah interrupted the book she'd been reading to him, his hands grasping at the stretched cotton of her t-shirt, "When will the baby come out your tummy to live with me, Mummy and Daddy?"

She'd looked over at Adora immediately, seeing her own feelings of shock reflected in her wife's expression. Dread crashed into her as she wracked her brain thinking of whether anything they had said might have confused Micah; she was grateful when she heard Adora respond to him, absolving her of the need to hunt down the right words.

"Micah, sweetie, the baby is going to live with us here. But I'm sure we'll all spend lots of time together."

Catra had held her breath as she watched Micah process Adora's reply; the baby kicked under his touch, punctuating her nervousness. His face had twisted in confusion, turning from Adora to look up at Catra.

"But... I grewed in your tummy. Is I 'sposed to live here too?"

"No, Mikey," Catra had hugged him to her belly, straining to keep him close despite its roundness, "You grew here because your mummy and daddy wanted you so much, but your mummy hadn't been very well so you couldn't get big and strong in her tummy. This baby, though, she belongs with me and Adora."

"I's not a big brother?"

Catra hadn't noticed she was crying until she had felt the pads of Adora's fingertips sweep across her cheeks, seeing warm tears slide over her wife's knuckles.

"You'll be more like extra special cousins," Adora had saved her from finding what to say again, "And I know she's going to love you very, very much."

Micah had laid his head on Catra's stomach and fisted his hand into her t-shirt even tighter, clearly still a little perplexed. She worked her fingers into the nape of his neck to soothe him, hoping the explanation made enough sense. He'd stayed quiet, only moving when the baby kicked too hard against his cheek, and had listened diligently as Adora finished reading the story they'd begun.

When they'd left Micah tucked into bed with his favourite teddy, Adora had held Catra as she cried again, agreeing profusely when Catra insisted she was only so emotional because of her hormones, and overtired because her awful nausea wouldn't fade even though she was already twenty-eight weeks along. It had been Adora's idea to give the next morning a positive head start with breakfast in bed, a treat they'd both fantasised about growing up in the care home, where the very concept of eating outside the dining room was close to heresy.

The idea had been a good one – at least until Glimmer called them the following Monday evening to ask why Micah had thrown a tantrum about not being allowed to eat his cereal in bed instead of getting ready for school. After Glimmer had gone uncharacteristically quiet when they'd explained the circumstances, Catra had worried that the whole situation was too confusing for the little boy and too sore for his parents to unpack. But now the moment was finally upon them: she'd imagined Micah meeting her child countless times, every bone in her body crossed in the hope it would play out happily.

Either way, we're about to find out.

The sound of their friends' cautious greetings in the doorway heightened her anxieties, her chest suddenly thudding nervously as Adora moved to help her sit up a little straighter.

“Do you want us to come back a little later? We can grab a coffee if you’re still resting.”

Catra shook her head when Glimmer spoke, staring straight past her to Bow. She’d been so fixated on introducing Micah to the babies that she hadn’t even thought about how she’d feel when she saw him. Bow seemed more apprehensive now than he had in years, prompting flashes of his actions in her office to burst into her mind. Her arm drew out towards him of its own volition, his name slipping through her lips; before she knew it was happening, they were shaking in each other’s arms, their quiet sobs stifled by the fabric of their clothes. She clutched onto Bow as tightly as she could, even though her whole body throbbed with the effort. They didn’t say anything, neither of them sure of what could convey their feelings adequately, before a sharp gasp nearby pulled them out of the hug.

“*Two* babies, Mummy!”

“I told you, Micah,” Catra heard Glimmer chuckling behind Bow, the mild pressure of her hand rubbing into Catra’s shoulder tenderly, “Your Auntie Catra is practically Superwoman!”

Micah’s head turned towards Catra, his expression shifting from excitement to worry as he saw the redness framing their eyes.

“Daddy, why is you both upset? Does Catra not like the babies?”

Catra laughed lightly, beckoning Micah to come over to her.

“No, no,” She ruffled his curls, patting the bed to encourage Bow to pull Micah up to sit on the mattress, “I love the babies very much, don’t worry. Do you want to say hello to them?”

Micah nodded eagerly, clapping his hands together in excitement.

“Okay, then. But we have to be nice and calm around them, alright?”

She studied Micah as he watched Adora help Catra wedge a nursing pillow into her side and pass the twins to her, both of them set in the crook of Catra's right elbow before she made room for him to huddle under her left arm.

"Here's Lyla," She nodded first towards the slightly bigger twin, "and this is Aurie."

"Lyla and Aurie," Micah rolled his tongue around their names, his fingers inching towards their tiny hands.

"Be gentle, darling," Glimmer called to him, "Remember they're not used to meeting people yet."

Micah looked up at Catra, hesitant to touch the girls.

"It's okay, go on. Just carefully, hmm?"

He leaned in further, his head grazing Catra's chest as Lyla's fist wrapped around his finger.

"We broughted birthday presents," Micah spoke faintly, only just above a whisper, "So yous won't be bored before you big enough to play with me."

"Well," Catra replied softly, "I think that's very kind, Micah."

He beamed up at her, his pleasure clear as day. Catra smiled back, surprised by the pride she felt towards Micah. She realised then that even though he wasn't her son, their journey together was still one of the puzzle pieces that had helped her to heal. No matter how many of her own children Catra bore, or how old Micah grew, the two of them would always share an important bond; after everything that had brought them to this point, the foundations of their lives were innately intertwined.

Catra watched as Adora stirred the pot lazily, tutting as tomato splashed all over the hob.

"Can you at least *try* not to make a mess?"

"I'll clean it up afterwards," Adora let her attention drift away from the pan of sauce as she turned away from the hob to face Catra, "I promise, okay?"

Catra frowned back.

"Don't stop stirring, 'Dor," Catra grimaced as the sauce began to gurgle, spitting red bubbles further up the splashback, "Look – it's overboiling now. You need to turn the heat down; it's only meant to simmer!"

"Alright, alright. Are you sure you don't just want to take over?"

"That would be sensible, wouldn't it? Except..."

Catra sighed as her younger daughter snuggled further into her, her small legs wrapped around her mother's waist and hands clinging to her t-shirt.

"Come on, let me take her."

Catra acquiesced as Adora turned the hob off and cooed at the baby on Catra's hip, knowing full well what was about to happen. She eased Aurie away from her chest, prying her fists off her top and hoping that the giggles Adora was managing to draw out of the kid would distract her until she'd been completely transferred. Catra exhaled in relief as Aurie smacked her hands together in glee while Adora chatted with her, stepping away as quietly as she could to turn the heat back on and taste the sauce, setting some aside for the girls before adding seasoning to the rest. She was stunned that Aurie hadn't immediately protested; the younger of their twins was incredibly high-need, constantly wanting to be held – preferably by Catra – no matter the time of day. Catra had even resorted to co-sleeping when she was particularly fussy, bringing the baby into her and Adora's bed so she could suckle

through the night as and when she pleased, shrugging off Adora's objections that it was discouraging Aurie's independence. Deep down, Catra wasn't that enamoured with the idea of forcing their babies to become more self-sufficient anyway; they were only eleven months old, and she was quite happy to lavish them with all the affection that she'd felt so starved of during her own childhood. Besides, a raging tantrum at 1am wouldn't help anyone get a good night's sleep. Still, Catra hated the sore twist in her gut that came from knowing their other daughter – calm, contented, adaptable Lyla – rarely got the same amount of attention from her. She glanced over at the highchair next to the breakfast bar, studying Lyla as she grabbed soldiers of toast in her pudgy hands and sucked the butter off them. Catra couldn't help herself. She flew past Adora to her, revelling in the squeaks of pleasure Lyla gave when she dotted kisses all over her face.

"Cat, the hob...!"

"I know, I know!"

Catra smoothed her thumb over the baby's cheek affectionately and skulked back to the pan, brushing Adora's arm faintly with her fingers as she passed her. It was a mistake – as soon as Aurie was reminded of Catra's presence, she screamed out for her.

"*Eeem!*"

Adora tousled Aurie's thick curls, guiding the baby to look at her face as she spoke.

"Shhh, sweetie. Imma's cooking."

Catra turned to them briefly, the baby's face getting redder and redder with discontent.

"Aurie, stay with Mama for now, okay?"

Catra focused on stirring the sauce, biting down on her bottom lip as Aurie raged in Adora's arms.

“Adora...”

“Catra, you’re going back to work full-time next month! We can’t let her carry on like this.”

“She’ll be good as gold once I have her, she always is. Just hand her over, it’s fi-”

“No. I’ll watch them in the living room, and you finish this.”

Catra blew air through her nostrils, leaving the pot on a low simmer so she could haul Lyla out of her highchair and quickly run a damp cloth over her before following Adora to the other room. Lyla burbled nonsense words at her as they travelled, her lips forming around the ‘Imma’ sounds that Catra always listened out for keenly. Lyla was, as expected, a little further along than her sister – she could just about say ‘Mama’ and ‘Imma’, and her delight when Adora and Catra responded to her newfound words was infectious. Catra hoped her progress would rub off on her twin sooner rather than later.

The babies had been very similarly matched for their first six months, both fairly relaxed in personality. But once they’d gotten too big to share their cot, their needs had drastically changed. Catra could remember how her chest ached that first afternoon when Adora had finished assembling the second crib, and they’d watched their girls writhe atop separate mattresses, their arms stretching out for a bed partner who was no longer there. Adora had been right when she’d promised it would get easier, but Catra loved how they’d always curled into each other like they were two halves of a whole; after their birth, she’d convinced herself that the only reason their girls had survived so unscathed was because they’d benefited from some kind of inexplicable twin support system unique to them. She couldn’t accept that they’d just all been lucky for once. Even though Catra knew she had come to live a life of relative fortune, she was yet to be convinced that the grand theory of luck held up at all.

Splitting the girls at night had at least informed their parenting. Both Catra and Adora had learned quickly that Aurie would never settle unless she was held. They'd tried turning the lights off and whispering to the twins in the darkness, but it was no use. Lyla would fall asleep after a little whining, but Aurie would scream desperately, her cries growing more anguished until Catra couldn't bear it any longer and rocked her baby to sleep. It wasn't sustainable, sure, but after a few weeks, she'd worked out that most nights, it was enough for her or Adora to sit next to the cribs in the dark, a hand laid comfortingly next to Aurie while both their daughters thankfully drifted off to sleep. When Adora remarked that Aurie often didn't react to their voices when Lyla wasn't right by her, the thought had hit them both at once.

"She's been copying her sister."

"'Dor, I'm not sure she can hear us."

Aurie's diagnosis wasn't nearly as severe as they'd both expected – though she had significant sensory loss in one ear, she could hear fully in the other – but getting the baby's hearing aid fitted was enough to send Catra into a whirlwind of grief. She couldn't stop thinking about how alone Aurie must have felt without her twin beside her at night, unable to see or hear her mothers clearly and denied her usual self-soothing mechanisms. It had taken weeks of constant reassurance from Adora to halfway convince Catra that the hearing loss couldn't be her fault, and that it had nothing to do with anything they had or hadn't done during her pregnancy.

"Sometimes it just is this way, Cat. And they were preemies – we're lucky it wasn't worse."

There it was – luck again. Catra didn't trust it at all.

The one thing Adora did often say that made Catra feel a little better was how intelligent their kids seemingly were; they'd discovered so many little things the twins did instinctively that had obscured Aurie's disability beforehand. Adora would sit each

morning with the twins on her lap, and as soon as they were able, they'd wriggled round to face her, craning to look directly at her when they were being spoken to. Catra and Adora knew now that it was a clear sign of early lip-reading. And Lyla would always wait for Aurie to catch on after she responded to loud noises or gurgled some early semblance of a word, watching her sister for an echo of her actions. It filled Adora with a pride Catra longed to feel so easily, that she wished would overpower the all-consuming need to shield their babies from the bad things that weren't supposed to happen to them but inexplicably *had*, ever since that first awful, unexpected contraction in her office. Catra would have laughed if someone told her a year ago that the tables would turn like this: that her anxiety-ridden wife would be the unruffled, level-headed parent while she fretted over multitudes of possible problems.

Catra returned to the stove, having left Lyla playing on the floor with Adora and Aurie. She pushed a silicone spatula into the pan, loosening the thickened tomato that had settled on its heavy bottom. It wasn't perfect – Lord knew that little she'd cooked since the twins were born had been – but it would do. She went into the fridge to retrieve the gnocchi she'd shaped the night before, having forced herself to knead and roll the dough despite her fatigue. When her wife had returned home late from work after an emergency surgery, she'd guffawed in disbelief at the effort Catra had gone to, marvelling at how she'd managed to make gnocchi from scratch after handling the twins' laborious bath and bedtime routine on her own.

"It's only lunch with Glimmer and Bow – they'd give us a pass even if we ordered pizza!"

But Catra had shrugged Adora off as she set steaming bowls of canned soup down on the kitchen table for their makeshift dinner, asserting that she'd wanted to do something that made her feel more like her old self. It was bad enough that her weekly office visits and check-ins with Entrapta had largely fallen by the wayside, her energy utterly sapped by motherhood. She'd told herself every week that she'd get their catchups back in the diary,

but – knowing that it was all ticking along fine with her appointed maternity cover and that she could continue reviewing urgent matters by email – it was far too easy to take the step back she'd never imagined agreeing to before.

She boiled the gnocchi, observing the soft dumplings as they somersaulted to the top of starch-saturated water before mixing them into the two pots of sauce. Catra hummed under her breath as she finished preparing the meal, readying it to be reheated in the oven. It was an old song that she used to play on her guitar and had sung to her bump in the early months of her pregnancy; it had become a lullaby for a short time too, though she rarely felt the desire to play anymore.

Once she'd tidied up, Catra wandered back into the living room. She found Adora guiding the girls as they built towers of plastic rainbow blocks; both the babies were enamoured with the game, cackling as they knocked the coloured cubes over. Catra settled herself next to Adora on the carpet, running her fingers through her wife's hair as Melog purred at her feet. It was nice, feeling the length of Adora's long, silky strands pass over her palms. She'd made Adora cut her own hair over the bathroom sink when the girls were only a month old, weary of how they tugged on her long ringlets, and resentful of how long her thick hair took to wash and diffuse dry. Catra had prioritized practicality over curl pattern, but she'd told herself the shoulder-length bob she'd learned to maintain wouldn't stay forever.

Surprisingly, Lyla crawled over to her first, grasping at Catra's torso to pull herself up from the floor and stand at her full height. Catra praised her efforts as Aurie approached them, supporting the tot as she teetered unsteadily on her feet.

"Well done, Lyla! Are you having fun with Mama?"

Lyla responded with a gurgling grin, one hand moving from Catra's shirt to her mouth.

"Mama!"

“Yes, Mama’s been playing with you, hasn’t she?”

“Ma!”

Catra was side-tracked momentarily by Aurie’s outburst as the girl burrowed into her side; she looked over at Adora, who was practically bursting with happiness. For all the times Aurie had attempted to call out for Catra, she’d yet to put much effort into Adora’s epithet. But perhaps, Catra wondered, the tide was beginning to turn. Maybe if they did persevere, they really could overcome Aurie’s terrible separation anxiety.

Lyla responded to Aurie’s exclamation with her own gibberish as she dropped into Catra’s lap and rolled towards her sister, a volley of unintelligible sounds going back and forth between them.

“And... they’re back to twin-speak.”

“She said it though,” Adora beamed at Catra, ruffling Aurie’s curls, “Who’s her favourite now, huh?”

Catra rolled her eyes, though she couldn’t hide her pleasure from Adora even if she tried.

“We knew she’d get it eventually.”

“Given her mother is a total smart-arse, it’s not much of surprise, I suppose.”

“Hey!” Catra poked Adora in the belly, “You should watch out. I might bake arsenic into your lunch if you get into my bad books.”

“Hmm...” Adora craned her neck up towards Catra, beckoning her to close the gap between their lips, “You’d end up poisoning both of us if you did that. Who’d raise these little monsters then? Not the best plan.”

“Maybe not,” Catra pecked her lips, “I’ll have to reconsider.”

It had only been a joke, but Catra had accidentally reminded herself of an old reality she'd wilfully ignored for years. It was suddenly too easy, recalling memories of the long nights she'd lain awake figuring out a million different ways she could deploy poison; it was even more painful to know that she probably would have followed through if she ever got the chance. If it would have gotten her out. She did her best to brush her thoughts off and slumped further towards the floor as the girls pressed into her, their hands reaching out for Catra's collar. She knew what they wanted; barely seconds after she eased her t-shirt up and snapped the front clasp of her bra open, they'd latched, her arms encircling them instinctively for support.

"It's nearly lunch time, Catra."

Catra knew Adora wanted to encourage them to eat more at meals and suspected the twins were always too sated with milk to make more of an effort. She responded firmly, blocking the conversation before it could even begin.

"They hardly ate this morning. Maybe we shouldn't force it so much – they never finish what we give them."

Catra waited for Adora's expected response – she knew Adora was right, and that really, they had to get the girls to eat a wider variety of food, and enough of it – but Adora thankfully didn't seem to be in the mood for their usual debate. Instead, she stayed silent, stroking Melog in her lap with one hand, her other fingers rubbing at the base of Catra's skull. She nuzzled into Adora as the twins nursed, wishing that they got to spend more time like this, just the five of them. But as always, their bubble burst too soon. Adora pushed herself to her feet and rushed out the room as the doorbell rang for the second time in a minute – a sure sign that Micah was impatient on the doorstep. Catra watched as Lyla started to wriggle on her thigh, stirred by the commotion she could hear in the hallway.

"Mama's gone to open the door – do you know who's here?"

Aurie pulled away from Catra's breast, twisting as she looked around to work out what was diverting her sister's attention. Catra squeezed Aurie's leg gently, drawing the baby's focus to her lips.

"The doorbell's gone, Aurie. Ding-dong!" She tapped on their noses lightly with each syllable, her voice a singsong, "Ding-dong!"

"*De-dahh!"*

Catra nodded encouragingly as her babies tried to copy her.

"That's it! Ding-dong!"

They kicked their feet out excitedly, thrilled by their mother's praise. Catra leaned forwards and pushed herself off the carpet carefully as they clung to her and returned to their feed, settling back on the sofa cushions just in time for Micah to come running into the living room.

"Catra!"

"Hey, Mikey!" She reached out to give him a high five, "What's good?"

"Can I play with Aurie and Lyla?"

Micah rocked on his tiptoes, a hopeful expression dancing on his face. Catra smiled at him; at five and a half years old, his mannerisms were already so much like his father's.

"You can later," Catra replied, already regretting the disappointment she was about to cause, "They're nursing now and then we're going to have our lunch, so we can't play right away."

She watched Micah's face fall, his predicted dissatisfaction made evident. Catra sighed, glancing up at Bow, Glimmer and Adora, who had entered the room halfway through their conversation. Adora stepped in immediately, squeezing the boy's shoulders.

“I wouldn’t be too upset if I were you, Micah. I bet you can’t guess what Catra’s made for lunch, especially for you because it’s your favourite!”

Micah’s eyes lit up.

“Tomatoey potatoes?”

“Uh huh! And I just put it in the oven with *extra cheese on top*, so really, I don’t think you’ll want to wait.”

“Jeez, Cat,” Glimmer chipped in, dropping onto the sofa next to her, “Tell me you didn’t make gnocchi from scratch for six.”

Catra chuckled, “I mean, the kids won’t eat much, so technically it’s only five portions...”

“God, I can’t with you sometimes,” Glimmer rolled her eyes humorously, letting Micah scramble on top of her. He leaned forward in his mother’s lap to stroke the twins cautiously, though the babies still squirmed at the unexpected contact, “Hey, don’t distract them, sweetheart, they’re feeding. And Catra said it’s not playtime yet, okay?”

Micah’s face crumpled further than it had before; he was clearly on the verge of tears.

“Mummy, you said I could practice my big brother-”

“Not now, darling-”

“But *my new brother* is coming!” Micah screeched, uncharacteristically distressed, “You promised...!”

“Shhh...” Glimmer rocked Micah in her lap as he burrowed his crestfallen face in her chest, glancing up at Catra and Adora nervously.

“Glim?” Catra prompted, “What is he talking about?”

Glimmer bit her lip, tightening her hold on Micah.

"We wanted to tell you today," Bow cut in, moving to perch on the sofa arm next to Glimmer, a supportive hand placed on his wife's back, "We didn't mention it because of... well you know, everything going on with you guys, but we were approved to foster a few months ago."

Catra stared at Bow, his words repeating on loop in her head. It was the last thing Catra had expected to hear, and despite herself, she could already feel a long-lost haze of bitterness building in her chest.

Bow balanced Lyla on his knee, giving Adora a chance to finish eating now that the twins were unwilling to stay in their highchairs. The meal had passed swiftly as everyone tucked into the food eagerly, effusively complimenting Catra's cooking to try and ease the awkwardness. Even the girls had managed to eat a decent portion of their cut-up gnocchi, their restlessness mostly alleviated by Adora's enthusiastic reaction to their appetite. Only Catra remained withdrawn, picking at her plate as she clutched Aurie close to her. He could feel her eyes on him as he held her other daughter, a complicated mix of trusting consent and soreness boring into his skin. Bow finally caught her glare for a brief moment, relieved to see that it was no longer quite as cold as before; while he'd been unsure of how Catra would react to the news that he and Glimmer were becoming foster parents, he certainly hadn't anticipated the ire that had hardened so quickly in her eyes.

"*Everything going on*?" Catra had responded coolly, "You can say it, you know. It's not a dirty secret."

"Catra, that's not how I meant it-"

But Catra's arms had already wrapped protectively around her daughters, her palm closing over the smaller girl's hand.

"We know," Adora had interrupted briskly, cutting through the tension, "That's incredible, isn't it, Catra? Fostering!" Adora continued when it became clear Catra wasn't going to respond, turning her attention back to Bow, "Do you have a placement yet?"

"A two-year-old boy, coming on Monday. He's been in the system for just over a year."

"We found an agency that places refugee kids," Glimmer's voice had sounded desperate, keen to appease, "Catra, with everything you went through... We just wanted to do something good. Give one of these kids a better start."

Bow had tried to make eye contact with his friend, but he'd fast realised that they'd walked right from one sore spot into another. The twins had started to grizzle, their mother's souring mood seeping into the atmosphere; Catra had muttered her congratulations unconvincingly and abruptly ended the girls' feed, demanding Adora take the twins from her as she readjusted her clothes. She sat with a strange reservedness as he and Glimmer tried to explain more about the process of fostering, soon leaving the room under the guise of checking on the food. When it had become clear that Catra wasn't coming back, Adora had swiftly followed her with whimpering babies in tow, noticeably flustered as she spluttered her apologies at them.

"Bow," Glimmer had looked up at him worriedly, anxiety deepening the crease in her forehead, "I didn't think she would react like this!"

"No, I..." Bow's throat had closed up, confusion clouding his thoughts, "I didn't either."

He'd joined Glimmer on the couch, sandwiching their son between them as she rubbed Micah's back soothingly. They'd sat alone for

ten long minutes before Adora had returned to announce the twins had calmed down and lunch was ready to eat.

The conversation had dried up again now, despite Glimmer's attempts to encourage Micah to tell everyone what he'd been doing at school. The boy seemed to be fatigued by the ongoing tension, unused to watching it play out. Preoccupied with helping Glimmer and Adora to stack some of the used dishes, Bow missed Micah slipping away from his chair and ducking under the table to find Catra; he emerged to stand between her knees, his hand reaching out gingerly to pet Aurie's arm as he rested his elbow on Catra's other thigh.

"I sorry you sad, Catra. I not meaned to be naughty, I just wanteds to play."

The whole room seemed to halt as Micah spoke; Catra dropped her fork in a clatter onto her plate, immediately shocked and mollified in equal measure.

"Oh, Mikey," She cupped his cheek, eyes flicking up guiltily to Bow's for a split second, "You weren't naughty, and you didn't make me sad."

"But you not smiling anymore!"

"Sometimes when I'm not smiling, it's just because I'm thinking about things that are hard to think about. It's not because of what other people do."

"Not me?"

"Especially not you! You make me *very* happy. Best friends, right?"

"Yeah," Micah snuggled into Catra further, turning his head against her stomach to face Aurie, "We is all best friends!"

Bow watched as Catra exhaled a quiet breath of relief that matched the one stuck in his own lungs. He cleared his throat, returning the timid smile Catra offered him.

“Why don’t you sing us the song you learned at school, Micah? You can show the girls all the actions too.”

Micah nodded enthusiastically in response to his father, his little chest puffing up as he prepared to sing.

“Don’t forget to face Aurie, darling,” Glimmer prompted him, “She loves music, remember?”

Adora squeezed the top of Glimmer’s arm in gratitude as they loaded crockery into the dishwasher. Bow knew that Adora had spent many of her commutes home calling Glimmer on the hands-free as she drove, sharing all the adjustments they’d learned to put in place to communicate better with their daughter and revealing her concerns about how Catra was processing the whole thing. She had apparently stopped playing guitar completely since the diagnosis, and all three of them were aware now that it had become somewhat of a coping mechanism since Drew’s death. Adora had noted that Catra hadn’t played for the girls in several months, even though both of them had always loved being laid on their playmat beside the instrument’s soft vibrations. Bow remembered the way Catra used to laugh at how Aurie brightened so much when he or Glimmer brought Micah over and they’d sing nursery rhymes to the babies; since they learned of her hearing loss, Bow had wondered a few times whether being able to feel the sound was why Aurie’s whole body would visibly react with such pleasure to her mother’s strumming.

True to form, Aurie moved with the melody as she watched Micah sing, her arms jerking in the air as she attempted to copy Micah’s exaggerated actions as much as she was able. She bounced on Catra’s thigh when the song came to an end, her excitable vocalizations easily drowning out those of her twin. Micah repeated the song, encouraged by the gummy grins that grew on the girls’ faces.

Bow studied Catra as she watched the interaction, seeing past the expression of enthusiasm – clearly pasted on for the kids’ benefit – to recognise a familiar sadness behind her eyes. They had

known each other, and seen the rawest parts of one other, for long enough to break down facades.

He motioned for Adora and Glimmer to come back to the table, suggesting Micah continue singing with the twins in the living room, where they could move more on the floor. Catra started to push her chair back, but Bow's hand jutted out to cover hers, like it had so many times over beer garden picnic tables and lacquered pub bars in their former lives. She allowed Aurie to be taken from her despite the baby's immediate objections, her body stiffly motionless until only the two of them were left in the kitchen.

"Let's take a walk."

She nodded dumbly, her unusual passivity continuing as he told their wives what they were doing and heralded her out the house. The May sun shone on them the same way it had on him and Micah five years ago, when Bow had started his tradition of trading pain for pavements. They walked wordlessly through residential streets, neither of them pursuing a defined destination or topic of conversation. They were rounding their fifth corner when Catra finally spoke, her voice trembling.

"I'm sorry, Bow. I should be more supportive."

He gripped her hand, squeezing it to communicate what she needed to hear.

I know. It's okay.

"I'm ashamed."

Bow turned to look at Catra, noticing how she'd shrunk into herself, her shoulders sloped instead of strong.

"Cat, there's nothing to be ashamed of – we kind of bombed you with it. We should have kept you in the loop, really-"

"Not that. I..."

He waited for her to continue, but Bow could tell there was a sob suppressed in her throat, "You can tell me."

Catra looked up at him, revealing the same anxious fear he'd seen when she'd fretted over her and Adora's early relationship, when she'd thought she lost the love of her life, and when moments of crisis had struck during her labours.

"I can't stop worrying about her. Whether she'll be okay at nursery, or if she'll need speech therapy. Whether she'll be made to feel behind, or – *or less than* – with Lyla there for everyone to compare her to."

"That's completely understandable, Cat. And Aurie's birth... her birth was difficult. We both remember that. This whole thing is not easy."

Catra stopped in her tracks, pinching the bridge of her nose. Bow waited for her to look up, but Catra's eyes stayed downcast and hidden by her curls, directed at the curb.

"I don't really remember her being born, Bow. I thought it was déjà vu, or that I was going crazy." Catra steeled herself to meet his pupils, her brow wrinkled, "I never told Adora. She was so happy she was there for it after missing Lyla's, saying how important it was that we got to share it. But I don't feel like I was there for Aurie, not the way I should have been. And when we found out about her hearing... fuck, it's just... it's another thing I missed. The whole time I was pregnant, Bow, I completely missed her! How could I miss that?"

"You can't blame yourself for that, Catra. Even Adora didn't realise, and she's-"

"I carried them, Bow, and it wasn't my first pregnancy. I should've known!"

She stormed ahead before he could reply, her brow furrowed; Bow skipped a step to keep up with Catra, rushing to stay within earshot of what she was saying.

"Bow, you're taking in a child who has probably been through something terrible, who has been at risk of so many awful things happening to him. Do you know how big a deal that is? My whole childhood, I used to wish every night that fostering or adoption, or *something*, would happen for me. I mean, you know I wanted to do that, me and Adora, before she said she wanted us to carry."

Catra bit her lip, hesitant to continue; Bow came closer to her as they walked, his ongoing silence a tacit confirmation that she should carry on.

"It's so ridiculous. Here I am, with everything I have to offer my kids – who haven't come from any of that kind of trauma – and I can't get past thinking how it's unfair that *my* daughter has to suffer, that I still failed to protect her. And I know I'm the problem, acting like this is some kind of tragedy. I'm so mad at myself! But I..."

Her tears began to flow then, and Bow halted both of them. He pulled her into his chest, wrapping his arms around her shoulders.

"I thought I dealt with everything that could hurt them already."

"Hey. You already got more than you bargained for with twins – you need to go easy on yourself. But Cat, our kids are going to get hurt. That's out of our control. We just have to make sure we're the people picking them up after, not the ones causing it."

Catra sniffled, prodding his chest.

"When did you turn into such a wise-arse?"

"When did you become such a sap, dude?"

She pushed off him, laughing through her tears.

"At least I have some fucking hormones to blame."

They walked further in silence, their skin cooling as a new breeze flowed past them. Eventually, they circled back to the house, tear

tracks erased from Catra's face.

"I'm really proud of you, you know," Bow felt Catra bump his shoulder as she spoke, "This kid doesn't know how lucky he is."

Bow smiled to himself, nudging Catra back. She had no idea quite how much their friendship had shaped him, and how the richness she'd brought into his life went so much further than the surrogacy that had delivered his first-born son.

SEVEN YEARS AFTER

Catra spluttered as warm water splashed in her face, bubbles catching on the tips of her eyelashes.

"Hey, little monster. Come over here."

She pulled the three-year-old over to her, the bathwater lapping at their skin.

"Sit with your imma for a minute, hmm?"

Lyla giggled in her arms as she blew foamy clouds off her daughter's face, her damp hair sticking to Catra's chest. She squeezed the girl tighter, tickling her belly lightly as she wound her fingers around the toddler.

"Imma!" Lyla screamed with laughter as she squirmed, "Dat tickle!"

A wave of water surged as Aurie lunged towards them, her wet curls saturated with conditioner and only half-combed.

"Imma, Imma! Tickle me!"

“Are you sure, Aurie? Once the tickling starts, it’s hard to stop...!”

Catra reached out for the girl, her fingers running behind her daughter’s neck to draw out gleeful shrieks. She caught Adora’s unimpressed raised eyebrow from the other end of the bath, wide tooth comb held aloft.

“If you insist on this ridiculous hair-washing routine for them, you have to at least let me finish it.”

“Sorry, ‘Dor,” She smiled at her wife apologetically, “But I just don’t know *how to... resist... this... deliciousness!”*

The girls squealed as she punctuated each word with a kiss to their cheeks, their noises getting even shriller when Adora splashed the three of them with her foot.

“Aurie, bring your deliciousness over here so I can finish your hair!” She flicked her fingers towards herself, waving the comb in her other hand, “You can have all the tickles you want when I’m doing Lyla’s hair.”

“Mama...”

Aurie stuck out her bottom lip, looking back at Catra hopefully.

“That’s not gonna work today, kid. Go on.”

The toddler scuttled back after a moment of indignation, curling around her mother’s body and sucking her thumb as Adora finished detangling her curls. Catra watched them as Lyla settled in her arms, mindlessly finger-combing the little girl’s hair as they waited, becoming a reflection of the scene across from them in the oversized tub. Catra rubbed Adora’s calf tenderly with her foot, her knee bent against the inside lip of the bath.

“Alright then,” Adora tapped Aurie’s shoulder, “Swapsies!”

The girls slid past each other in the water, their hands holding onto the colourful rubber grips suctioned to the bathroom tiles;

Catra called out to Lyla as Aurie practically vaulted into her lap, almost knocking the air out of her.

"Don't jump on Mama, Lyla!"

It was unnecessary, really – as the girls had grown from babies to toddlers, Catra had observed how they'd each picked up different behaviours from her and Adora; Lyla had developed her cool and practical temperament while Aurie had absorbed every excitable mannerism of Adora's lively nature. Nevertheless, if it weren't for the purple glitter hearing aid mould that Aurie wore in the daytime – and the matching sparkly lilac hair clip that Lyla insisted on fixing above her right ear every morning – few people besides Catra and Adora would be able to tell the girls apart.

She blinked suds out of her eyes as she reached up to grab the plastic jug from the shelf above her, leaning forwards a little to fill it under the bath taps. She held one hand over Aurie's brow, the girl's hands coming up under hers to shield her eyes, and poured the clean water over her head slowly, inspecting how effectively the thick white product melted away from her daughter's deep chestnut hair. The twins' hair was almost their only feature that didn't resemble Catra exactly, their ringlets lighter and a little looser than her dark brown curls. Otherwise, they'd inherited the uncommon amber colour of her left iris, the sharp point of her chin and the olive tone of her skin. It was uncanny sometimes, seeing so much of herself redrawn in her daughters' identical faces after a lifetime of only recognising similarity in the bathroom mirror.

Catra watched Adora as she set the jug down and squeezed gel into her wet palms, nudging Aurie with her elbow to sit still. Her wife had been right those few years prior – the sense of belonging she'd found in their little family was profound beyond her expectations. Catra smiled to herself as she smoothed and scrunched emulsified gel into Aurie's hair, squeezing excess water out; she was certain that even if Adora didn't already feel it as deeply as Catra did, she would soon.

Catra murmured the beginnings of a song under her breath to Aurie, her lips trilling close to her hearing ear.

"*Hinei ma tov umanayim, shevet achim-"*

"GAM YACHAD!*"*

Aurie splashed as she sung loudly, repeating what she could of the lyrics over and over again. Adora looked at Catra pointedly, silently warning her that given she'd started this impromptu singalong, it was up to her to end it later.

Over the years, Catra had become more involved at the synagogue she'd found herself frequenting when she and Adora had broken up, and the girls were used to going fairly regularly. They'd been blessed by the rabbi and given their full Hebrew names at five weeks old, the ceremony being one of the first official outings for which they'd managed to get all four of them out the house. It had been a nice opportunity for a celebration once the stress of the birth had begun to fade, their friends and family gathered in the synagogue hall after the service around tables of sweet pastries, torn challah bread and fast-emptying bowls of hummus and matbucha. Catra had hesitantly settled into a chair when the babies needed to nurse, finding a number of mothers were already doing so, the nervous beat of her heart easing as the women joked together about how breastfeeding at least got them out of drinking the vile kosher kiddush wine during blessings. Gazing at her girls, she'd realised then that whatever her inevitable shortcomings as a mother would turn out to be, she'd already succeeded at giving them a community. Catra hadn't had the energy to think about it much in the hazy days after the twins were born, but she and Adora hadn't needed to cook a single meal until the babies were nearly three weeks old; every day, someone had volunteered to deliver food to them, thanks to a meal rota shared amongst friends and congregants. And that morning, the turnout – which was far larger than Catra had expected, considering that she'd not attended a Shabbat service since her pregnancy became too arduous for early Saturday morning alarms – was testament to it. For all the strange little

customs and quirks Catra had never quite understood since she discovered her heritage, she saw that the community really did consider her – and her family – as a part of them. Her daughters would have somewhere to turn when they needed guidance or support, and they'd grow with a cultural map designed to help them navigate the world.

Their membership of the synagogue had become useful sooner than Catra had expected. When the girls were around fourteen months old, she and Adora had started taking them every so often to children's services; unsurprisingly, Aurie had adored the swell of instruments in the room, often wriggling out of Catra or Adora's arms to toddle right up to the service leader, her hand stretched out towards his guitar. Eventually, it had become routine for the musicians to bring a mini maraca for Aurie to hold, and by the time the girls had turned two, Aurie had learned a handful of words from the songs that were sung each time. The cluster of Hebrew words – *shalom, shabbat, hinei, Shema, Torah* – weren't a particularly useful addition to her vocabulary, but it was the first time Aurie had succeeded in saying anything that she hadn't copied from her sister. Catra was determined that Aurie would have something that didn't feel like she was always catching up to Lyla; despite her reservations that Aurie's English needed to improve first, she made sure to sing with the twins after she collected them every day from nursery and when they lit the Shabbat candles each Friday night.

Adora rubbed the base of her belly as Aurie sang, pausing her push of the comb through the other twin's hair. Lyla turned around, curious to see why the pull on her curls had stopped; watching Adora, she leaned in close, patting the skin by the spot Adora's fingers pressed.

"You gots be still. Dat's hair time rule."

The older twin's attempt to educate her unborn brother was neither uncommon, nor particularly easy to take seriously. Lyla had become extraordinarily conscientious, moving on from her previous obsession with caring for Melog to develop a significant

fascination with how Adora's stomach had grown over the past six months. Adora had even joked to Catra that their daughter was downright misogynistic – ever since she'd found out she was becoming a big sister, she rarely demonstrated any concern for Adora herself, always rushing to find out how "her baby" was every time her mother entered the room.

"At this point, Cat, I'm pretty sure I'm just a vessel for her sibling. She'll end up burning down abortion clinics if we're not careful!"

Even though it ruffled Adora, Catra was a little more relieved that one of the girls had taken an interest – Lyla's reaction to the impending birth of their son was fairly more predictable than Aurie's. They'd both been too young to notice any change when Samir had arrived shortly before their first birthday, nor could they really understand the significance of his adoption only a few months prior. As far as Lyla and Aurie were concerned, their circle had always included Auntie Glimmer, Uncle Bow, Micah and Samir.

Despite everyone's expectations that Catra would be the one to understand the little boy most, it had been Adora who'd helped Bow and Glimmer to coax Samir out of himself. While they hadn't had too many problems easing him into his new home and routine – and they'd all been relieved at how comfortably Micah and Samir had learned to get on in those first few months – Samir still refused to speak outside Bow and Glimmer's home nearly a year after he'd first been placed. Overhearing Catra's billionth conversation with Bow about Samir's lack of progress on speakerphone, Adora had promptly taken her wife's mobile and informed their friend that she was in fact the only one who had lived experience of being plonked in a stranger's house one day, and perhaps they should consider her as having something valuable to share. He and Glimmer had sheepishly conceded, and it had only taken a few more months of Adora suggesting why Samir might be behaving in certain ways before he'd started to properly come out of his shell.

It was shortly after this breakthrough – cemented by Samir's first announcement at Catra and Adora's communal Sunday table that

he would like "*more pita, please"* – that Adora had admitted she wanted to try again to conceive. The concept of a third child hadn't been something Catra had thought about before, but as she looked into the hopeful blue of her wife's eyes, it suddenly seemed ludicrous that it hadn't been in their plan all along. They'd taken a long bath together that night once the girls had gone to sleep, topping up the hot water as they talked about their finances and the practicalities of making it work. To a large extent, it had just been due process; neither of them was very good at saying no to the other, and they'd emotionally committed to the idea the minute it left Adora's lips. When their pregnancy test had finally come back positive on the thirteenth anniversary of Drew's death, Catra couldn't help but think there was something spiritually intentional – destined, even – about this child's life, even though she could tell Adora secretly thought she'd gone completely crazy for saying so.

The feel of cool porcelain against hot skin was just as satisfying as it had always been.

Adora rested her forearms against the tiled bathroom wall, her forehead dropping downwards as she focused on the cold water rolling down her spine.

"You really were onto something with this."

Catra's lip twitched, one hand splayed on the wall next to Adora while the other pressed a drenched sponge against her shoulder.

"Well, I might not have a fancy medical degree, but I do have some first-hand experience."

Adora snorted, twisting to face her wife.

"You're gonna hold this over me for ages, aren't you?"

“Don’t know what you could possibly mean,” Catra retorted, “Me, regularly remind my wife that I, in fact, do know better?”

“Doesn’t sound *anything* like you, Cat.”

“No, not at all.”

Catra pushed off the wall, grabbing Adora’s hairbrush from the sink counter and nudging her to sit down on the stool they’d moved into their en-suite shower. Adora slowly lowered herself down to it, groaning a little at the throbbing aches in her body while Catra got to work quickly, unravelling the knots that had matted in Adora’s tangled hair and sectioning it to be braided.

“You know what this reminds me of, ‘Dor?”

Adora sucked air through her nostrils, almost as if she could smell the chlorine in their bathroom.

“Swimming.”

She could sense the slow smile spreading across Catra’s face, even though she couldn’t see her; they’d always paired up after their swimming lessons, rinsing chemicals off their skin and tugging one another’s wet hair into tight plaits to stop it from dripping down the back of their itchy school uniforms.

“Do you think we’d have ever guessed we’d end up here? Back then?”

Catra’s hands loosened a little on Adora’s hair, blowing air through pressed lips as she considered her answer, “I don’t think I’d have guessed a lot of what’s happened since we were kids.”

Adora bent one arm across her chest, catching Catra’s fingers as they rested momentarily on her shoulder. They sat for a second in the quiet, until Adora couldn’t help herself.

“I’d have *died* if I knew you were queer.”

Catra giggled, fixing one of the twins' turquoise hair bands at the bottom of Adora's braid.

"Okay, Romeo, everyone knows that you were super gay for me since the dawn of time – you don't have to prove it."

"God, you were gorgeous," Adora leaned back cautiously against Catra's stomach, her wife's towel bristling against her spine, her tone instantly firmer and more assured, "You're the best thing that ever happened to me, you know, Cat."

"Don't say that too loudly," Catra teased back, "Your mother's watching our son in the next room."

Adora waved her hand in the air dismissively.

"As if she doesn't already know."

Catra leaned down, pressing a kiss to the top of Adora's head. These moments of solitude were so rare between them now – Catra was suddenly flooded with gratitude that her father-in-law had suggested he go and pick up the twins so she could help Adora get washed up. The whole day had felt like a bubble in time since Catra had guided Adora into bed with the baby and worked with the midwives to clean up bloodied towels and wet plastic sheeting. Her wife's labour had been even longer than Catra's first, though it had ultimately played out in their favour. By the time Adora informed Catra it was time to call the midwives, she'd already got the girls dressed for nursery and was bundling them into Glimmer's car before Lyla could continue questioning why their mama had been making such strange noises all night. Their son – already nearly twice the weight that their girls had been at birth – had made his appearance little more than an hour later, Adora's arms slung over Catra's and her mother's shoulders as she kneeled on the bedroom floor between them.

The house was oddly quiet now they were almost home alone. They could only hear the whimpers of the baby from the bedroom, and the soft crooning of Adora's mother seeping under

the bathroom door. As she moved to stand in front of Adora, Catra could almost feel the strain growing in her wife's body; she'd felt it herself so many times when a child she'd carried craved her warmth.

"Come on," She rubbed the outside of her thigh soothingly, ready to coax her to her feet, "They'll be home any minute, we should get dressed."

But Adora had turned to stone, her palm suddenly clamped tight around Catra's elbow.

"Cat. What if they hate him?"

"There's fat chance of that, they'll probably ignore us the minute they see him-"

"What if they think I'll love him more?"

Catra paused, supporting Adora to push off from the stool and wrapping a towel around her gently. She enveloped her in her arms despite the wetness of her wife's skin.

"They won't, I promise you. Nothing here is changing – only growing, right? Just like we told them."

Adora gulped audibly, her forehead coming close to rest against Catra's.

"I don't know what I'd do without you, Cat. If we hadn't had found each other again, or you hadn't made it..."

They both shivered then, their minds running through the numerous times that Catra's place in the world had seemed incurably precarious, her ties to Adora almost severed to the bone. Catra held Adora a little longer, trying and failing to reconcile the previous versions of themselves with the women they'd become. The front door slammed shut in the distance, the mingled voices of their daughters reverberating from the floor below. They stayed in the bathroom for a few seconds longer – as

they drew apart, Adora traced the flowers that bloomed on Catra's collarbone, the buds on her own wrist softly reuniting with their match. It dawned on Catra slowly and all at once: the past might have been a dangerous place, but even during the darkest of nights, she'd always seen a distant light ahead.

For the first time, the words burned irrepressibly on her own lips. Though she'd been its recipient so many times over the years, Catra had yet to voice the exact wording of the one promise that – above all her other pacts – would remain impossible to break.

"Adora," she whispered, commanding all of her wife's attention before they stepped into the next chapter of their story, "I waited so long to call you mine. And I love you."

Chapter End Notes

> I didn't want to add a spoiler in the opening notes, but one thing that was really important to me was including representation of hearing loss in children - something that doesn't get discussed nearly enough despite how common it is. A lot of what is described isn't exactly parallel with my own experience of being a deaf child (I wasn't diagnosed until school despite being deaf since infancy, and have severe hearing loss in both ears rather than in just one) but some of Catra's reaction comes from conversations I've had with my own parents about what they went through and how our household adapted when I got my (yes, also bright purple and glittery!) hearing aids. After incorporating it in this chapter, I'd definitely love to write more stories centering the experience of those with hearing loss... maybe I will someday!
>
> Wishing you all a lovely Saturday, and thank you for investing in this story and reading :) ❤

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